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SPEAKING PART I

RAIN

- **Do you like rainy days?**

Yes, absolutely! I like when it rains... I love all the freshness around, the cool breeze after a heavy rain. It's wonderful!

- **What do you do on rainy days?**

Well, rainy days are the best days to watch movies I have been longing to watch or catch up on my unfinished reading. Movies and books will make up my whole rainy day. Sometimes, I would rather spend with my pet and teach it new tricks.

- **What is the importance of the rainfall?**

Well, currently, I am living in Hanoi, which is located in the northern part of Vietnam. I suppose that in the north, the rainy season comes during the summer months, extending from mid-April to mid-October. This is because during this time of the year, the city's climate is influenced by the southwest monsoon, which brings moist air from the oceans to the land and causes torrential rain.

- **Does it rain much in Vietnam? (Where? When?)**

As it is entirely located in the tropical belt, Vietnam receives quite a great amount of precipitation every year. However, the part that records the highest rainfall is the northern section of Central Vietnam when the northeast monsoon arrives, between September and December. This region can also be affected by the typhoon season in the Western Pacific, which can see severe storms lashing the coast from August to November.

- **Is there any part of Vietnam where it doesn't rain much? (Where?)**

In general, I guess the driest place in Vietnam might possibly be Ninh Thuan province, which is situated on the south-central coast. The weather there is quite extreme with a lot of wind as well as a hot and dry atmosphere during the year. Also, there is no winter here, and the average temperature is considerably higher than most other parts of the country.

- **When (in what month/season) does it rain most in your hometown?**

Well, currently, I am living in Hanoi, which is located in the northern part of Vietnam. I suppose that in the north, the rainy season comes during the summer months, extending from mid-April to mid-October. This is because during this time of the year, the

city's climate is influenced by the southwest monsoon, which brings moist air from the oceans to the land and causes torrential rain.

- **What about the other parts of Vietnam? (In which season does it rain most in other parts of Vietnam?)**

Well, the southern part of Vietnam, especially the Mekong Delta, gets plenty of rain and hot, humid weather during the southwest monsoon from April to September, with June and July being especially wet. Meanwhile, the center of the country receives the most rainfall between September and December, during which time the region suffers from severe storms and flooding.

- **Can you remember any time when it rained particularly heavily in your hometown? (When?)**

Yes, of course. I suppose it was about a year or so ago, when we had several days of torrential rain, almost non-stop, and so the whole of my neighborhood got flooded. You know, the water was, like, up to my knees, and so the traffic came to a complete standstill. So, yeah, that was probably the worst time I can remember.

- **Does rain ever affect transportation in your hometown? (How?)**

Yeah, for sure. As a matter of fact, rain often causes severe traffic congestion, especially when there is heavy downpour. People should expect to be stuck for hours in a traffic jam. I'm not exactly sure why, but it's possibly because vehicles tend to move slower in the rain.

PLANS AND GOALS

- **What is your plan for the future and when will you start?**

I'm planning to start my own advertising agency when I'm in my third year at university. I've been preparing this plan of mine ever since I was a high school student and I've raised nearly enough capital now.

- **How do you intend to achieve that?**

I'm working on raising capital, and I also need some partners to work on this project with me – I've shared my plan with my friends and some of them seemed really interested in it. And once I've got someone, we'll take care of the rest together.

- **Do you plan to spend many years overseas?**

Yeah I really do. I always wanted to study in an overseas university as it would ensure a better educational environment and quality education compared to the universities of my country.

Apart from that, the opportunity to learn about the diverse cultures and people in a foreign university is something I don't want to miss. Finally, a foreign degree, especially a degree from a reputed USA or UK university is helpful for better career prospect in our country.

- **If you go abroad, do you plan to live in the countryside or in a big city? (Why?)**

I'd prefer living in the countryside, mostly because I want to experience the tranquility there. Another reason is because the traffic and air pollution in some big cities are almost unbearable, and I seriously don't want to get stuck with all the problems of city life.

- **After you go abroad, do you plan to join any clubs?**

Oh yes, I'm into joining some local clubs to pursue my personal hobbies such as photography and hiking. You know, the main factor is that club activities can enrich my spare time with lots of happiness and positive experience, and also can help me meet new friends and get familiar with the local community.

WEATHER

- **What's the weather like today?**

It's freezing, oh my God... but luckily it hasn't rained today. It was raining all last week... I was soaked to the skin whenever I went out to go to work even though I was wearing a raincoat, and the rain made it even colder!

- **What's the weather (usually) like in your hometown?**

It depends on the season, but most of the time it's really hot in my hometown. And it's been getting hotter and hotter in recent years...maybe one big reason is because of global warming.

- **What's your favorite season? (Why?)**

I really like the fall, mainly because of its cool weather, which makes me feel really comfortable and ready to go out any time of the day. The other seasons... well, summer's too hot, winter's too cold and spring's too humid.

- **(Similar to above, but different) What's your favorite weather? (Why?)**

Cool weather. It makes me feel really comfortable and ready to go out any time of the day. Just imagine sitting in the park, reading a book in the sunshine with the wind gently blowing through your hair. Isn't that awesome?

- **Do you like snow? (Why?)**

I've never seen or touched snow before so instead of saying whether I like it or not, I would say I'm really curious about it. I've been dying to see the snow falling since forever but haven't really got the chance to do so.

- **Do you watch the weather forecasts?**

Rather than the weather forecasts shown on TV, I often look at the ones on my smartphone – you know, there're some applications that help predict the weather conditions for up to a week!

- **Does the weather ever affect what you do?**

Yes, of course. For example, I tend to get really lethargic and lazy in the winter, all because of the cold weather. All I want to do is to get some nice sleep under my warm blanket and never have to leave the comfort of my home, and this seriously affects my work and study sometimes.

ROBOTS

- **Are you interested in robots? Why?**

Option 1: No, I'm not really keen on robots because I'm kind of a low-tech person. Also, a robot is a luxury technological product that I have never been able to afford, so I don't feel like I want to know much about them.

Option 2: We all are already surrounded by robots and I think yes I am too an extent interested in them as well. It will be amazing to see the robots doing things that we don't like making us more productive. So, for example, when a robot would be driving my car, I will have time to read my novel or have a chat with my friend.

Option 3: Yes, robotics engineering is something I take a keen interest in. I actually subscribe to a journal dedicated entirely to robots called "The Robot Workshop". The other day I read a really interesting article about how robots can be used to perform surgeries.

- **Would you like robots to work in your home?**

If I had a lot of money, I'd like to have a robot in my home. As I'm always occupied with my work, I need a robot to help me do chores and prepare meals whenever I come home at night. That'd be great!

- **Would you want to take a car where a robot is the driver?**

No, I wouldn't want a robot to drive my car. It would be too dangerous and risky for me to take a drive with a robot. Because a robot is programmed by humans, I don't think that it can handle road incidents quickly and efficiently enough to ensure safety.

- **Will robots replace human beings in the workplace completely?**

Well, I have to admit that robots play an important part in our modern life. However, they will never completely replace the roles of humans at work as they are incapable of feeling emotions and thinking deeply like humans. For example, in a conference, people have to discuss problems in great detail before giving solutions and making decisions, but robots lack the capacity to respond to all questions instantly and effectively.

- **Do you like the idea of robots helping you at home or driving your car?**

Option 1: Yes, definitely. It would be great to have a robot helper at home, and I like the idea of driverless cars - I think driving would be safer if cars were controlled by robots.

Option 2: I am pretty content with robots working at my home doing things that I really don't like. So, for example, things like cleaning the room or the car, well if the robot does it I am good with it. Or, for sometimes make food for me.

SHOPPING

- **Are there many shops near your home?**

Yes, there are. As my city has increasingly developed, small stores and shopping malls are omnipresent. In my neighborhood, products of these shops are very diverse and up to the mark, accommodating the shopping demands of its residents.

- **Do you like shopping (Why/ Why not)?**

Of course, I enjoy shopping a lot. Shopping activities relieve my stress, especially when feel overloaded with work. In my opinion, it is also a chance for us to compare the quality of goods and acquire a better taste in things.

- **Who usually does the shopping in your home?**

Well, it may be my mother. Every morning, she goes to the store to choose hygienic and fresh food for our family's meals. Her favorite pastime is buying second-hand clothes in small markets. Sometimes, when I'm free, I go with her to a big supermarket to purchase basic necessities like shampoos or soaps.

- **How often do you buy something in a shop?**

Very often, as I rarely have time for window-shopping? Practically, I always make a list-to-buy before going to stores and markets, and hardly leave without a shopping bill.

- **What kind of shopping do you like doing?**

To be honest I dislike most shopping. When I need a pair of shoes I just buy the first ones I see. When I was younger though I was a bit of a shopaholic and went on shopping sprees all the time – mostly for music and gadgets.

- **Is shopping a popular activity in your country?**

Yes, it's very popular. Saturday is the busiest shopping day, and lots of people treat shopping as a kind of leisure activity, rather than something practical.

- **What types of shops do teenagers like best in your country?**

That's a really hard question to answer because there are so many different shops. But I guess the new shopping malls are where most young people go and they are more popular nowadays than the old markets. That's probably because there are more facilities there and they're just cooler and nicer places to be – outside can be really hot in my country, especially during daytime.

NAMES

- **Does your name have any particular meaning?**

Let me see... Well I think it means "bright pearl" or "shining pearl"? I guess my parents wanted me to become an intelligent and successful girl so they gave me this name.

- **What's the origin of your name? (or, your surname)**

It's pretty lame really... Dad wanted to call me "Ngoc" or "Chi" back then but he couldn't decide which one, then one cousin of mine asked him whether I had a name and he just blurted out "Minh Chau". My cousin then spread the news about my name to everyone, which was something Dad didn't expect at all, and well, I am stuck with this name now.

- **Do you like your name?**

At first no, because my friends often made fun of my name, like with some puns. But then I gradually learnt to accept it, and now I can't imagine having a different name from this one.

- **What do your friends call you?**

My friends back in secondary and high school tended to call me “Cat” or “Fat Cat” because of my nickname on social networks - well I love cats after all. University friends don’t really give me any nicknames; they just call me “Chau”.

- **Did your family have a (nick) name that they called you when you were a child?**

Hmm...well, no? They just called me “Chau”. I think in some other families, parents would give their children some kind of nick name but that’s not the case in my family.

- **What names are popular to give to babies in your country?**

I think people tend to choose some names like Linh or Trang for girls – I don’t know the actual meanings of those names though. For boys, the two most popular names, I think, are Son, which means the mountain and Hieu, which means to show affection and respect towards one’s parents.

SWIMMING

- **Do you like swimming?**

Of course, I love swimming. It is a very healthy and motivational sport. I think swimming can endear itself to many people because water-related activities always deliver a sense of excitement and refreshment.

- **How often do you swim?**

Well, it is largely dependent on the season and weather. In the summer, I usually go swimming with my close friends. During the hot weather, immersing yourself in the cold water is irresistible. However, in my country, it is virtually impossible to swim in the winter.

- **Where do you swim in your city?**

My school possesses a standardized swimming pool, which is very popular among students. I often go there and the public swimming pool near my house is also my favorite option.

Although the swimming pools in luxurious hotels are very appealing, they are beyond my means so I cannot swim there.

- **What are the benefits of learning to swim?**

Well, there are a few; first it’s a lot fun, especially if you go with your friends, and then there’s the fact that it could save your life one day if you know how to swim, or you could even save

someone else's life if they are in trouble. Then, as I said before, it's one of the best forms of exercise so it's a really healthy activity.

- **Is it difficult to learn how to learn to swim?**

Well, a little bit, I think. Most sports require some form of physical exertion and swimming is not without exception. The first time, I was confronted with a lot of difficulties in maintaining stamina and also in holding my breath under water. However, with the assistance of my friends and continuous practice, I think I'm a good swimmer now.

- **Do you think children could develop swimming into a career option?**

It depends on whether they're good enough or not. I mean, there are only a few people in the whole world who are champion swimmers, just like in any sport, so the likelihood of a child or young person being able to earn their living just from swimming is quite low unless they are one of the best in the world.

NEIGHBORS

- **Do you know your neighbors?**

Yes, of course I do. People in my neighborhood know each other quite well, and all of them are very friendly and lovable. The family living next to my house is always willing to offer assistance when we need, and so is my family.

- **Do you like your neighbors?**

Well yes, I love them, because they are good neighbors. The family next door has a grandmother whom I really respect, as she always gives me useful advice. I think that we live in harmony with one another.

- **What do you think of your neighbors?**

As I have said, they are warm-hearted people. They receive a lot of affection and admiration for their kindness and generosity. I think it is quite good fortune for my family to live next to them.

- **How often do you see (or talk to) your neighbors?**

I think very often. Each morning, we frequently greet when we meet each other. Whenever I am not occupied with schoolwork, I will visit the grandmother to talk to her. Her life experience and advice have helped me to overcome many difficulties and challenges.

- **When do you meet your neighbors?**

We meet every day, since we live next to each other. Particularly, at the weekends, the neighbors will gather in the biggest house to hold a party or BBQ, which is very appealing to the children.

SUNNY DAYS

- **Do you like sunny days?**

To be honest, I'm not into sunny weather. I'd prefer a partially cloudy day without rain, when the weather is pretty cool, so that I could pleasantly take part in outdoor activities without getting sunburn or sweating from the heat of the sun's rays.

- **What do you like to do when it's a sunny day?**

Option 1: On a sunny day, I like to wake up early and take a walk around my neighborhood to enjoy the warmth of the sunshine, when the temperature isn't too high. I also prefer to do the laundry as clothes dry faster due to the lower humidity on these days.

Option 2: Sunny day is the best weather to do some outdoor activities. The first thing I like to do is my personal errands such as going to the mall, buy food at the market and visit different places. In fact, I normally go out on weekend's afternoon to do these activities with my friends. To sum up, sunny days is the best time to do almost everything.

- **Would you like to stay at home or go outside when the weather is great?**

I've always had the urge to go outside on a nice day, as the beautiful weather makes me feel really comfortable from the inside. Also, there's no hindrance of crappy weather to outdoors activities, so I think I just can't stick to staying in bed and missing such an occasion.

- **Are there any technologies with sun in nowadays? For example?**

I am not sure if I get your point but if I understood it right, you maybe pertaining to technologies like solar panel. This is device used at the rooftop of your house which absorbs sun energy to provide electricity at home, but most importantly this device is environmental friend and can help you save money as you no longer need to pay for electrical bill. Well, I have read that people in UK have these devices at home. This is pretty much what we need to help the environment and to save money.

- **Are there many sunny days in your hometown?**

My hometown is in the middle region of a tropical country which means there's usually sunshine. In fact, due to its coastal location, it's the driest and hottest region in my country, especially in the summer, so the weather is somewhat extreme.

- **Do you like sunshine?**

I definitely love sunny days, on which I can hang out with friends or do some sports. It is even better with the winds blowing. Sunny days are somehow helpful for laundry as well as cleaning both inside and outside the house.

- **What would you do on sunny days?**

I'd love to participate in some outdoor activities under the sun like meeting up with some friends or do some sports, especially swimming. Or I'll grab the chance for a photography tour. Everything becomes so clear and stunning on sunny days, no matter it's early in the morning or late in the afternoon, as long as the sun shines, I'm sure I'll find inspiration almost everywhere.

COLLECTING

- **Did you collect anything (such as stamps or CD's) when you were a child?**

Of course I did. When I was a child, I and my sister really enjoyed collecting Barbie CDs. At that time, the Barbie CD collection was considered as my biggest treasure. Before the Internet went viral, watching CDs was one of teenagers' favorite pastimes.

- **Do you still collect them now?**

Well, I don't. I have grown out of the Barbie CDs. Moreover, thanks to advances in Technology, we can now watch everything on the Internet, so there is no need to collect CDs.

- **Do you collect anything as a hobby now?**

Yes, I do. As a girl, I am really fond of collecting gorgeous dresses in various styles. Whenever I have time, I always go around shopping malls to keep myself up to date with the latest fashions. Up to now, I have assembled a collection of more than 30 dresses.

- **Why do you like collecting things?**

Well, collecting things gives me a sense of excitement. When you are able to gather things together that you love, you feel extremely satisfied. Collecting things allows me to pursue anything that I like, from the cheapest to the most luxurious.

- **Do people in your country like to collect things?**

Yes, they do. However, the things collected vary from people to people. While the wealthy are interested in collecting luxury cars and expensive stuff, others collect simpler things, even family heirlooms, which is dependent on their own inclination or interest.

- **Why do you think people like collecting things?**

Because collecting things is a pleasing hobby. As I have said, the feeling when collecting our favorite stuff day by day is really appealing, which helps to relieve stress and pressure at work or school. Moreover, I think collections can tell you a lot about their owners, such as characteristics or personalities.

CONCERTS

- **Have you ever been to a live concert?**

Yes, I have been to numerous concerts before. I really enjoy listening to live music with my friends and my family members. To me, the atmosphere experienced in a live concert is extremely exhilarating. In live concerts, the artist will have the chance to express himself more freely than in recorded performances.

- **What sorts of concerts do you have in your country?**

Well, the types of concerts that take place in my country are very diverse. There are different genres of music in different shows, catering for the demand of audiences of all ages, such as: pop music, rap, or classical music. Although there is also a revival of interest in traditional folk songs, pop music concerts attract the largest crowds.

- **Are concerts ever held in your hometown?**

Yes, quite often. Normally, there is a live concert with many renowned artists that is held in the center of my city on special occasions, which never fails to appeal to audiences.

- **When was the last time you attended a concert?**

Well, it was last month. My friends and I went to a live classic at music concert to get away from the burden of work, and the music did live up to our expectations. It was really engrossing to enjoy the aesthetic qualities of classical music played by a talented orchestra in a superb concert venue.

CLOTHES

- **What kinds of clothes do you usually wear?**

Primarily jeans, t-shirts, hoodies, sneakers, etc. I don't like wearing anything outlandish because I don't like drawing attention, since I'm not a social butterfly, but I don't go for a conventional look, either.

- **Do people around you also wear the same type of clothes?**

We are living in a multicultural society so people have a multiple choice of everything, from what they eat, what they say to what they wear. Therefore, it is hard to say people around me also wear the same kind of clothes.

- **What kinds of clothes do other people wear?**

I guess it depends on each person's personality. For example, a woman who is soft-spoken and likes to daydream usually gravitates towards frilly pieces like lace and ruffles. A culture loving person tends to dress more urban and sporty than most fashionistas.

Almost all of Vietnamese schools require students to wear uniforms and there will be no exception. Teachers suppose that wearing a uniform is a badge of pride, and creates an identity for a school and is an important part of being a school student.

- **Do you think clothes are important to people? (Why?/Why not?)**

Of course I would say yes. Clothing is a basic human need. For most people, clothing gives us protection from the weather. While for some people, clothing defines their fashion sense and creativity and they use it as a way to express their personality.

- **Do you prefer to wear formal or informal clothes?**

I would choose informal clothes since being creative; mixing and matching what I already have; and being able to come up with a new look after that is a huge satisfaction for me. Formal clothing is often set in its own way and looks quite conservative to me.

- **Do/did you wear the same clothes at school and at home?**

Oh, definitely not. I always wore the school uniforms which was a blue jacket with a white shirt. They were very simple and boring. So when I reached home, I intended to put on my favorite outfits.

- **Will you change your clothes when you go home today?**

Oh, yes. The formal clothes really make me nervous so after I go home later, I'll take them off and change my sweatshirts.

- **Did you have any special clothes to wear when you were a child?**
Did you like them?

Yes, when I was a child, I needed to wear a uniform at school from primary school all the way to the very last year of high school, which is an institution, so I believed my parents had to follow this tradition. However, I really couldn't stand the school uniform because the clothes were a bit too old-fashioned; in addition, sometimes I was reluctant to wear them because they were too large. I doubted why they couldn't be a bit more trendy and colorful like the ones in other countries, like Japan and Australia.

EMAIL

- **Do you like to write a letter or email?**

I really like writing letters to other people, especially on special occasions. I remember writing many letters, like birthday letters, or farewell ones to any of my friends or relatives who had to go somewhere far away from me. My friends and relatives always feel happy when they receive a letter from me; they say that it makes them feel important and cherished.

- **Do you think emails are useful?**

Emails are really useful and important to me. I can use emails to contact people who are staying far away from me, and this really comes in handy as I have lots of foreign friends. Moreover, I can receive notifications of special deals or interesting information through emails by subscribing to any online channels that appeal to me.

- **What sorts of letters (or emails) do you think are the most difficult to write?**

Formal emails, like the ones you send to recruiters, to your boss, to your professor and so on, are very difficult to write. You have to choose the right tone for the emails so that they do not appear too casual or too serious, and you have to pay attention to the format of the emails too.

- **Do you prefer to write letters or emails? Why?**

It depends. For special occasions, like on someone's birthday, I prefer writing letters to congratulate them as handwritten letters can show my sincerity. However, if I need to write something formal, say to a recruiter to apply for a certain position, email is my first choice. It's instant, easy to format and I can attach different files with it so it is very convenient too.

- **Do you think email might one day replace handwritten letters?**

I don't think so. Handwritten letters still carry in themselves special meanings, one of which is that they can show a writer's sentiment. I always think that it feels different when you look at someone's handwriting, like you can actually sense their feelings when they wrote the letter. So handwritten letters are irreplaceable, at least to me.

- **Do you often send emails?**

Normally it seems like a daily routine for me to write emails to my clients about how to use the system; but if they complain to me about the poor user experience, I sometimes really find myself getting stuck in explaining to comfort them.

- **Do you think people will still write letters in the future?**

Well, if I were to choose between the two, I will probably go with writing an email because I can have plenty of time thinking about how to express my opinion correctly and clearly, besides, the whole conversation can be tracked in the mail list; whereas, making a telephone call usually leads to misunderstanding because sometimes it is not very accurate and obscure.

FRIENDS

- **Do you have many close friends?**

I have only one friend I would confide in. I'm quite picky and more importantly, I have a somewhat irrational fear that none of my friends really like me and that I'm just a guy they can barely tolerate and it is hard for me to live in harmony with them.

- **Do you think friendship is important?**

There is no doubt that friendships play a vital role in our life. They make our lives interesting and wonderful. They help us develop a sense of sharing whether they are tangible things or just inspirational or motivational words of wisdom.

- **Which do you prefer to spend time with: a friend or spend time alone?**

It depends. Normally, I'm more of a loner and generally spend more time in solitude than with friends. But when I'm in a bad mood, loneliness makes me feel isolated from the whole world. These days, I will hang out with my friends so that sad and unhappy thoughts cannot come into my mind.

- **What kind of people do you like to have as friend?**

I find myself attracted to people who are honest and who know how to behave with others. I always avoid making friends with people who have a superiority complex.

- **Do you like face-to-face conversations with people?**

Actually I like to talk with cyber friends more than having real-world conversations. I think others observe me a lot, they judge me and hence I become very self-conscious and shy away from speaking face to face.

- **Are most of your friends from school or from outside school?**

Most of my friends are from high school. People who I met at work or from clubs have less in common with me, whereas at Uni we all shared interests in the same things and subjects.

- **How often do you meet with your friends?**

When I was younger, I used to meet my friends almost every day. Even friends outside of school were a part of my daily social interactions. But now, as a 23 year old working professional, I barely meet anyone during weekdays. I meet my closest friends only on some weekends. These meetups are sporadic too.

- **What do you and your friends do together?**

My closest friends and I have a mutual interest which is we always have a thirst for clothes shopping, so whenever we have time, we will go shopping together until we break the bank. Sometimes when we are out of money, just window shopping is enough.

- **How do people in your country meet others and make friends?**

I don't think it particularly matters what country you're from. In every country, you can make friends just by sitting next to someone a few times during class, and then a friendship logically happens. Otherwise, you can make cyber friends through social networks like Facebook or Twitter.

- **Do adults and children make friends in the same way?**

Adults use self-disclosure to develop trust and loyalty among friends. This is quite complicated in practice while children usually use common interests and goals as the basis of their friendships. More importantly, kids have a whale of time with whomever, but adults have to use their time for work and taking care of their family.

- **Do you think it is possible to become real friends with people you meet on the internet?**

Of course it is possible to establish real friendships with someone online. What you need in a friendship is truthfulness, reliability, empathy, respect and loyalty. If you're getting all that from your online friends then you can consider them as genuine friends.

- **How do people (in your country) meet others and make friends?**

Well, it's kind of hard to say but people that I know around me tend to become friends because they were classmates in high schools or universities, but maybe for others, they just are co-workers so they develop good friendship in the workplace.

- **Do you think it's easy for people to make friends at work?**

Yes, people in the workplace all tend to be sociable so that every one will have more promotion opportunities and at least be productive. Besides, working in the office without friends will be tame because people won't find partners to talk about work or their own life.

- **Is it important to have good relationships with colleagues at their workplace? (Why?)**

Yes, I do. I feel that it's hard not to have friends in the workplace. After all, we are going to spend over one third of our waking life each week at work, so you know, I don't want to be socially isolated during that time, which will have bad influence on productivity.

- **Would you say the students (at your school/university) have a good relationship with each other?**

Well, I'm afraid that not every student in the school have a good relationship with others because some of them seem to have a social problem, they are good at chatting with others, and are only willing to indulge themselves in the study. Hopefully as they grow up, they will recognize the importance of communication.

- **How would you describe a "good relationship"?**

A good relationship between friends in my opinion is where both people are able to be themselves, respect each other, treat each with kindness and know how to give themselves and the other appropriate space.

- **Do you ever help a friend by giving advice?**

Oh, yes, one of my friends smokes a lot and if he keeps smoking he is going to get lung cancer or something. So I consistently tell him about the problems that this stuff causes, get him a little sentimental, exaggerate and tell him to stop.

- **How often do you like to hang out with friends?**

I hang out with my friends to somewhere from time to time. Normally if we have lots of time in the weekends, we will go to the cinema to watch movies with our kids to have a good time; but if we don't have plenty of time, we'll just have dinner together in a restaurant.

- **Who do you usually like to hang out with?**

Usually I'd like to hang out with one of my close friends. Actually we live in the same community so we can meet frequently. Besides, both of our kids are in the same class in the kindergarten, so we'd like to take them to the park or playground together.

- **Where do you like to go when you hang out with your friends?**

Well, that depends. We sometimes go to the restaurants to enjoy the tasty food if someone finds a decent place; and if we have plenty of time, we'd like to plan a hike or camp in the nearby forest park to enjoy the natural life. That would be a very memorable experience.

- **Do you like to go out with a big group or just few friends?**

Well, if I were to choose between the two, I will probably go with hanging out with a big group people because I feel that I am an extrovert, I like to meet different people to know about different kinds of life and make myself more sociable; whereas, you know, with few people around, it would be hard to find something interesting to do, such as travelling, hiking, etc.

MUSIC

- **Do you like listening to music?**

I love listening to music, especially US-UK. My favorite artists are Miley Cyrus and Troye Sivan; their songs always sound awesome to me.

- **When do you listen to music?**

Basically I listen to music whenever I feel like doing so, but maybe I most often do that before going to sleep, when I'm on the bus, or when I don't have any important tasks to work on.

- **Did you learn instruments?**

I didn't take up any musical instruments, and haven't still. I have always wanted to learn to play the piano ever since I was a kid, but never got the chance too. I'm planning on getting some piano lessons this summer.

- **Did you have any music classes in school?**

I used to have music classes back when I was in primary school and secondary school only. I really loved my music class in secondary school - for our midterm and final tests, we had to form a group of at least four and perform a certain song that we chose ourselves. It was so much fun.

- **Do you think it is necessary for children to have music classes?**

In my opinion, children should always have music classes. Music has been scientifically proven to have positive influences on one's way of thinking and feeling, so it will do people good if they can experience music from an early age.

- **What do you think of Vietnamese traditional music?**

It's not really to my taste, to be honest. I literally cannot listen to traditional kinds of music such as "ca tru", "cai luong" or "cheo". I really like listening to songs created during the war though. Maybe because my dad was a soldier, he often told me stories about his years in the army and so I can somehow relate deeply to those kinds of songs.

- **How much time do you spend listening to music every day?**

It depends. I often listen to music when I'm doing the housework or when I'm on the bus. At that time, I feel like I can immerse myself in my own world. When I need to really concentrate on school work, I don't really listen to music as it can cause some real unwelcomed distraction.

- **What is your favorite kind of music?**

I don't have a particular taste in music. I can pretty much listen to everything as long as it sounds good to me. Still, I can hardly listen to Vietnamese traditional music, some countries' folk songs and several tracks belong to the classical genre.

- **When did you start listening to this type of music?**

[Let's just say I'm into rock music]

The first time I heard a rock song was when my dad turned on the TV and there was a performance of a very famous rock band in Vietnam called "Buc Tuong". It was amazing. I started searching for more songs from the Vietnamese band, and songs belonging to the same genre, and have decided ever since that rock music would be a part of my spiritual life.

- **How do you feel when you listening to music?**

Relaxed and free, I guess. Music, to me, is a way of hiding from all the hustle and bustle of everyday life. I listen to music when I'm under a lot of pressure, and I just feel so fine. It's the feeling of finally coming home after years and years of living far away, I think.

- **Can you play any musical instruments?**

Unfortunately, I had not learned to play any type of musical instrument when I was a little boy. I remembered that in schools, teachers always told us to put all energy into studying and preparing exams. The music lessons, along with physical exercises and paintings, were not so important as the schools claimed to be. I really felt pity when I grew up.

- **Do you think children should learn to play musical instruments?**

Yes, I think it's a great skill and it's really enjoyable to be able to play a musical instrument. All children should be given this opportunity.

POLITENESS

- **Do you think you are a polite person?**

I do think I'm a polite person. I treat other people nicely and patiently, and I do not insult anyone unless they truly deserve it. Also, I properly apologize when I make mistakes and I show my gratitude when other people help me.

- **Do you think people should be polite? Why?**

People should always be polite - it shows that they have good manners and it helps them earn others' respect. Being polite is like having good social skills - it can help one widen their social network, and this can positively influence one's private and professional life.

- **How do people in your culture show good manners towards others?**

In Vietnam, showing good manners is when a junior properly greets a senior and talks to him/her politely with sufficient and correct honorifics. Politeness also shows during a meal, when people need to wish the others to have a nice meal and when the younger ones have to wait for the older ones to finish before cleaning the table.

- **Have there been any changes in politeness in the past few decades?**

I always have this feeling that people start being less and less polite to each other as time passes. Maybe one of the reasons lies in the etiquette and codes of conduct that have gradually changed over time. In the past, it was very important to behave according to one's

social class, and those of a lower rank had to obey those of a higher one. But today's society is different - you need to work hard to earn somebody's respect.

- **Who taught you to be polite?**

This may sound weird but my friends actually taught me to be polite. I wasn't a very nice person when I was a kid, and my parents often scolded me for being rude to elders. One day, I remember watching one of my friends talking really nicely and politely to a senior. She was praised, and so I started imitating her. My parents were really surprised when I changed my attitude, and they gave me some sweets as I was "being a good kid". I have been showing my politeness to everyone ever since.

WATCHES

- **How often do you wear a watch?**

Since childhood I have had affection for watches, so I wear my watch all the time. In fact I'd feel naked without my watch. But I usually reserve nicer watches or the ones with sentimental value for special occasions or when I wear luxurious clothes.

- **What was your first watch like?**

I developed my affection for watches with a little cute Mickey Mouse dial shaped watch. And I guess everyone around my age used to own one like that as it was quite in at the time.

- **Did your parents allow you to wear a watch when you were a child?**

Yes, I used to have one of those sports watches with a lot of functions on it. It was black and I used to wear it all the time. But then it got damaged and I never bothered to replace it.

- **What kind of watches do you like to wear?**

I'm a big fan of dress watches with a leather strap. It completes me. It gives a classic look and complements my outfit irrespective of the occasion.

- **Do people still wear watches in your country?**

There are lots of watches being manufactured or imported and sold in my country since there are tons of people who love wearing them. Some would love wearing them for their utility while others would prefer to wear them as an accessory.

- **Did you receive any watch as a gift when you were a child?**

Yes, the one I mentioned above, the Mickey Mouse dial shaped watch. My father recognized

my enthusiasm for watches and he gave it to me as a birthday gift when I was about 7 remember jumping around because of the excitement.

- **Why do you think some people buy expensive watches?**

There are a lot of possible reasons, it depends on the individual, but many older people still see a watch as jewelry, rather than just something functional that tells the time, so they like to have a nice watch. Others might like to wear an expensive watch just because they like the brand, just like shoes, a hat, or purse or something like that.

- **Do you think the watch you wear says something about your personality?**

I think if you want it to, it can, but not always. There are some really rich and famous people who don't wear a watch or just wear a regular watch, and there are other people who wear any old watch whether it seems to suit their personality or not.

GARDEN

- **Does your family have a garden?**

No, we don't have one at the moment, but I think my parents are planning to buy some land so that we can have our own little garden. My mom's really into flowers, you see; she's wanted to have a garden for herself ever since she was young.

- **Do many people in Vietnam have their own garden?**

In the inner city areas- no, there's no room for gardens, they are just concrete jungles. But in the suburbs or in the countryside then yes, lots of people have their own garden. I mean my aunts and uncles live in the countryside and they have very large gardens in which they plant tons of vegetables and flowers.

- **If someone has a private garden in Vietnam, do they usually prefer to grow flowers or vegetables?**

It depends, I think. I've never seen anyone with a private garden in the city, but if there is one, then the owner must want to grow flowers. Taking care of vegetables in the city requires a lot of work and effort. People from the countryside, on the other hand, often grow vegetables on their private plots.

- **Have you ever grown anything? (in a garden, or possibly in a flower pot)**

I used to grow some sort of beans in a very small pot back when I was in primary school. We had an assignment in which we had to grow beans and bring them to class. It wasn't very

successful though; the rats in the yard just kept eating all the beans and I couldn't bring anything to class at the time.

- **Do Vietnamese people like growing flowers?**

I'm not really sure, but I guess not many people like growing their own flowers. I think most of the time they just go to the market and buy some flowers instead.

- **Do you like growing flowers?**

I don't. Flowers are actually not my cup of tea. They surely look beautiful and some even smell really good, but I just can't see the point of constantly looking at or taking care of flowers. I prefer cactuses.

TV DRAMAS

- **Are drama series popular in Vietnam? Why?**

Yes, they are quite popular, especially among housewives. I think people like drama series because of their diverse themes, entertaining storylines and because they are an escape from the stress and pressure of daily life for the audiences.

- **What is the difference between the favorite TV dramas of young people and old people? Why?**

I think young people are more interested in action and adventure, which seems to match with their age. On the other hand, old people would rather watch slow dramas, especially those which deal with family themes. The difference is due to the age gap.

- **Do you think TV dramas reflect what happens in the real world?**

Only partly. The themes of TV dramas are quite similar to reality, in so far as they often deal with contemporary social issues, such as divorce, domestic violence or family conflicts.

- **Do you think people change their tastes in TV drama when they get older?**

Yes, to some extent. As you get more mature, you will be more into slow, meaningful dramas. However, whether we change our preference or not is largely dependent on our own interests.

- **What is the difference between Vietnamese and foreign TV dramas?**

Well, Vietnamese drama series often exploit family themes. Meanwhile, foreign dramas consist of broader topics, which include crime, law and medicine, catering for a wider demand from viewers.

- **What is the influence of foreign shows on Vietnamese viewers?**

I think they give Vietnamese people a chance to know more about foreign cultures, lifestyles and codes of conduct. Youngsters are more aware of the diversity of cultures in the world, thanks to the influence of imported shows.

- **Some people say that soap operas don't reflect real life, what do you think? Why?**

Well, I think this might be true. The plots in soap operas are quite light, which contrasts with the harsh reality of everyday life. As a matter of fact, life is becoming increasingly demanding, while soap operas rarely take people out of their comfort zone.

- **Do you think soap operas have a bad influence on children?**

Well, I think it depends on how seriously children take soap operas. They must have some influence, because they are shown on prime time television. However, parents should teach children how to distinguish between the fantasy world of TV dramas and the real world.

- **Do you like watching TV programs?**

Definitely music channels such as MTV or V-channel. These channels offer a wide variety of music every day. In addition, they also interact with their audience by allowing them to vote for the Top 20 songs of each week or to play the songs they requested.

- **What type of TV program do you like most?**

Being an architect, I used to not only read books but also watch TV documentaries in order to pick up information related to my field. My favorite TV series is "Live or Die" which has been aired since 2012 and helps me broaden my horizon in architecture. But, recently, because I found that the Internet is full of better material, I've been streaming videos, which is a much more efficient way to enhance my knowledge.

- **Do you prefer to watch TV alone or with your friends?**

I'd rather watch films with my friends. We always have a good time together, and afterwards we talk about the movie, whether we enjoyed it or not.

INTERNET

- **Do you use the internet (very much)?**

I am currently in my first year at college, so using the internet is a must. I need to hand in assignments and sometimes complete the quizzes through the college intranet. Aside from that, I also use the internet to gain access to entertainment resources such as movies, music or novels online.

- **When was the first time you used the internet?**

I first accessed the internet when I was in grade six, which was about 7 or 8 years ago. I was in my English class and the teacher set up some online exercises for us, and it was the first time I learned what the internet was and how to use it.

- **Is the internet very important (or, useful) to you?**

It is so important to me that I cannot imagine living a day without using it. The first reason is because most of my work and assignments require the use of the internet, like submitting an essay to the professor, or doing some research using the information found on the Internet. Besides, I actually live quite far from my parents right now but we are still a close-knit family, so with the internet I can make video calls and keep in touch with all the family news.

- **Do think you can (or, could) live without the internet?**

I actually experienced a time when I lived without the internet. It was before I entered grade six, and I felt completely fine. I'm not addicted to using the internet, but it would be impossible to pursue my studies without it.

- **Do you often (or, do you ever) buy things on the internet?**

Yes, I love shopping online. The first time I did that was when I wanted to purchase a book which I couldn't find at any bookstores in my city. I ordered and received it in just a few days, and it was in great condition. This was when I got really into online shopping - I started buying a lot of books online, and then other types of consumer products ever since

FRUIT AND VEGETABLES

- **What's your favorite vegetable and fruit?**

My top three are broccoli, celery and grape because all of them are both nutritious and delicious. Also, I want to give mushrooms an honorable mention as they are one of my favorite things to cook with, although they are a fungus.

- **How often do you eat fruits?**

I think I eat fruits at home on a daily basis. I always buy a lot of different fruits in the shopping mall in the weekends for my whole family.

- **Are there any special fruits in your hometown?**

Oh yes, there are loquat trees everywhere in my hometown. Loquat is very sweet and has lots of nutrition and can become medicine.

- **Should we eat vegetables every day?**

Yes, we do. We really need to eat vegetables every day because you simply cannot find another food group that is as perfectly matched to our everyday human needs as vegetables. There are various protein, fiber and vitamin that cannot be found in other food like meat.

- **Do you like eating fruit and vegetables?**

As a matter of fact, I love eating vegetables and fresh fruits. Not because it's good for my health, although it really is; but because I was lucky enough to be born into a culture where vegetables and fruits are essential part of the daily diet.

- **What kind of fruit did you like most when you were a child?**

I used to love peeling the skin of bananas, so I really enjoyed eating them. Then, when I got a bit older, I changed my mind.

HISTORY

- **Who you admire most in the history?**

One of the historical figures that I admire the most would be Thomas Alva Edison. He was an American Inventor who lived at the end of the eighteenth century. It is said that Edison was one of the greatest inventors in the world, as he had found more than 1000 inventions during his time.

- **Do you like (to learn about) history?**

Yes, I am a big fan of reading historical stories. When I was a little boy, I always took some historical books from my father's bookshelf and read the historical events. I feel that history not only can cultivate my mental development, but also give me a better picture of human society.

- **What historical event do you find most interesting?**

Personally I am fond of the Battle of Red Cliffs happened in the early period of Three Kingdoms, which was a decisive battle at the end of the Han Dynasty. It was also the typical battle in Chinese history renowned for the fewer and weaker defeating the more and stronger.

- **Do you think history is important?**

Yes, the main factor is that like our native language, history forms a cultural identity and keeps a unique record of country, and also we can learn the experiences from history to correct our current actions.

- **Do you like to watch programmes on TV about history?**

Yes, I enjoy watching some documentaries about history on TV because I can see a lot of video materials that cannot be seen in the textbooks. I always watch them at home during my time off with my son to learn something about history.

- **Do you think you can really learn history from films and TV programmes?**

I don't feel that watching the current TV series can make you be aware of the history, you know, TV programmes are more engaging than books, however the true historical events in most of the TV series have been distorted by the producers to cater for the audience. It's really shame as the young people will misunderstand the history by these irresponsible productions.

- **Do you think the internet is a good place to learn about history?**

Yes. History is full of debates so you can find both of the two sides of opinion online which will help you be aware of the true facts and think critically. I always google some engaging historical materials about the Song Dynasty, for example, to know about the truth.

- **Have you learned something from historical movies?**

Of course, quite a lot. The study of history is essential as it provides us with real life case studies that can be learned from. I can learn from their mistakes, made by previous generations so that I can avoid those mistakes for myself.

JEWELRY

- **What's your attitude toward jewelry?**

As a lady, jewelry plays an important role in my fashion world this is due to the reason that jewelry adds color to my clothing and makes my outfit looks elegant. For instance, I usually wear my silver-plated earrings and my silver bracelet when I go out. It may be simple but it looks classic.

- **What kind of jewelry do you like to buy?**

Well, I don't really like accessorizing a lot but I like wearing earrings most because of the reason that earrings makes my face looks more attractive. You know, it can make me look more sassy. Therefore, I can say that earrings are a must whenever I go out.

- **Do you like wearing jewelry?**

I don't own many golds or diamond jewelry. Probably, I don't like putting on much of them. But I do love accessorizing my clothes with artificial jewelry. I have a dozen of earrings. All that I have collected over a period of time. I do even own some hand wrist but not much of them either.

- **How often do you wear jewelry?**

I am a lady so I would say that I frequently wear simple jewelry when I go out such as a pair of earrings and a watch this is because of the reason that it adds intensity to my overall outfit. For instance, when I hang out with my friends I must wear these accessories because most of my friends are fashionable so I must fit in. Basically, jewelry is just part of our fashion trend.

- **When you may like to wear jewelry?**

Since I am a guy and men generally have limited options when it comes to jewelry, I would definitely choose a watch on any given day to accessorize. Some of my guy friends wear men's bracelets and I think they look really cool with those, too. Of course men can put on earrings and necklaces, but personally I think it's hard for a man to look neat with too many accessories. I truly believe in 'Less is more' for men regarding jewelry.

- **Have you ever sent others jewelry as a present?**

Yead, for one time. I have bought a watch as a gift to a special friend of mine The watchband itself made for a beautiful piece of jewelry because it consisted of different colorful gemstones. I gave my present on her big day and needless to say, she was speechless and over the moon.

- **Why do some people love to buy expensive jewelry?**

Option 1: I think the reason is because the pieces of jewelry a person wears can tell us heaps about their social and financial status. A very wise person whose name I can't recall once said: "You can tell a lot about a man by looking at the watch on his wrist." The choice of jewelry can also inform us of the fashion sense of style that person is pursuing.

Option 2: Well, I haven't thought of that question but I guess that fancy jewelry is part of a person's status in life. This is common for those wealthy people; they normally buy luxurious jewelries to show off. Diamonds for instance, diamonds are one of the most expensive jewelry worn by most women; if you wear diamonds in a party you will look exquisite. All in all, expensive jewelries are for those rich people.

- **Do people in your country ever wear jewelry, such as rings or necklaces?**

The majority of Vietnamese women I know adore wearing jewelry. I notice that some of the common pieces of jewelry they own and wear are earrings, necklaces, bracelets and rings. I think the main reasons why Vietnamese women love and wear jewelry to make a fashion statement like celebrities and fashionistas. Vietnamese men wear jewelry too, but their choices are usually watches or wedding bands for those married.

DAILY LIFE ROUTINES

- **When you wake up?**

Well, let's see. I'm quite a morning riser since I wake up really early. Maybe at about 5 o'clock. Waking up early makes me feel good and productive, I know when I'll get in bed tonight that I'll feel like this was a good day, that I deserve a nice sleep, and that tomorrow will be just as good.

- **Which time do you like most in a day?**

Option 1: Personally I enjoy late night and early morning before sunrise, when everything is filled with dim gray light. It's a great time for a walk after a night of working or jogging in the local park near my place, especially if the weather is cloudy, or slightly rainy. In this time, I can loosen up and find my peace of mind.

Option 2: I am a morning person so I would say morning is my favorite part of the day most likely because it signifies a new day and a new beginning. There are times when I have a bad day but I always think about the quote that says, "Tomorrow is another day". In a word, waking up every morning is the best feeling ever.

- **What's your daily routine?**

As I have mentioned I am a morning person so obviously I start my day with a cup of coffee, breakfast and a good shower then everything follows. Apparently, I go to school on weekends so I normally go back home to do my homework and take a rest while I go out for a friends' date on weekends or spend time with my family. Pretty much I have a simple and happy lifestyle.

- **What is the busiest part of the day for you?**

To be honest every day is a busy day for me but I am normally occupied in the morning because of the reason that I usually rush about everything especially during school days. You know, I sleep late at night and wake up late in the morning. Basically, I have to get up at 5am, make my breakfast, prepare my things, take a shower and ride my bicycle to school. Over all, I have to speed up every morning.

- **What would you do in your spare time?**

Well, I do quite a lot of sport actually. I go swimming twice a week. There's a very good pool just around the corner from my office. I swim for an hour and do about 40 lengths. I also cycle to work when I can. Apart from that, I do a lot of reading and photography.

- **What's the difference of routine between you and your teenager's times?**

Well, I can say that there's a huge difference between my life back then and my present life. You know, when I was a teenager I was irresponsible about my everyday lifestyle because of the fact that I have nothing to worry about apart from my school work, also, my parents were there to take care of me. As opposed to my life now, my routine and time management has become stricter. Ever since I stepped into college things got tough especially that I have to live on my own now. I have learned to be independent and become more responsible with my personal life and school life. Such as sleeping early and waking up early in the morning

- **What would you like to change in your daily routine?**

I would like to wake up early in the morning. I usually wake up at around 9.00 am and that's mainly because I am late to go to bed and I would like this one aspect to be changed from my current daily routine.

- **Are all your days the same?**

Not really. For me, a day-off is quite different than the busy working day in every perspective. Apart from that different circumstances and events make the days different from each other. While Sunday is a day to spend time with my family members and to meet friends and play with them in the evening, I have a tight schedule at the university and work on Monday.

BIRTHDAY

- **Can you remember a birthday that you enjoyed as a child?**

I still remember my 13th birthday. It started out with no plan and we decided to just have fun within my family members but as it turned out to be, people started coming just like that, some saw my father getting cake and others simply wanted to wish me. It was a surprise of its own kind and we had almost 50 people in the house. It was real fun, meeting people and then opening the gifts.

- **Do you think birthdays are important?**

Yes, absolutely I do. Everyone, regardless their age, deserves to have a meaningful birthday celebration not only to mark another milestone of their life but to share wishes and happiness with their beloved ones.

- **Which year's birthday is the most important one to you?**

I think 18 is an important birthday for people because that is when you really declare your independence and are totally responsible for your behavior.

- **Do you usually celebrate your birthdays?**

Yes, I do. Although it is not very huge party but I make sure that there is a party and that I have all my near and dear ones surrounding me during my birthday.

ADVERTISEMENTS

- **Have you bought things because of advertisements?**

I think I bought my phone after I saw its advertisement. It was a great advertisement and after seeing it I was like, I need to find out more about this product. And it truly turned out to be a great product.

- **Why do you think there are so many advertisements now?**

The main factor is that adverts are the most efficient way for the companies to reach their end users, and also every company wants to stand out from the crowd in such fierce competition.

- **Can you usually see advertisements?**

Definitely, I can. They appear all over the place from the streets to social media with a high density. For example, there is a multitude of colorful flyers stickled on the street walls in my city.

- **What sorts of advertisements have a deeper impact on people?**

Instead of selling a product, the advertisements that share a story which can connect to the individual, I think these are the kinds of ads that have deeper impact on people. Because somehow people can relate to the scenario and hence feel more connected to the product

- **Do advertisements influence your choice of product?**

Surely, it does. Advertisements have come about to affect our choices in way like never before. But, when it comes to choosing between a well-known or trusted company and the newly established, irrespective of the ad I prefer the trusted one.

NEIGHBOUR

- **Do you think the relationships with your neighbors are good?**

Option 1: Definitely, yes! Well, it is more of a friendly relation because we both work for the same company and share our cars to work together. It is almost like a family friend and we do help each other out in tough situations.

Option 2: Unfortunately, I don't really feel so. Being a bachelor, I spend most of my time either working or studying or being part of some extracurricular activity. So, rarely do I get to spend time with my neighbors. However, I do know that there is an old couple that lives next to my house and we do pass smiles when we meet.

- **Do you think it is important to have good neighbors?**

Yes, I feel that having a good relationship with them can allow me to lead a comfortable life in the community. I can make new friends with them, sharing the same interests and I can learn more skills from them about how to educate my boy.

- **What kind of problems can people have with neighbors?**

Although, I do believe neighbors are people you would love to have, but then having people beside you who don't understand basic nature of living, is truly a mess. For example, people who play loud music or those who ring your bell and run away. Then there are some people who tend to bitch about you in front of others. I think probably these are the kind of neighbors you would rather not have.

- **How well do you know your next-door neighbors?**

As I am living in my house for more than 3 decades, I know maximum of my neighbors very well. We meet in the evening daily and sometimes my family travels with my next-door neighbor in the holidays.

- **How can neighbors be helpful?**

Neighbors, I believe are a family away from home. So, it is not only about just helping you in need, for example, in cases of emergency but also provide the emotional support when needed.

- **How your neighbors helped you before?**

I think I'm lucky, I've got good neighbors because I know I could call on him if I needed to. We will always help each other if we can. I dug his car out of the snow for him once as he didn't have a shovel and he returned the favor in other ways, taking in parcels for me when I'm away for example.

WATCH

- **Did you wear a watch when you were a child?**

I don't clearly remember wearing a watch while growing up on daily basis. However, whenever those fancy watches used to come around, I have always tried them. Sadly they did not work out for a long time, but it was always fun to have them. But, as I reached by Intermediate College I did start wearing watches on a regular basis.

- **Have you received watch as a gift?**

Yes, so far I have received two watches as gifts in my two last birthdays. One of which is an Omega Seamaster Cosmic from my parents when I graduated from high school. It is kind of a vintage wrist watched which became a very handy fashion item for me over high school time.

- **In which way can a watch be useful?**

Well, in my opinion, when we want to know the current time, a quick glance towards our wrist is a much classier way to keep tabs on time during a date or a meeting. Not to mention how rude it would seem to our companions if we pulled out our phone during a conversation.

- **Who do some people love to wear expensive watch?**

As you know, watches are also considered a kind of jewelry, especially for men. It is a statement piece for the modern man, sitting on the thin of his wrist, representing style and status and having expensive one ad on to it.

INDOOR ACTIVITY

- **What's your favorite indoor activity?**

It really depends on how I'm feeling. Normally, I love the internet and love doing research. I also really enjoy watching DVD's I love looking at the shopping sites and choosing new DVD's and books in the local library.

- **Do you prefer to play indoor games or outdoor games?**

It actually depends on the weather. If it is summer, I'll go for the indoor games, obviously and during winters I like to play outdoor games!

- **What indoor games did you play when you were a child?**

As a child I enjoyed playing chess. I think chess is probably the best known board game in the world. It's a game for two players, and the aim is to defeat the other player by taking his or her pieces and eventually trapping his King. I liked playing chess because I enjoyed the challenge of thinking ahead and trying to outwit my opponent.

- **What sorts of indoor games do children in your country play now?**

As far as I'm concerned, the kids today only go for one or two types of indoor sports, instead they are more hooked on outdoor activities simply because they are vibrant and dynamic than the previous generations. One of the most popular game I guess is chess as it involves little movement and requires only a board to play

SHOES

- **Do you prefer to wear comfortable shoes or beautiful shoes?**

Option 1: If I were to choose between the two, I'll probably go with some comfortable shoes, like athletic shoes, because they are not expensive, and can be worn on most occasions. Whereas, good-looking shoes sometimes cost too much.

Option 2: Ah, that's an easy one! I much prefer comfortable shoes, cos for me, comfort is definitely the number one priority. But that's not to say I don't care at all about how they look. I mean, I don't wanna go around wearing shoes that look hideous! You know, that would be pretty embarrassing. But as long as they're ok looking, then that's good enough for me.

Option 3: Although I'm hooked on shoes that are in vogue, particularly ones that are sold in limited numbers, I must admit that comfort is my top priority in buying a pair of shoes. Usually, I will go for sneakers of famous brands like Nike, you know I just kill two birds with one stone as their shoes fit well and are extremely all the rage as well.

- **What kind of shoes do you usually wear?**

Option 1: I mostly wear flat shoes rather than high heeled shoes because I find them more comfortable. I also go for shoes that aren't lace-ups so that I slip them on and off whenever I need to.

Option 2: It depends on the occasion, for work I have to look smart and presentable, so I tend to wear closed-toed, medium heels, usually dark in color, but when I'm just relaxing or going out dressed casually I love wearing my Converse sneakers; I have several pairs in various colors. And if I go out at night, someplace special, I like to wear high heels.

- **Do you think the type of shoes someone wears reflected their character?**

Yes, I do. People say that first impressions are important and I think that goes for shoes too. If you see the person wearing a worn out pair of shoes, it gives you the impression that they are sloppy. On the other hand, if you see someone wearing brand name shoes that cost a fortune, you know that the person has plenty of money to splash around and don't care about costs.

- **Do you like shopping for shoes? (Why/Why not?)**

Option 1: No, I can't stand go shopping for shoes, it's really tiring and time consuming. I remember when I bought my shoes last time, it took me hours to find the suitable shoes, and it's really painstaking.

Option 2: It's ok I suppose, but it's not something I especially enjoy doing. You know, for me it's just a matter of finding the right shoes and buying them, and the faster I can get it done, the better!

Option 3: I'm a big fan of shoes and often spend hours browsing for stuff on virtual stores and Facebook pages to get the best deals. Shoes for me are a perfect piece of ornament, making me stand out from the crowd, and for that purpose, I tend to opt for the trendiest shoes from big brands like Nike.

- **Have you ever bought shoes online?**

Option 1: Actually, I have never bought anything online, even shoes. You know, although it's convenient and time-saving, I still prefer going directly to shoes stores, where I could try on and make a bargain.

Option 2: Yes, sometimes, I've bought some sneakers online and also a couple of pairs of high-heeled sandals, but I usually like going shopping for shoes and other clothes with my friends, we make an afternoon of it, you could call it retail therapy.

- **What do you look for in a pair of shoes?**

Well, during my purchasing, I pay heed both to style and convenience. I try to find such products which combine these qualities. Moreover, I prefer flat leather shoes rather than high-heeled.

- **Why some people love to buy a lot of shoes?**

I suppose that, first of all, such people are affluent and they can afford to do it. Secondly, they would like to keep up with the latest trend and become fashionable. You know, my mother is also a slave to shoes.

- **Do you think it's reasonable to spend a huge amount of money on shoes?**

Again, it depends. If you have a lot of disposable income, then you should spend it on whatever you like. But, if you're on a tight budget then buying anything expensive is a challenge.

BRING THINGS

- **What would you like to bring with you when you go outside?**

Option 1: Well, you know, there are certainly some items that I'd consider essentials whenever I go out. For example, a pair of headphones to listen to music when I'm on the move. It really makes my daily commute less boring.

Option 2: Well, it has got to be my smart phone. You know I'm kind of an Internet addict so having my phone by my side is a must, cause you know, I can do practically anything with it, from surfing Facebook to creating documents, you name it.

- **Have you ever forgotten to bring your things?**

Well, I gotta admit I'm quite a forgetful person. There have certainly been times when I've left the house without my keys, my phone or even worse, my wallet. It's really a nuisance finding out that you have no cash on hand when you want to pay for, like, a coffee or something.

- **Do you bring the same things when you go out in the morning and in the evening?**

I guess I do bring different items at different times of day. Like, for example, in the morning when it's really sunny, a pair of shades might come in handy so I always bring that. By contrast, at night when it can get a bit cold, it's quite useful to have a light jacket to brace yourself against the chill.

- **How do you remember the things that you need to bring out?**

Well, to be honest, I have a memory like a sieve so remembering every daily task, including what should be brought along when I go out is challenging to me. And actually, I always take advantage of my notebook to jot down the list of my essential items with a view to bearing all in mind.

MAGAZINE

- **Do you like reading magazines or newspapers?**

Well, if I were to choose between the two, I'll probably go for reading magazines in my spare time because they are well printed and always have in-depth reporting on some particular events; whereas, you know, newspapers always report the same news as the Internet, so they now seem to be not so indispensable.

- **What type of magazine you may like to read?**

I don't read magazines these days, but I used to read motorbike ones. Also, I usually read news articles using a computer or my cellphone.

- **What section do you like in a magazine?**

I really enjoying reading articles from magazines with scientific content and that's mostly because I love mathematics and computer science. I also want to know how the market's going, so I love reading articles about the stock market, I don't have any specific reason why I read those articles , it's just a personal preference .

- **Do you prefer to read local news or international news?**

Well, if I were to choose between the two, I'll probably go with reading domestic news because they are closer to home, and they affect me more; whereas, you know international news sometimes have nothing to do with my daily life, so I just read the headlines.

- **In the future, do you think more people than today will read magazines, or fewer people?**

I think people these days prefer to read news articles on the internet, rather than read physical newspapers. It's much more convenient to use computers or mobile phones to read news articles. You don't have to buy newspapers and you can read a lot of different articles from many companies, even articles written in lots of different languages for free!

PUBLIC TRANSPORTATION

- **What form of transport do you prefer to use? Why?**

Without any doubt I would say motorbikes. You can see people driving a motorbike all over the place in my country. Almost everyone travels by motorbike. The reason why motorbike is so popular I think is due to their reasonable price and convenience. They also extremely varied in terms of size, color and quality, thus a wide variety of choices is available for everyone.

- **Do you like taking the bus? Do you often take it?**

Yes I enjoy taking bus and I do it almost every day. Since my house is so far away from my university, it's impossible for me to travel by motorbike. In addition, the air is heavily polluted by exhaust fumes and traffic jams always take place, especially during peak hours. Thus, I'd prefer to take the bus, to save time, save gasoline and causing less pollution.

- **What will become the most popular means of transport in your country?**

I think buses will take the lead. You can travel the distance without much worries about ticket price or rainy weather outside. Also new buses now offer better services like comfortable seats for the elderly or good air conditioning systems.

- **Can you compare the advantages of planes and trains?**

Planes and trains regularly depart and arrive on time. Plus, there are many convenient facilities catering particularly to certain groups of passengers. However, traveling by plane is clearly time-saving and enjoyable in terms of on-board services like meals or comfortable seats, while traveling by train offers you a chance to see the world outside, admire the views from their seats. It's totally a great experience for most train-travelers.

- **How much time do you spend travelling on a normal day?**

I have to commute from my home to my workplace on a daily basis. It normally takes me 30 minutes to travel back and forth.

- **Would you ride bikes to work in the future?**

Definitely not. Riding a bike means you're exposing yourself to the unpredictable weather and to air pollution. What is worse, I'm afraid the main streets or the highway are too dangerous for cyclists, as cars, motorbikes and buses will travel at a very high speed. Thus I'd rather ride a motorbike or take the bus instead.

- **Do you prefer public transport or private transport?**

I think I'd prefer public transport. It's much more inexpensive and because it can contain a large number of people, it helps ease the intensity of traffic jams during peak hours and reduce the greenhouse gas emissions caused by vehicles. Private transportation is more costly in terms of fees, taxes and gasoline.

POLITENESS

- **Do you think people should be polite? Why?**

In my opinion, politeness should be considered as a basic virtue that every person must acquire. Being well-mannered may not get you straight to the highest position at work within one day, but would give you respect, trust and kindness from other people, all of which are beneficial for you in a long run.

- **Who taught you to be polite when you were a kid?**

I guess similar to most people, I was raised to be a polite person by my parents. As I spent most of my time around them, they tried to set good example for me. They also gave me advice and told me moral stories about how being polite and kind to others can help me a lot in real life.

- **How people how politeness in your country?**

We really value politeness and good manners in the UK, and there are many types of polite behavior. One of the first things we learn as children is to say "please" and "thank you". As adults, I think we are careful not to be too direct in the language we use. For example, we would never say "Bring me the bill" in a restaurant because this kind of direct instruction would sound rude. It would be much more polite to say "Could we have the bill, please?"

- **How important is politeness for you?**

Over a period of time, I do have realized that a certain degree of politeness is important for me. It does pinch a bit when someone talks harshly to me. With the closer group, one does not feel it much because you are communicating on the same level. But, with others, in my opinion, a certain level of respect and courtesy is expected.

- **Are we less polite with members of our families than with people we don't know?**

I suppose it's normal to be a bit more relaxed about politeness with family members. Most people tend to speak in a more informal way at home; in the UK, we still say "please" and

"thanks", but it's fine to use colloquial language and things like nicknames that you would never use with someone you didn't know.

- **How the way people show politeness changed?**

People have definitely become more vocal, in my opinion. It could probably because we have become more globalized or because we have found a flair for passion. There is more of individuality coming into existence and people have loosened the ties with others. So, if a child believes in his or her dreams or opinions, they are more confident to fight against even the forces of love, like parents. Earlier, it was assumed whatever the parents thought off is correct. So, there was no question of conflict.

HOUSEWORK

- **Do you like doing housework?**

Option 1: Yes, I'm really into helping to do some housework if I have time because I find it can help me let off steam. I sometimes go shopping for groceries, mop the floor and clean the bathroom with my family during the weekends to make my home more comfortable.

Option 2: Housework is something I don't do out of love for the work but for my family members. It is a way of showing to them that I am responsible as well for matters of family. More are the number of people helping towards housework; less is the burden on a single individual.

Option 3: I have to admit I hardly do any housework, although I usually try and help out after meals by washing the dishes and tidying up the kitchen. My mother usually takes care of most of the household tasks and she has a helper for the heavy cleaning and things like that.

- **How do you think housework could be made more interesting?**

Option 1: I guess you should find the changes between before and after housework, then you will be motivated to do the chore to make the home better.

Option 2: The best way to make housework interesting would be to involve a lot of members. If only a certain set of people always do the work, it creates a lot of irritation or dissatisfaction among individuals. Making housework as a chore that everyone does for the place they live in, will make it more interesting and strengthen the bond among family members.

Option 3: That's a good question. I guess um... it could be made into a game, I suppose, for example have a competition with your friend to see who can, like, clean a room the fastest. That could possibly make it a bit more interesting and exciting. What else? Uh let me see... that's all I can really think of, I'm afraid – just make some game out of it!

- **What kind of household work do you often do?**

I generally help with laying the table, washing the car and buying grocery. Additionally, I also drop and pick my younger sister from school while helping her with her studies. Also, sometimes when a lot of guests came in together, we would help our mother in hosting the guests.

- **Are there any specific tasks you dislike doing around the house? Why?**

Yes, I hate having to clean my room, but I have to do it every now and then. I don't mind organizing my things but I prefer if someone else does the actual cleaning.

- **Did your parents ask you do any housework when you were a child? = When you were a child, did you help with work around the house?**

Option 1: Yeah they did. Mainly it was, like, tidying my room, cos it was always quite messy. Yeah, that was the main thing. And uh, what else? Oh yeah, sometimes they would ask me to help with the washing up, but that was pretty much it. So I guess I'm kind of lucky, in that my mum did most of the housework

Option 2: No, on the whole, they didn't because they wanted me to focus on my homework. Occasionally, I did do a little bit to help, like sweeping or mopping the floor, if there was a lot to be done, but by and large, I escaped doing most of the household chores, so I was pretty lucky I suppose!

Option 3: I used to help my mother in the kitchen quite often but that was about it really. As long as I can remember our family has always had a helper to do most of the cleaning and laundry and other jobs like that. So there wasn't much that I was asked to do around the house, but I used to enjoy helping my mother cooking and baking in the kitchen.

- **Do you think children should do some housework?**

Yes, I feel that doing some housework can cultivate my hands-on abilities, and sense of achievement as well. I remember that when I was a little boy, I was often told to take out the garbage, wash the dishes and go out to buy some flavors. Therefore, I strongly recommend that children should take part in the daily household work.

- **Which do you think is better for doing housework, a machine or a person?**

If I were to choose between the two, I'll probably go with machines because they can do housework better and more efficiently, for example, people are using machines to mop the floor, wash dishes and mow the lawn, whereas, you know, doing these housework by hands is really time consuming.

- **In the future, do you think machines will replace humans for doing housework?**

I guess in the age of fast living and a culture of convenience, a machine can really help a lot in doing housework, and do it better and more efficiently, like mopping the floor, washing dishes and mowing the lawn. But I don't think that machines will totally replace humans because there is still a lot of housework that are suitable for humans like cooking.

TREE

- **Do you like trees?**

Yes, I am a tree lover because trees let me breathe better, without them I couldn't survive any longer.

- **Are there any important trees in your country?**

There are many important trees in my country. The use of bamboo, for example, can be ranged from furniture making to building construction. Besides, the weeping willow trees symbolize the new hope in ancient China, therefore, there are many poem complimenting them.

- **Is there a forest near your hometown?**

Yes. It's just the world-renowned Huangshan Mountain with various kinds of trees living there, the most famous one are pine trees.

- **Would you like to live in a place that has a lot of trees?**

Yes, I'm really into getting close to nature cause I believe it's the most healthy and natural way of living. Although it's unreasonable to have such lifestyle in Beijing now, I still hold that dream in my life.

- **Where can one find trees (or forests) in your country?**

I guess trees can be easily seen in my country. If you are in cities, there are always many sycamore trees along the streets; or if you are in the suburb areas, you will see forests in various sizes.

- **Do you think places with trees attract more visitors than places with few trees?**

Well, yes. Obviously places with lots of trees are shadier, cooler, more humid and much less windy; therefore, people will feel more comfortable and more likely to get close to nature.

- **Did you ever climb trees when you were a child?**

Yes, of course. There are many trees in my community when I was a kid; I always climbed trees to get higher or to seek the birds' eggs.

- **Have you ever planted a tree?**

Yes, once. I remembered when my middle school once organized hiking in a mountainous area, we planted several saplings in the forest, and I guess they have grown up into big trees already.

- **Do you think more people should plant trees?**

Yes, I believe more trees should be planted both in and outside the cities because they can absorb the pollutant gases and provide enough oxygen; besides, tree can save water and prevent soil erosion. Therefore, trees are critically important to keep our eco-system balanced. We are supposed to not only plant more trees, but protect the existing ones.

- **Do you think trees are important? What are their benefits?**

Certainly, trees are vital. As the biggest plants on the planet, they give us oxygen, store carbon, stabilize the soil and give life to the world's wildlife. They also provide us with the materials for tools and shelter. Trees also help prevent flooding and soil erosion, absorbing thousands of liters of storm water.

- **Do you think we need to protect trees?**

Yes, I do believe that we need to care about trees, now more than ever because we would be in real trouble without our trees and forests. If we want to stand a chance against climate change and ensure the possibility of a bright future, we have to stand up for our forests.

PAINTING

- **Can you paint?**

I am a novice painter. So, yes I can paint, little bit here and there but not very well.

- **Do you like painting?**

Yes, I do love paintings. I think that paintings can help one to express things better. So, instead of 10000 words hanging on my wall, I will prefer a painting of something on my wall.

- **What kind of paintings do people like?**

In my opinion, people love hanging landscape paintings at home. Bringing in the beauty of Mother Nature somehow ease people's mind after a long day at work. Another style of drawing that most people also like is portrait. It could be portraits of someone important to them or even their lovely pets.

- **Have you ever sold one of your paintings?**

No, not yet. I think there is so much that I need to learn before I could start selling my paintings.

- **Are you impressed with people who know how to paint?**

Yes, too an extent. It is always great to meet people who know a form of art.

- **Do you like to watch a person painting?**

Yes, it is so relaxing to watch someone paint. The painter is almost completely drowned in the painting and the way he or she uses brush and the colors, it is great to watch.

- **How much are you willing to pay for a beautiful painting?**

I think I can almost around 1000 for a beautiful painting but not more than that. I do love paintings but then I am not such a die heart fan of them that I go on and spend my entire salary on just one painting.

- **Do have paintings at home for decoration?**

Yes, I do have some painting at home, at entrance and then some in my bedroom and few in the hall. Every painting says something about the room and the person living in it. Like, the one that I have in the room is of a woman who is looking at the sky. It is something that I relate to, because it tells me that one should go ahead and follow his or her dreams.

- **If you could be given the talent to paint, what would you paint?**

Yes, I do have some painting at home, at entrance and then some in my bedroom and few in the hall. Every painting says something about the room and the person living in it. Like, the one that I have in my room is of a woman who is looking at the sky. It is something that I relate to, because it tells me that one should go ahead and follow his or her dreams.

- **How do the colors make you feel?**

Colors make me feel alive. There is so much to express with colors. Red, blue, black, yellow, white. And then there are so many shades of these colors. You can express, love, anger, fight, happiness, sadness, excitement and so much more with just colors and it is all so much amazing.

- **Do you often visit art galleries?**

To tell you the truth, I have never visited art galleries before. Unless I have a guide to acknowledge me, art galleries would be quite boring for me.

- **What kind of things you may like to paint?**

Option 1: I like using colors to express myself. So, it is not like a home painting or a woman or something particular. It is just random colors thrown on the canvas, trying to figure out the sense of their existence.

Option 2: My main inspiration is Japanese manga. The drawing topic is extremely varied, however only manga seems to show great potency for my level. I have a big collection at home and as I sometimes go through it again, I can see how much I've improved.

- **Is it easy to learn how to paint?**

I think I must say it's even challenging for a lot of people. I absolutely failed when it comes to drawing still life paintings like fruit and flowers. I think for those who succeed in drawing or arts in general, they first must have God-gifted talent, then comes to the long-term commitment to arts that requires extreme practice and high patience.

- **What benefits can you get from painting as a hobby?**

I think the meditation efficiency worth's mentioning first. Colors in some ways reflect our thoughts and emotions very well and somehow stimulate our body to defense against our negativity inside. For me, in particular, I think what's so interesting about painting is that you have no idea how harmonized colors can become until you actually try.

BIRD

- **How do you feel about birds?**

Well, I take a very keen interest in nature, so I love to learn about different species of plants, animal kingdom, and yes, birds. They are truly fascinating creatures and they come in all shapes and sizes. Bird watching is one of my favorite things to do.

- **Have you seen many kinds of birds?**

Well, living in the city, birds are a rare sight. Most of the stuff about birds that I've seen is on documentaries of the great outdoors. I mean, I've seen some common breeds in real life like pigeons and such, but nothing too exotic.

- **How do Vietnamese feel about birds?**

Overall, they are not very into birds. Only elderly people are fond of keeping birds. Most of people only like to eat them especially game birds like pheasants. People in remote areas often hunt for birds in the wild and roast them over an open fire. They are considered a delicacy where I come from.

- **Are there birds near your home?**

You know, I haven't spotted any in my neighborhood. You're more likely to find them in zoos, national parks or in the countryside. Also, a lot of barbershops in Hanoi have bird cages. Not sure why that is.

- **Have you seen many different kinds of birds?**

I have only seen a few, I am not much of a bird watcher. The ones I have seen are pretty common, like pigeons and sparrows. I haven't sighted any exotic breeds.

LANGUAGES

- **Do you like learning languages?**

Yes, I do like learning languages. I like English as a second language more than my native tongue and spend a lot of time practicing on it. I have also started to learn French recently.

- **How did you learn the languages that you know?**

Option 1: I think the most effective way to learn a language is to practice more with a native speaker. By doing this, you can improve both listening and oral skills simultaneously; you will be fluent in this language. Besides, I also do general readings in my spare time and keep a journal in English.

Option 2: I think the best way to learn a language is through interaction with a native speaker. By doing this, one can improve their oral as well listening skills. Apart from this, I also read the regional language in my spare time.

- **Why do people learn more than one language?**

Option 1: I think people learn as many languages as they can because language is a necessary tool to have conversations with foreign people and learn their cultures. Understanding many languages helps us to open the door of many more opportunities in this world.

Option 2: I think people learn more and more language because language is a necessary tool to interact with foreign people and learn their culture. Understanding many languages opens doors for many opportunities in the world.

- **Do you think that all children should learn foreign languages at school?**

Yes, I think that kids are better at learning a second or more foreign language at school. They learn things fast at a young age, and I'm certain that a mastery of other languages pays well for kids when they go into the adult world in the future.

- **Do you think that English is difficult to learn?**

I think it is not only English. It is really hard to really master a language and learn all the cultural and social meanings in the conversation or messages. And every language has their own language pattern. I think most language learners can grasp the key structure and vocabulary but it takes time and a lot of effort to really master it.

- **Do you think learning languages is important?**

I think not only me but English has surely become an important language for communication. With globalization taking place at such an incredible speed, to be able to interact with others, English has become an essential language. In my case, I am a blogger. So, I want more and more people to be able to understand what I am trying to tell.

- **How long have you been learning English?**

Option 1: I have studied in an English medium school since my childhood. So, I guess it has been now 18 years that I have learnt and read English.

Option 2: I have studied in a regional school where the books were in regional language. But, English was still taught to us. So, technically I have been learning English for past 18 years but the thorough understanding of English has come to me only while preparing for IELTS.

DANCE

- **What kind of dance is popular in Vietnam?**

Well, actually, I don't have much knowledge about dance, and in general Vietnamese people don't dance, at least I don't know anyone in my acquaintance who dances. So I'm afraid I have no idea about the answer of this question.

- **Do you like dancing? (Why? /Why not?)**

Option 1: No, because first of all never did I dance before, so I don't know how to dance. Then secondly, I'm introverted and dancing is sort of showing yourself, so I don't think it complies with my character.

Option 2: Well, I love to dance but I'm not much of a dancer to be honest. When I dance I find myself thinking too much about the steps instead of just feeling the music, rhythmic movements and let the body take control.

- **Do you like to watch others dance?**

I do love watching people dance because when they dance, they look like they are really enjoying themselves and having a good time. I can feel their energy and appreciation for life

when they let their body move to the music. Somehow it makes me feel rejuvenated and inspired.

- **In the future, would you like to learn dancing?**

I don't really know about this. I used to have much more time for things like ballroom dancing lessons back when I was a student but now I'm pretty caught up in my work. But who knows, maybe when I can manage to set some time aside for myself I will take up dancing again.

- **Do you think there are any advantages for young people (children) to go dancing?**

Well, since there isn't anything that is thoroughly bad, so I believe there must be some benefit for young people to learn dance, because at least they could doing it like an exercise.

COOKING

- **Can you cook?**

Option 1: Yes, I'm confident to say that I'm quite a good cook. I often cook traditional Vietnamese dishes for my family and friends, and they really like my masterpieces. Sometimes, I learn how to cook foreign dishes by following some recipes in the Internet and watch clips on YouTube, and it turns out really good.

Option 2: I would say, I am just fine at cooking. I can surely cook food for myself or two other people but not for a huge bunch of people. Neither do I know how to cook the great delicacies that my mother can cook.

- **Do you often do any cooking?**

Option 1: Normally I don't frequently cook at home on weekdays because I have no time. But on weekends, I usually cook food at home for my family.

Option 2: I am working woman and currently living with a friend in a new city. Initially we did not cooked, but now we are cooking daily.

- **Do you like cooking? (Why?/Why not?)**

Yes, I'm quite into cooking because I believe that good dinner could guarantee our health and also I'm a foodie, I'd like to taste all kinds of tasty food. I always do some cooking in my home with my family during the weekend to enjoy the family time.

- **Do you think children should help their parents prepare meals?**

I remember when I was a little boy, I was used to help wash the vegetables, go out to buy some flavors, etc. I strongly recommend that children should take part in this kind of housework

because it can help cultivate the hands-on abilities, a sense of achievement and even learn some table manners.

- **Who taught you how to cook?**

My mother was a great teacher who often showed me step by step how to cook a traditional Vietnamese dish. I've learnt a lot of cooking skills/techniques from her. Besides, as I've just mentioned, I sometimes follow recipes from the Internet or learn from well-known chefs like Gordon Ramsay.

- **Is it important for husbands to know how to cook?**

I think yes. It takes away the monarchy of woman in the kitchen. Even more, it strengthens the bond between the husband and wife. A woman when eats the food made by husband would definitely love him more. Because, it shows that the man treats her equally and respects her.

BOAT

- **Do you prefer to travel by boat or ship?**

Well, to be honest, I have never thought about it before, but if I have to choose, I will go with traveling by boat. Although I've heard people saying that boat are dangerously lighting fast, this is the aspect I like about boating. I tried it once some years ago and that was one of the most fascinating experiences I have ever had in my life. It's also cheaper than travelling by ship, though.

- **How often you may go boating?**

Seldomly, actually. Since I'm a university student living in a big city like Ho Chi Minh City and I am too busy with my study, I hardly have any change to go for a boat trip. Fortunately, my uncle, who lives in coastal area, the middle of my country, is a boat owner, so I can enjoy boat journeys whenever I to visit him.

- **In your country do people use boats?**

Yes, there are all kinds of boats, for personal use and commercial use. They're very common on the coast.

- **What have you ever done by boat?**

I once travel by boat to my grandma's home along Yangzi River and that was the only time I travel by boat because it cost me for more than 3 days, and the food there was nothing but delicious and I had no alternative but to survive on a diet of instant noodles.

- **What do they use boats for?**

Lots of businesses use boats, or ships, to transport their goods to other countries and I have several friends whose families have small boats for using in their leisure time, mainly at weekends, they go fishing or diving or sometimes just to sail around the coast and visit one of the many fishing villages that you can find.

- **Would you like to own a boat?**

Yes, one day in the future maybe. It's a great way to relax and see something different and it's nice and healthy being out on the water for an afternoon.

- **What would you do with a boat?**

I think I'd do the same as most people here, go fishing and diving, take my friends along with me, maybe take some food and drink with us and have a picnic or sail round the coast and explore a bit.

- **Would you shop online or in a store for a boat?**

I'd probably do some research online first, you know, about different models and specifications, and then go to a dealer and actually look at any boat that I was interested in. Obviously I'd want to take it for a test drive and make sure that I like it before buying it. If I found a boat I liked and wanted to buy then I would try to find it at the best price so maybe I'd buy it online or maybe from a local boat dealer depending on the best price I could get.

NUMBER

- **Do you have a favorite or lucky number?**

Yes, my favorite number is... because it's the day I was born on, and it's my lucky number.

- **Do any numbers have special importance in your country?**

Yes. The number 7, for example, is supposed to be a special number in my country. It appears in so many places, like the seven days of the week, the seven main notes in music, and the seven ages of man that Shakespeare described.

- **Are you good at math?**

No, I'm not very good at remembering numbers. I don't think it's necessary to learn them by heart; I just save them on my phone.

- **What numbers do people often have to memories?**

The most important number to remember on a daily basis is the pin number for your bank card. Without this you can't pay for anything or get cash out.

FLAT OR HOUSE

- **Where do young guys usually live in Vietnam, in flats or houses?**

The vast majority of young guys in Vietnam live in flats, but it depends on their incomes. If they are terribly posh, they can definitely afford those luxurious houses; but to common people, houses are something they can't afford.

- **What are the differences between flats and houses?**

There are so many differences between flats and houses. For starters, as far as the definition is concerned, a house is a building which usually has more than one floor and is intended to be used by one family. It normally has a garden, a swimming pool and a garage. A flat is a place for people to live that consists of a set of rooms that are part of a larger building. Another difference is that the houses are normally much more expensive than flats, which explains why most of people are living in flats rather than houses today.

- **What can you see from the windows of your flat?**

My flat is on the 30th floor, which offers me a panoramic view of the whole community: the fountains, statues, trees, flowers and green grass. And when night falls, with all the lights on, the view is breathtaking!

- **What color would you like to paint your flat? Explain why (for girls only)**

Well, it has always been my dream to paint my flat blue, the sky blue. And it would be great if I could paint some white houses with blue domes on the walls. It will definitely remind me of Santorini in Greece, so dreamy and fancy! Besides blue, I am thinking that pink might come out great as well. You know, pink is the every girl's fantasy. Barbie pink, so girly, so fancy...It will give me a feeling that I am living in a fairyland.

- **What can you see on the walls of your flat?**

There are some enlarged photos of my family and me on the living room walls; and some huge posters of my idols Jude Law and Lindsay Lohan on my bedroom walls; besides, quite a few delicate paintings on the dining room walls. Photos can always remind me of the unforgettable experiences that I had before. And paintings totally liven up my rooms.

- **Why do Vietnamese love to hang paintings on the walls of their flats?**

I guess paintings can liven up rooms, put people in a good mood and most importantly, they can show good taste that owners have in arts.

- **Can you give me a simple introduction of the layout of your flat?**

Well, my flat is a south facing 30th floor unit which has a living room, three bedrooms, a dining room, a kitchen and a utility room. The bedroom has a huge bathtub and a dress room. The north south layout and the balcony provide good natural light, ventilation and a panoramic view of the community. My flat is furnished and decorated in a fancy style: European style furniture, huge French doors, crystal chandeliers, fancy wallpaper, delicate paintings and beautiful flowers.

- **Which room do you love most in your flat?**

Option 1: I love my balcony most. There are some oversized armchairs and an umbrella table out there. It is exactly what I love about it. When it comes to a sunny afternoon, I love to sit on the balcony, soaking up the sun, enjoy the fantastic view, listening to the music, sipping a cup of tea while having some finger snacks. It is super nice.

Option 2: I would say my favorite room is probably my living room, firstly because that's where the TV is, and secondly because it's got big floor to ceiling windows which overlook the river, so we have a really cool view. Oh and one more thing to mention would be that it's by far the most spacious room in the flat, because all the other rooms are about half the size, if not less.

- **How is that room decorated?**

Well, regarding the walls, we've got a few family pictures hanging up, which gives the room a nice personal feel. And as for the flooring, we basically just decided to use ceramic tiles, because they're very practical in terms of keeping clean, but we've also put a small carpet down by the sofa to make that area a little bit cozier. So all in all I'd say it's a really nice room for chilling out in.

- **What furniture is in that room?**

Well, on one side there's a big bookshelf, which basically stretches across the entire wall, coz we've got a lot of books! Then against another wall, we've got a nice big sofa, which probably seats about 8 or 9 people, so it's great for when we have friends over.

OR: What do you like most about your home? Well, probably what I like most about my home is that we have a really great river view, because we live quite high up, on the 20th floor, and our flat is right next to the river. So I feel really lucky to have such a nice view, and I never get tired of it.

- **Is there anything you would like to change about your home?**

Thinking about it, I'd say there probably is, yeah, for example one thing I would quite like to do is knock down the wall between my kitchen and the living room, because at the moment,

there's not much space in the kitchen, so if we got rid of the wall, it would make everything much more spacious, I think.

- **Is there anything that needs to be improved in your flat?**

Truth to be told, I am quite satisfied with my flat right now. Although it is not huge or posh, it is cozy and warm. It can give me a sense of belonging, which I think is what a home is for.

OR: Well, I kind of like my home the way it is, but I guess if I had to change anything, then one thing I might do would be to get rid of the wall between my living room and kitchen, as it would then make things a lot more spacious.

- **How long have you been living in your flat?**

It has been over ten years since I lived here. I experienced a lot while I lived here. My flat now is of great sentimental value to me.

- **Do you want to move?**

Option 1: Frankly, I want to move because I have been dreaming about moving to a new flat. But psychologically, I don't feel like moving out because I experienced a lot while I lived here. The whole place is of great sentimental value to me.

Option 2: Do you like the area where you live? Yeah, on the whole I'd say it's a pretty nice place, you know, there are quite a few good restaurants and shops, and most of the buildings are pretty new. So it's quite an up-and-coming area, and I'm really happy to be living there.

- **Are you planning to buy a house now?**

No. Actually, I had been planning to buy a house for quite a while. Unfortunately, the dream has drifted away because of the ever soaring house prices in HCM city. Right now, I guess a house is nothing but a dream for me.

- **What do you think the houses would be like in the future?**

Option 1: I think they would be intelligent, multifunctional and human based. Preferably, with huge French doors, a fantastic sea view and a beautiful garden.

Option 2: In the future, what sort of home (flat, house etc.) would you like to live in? Well, thinking about it, I'd say I would like to live in a villa overlooking the sea, the main reason being that, with a villa, I would get my own garden, which wouldn't be the case if I lived in a flat, and I think having a nice view of the sea would be great for helping me relax whenever I needed to.

- **What do you think of hiring a housekeeper to do all the housework?**

It is a good thing. Most of the white-collar guys are pretty busy with their work and have no time or energy to do the housework. After a whole day's work, the only thing in their minds is

to drag themselves home, grab something to eat and get some sleep; so hiring a housekeeper can absolutely relieve the people of the tiring household chores. On the other hand, housekeepers, as an occupation, can alleviate the huge employment pressure. It is a win win situation.

- **How is your relationship with your neighbors?**

We are really close. You know, it has been almost ten years since we were neighbors. We know each other quite well and we often have a small get together once every two or three weeks. The saying that a near neighbor is better than a distant cousin is totally true. We can always have a blast when we hang out.

CELEBRITY

- **Who is your favorite celebrity in Vietnam?**

Off the top of my head, I guess I would have to say it's X. I'm not sure if you've heard of him, but he's the founder of Y, and one of the most successful businessmen in the country. And I basically admire him for everything that he's achieved, especially as I think he had to deal with a lot of rejection early on in his career. So yeah, I'd say he's probably my favorite celebrity here in Vietnam.

- **Would you want to be a celebrity in the future?**

I don't know actually, because obviously it would be nice to be adored everywhere you go, and have lots of VIP treatment travelling around the world. That would be quite nice! But I think there would be a lot of downsides as well, for example lack of privacy, the paparazzi. So I think all things considered, I probably wouldn't want to be a celebrity.

- **Do you like reading about celebrities?**

Yeah I do, but it also depends on the content, because I mean, pointless stuff about what they get up into their private life doesn't really interest me that much. But what does interest me is reading about how they became good at what they do, because I think there's a lot that can be learnt from them.

- **Have you ever met a celebrity?**

Um...I don't actually think I have. It would be nice to, but up to now I can't say that I've had the pleasure of meeting any! I mean, I've been to a few pop concerts and seen some famous singers perform, but I don't think it really counts, as I've never actually met a celebrity up close or shaken their hand or anything.

- **Do you think we should protect famous people's privacy?**

Yeah, without a doubt, cos I think privacy is something that everyone should have, regardless of who they are. So just because someone's famous, I don't think that gives us the right to go intruding into their private life!

- **How do celebrities influence their fans in Vietnam?**

I'm not really that sure to be honest with you – I've never really thought about it! But I suppose one aspect could be the clothes they wear, you know, that's probably likely to influence their fans choice of clothes to some extent. And uh... what else? Um.. oh yeah, I guess their general behavior may also have some kind of influence on their fans. So for example, if a celebrity conducts himself well, then it's probably gonna rub off on his fans and have a positive effect on them, and vice versa.

TEACHER

- **Do you have a favorite teacher?**

Um... Yeah, I suppose I do, but it's actually kind of hard to pick out a favorite because I've been really lucky with all my teachers. You know, they've been really great, at least most of them anyway, but I guess my favorite teacher would have to be my English language teacher, because she was incredible. I mean, the amount of effort she put into her teaching, and her attention to detail, were just amazing. And not only that, but she also showed a genuine care for all of us, which left a really deep impression on me. So yeah, out of all my teachers, I'd say she was probably my favorite.

- **What kinds of teachers do you like?**

I guess.... um...first of all, teachers who are passionate about their subject, because you know, if they show enthusiasm for what they're teaching, I'm much more likely to get interested in that subject and do well in it. And as well as this, I also like teachers that are supportive and...what's the word....approachable. So in other words, teachers that show patience and understanding, and are there for you if you need help.

- **What are the qualities of a good teacher?**

Um.... I guess the best way to answer this would be to think of some of the good teachers I've had at school and university. So please hang on just a second while I have a quick think about it.....! Ok, well the good teachers I've had have shown a genuine care for their students. You know, they genuinely want their students to learn and develop. It's not just simply a job to them. So yeah I think that's the most important thing – taking their job seriously and really caring about their students' development.

- **Do you think teachers should be angry at students or not?**

No, I think as a general rule, teachers shouldn't get angry at students. You know, it never ends well when teachers get angry, at least in my experience! So in my view, I think teachers should always control their temper, whatever the situation, and instead use other means to get their point across. I mean, I'm sure you've experienced it before, that when a teacher gets angry, the whole atmosphere in the class changes, to one of fear, which is definitely not conducive to learning.

- **Do you like strict teachers?**

Yeah I do. I have no problem with them at all, as long as they're fair! Because I think, on the whole, they tend to set high standards, and so consequently, that makes us work harder and learn more. And the other good thing about strict teachers is that they keep students in line, which means that the class won't be interrupted by slackers who just want to joke around and be a nuisance.

- **What's the difference between young and old teachers?**

There's probably not all that much difference actually, but I guess the main one would be the level of experience. You know, I think it's fair to say that old teachers tend to have more experience than young ones, and so they'll be more skilled at adapting to any kind of situation that might arise in class, whereas young teachers might struggle.

So that's one difference, and I suppose another might be the use of technology, cos probably a lot of old teachers might stick to the traditional teaching methods they're familiar with, whereas young teachers, I think, are more likely to bring technology into their teaching, such as using iPads and laptops in class. So yeah, I'd say these are probably the main differences.

PHOTOGRAPHY

- **Do you like to take photographs? (Why?)**

Although I'm not a big fan of photography, I do enjoy taking beautiful and vivid pictures in my spare time. Whenever I travel to a new place, I always take my camera with me to capture stunning natural scenery. I also believe that photography is a kind of art that will cultivate our mental development and broaden our horizons of the world.

- **Do you prefer to take photos yourself or to have other people take photos? (Why?)**

I prefer to go with taking photos of others rather than taking photos of myself. The main reason is I feel that different people have different characteristics, so the photos will be more distinguishing and unique. Also, to be honest, I barely take a selfie because I'm not very photogenic and it will make me embarrassed

- **In what situations do you take photographs?**

Normally, I'll probably go with the scenery to take photos because I really enjoy the marvelous natural scenery such as the seashore, sunset and twilight. Sometimes I also take many photographs to capture the precious moment in my life, such as the graduation ceremony, the sweet moment with my friends and family

- **Do you prefer to send postcards to people or to send photos that you took yourself? (Why?)**

Well, if I have to choose between the two, I'll probably go with my own photos because they are unique and seeing a lot of comments from my friends is really a pleasant thing. Meanwhile, postcards are not as meaningful as photos taken by me.

DREAM

- **Do you often dream at night?**

Option 1: Yes I do. I have quite vivid dreams about things that are going on in my life at the time I even have nightmares sometimes.

Option 2: I usually have dreams when I'm upset about something. I guess it's my subconscious trying to worry to work things out. But other than that, I don't often dream.

- **How long can you remember your dream when you wake up?**

Option 1: Not really long I guess, they're usually very vague and I only remember the odd thing or image. But I can never remember the entire dream as they are too abstract.

Option 2: Honestly, I have a memory like a sieve, so I usually keep a dream diary so that I can analyze them later.

- **Do you like hearing others dream?**

Option 1: Yes, I guess. A lot of people are haunted by their dream, and they really just need someone to talk to about it. Some are scared out of their mind if they see nightmares.

Option 2: To be honest, I am kind of a quite curious girl so if others would like to tell me about their dreams, I would always be willing to hear. But then I would also forget their stories quite quickly, as my memory is not so good.

- **Do you think dream will affect life?**

Option 1: Yeah, to a certain extent, I think. Some people are really affected by what they see in their dreams. If they see death or suffering, for example, they may interpret it as an omen,

and they often take some precautions like being extra careful on the road. So yeah, I guess dreams do influence our behaviors.

Option 2: I can't say for sure but you know, some believe that what happens in their dream has something to do with their real life. But to me personally, as I have mentioned before, I even could not recall my dreams, let alone figuring out their meaning or possible effects on my life.

- **Do you want to learn more about dreams?**

Well, it's not an area that I take a keen interest in, so I gotta say no. I'm sure dreams can reveal truly fascinating things about our brain and our cognition, but to be honest, I'm more of an art person, so I prefer to learn about music or culture rather than dreams.

- **Do you remember your dream when you wake up?**

Option 1: Well, I can say that I often forget my dreams in a few minutes after waking up, so sometimes I confuse that I do not dream at all. But, recently I have read an article on dreams and it says that we all dream every night, but the matter is these dreams are quickly erased from our memory and I also do not know why.

Option 2: Well, I have to say that it depends. You know, whenever I have a nightmare, I can easily remember my dreams but when I really have a deep sleep, it is not a piece of cake.

- **Do you want to know more about dreams?**

Yes, if I have a chance, I would not mind digging deeper into dreams. People tend to think that what happens in their dream predictions for their future, so I really would like to find out whether there is some truth in it.

COLOR

- **What are your favorite colors?**

My favorite colors are baby pink, emerald and black and white stripes. Different tones of pink can make my complexion look great. And I think black and white is always the classic match. It is the timeless chic. It is always hip!

- **Do you think the different colors can show the different personalities of different people?**

I think so. People who fancy warm colors like bright red, gold yellow, baby pink or burnt orange might be more enthusiastic, frisky and friendly; however, people who are addicted to cold colors like purple, green, brown or grey tend to be more serious, modest and sophisticated. Well, this is just a general idea; it varies from people to people.

- **What colors do Vietnamese people love? What do these colors mean to Vietnamese?**

Red is one of the colors loved by the Vietnamese people. The color red symbolizes celebration, happiness and good things. In the celebration of the Vietnamese New Year, holidays and gatherings, red is a must. Even in western countries, people call days when something special happened made them happy "red-letter days" and they say "roll out the red carpet" to welcome honored guests. And the color "yellow" was in ancient time the symbol of royal family, especially the emperor. Yellow symbolizes supreme power, the highest status and nobility.

LETTERS OR EMAILS

- **Do you write many letters or emails?**

Yes, I almost write a lot of emails for my clients as part of my job on a daily basis. There are many things I have to write, for example, I usually write end user training for my clients to teach them how to use the system, or I write the development guide for my technical staffs to tell them how to code.

- **Which do you prefer, to make a phone call or write an email?**

Well, if I were to choose between the two, I will probably go with writing an email because I can have plenty of time thinking about how to express my opinion correctly and clearly, besides, the whole conversation can be tracked in the mail list; whereas, you know, making a telephone call usually leads to misunderstanding because sometimes it is not very accurate and obscure.

- **Is it hard to think of what to write?**

That's a tough question! But I would say that it depends on what type of content you will write. If it's a personal letter I guess that it is just a piece of cake as you can be informal with your letter. On the other hand, if it's a business or school related emails it might be a little tough since you must meet certain standards and be formal in writing. So, it will still vary according to its purpose.

- **Do you think people will still write letter in the future?**

I believe that as a major method of communication between people, letter writing has a vast and interesting history; besides, handwritten letters are personal. They show the receiver that someone has spent time and effort in communicating with them. They are a way of connecting two people that cannot be achieved through the impersonal use of texts or instant messages.

Therefore, I feel that the handwriting letters are irreplaceable in the future.

- **Do you think writing emails has strengthened or a weakened person's writing skills?**

Option 1: In my opinion, writing emails has a positive effect on the writing skills of people. As we all know that email is one of the most frequently used modes of formal communication. Therefore, it's practically true that a person becomes more organized in his writing while compiling formal content.

Option 2: As far as I am concerned, communicating via email has a negative effect on the writing skills of people in many ways. Some applications like auto-correction and spelling checkers have dragged the level of English down, especially grammar and vocabulary. Rather than being aiding tools, they have sub standardized the level of writing skills.

- **How do you communicate with others at work – by email or is it more convenient to communicate face-to-face?**

Oh in most of the time, I prefer to talk in person. Even though Too many people take the easy way out and try and do everything via e-mail, I often find that when I look the other person in the eyes and ask them something I get far more than I ever would over e-mail.

Other possible questions:

- **What sorts of letters or emails are the most difficult to reply to?**
- **What kinds of emails (or letters) do you receive that make you feel excited?**

NEWS

- **Are you very interested in the news?**

Yes, I'm really fond of getting news from various sources because I just want to make myself better informed about the world

- **Why do you want to know the latest news?**

It's very important for me to know what happened in the domestic and international events.

- **What sort of news are you most interested in?**

I'm more interested in foreign cultures. I like to learn about their religions, customs, and the foods they eat. Occasionally, foreign news interests me, too. I really like reading scientific related news.

- **How do you usually find this news?**

Well, if I have free time at home, I'd like to watch the news and editorials in the TV with my family; whereas you know, it takes time for the newspaper to publish so the news are always not so updated.

- **Do you prefer to read newspaper or watch TV to get your news?**

Normally I read news from TV news programmes, which are very convenient and updated; but if I'm too busy to watch TV, I'll read news from the Internet in my mobile phone.

- **Do you ever get your news from the internet?**

Yes, it's very convenient for me to get news from internet such as mobile phone. The news apps usually send me the most urgent notifications to me so it keeps me posted.

- **What sections of the newspaper do you usually read?**

I always read news in the politics section because I'm interested in political events happened in the domestic and abroad.

- **Do you think newspaper is important?**

Option 1: Yes, newspapers are very important in current society because they are still the most important medium for understanding the world. They deliver the most urgent and valuable news to the audience so that readers can know what happens in the current world.

Option 2: I believe news is very critically important because without regular access to news, most people would be unaware of the various events taking place, both locally and around the world, that have an impact on their lives.

- **Besides newspaper, what are some other ways people get news?**

Well, besides newspapers, people can get news by many other sources, such as TV programmes, radio, and Internet, which can all cater for the different kinds of people.

- **How important do you think it is more important, domestic news or international?**

I'm more interested in foreign cultures. I like to learn about their religions, customs, and the foods they eat. Occasionally, foreign news interests me, too. I really like reading scientific related news.

TEAMWORK

- **Do you like teamwork? [Why? / Why not?]**

Yes, I do. I think it is more interesting when various people work together in a team. You can learn a lot more because different people have different knowledge and also experience. Especially when the people come from different countries around the world - it can make it very interesting - because they think in a different way.

- **When was the last time you worked with a team?**

I worked on a team in my last position, 3 months ago I guess. In my previous retail position, we were split into teams by department to work Black Friday and each department would compete to achieve the highest sales. My team and I made an action plan to have each person cover a specific area so that no customer would be an oversight and go without assistance.

- **Do you like to work or study with others or just by yourself?**

That's a tough question... I like the combination of the two. It's great working in teams while getting and sharing ideas with each other, but it's also nice to sit at your desk and work hard productively. I like to do both so it's hard to choose one over the other.

- **What's the most important thing for teamwork?**

To my mind, the key point for a successful teamwork is listening. When members of a team learn and practice a few simple listening techniques. I think This happens because team members will feel that their ideas are being heard and coworkers also need to feel free to share their ideas.

- **Do you like to be a leader?**

Being a team leader instills a sense of purpose and accomplishment in people, myself included. I love having a team that I can help to guide and I also get joy out of developing them and watching them grow. I've been fortunate to have a list of great bosses who have invested a lot of time, money, and energy in me, and I like the prospect of paying it forward.

- **Do you think teamwork is important?**

Yeah, I'd say it's extremely important, because I mean so much of what we do in life involves working together with others. And not only that, but I think it's also true to say that what we can achieve with others is so much more than what we can achieve individually. And so I'd say this goes to show just how essential it is to have good teamwork skills.

TEXT MESSAGES

- **Do you text someone if he doesn't answer your phone?**

Well, it completely depends on the scenario and the rapport you share with the concerned person. If the one you are calling is not answering, they might be busy somewhere or stuck in something, you can always follow your unanswered call with a message stating let me know whenever you are free, or call me back whenever you are free.

- **Is there any chance when texting someone is better than calling him?**

I believe when the person answering the phone is having a conference or in a cinema, it's better to text him instead of having a telephone call. Plus, if the person needs to have a conversation with someone but find his day jam-packed for a phone call, texting is the way to go.

- **Have you ever had difficulty replying?**

Yes, I remember when I have to refuse some requests of friends; I have to think carefully about how to reply for a long time.

- **How often do you send text message?**

I almost send text messages on a daily basis. I always text my friends and family to greet, chat and make a travelling plan.

PLANT AND FLOWERS

- **Do you like flowers?**

Yes, I do like flowers. As an introvert, sometimes, I find myself feeling peaceful and relaxed while enjoying nice flowers in my garden. I have a habit of taking pictures of flowers after the rain. I feel most at peace spending chunks of good time on my own, in relative silence, contemplating the beauty of flowers with raindrops through my camera lens.

- **What kind of flower do you like?**

White roses are truly my favorite flower. They are traditionally associated with marriages and new beginnings. However, their beauty has also made them a gesture of remembrance. Therefore, a bouquet of white rose is a perfect way to say "I'm thinking of you".

- **Do flowers have any special meanings when they are put in different locations in your country?**

For an introvert like me, enjoying the harmonization of various types of flowers with different gorgeous colors in the garden or in florist shops could brighten up my days and lift my spirits. Do people in your country ever use flowers for special occasions?

Flowers are widely used in many occasions and festivals in our country to represent for a blessing, happiness and good luck. Most families have at least one kind of plants or flowers at home.

- **What are the occasions when people give or receive flowers?**

A bunch of flowers is considered as a gift for a wide range of occasions for both people to send and receive flowers. For example, in a birthday party, Women's day, or Valentine's day, colorful flowers are arranged nicely in a small vase and given to each other.

- **When was the last time you gave flowers to someone?**

It was a couple of weeks ago when I bought a bouquet of flowers as a present for my mom. She was deliriously happy when receiving it and put it in the sitting room so that everyone in my family can admire its beauty too.

WORK OR STUDIES

- **Is that a very popular subject to study in your country?**

Option 2: Yeah, I suppose it is quite a popular subject to study, and one of the reasons for this would probably be that a lot of students feel that this major will be useful in helping them find a good job after they graduate.

Option 1: I guess I probably wouldn't say so, no, mainly because it's a relatively new major in Vietnam, and as far as I know, there are not that many universities in Vietnam which offer this course.

- **Is your subject very challenging (or difficult) to study?**

Option 1: Yeah, I'd say it is quite challenging, mainly because of the huge workload we get. So for example, we're given a considerable amount of coursework to do, which always requires a ton of background reading!

Option 2: Actually, I wouldn't really say so, partly because we're not given that much work to do, and also because it's essentially not that complex (a subject), so everything's relatively easy to understand.

- **What do you do when you have a difficulty with your studies?**

I guess I normally either ask a course mate for help or go on the internet to try and solve the problem myself. And if I'm still stuck, then I'll go and ask my lecturer for help, but this would be as a last resort, as I don't really like to bother my lecturers unless I really need to.

- **How did you learn science at school?**

Well, we mainly just went through the textbook and took notes, so it was pretty similar to other subjects. Though saying that, we occasionally did some experiments, which were quite fun, but unfortunately those classes were pretty few and far between.

- **Why did you choose ...as your major?**

Basically it was due to the fact that my parents thought it was a useful major which would stand me in good stead after I graduate. Personally I'm not so sure, but seeing as I couldn't think of anything better, I went with my parents' decision.

- **What do you like about your major?**

That's a good question, and I guess basically the thing I find most enjoyable about my major is analyzing case studies of various international companies operating in Vietnam, because for me, stories are the best way to learn things. And as well as this, I also like the fact that our lectures are quite interactive, because we are encouraged to ask questions instead of just sitting and making notes, and this tends to make the lectures much more interesting.

- **What's more important when studying the student or teacher?**

Well it's really hard to say, because obviously both play an important role, but I guess I'd say the student is probably more important because generally speaking, most studying is done out of the classroom at least that's the way I see it!

MUSIC

- **What kind of natural sound do you love to listen to? And explain why.**

I love to listen to birds chirping, leaves rustling, rain falling onto the ground, waves lapping over the beach and streams gurgling down in the valley. They are the real sound of nature. The beauty is indescribable.

- **Do you love listening to music?**

Absolutely, I am a big fan of music. Music can always weave its magic to give people different feelings. And people say that music speaks international languages. I think it is totally true. Say, people from different countries can all appreciate the same music.

- **What kinds of music do you love listening to?**

I love so many kinds of music, such as R&B, soul, new age, reggae and blues. Among all these kinds of music, I love R&B most. When R&B singers sing, they perform with all their heart and soul. And I can feel overwhelming emotions coming out from their voice.

- **Where and when do you usually listen to music?**

Actually, I always take my iPod with me, so basically, I can listen to music anywhere and anytime I want. The MP3 has been such a blessing! Thanks to the inventor of the MP3, my music world is awesome!

- **Where would you prefer to listen to music, at home or in the concert hall?**

I prefer to listen to music in the concert hall because I can get the incomparable audio and visual enjoyment. It is something that listening to music at home can never hold a candle to. The atmosphere is overwhelmingly amazing!

- **Which way would you prefer to listen to music, MP3 or HiFi ?**

I prefer MP3. The biggest selling point of it is "portable" and "compact". And I can listen to music anywhere and anytime I want. HiFi does have the unparalleled sound effect, but it only works at home. There is no way for me to take a HiFi with me when I am out.

- **Do you play any instrument? And what is it?**

Actually, I am not a big fan of instruments. I enjoy listening to music, but performing instruments is not my strong suit. I did learn to play the piano for a couple of months when I was little, but I ended up quitting. I think this whole hobby thing requires music talent, which I definitely don't have.

- **How do you feel about the phenomenon that parents in Vietnam are always forcing their kids to learn all kinds of instruments?**

First, it is quite understandable that parents want their kids to have the edge over other kids, so they would do whatever it takes to discover their kids' hidden talents. Learning instruments is one of them. But here is the question: Do their kids really love it? Do they really want to learn it? If the answer is a "no", parents really shouldn't force their kids to learn it anymore. Cramming lots of skills into innocent kids is miserable! I think kids should have a carefree and lighthearted childhood. And of course if kids love it, it can spice up their lives, cultivate their temperaments and aesthetic judgment. And it can also make their kids have the edge over their peers.

- **How do you feel about those kids who know how to play lots of instruments?**

I think they are quite talented, versatile and arty, I mean arty in a good way.

- **Do you think it's important to give music classes in the school?**

Yes, of course. I certainly believe that music if taught as a subject can improve the performance of students not only in Music but also in some of the academic subjects. It helps them relax and they may develop a taste for music.

NATURAL PLACES

- **Do you have like visiting natural places?**

Yes, I am fond of getting close to the nature. Once I am free, I'd like to visit one of the forest parks around Beijing. These places are not only really perfect for physical activities, but also can help me let off steam.

- **What are some well-known natural attractions in your country?**

There are so many natural attractions in my country, for example, the best one, in my opinion, is the Huangshan Mountain, which earns a high reputation for its magnificent natural scenery. Besides, I travel to the Inner Mongolian grasslands every year to see the vast grassland as well as the blue sky and the white cloud which can be rarely seen in Beijing.

- **Have you ever gone camping?**

Yes, just once, but really memorable. I went to the Liangshan Mountain with my friends and my son early this year. We slept in the forest in the camps at night. It was totally dark outside, but we sang the songs loudly with others and heard the sound of rain dropping on my camp gently. It was really an interesting experience.

- **How do city kids in your country have contact with nature?**

Cities in China usually have many parks in them so that children can visit with their parents. Most of these parks have plenty of trees, meadow, rockery and even lakes, which are good enough for children to get close to nature. Besides, on holidays, children will have opportunities to go for an outing to some natural scenery.

- **What are the benefits of learning about nature?**

People can definitely benefit a lot from nature. Apart from the physical fitness, people can loose up in the natural environment and inspire their love to life. As for children, I believe getting close to nature can cultivate their natural motivations to investigation and discovery the world around them based on their interests

NEARBY SHOP AND MARKET

- **Are there any shops near where you live?**

Yes, there are two small shops near my home. Though they are not very big, but I can still always get what I need in them.

- **Do you think it is important to have shops near people's homes?**

Yes, definitely. It would be very convenient to buy something needed for household if there are shops near people's homes.

- **How often do you go to these shops?**

I go to these shops once a week, buying some bread and drinks, and some other groceries.

- **What's the difference between shopping in a market and a store?**

Well, between the two, a typical supermarket always covers a wide range of commodities compared with the street market, for example, people always drive cars there with families to buy all kinds of things for a whole week; on the contrary, the shop sometimes sells fresh vegetables and fruits, people always tend to buy food for dinner after work.

SCHOOLS

- **What part of your secondary school education did you enjoy most?**

I believe that my secondary school had taught how to endure hardships if I wanted to achieve my goal. You know, in my country, the competition of entering university is badly fierce, so I had to work very hard in order to be eligible to pursue my education in the future.

- **How do you feel about your high school/secondary school?**

I guess my high school has a rich history and provides a safe, supportive learning community where all students are challenged to reach their highest levels of achievement and grow as individuals.

- **Why did you choose to attend that particular school?**

I chose to attend my school because it was the most famous school in my hometown. It has gone through so long history that many scientists and politics graduated from it. And I believe I could be qualified to get to university after years of studying there.

- **Which class did (do) you enjoy the most? (Why?)**

In my secondary school, English was my favorite subject because I found it very easy to remember the new word, and the sentences I learned were not hard at all. Besides, thanks to my English teacher, he taught me and corrected my pronunciation so that I could speak quite fluent English.

WEEKENDS

- **What do you usually do on weekends?**

Option 1: Normally I'll go out to some stunning natural sceneries to let off steam with my family or friends on weekends; but if it's not sunny, I'll stay at home for the whole weekend. Mostly I just use the internet to kill time.

Option 2: First, I like to sleep a little later than normal, just because it's more relaxing not to have to get up early like I usually do, but I don't like getting up too late in the day because then I feel like I've wasted some of the weekend. I also like to have lunch or at least one meal with my parents over the weekend, depending on what I'm doing, and what their plans are.

- **Why do you think many people consider the weekend to be important?**

People generally have more time at the weekend so they spend more time with people they love or doing things they really like rather than just studying or working. And, of course, it's an opportunity to recharge your batteries before returning to work or whatever you do during the week, feeling more energized and ready to face up to the challenges again.

- **What would your ideal weekend be like?**

Option 1: Never ending! But seriously, I suppose it would include some time with my friends and family and maybe doing something special such as visiting a new place or trying a new activity with my friends.

Option 2: It would be interesting, but not too busy to be tiring, and I would like to have enough time to chill and relax too. It's hard to be more exact, because there are so many possible things you could include in a weekend which would be fun.

- **What are you going to do next weekends?**

Next week, I plan to go to do some shopping because as the Spring Festival is just around the corner, I need to go to some super markets to prepare some food and other groceries; besides, I have to buy some new clothes for my family for the coming new year, it's a an old Chinese tradition.

- **Is there anything new that you would like to do on weekends?**

Yes, actually I've been thinking about going to the gym on Saturdays. I have to do some exercise; I'm so out of shape now!

- **Do you like working on weekends?**

I don't think I do. I always spend the whole weekends with my family. I barely work on weekends.

- **Do you think employees should have to work on weekends?**

If I were an employee, I would think this is a horrible idea. Employees are human, we all deserve to have some off-work time.

- **What do other people in your hometown usually do on weekends?**

Well, there are so many people in my hometown, it's really hard to say, probably most people tend to stay at home to enjoy the family time, but personally speaking, I guess there are not much entertaining facilities in my small hometown for people to go.

- **Do you feel that weekends now are more important to you than when you were a child?**

Yes, the main factor is that after five-day of hard work; I really need some leisure time to let off steam, or travel around to experience the stunning natural scenery. Whereas, when I was a kid, I had plenty of time to play; every day was almost the same.

NOISE

- **Do you mind noises?**

It's really hard for me to say no. I mean, I really can't bear noisy people, noisy places or even noisy things. For me noise is the number-one distractor when it comes to studying or working. You know, they actually just go ahead and interrupt my flow of thoughts.

- **Where can you hear loud noise?**

The noise can be frequently heard around the places such as airports, bus stations, and construction sites.

- **What kind of sound do you like/dislike?**

I think there is one sound that can always lull me to sleep, the rain sound. There are nights I was so stressed out that I can hardly sleep no matter how much I tried, and then I went online searching for some sound for deep sleep or relaxation, and rain sound is always one of the top choices. And since then rain sound has become my go-to on sleepless nights.

- **Is there any noise in the place where you live?**

Option 1: Well, I have to say that I face up to a rich variety of noises on a daily basis. The first type of noise is from traffic, especially during the rush hours. The second is noise from factories, construction sites which never fail to distract me from working, thereby reducing my productivity.

Option 2: Yes, just recently, my neighbor was decorating his apartment upstairs in our high-rise in the daytime. I was really bothered by the noise of the drill.

- **Do you think the world is getting noisier?**

Indeed. I do think the level of noise is increasing overtime mainly due to human activities. The situation gets even worse if you live in a big modern city at a young age. Your auditory must be trained so hard to tolerate such noise every day. It is really alarming now to raise people's awareness towards this "invisible" killer.

SCIENCE

- **Do you like science?**

I love science so much because it can explain everything in life. It allows me to know where things come from and how we act, why roses are red, how airplanes fly, and so much more! Besides, it is never ending, which means that there is always something new to discover because the topic of science is so huge.

- **What science have you studied?**

I have studied several science in the middle school and university, such as maths, physics, chemistry, biology, geography and computer science. I found most of them were very challenging and thought-provoking.

- **What do you find most interesting about science?**

Option 1: Science in itself is pretty interesting because of the broad concepts that it brings into the picture. So, it is all about nature and its components: biology, physics, and chemistry do make our daily lives possible. I believe the fact that no matter one does not pursues it in their lives as a career, science surely helps in leading a better life.

Option 2: The most tempting things about science is that it binds life. What I see around me, I can find the reasons for their existence in science. From the matters to space, science allows a person to understand themselves better through biology and then make life simpler with physics.

- **What science subject did you like the most in school? Why?**

Option 1: Chemistry has been my favorite subject because it taught me about our surroundings. Surely Biology was even interesting but the difficult terms it presented was not something that fascinated me. The greatest lesson anyone can ever learn from Chemistry is that

mixing is essential but one must remember that it can be both constructive and destructive. In addition, some things can be taken back others not.

Option 2: I loved Physics a lot because of the various problems it presented. There was always a way of doing things and then a simpler way of doing the same things. Finding the best way of doing certain things fascinated me and allured me to practice more. Even more, since the concepts of physics could be applied in my daily life, it did become my favorite subject.

- **How has the science that you have studied helped you?**

I am not pretty sure about this. However, if I have a chance, I really want to dig deeper into the process of chemical tests. i don't know why but seeing scientists carrying out experiments really raises my curiosity about science and hope one day I can give birth to wonderful findings.

SWIMMING

- **Can you swim?**

Yes, I can. We were taught swimming when I was in Class VIII, in my school. It was compulsory for us to learn swimming at that time, and I am thankful to the school to teach us.

- **Do you like swimming? Why?**

Swimming is definitely my favorite sport. It brings me such a great sense of freedom that no other activity can allow me. I've found that swimming is the most effective way to take my mind off things that are troubling me.

- **How often do you swim?**

Well, it really depends on a lot of different things, for example, weather. You know there are four distinct seasons in the northern area of Vietnam where I live and I only feel comfortable to set foot in the water when it's warm enough. So, I tend to go swimming more often at certain times of the year than the others.

- **Is swimming good for children, in your opinion?**

I certainly think children can benefit greatly from this activity. For the first thing, swimming is one of the best ways for them to stay healthy and keep fit. Besides, children's being able to swim from early ages can help save many lives every year from drowning accidents, which happen more frequently among children than adults.

- **Should it be a compulsory activity for children at school? Why?**

Let me think for a moment. I do think it's extremely useful for schools to include swimming in their curriculum so that drowning risks can be reduced, like I mentioned earlier. But whether or not it should be made mandatory is a different story. Some schools simply can't afford to provide proper swimming lessons for their students.

- **What do you think are the benefits of swimming (or of knowing how to swim)?**

As for benefits, well, it's great exercise, full cardiovascular benefits for your heart and it's also low-impact exercise so people of any age can do it without risk of damaging their joints. And of course, it's a great way to have fun at the beach with friends – or as we do – at the pool when we're relaxing.

- **Where do Vietnamese like to go swimming?**

Okay, well, back home people don't really swim that much, except when they're children. We used to swim in the river near our home, especially when it was very hot. Here, it's different – we have a swimming pool in the apartment complex where we were staying, so I probably swim about three or four times a week because it's a great way to relax, and it's good exercise too.

- **Are there many places to swim near you?**

Yes, there are a few public swimming pools in our city. One of them is very close to my house. There is also a big indoor sports complex in our city, wherein there are two or more swimming pools. Also, some outdoor swimming pools are available, but one can use them only in summers as they are very cold in the winters.

- **Do you think everyone should learn how to swim?**

Surely, yes. I think it is very important these days. A person who knows swimming can actually go on and enjoy a different aspect of life i.e. water. Like, if you go on to a beach with your friends, you can enjoy yourself with your friends. Even more, it is very helpful for security reasons and I think it is very important for children to learn it.

WALKING

- **Do you usually walk to school/work?**

Yes, I do prefer having long walks with my friends and even sometimes alone, when I need to clear my thoughts. I think walking in so many sense help you to bond with the other person. Because, it is that time when we are slow and really talking to the other person. There is no rush, no deadline to meet, nothing on mind apart from what is coming out from heart. And, then times when I walk alone, it does help me get clarity on life.

- **Do you like to take a walk?**

Sure, I like to walk. I normally walk around the park near my house to get some exercise. It's also a good way for me to relax and clear my head. I normally go for a walk in the early morning or the evening when the weather is cooler.

- **Do you like to walk on your own or with others?**

Option 1: I prefer to walk by myself. Like I said before, I think walking is a good way to clear my mind and think about any problems I have or decisions I have to make. Also, I like to walk fast so I don't want to have to slow down for someone else."

Option 2: It depends. So, if I am really messed up with my life and want some clarity, I prefer walking alone. But, in times when I am tired and feel emaciated, I prefer going out on a walk with my friends. It helps me to relax a bit and then carry on with life. So, for me both go fine, my mental state is what makes the difference.

- **Would you say that your city is a good place for walking?**

Definitely not. It's much too crowded. The sidewalks are taken up with motorbikes and other stuff so there's nowhere really to walk. Also there is heavy air pollution so being outside for a long period of time is not good for your health.

- **Do people in your country walk a lot?**

Not really. At least not in cities. Like I just said, cities are too crowded to make walking a good option. People normally get around by motorbike, car, bike, or public transport. Not to mention in the summer it's too hot to walk long distances.

- **Do you think walking is important?**

Option 1: Yes, I think it's extremely important. Nowadays most of us live a very sedentary lifestyle which means we don't get enough exercise and are often overweight. Walking is a simple way to stay healthy and avoid a lot of modern health problems.

Option 2: Definitely yes. Walking is surely an important part of our lives because it helps us in so many ways. You not only get positive results in terms of physical health but it helps improve your mental health, hence giving you the entire advantage.

- **Do you think walking in the countryside is better than walking in the city?**

Option 1: I think the country is a much better place to walk because rural areas avoid all of the problems that urban ones have. The air is fresher, there is more space, and you don't have to worry about being hit by a bus or motorbike.

Option 2: Surely yes. On the countryside, you are more likely to find greenery, free roads, more parks, but with cities, there are certain issues. Like, most of them have got big building so while walking there is not much that you can capture about nature. Also, with cities, there are issues like pollution, which do affect us in many ways.

EVENING ACTIVITIES

- **What do you often do in the evening?**

There's not much to say about my evenings, I'm afraid. I tend to spend most of them in my room working on class assignments. People may find the way I spend my evenings dull but, as a final year student, I have important exams to prepare for so I hardly find time for other activities.

- **Who do you usually spend your evenings with?**

Well, it really depends on the time of the year. Since I've moved away from my hometown to go to Hanoi to study at university and I'm currently living in a shared house, most of my evenings are spent with my roommates or alone, except during holiday seasons when I return to my hometown to visit my family.

- **Do you prefer the day or night?**

Well, I am an early riser and the early morning is my favorite time of a day. I usually wake up at 5:30 am and start the day with a cup of tea. The early morning is somewhat different than the other parts of the day. It is quiet, refreshing and allows me to plan for the remaining day.

- **What do you do when you go out in the evening?**

Like I said earlier, I don't really go out that much, but when I do, it's either for grabbing something to eat or catching up with some friends. We usually hang out in the university's cafeteria because, you know, as students, we can't afford to go to fancy places.

- **Do you prefer staying at home or going out during evenings?**

I love taking long walks. So, if I am not busy at something during evenings, I usually take long walks with my friends or for that matter even alone at times.

- **What is a popular activity for young people in your country in the evenings?**

Well, Vietnamese youngsters love to go to KTV parlor to convey their feelings through music and sing their hearts out.

- **Do you do the same thing in the evenings as you did when you were a child?**

Option 1: No, I don't. In fact, my night life now is completely different. It is filled with works and studies, whereas it used to be carefree when I was younger.

Option 2: Like I said earlier, I don't really go out that much, but when I do, it's either for grabbing something to eat or catching up with some friends. We usually hang out in the university's cafeteria because, you know, as students, we can't afford to go to fancy places.

- **Do you often study/work in the evening?**

Yes, certainly. I'm a college student with a heavy workload, so I frequently devote my evenings to studying.

SHOPPING

- **Do you like (going) shopping?**

Option 1: Well, I love shopping because spending time on some of my favorite and essential things makes me feel happy. It is my favorite time pass which always elevates my mood.

Option 2: Actually, I don't like to go shopping very frequently. As far as I think, it's a waste of time and money. We should spend our earnings very carefully as we burn the midnight oil to be financially strong. So, we should spend on our needs not on accessories.

- **Do you spend much when you go shopping?**

I usually don't intend to spend much money when I go shopping because I believe that purchasing things from the concrete stores are definitely more expensive than the online store. Therefore I always just buy some necessities from the local supermarket.

- **Do you prefer to go shopping alone?**

Well, it depends. When I'm busy, I just make a list of what I need, then go to store, buy those things and get out. But usually at the weekends, I really like shopping for clothes and shoes with my best friend. She knows my style and she can help me choose stuff that looks great on me.

- **What do you usually buy when you go shopping?**

Option 1: Actually I only buy some groceries and food when I go shopping in the nearby supermarket. I get other things like outfits, electronic devices, and books from the online store.

Option 2: It depends on what I want to buy. So if it's just some grocery, I'd like to go to a big store where I can pick up almost everything on my shopping list. If I'm going to buy some clothes, I'd probably go to a boutique.

- **When do you usually go shopping?**

I only shop when there is a festival coming up, like spring festival or Christmas. That's the time when I could get lots of goods' discount.

- **Who does most of the shopping in your household?**

There isn't one person who does most of the shopping. I'd say it's a shared responsibility because we tend to go shopping together as a family.

- **Where do you normally shop?**

It depends slightly on what sort of shopping I'm doing. If I'm just doing the groceries, I'll go to the supermarket, but if I need a little retail therapy then I generally go to the retail park where there's every sort of shop available and I can window shop to my heart's content.

- **When you do go shopping?**

Typically I do the shopping at the weekend. There are times though when I'll pop out to the local corner shop or newsagents if I need a paper or a bottle of milk.

- **Do you prefer to shop in big stores or small shops?**

I mostly prefer to shop in department stores. You get a much better selection there and the customer service is generally much better too. Sometimes I go to small boutiques for clothes shopping – it can be more fun.

- **Is there any kind of shopping you don't enjoy?**

To be honest I dislike most shopping. When I need a pair of shoes I just buy the first ones I see. When I was younger though I was a bit of a shopaholic and went on shopping sprees all the time – mostly for music and gadgets.

- **Have you ever bought anything online?**

Yes I have and I shop online fairly regularly. I do my grocery shopping online nowadays because it's much more convenient to have it delivered to your door isn't it? And you get a

discount if you use your loyalty card. But I still prefer to shop for clothes on the high street. I prefer to try things on before I buy them.

- **Do you like shopping on the internet?**

Option 1: Absolutely! I love to shop on the internet because online shopping offers many advantages over traditional shopping. First and foremost, some online stores have amazing collections for every age group. Secondly, we can buy anything through the net without going to crowded marketplaces and it's a hassle free process. Thirdly, return policies have made it more attractive. Last but not the least, these stores have competitive prices for leading brands.

Option 2: Well, I am not very fond of online shopping. And the reason behind this is my poor experience. Most of the products which I bought through the internet were defective and duplicate. My credit card information was also misused. So, I always prefer traditional shopping over the internet.

- **What are the advantages of shopping online?**

I suppose the biggest advantage is that you normally get much more choice than you do on the high street. The you go online you can get something from almost any country in the world now – that's not exactly the same as in regular shops where you just find the same old produce.

- **What kind of shops is most popular where you live?**

That's a really hard question to answer because there are so many different shops. But I guess the new shopping malls are where most people go and they are more popular nowadays than the old markets. That's probably because there are more facilities there and they're just warmer and nicer places to be – outside can be cold in winter!

- **Would you like to work in a shop?**

No, I'm not interested in retail at all. You never know how difficult some customers can be dealt with. I honestly don't like to deal with that.

MUSEUMS

- **Are there many (or any) museums in your hometown?**

Not so many, actually there is only one museum in my small county about the local history. It allows the local residents to know better about their traditions and historical celebrities.

- **Do you think museums are useful for visitors to your hometown/country?**

I suppose the usefulness is limited, because compared to museums I'd prefer documentaries, but since I hardly went there, so my opinion might be biased.

- **Do you often visit a museum?**

Seldom did I go there, because personally I can't find anything meaningful in those materials.

- **Did you go to any museums when you were a child?**

Yes, when I was in primary school, my school organized a tour in one of the museums in my hometown, but I only have a vague memory about that.

- **When was the last time you visited a museum?**

I go to the museum a lot, when I come to the new place, I'll find some local museums that have interesting features. The museum I visited last time was the Guan Fu Museum located in the rural area of Beijing. It is a private-owned museum featuring Chinese antiques like porcelain, furniture's, jade and some paintings.

- **Do you think museums are important?**

Museums are really important in protecting, preserving, propagating and researching numerous human treasure. Once the antiques are in the museums, they are permanently out of circulation, which means they can be seen by public.

- **Do you think it's suitable for museums to sell things to visitors?**

Yes, the reason is that generally, most museums are nonprofit organizations, and these goods are their large portion of income, except the tickets, and also partly because these items are closely related to the theme of the museums, which cannot be bought in most other bookstores or shops.

SPEAKING PART 2 + 3

1. Describe a surprise party you would like to arrange for your friends or family.

You should say:

Who you would invite to the party

When and where you would hold the party

What you (or, your guests) would do at the party

And explain why you would hold (= have) this party or

And explain what preparations you would do for this party.

Sample answer:

It is not always easy to organize a surprise party and I did organize such 3-4 surprise parties for my family members and friends. The surprise party I would like to do is for one of my friends on his birthday. He is going to turn 26 next February and I'd through a completely surprise party for him at his home.

There is a good chance that his family members would organize a birthday celebration on the day, so my planning would be to through it at 12:01 am at night. I would keep everything secret from him and would let only 2-3 friends know about the planning of the party who would also participate in organizing it. We would buy a big birthday cake and birthday candles in the evening and 6-7 friends would gather together. We will buy our individual gifts for him and would go to him home exactly at 12:00 am. We will then notify his mother and would let her know that we are planning a surprise party for him. At exactly 12:01 am we'll enter his house and probably there would be a lot of shouting and birthday wishing. That would be a big surprise to my friend as he would **have no clue about** our arrival at his home on his birthday.

He is a very good friend of mine and I remember him to **be very supportive to me** in several times. A birthday is a very special day for a person and people become very happy when he finds that people who care him also celebrates and congratulates him on special occasions like a birthday or a wedding ceremony. I would organize the surprise party to make him happy and to enjoy the occasion.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **have no clue about:** không biết gì về
- **be supportive to someone:** ủng hộ ai đó
- **notify:** thông báo

Follow-up questions:

- **Why are parties important?**

People have parties to celebrate special occasions like birthdays, weddings, or the beginning of a new year. I think it's important to celebrate these things because they are landmarks in our lives. Parties are a good way to bring people together, and they're an opportunity to let off some steam.

- **Why do people throw family parties in your country?**

In the States, people throw family parties for all the same reasons people do in other countries, like traditional holidays such as Thanksgiving and Christmas. However, I'm not sure if other cultures do this like we do, but, in general, people here love to have parties! In my family, for instance, my mom will seriously use any excuse to invite family and friends over for a little soiree. This is more feasible in the summer, when my dad can barbecue hot dogs and burgers and we can hang out outside. So, yeah, I suppose we have family parties quite a bit.

- **Do people spend a lot of money on these parties in your country?**

Well, that depends on if they have money or not! I don't think it's a status thing, as I believe this question is insinuating. I guess there are some families in the so-called "one percent" of society that will lavish great bundles of cash on family get-togethers, but I've only seen events like that on TV! I think real people, at least those in my circles, like to actually do potlucks, where family and friends all bring a dish and something to drink. It's a communal effort. To my mind, that's more fun anyway.

- **What are the differences between serious parties and friendly parties?**

I think that there are many differences between these two kinds of party. In the former, the attire is often more elegant with guests wearing costumes and ties, while in the latter this doesn't always happen and they wear more casual clothes, such as jeans, t-shirts and so on. In addition, serious parties are often more of professional type, whilst with friendly parties, this isn't always the case. Moreover, it could be argued that serious parties are mostly held in restaurants or bars and most of the time are expensive, while friendly parties in houses or cafeterias and are cost-saving.

- **Why are some people late for parties intentionally?**

This is a really interesting question and to be honest I have never thought about it. I can't find a logical explanation why someone will do something like that and I would describe it as a really immature and unscrupulous action. But, unfortunately, there are many who belong to this category and some of them are friends of mine as well. A reason that comes to my mind is that someone doesn't want to go to a party but they are forced to do so. Indeed, there are many occasions and especially related to workplace or parties thrown by relatives where people are sometimes forced to be present. In this case, the only solution is going many hours after the commencement of the party. This is the only reason I can think of and partly justify this action.

- **Do you think parties will become more popular in the future?**

No, I don't think anything will change. People have always had parties, and I'm sure they always will in the future. Humans need to socialize and enjoy themselves, and parties are one of the best ways to do that.

- **Why do some people like parties while others hate them?**

Most people like parties because they have a good time at them - eating a nice meal, chatting to friends, or having a dance. People who don't like them might find social situations difficult because they are shy, or maybe they don't enjoy having to make small talk with people they don't know.

- **What would you do if your guests felt bored?**

The first thing I would do if my guests are bored in a party that I have hosted is to turn on the music or change my playlist. There are some people who don't like the conventional types of music and prefer something else. If music couldn't help, I would play a game to attract their interest or tell some stories from our different experiences and stages of life, which would definitely lead to lots of laughter and joy. I would finally arrange some indoor games and would declare some prizes for the winners to warm up the guests.

- **In some places people spend a lot of money on parties that celebrate special family event. Is this ever true in your country? Do you think this is a good trend or a bad trend?**

Like the other countries, the rich and wealthy families in my country organize family parties and they spend a huge sum of money for the parties. Mostly they prefer arranging party during the marriage ceremony or marriage anniversary, but the parties marking marriage ceremony last longer than the marriage anniversary party. When the parties are arranged, special decorative materials are used to decorate the house and almost all the rooms are newly decorated. Besides, catering services are engaged to supply quality foods for the invited guests.

Sometimes I think it is the wastage of money and wealth. They could have saved the money for the future use of the newly-wed.

- **Will there be more and more people to attend parties?**

Yes I think so. I truly believe that the number of party lovers will increase in the future. The opportunities to gather together with friends and relatives are shrinking in modern days and people would not want to miss parties where they can meet people, relatives and enjoy their time. Parties would be a way of relaxing and taking breaks for many busy employees and the increasing number of party attendees these days gives hints that in the future it will further increase.

2. **Describe a success you would like to achieve (in the near future).**

You should say:

What it is

How difficult you think it will be

What you should do to prepare for this

And explain why you want to succeed in doing this.

or explain how you think you will feel after you reach this goal.

Sample Answer:

Well, when it comes to my business life, my work and career, I am still **contemplating my options**, but right now, the real problem for me is getting married.

It is very hard to find a suitable match simply because I cannot **please everybody**. I must think about what my family wants, what the world around me would be pleased with, and the last person on the list to worry about is me. It will take a lot of searching, a lot of concentration. In my life, my **schedule seldom permits free time**, much less time to date, and I am often too shy to **begin from scratch**. I do not have many close friends, and those that I do have are either married or do not **make a very good match for me**. **An extra difficulty** is that I am not too good at the whole parents-in-law situation; I would find myself quite unhappy with this **traditional way of living**. Many Chinese must “put up” with their husband or wife, and also their parents and relatives, and must receive critiquing or judgment from all sides. I do not want to live this way and I don’t want a partner that I must “put up with”, I want to have love in my life.

But traditions are traditions and I must **follow some kind of pattern**. Thus, my first step might be to ask my parents and my aunt and uncle to look for a suitable partner for me, and then we can begin by writing each other, and when we feel we **have enough common ground**, we can **arrange a meeting**.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **contemplating my options:** dự liệu, dự tính các lựa chọn
- **please everybody:** làm vừa lòng mọi người
- **schedule seldom permits free time:** lịch làm việc không có thời gian rảnh
- **begin from scratch:** bắt đầu, khởi đầu (từ lúc chưa hề có gì)
- **make a good match for:** phù hợp với
- **an extra difficulty:** một khó khăn thêm nữa
- **traditional way of living:** lối sống truyền thống
- **follow some kind of pattern:** theo một kiểu mẫu nào đó
- **have common ground:** có những điểm chung
- **arrange a meeting:** sắp xếp một cuộc hẹn

Follow-up questions:

- **How would you define success?**

Hmm, there are so many ways to define it. I believe success is feeling my life is worth living, and being a good person to those around me. If I have a partner, or children, or relatives dependent on me, I would consider it a success if I were able to provide them with a good life style and everything they need. Success would mean my reputation as a good person travels ahead of me. It would mean I would have a goal and hope for life, and would stand out amongst others.

- **Do you think most people want to succeed in life?**

I would imagine they do. But as I said, there are many ways to define success, it is the inborn desire of a human to want to be the best they could be, to want more. Everybody wants life to be worthwhile, they want their husband or wife to be proud of them, they want their children to admire them, and they want a sense of fulfillment. It's natural.

- **When do people most want to be successful?**

Well I would say it's after they realize that life is a struggle and that they must make it on their own. When we are young we can depend on others and do not feel the need to make something of ourselves. It's when the pressure kicks in and the understanding comes to us that we find we must choose for ourselves whether we will be happy or sad, a success or a failure. When we grow up and are more mature, we begin to have others depend on us, looking to us, and we feel the responsibility to do our part in the world.

- **What kind of success is most important to Vietnamese people?**

Well, originally it was about being a good provider for one's family, finding one's children a good husband or wife, having enough land to live off. But now that China is much more open,

people begin to feel success is about milking enough money to never have to worry about anything. It's also about giving that feeling of relaxed and easy living to their children. Get them into the best school, buy them a house so they don't have to work, hand life to them on a silver platter. This is beginning to be the image of success, and the people of this country are bombarded with advertisements, movies and pictures of the easy life, the rich and famous, and they feel this is the only way to succeed. I myself feel it has its downsides, and must really consider what I want for my life.

- **Do you think that successful people are always happier than unsuccessful people?**

Again, this depends on your idea of success. But whatever it means to a person, if they are dissatisfied with the cards they are dealt and do not realize they can determine their success, and then yes, I imagine they are no happy at all. But, sometimes, those that we think are successful on the outside, or what we see of them, are not happy, they do not consider their life worth the trouble. So, no. I do not think "successful" people are always happier than "unsuccessful" people.

- **How to measure a person's success?**

There are several ways to define the success of a person. I could start off by highlighting the fact that a success story is sure to have a good financial condition. It is not exaggerated to say that he can have money to burn. In addition, success is illustrated by a person's social status. Successful people will be held in high esteem. Last but not least, contributions to society can be another demonstration of success.

- **Do you think the way people gain success has changed?**

Well, there are no changes in the process of achieving success nowadays in comparison with the past, I think. You know. To reach the zenith of success today or even in previous time, people need to burn the candle at both ends. Put it another way, they need to be hard working to achieve success. Moreover, sometimes Luck can make a contribution to people's success.

- **Is failure a necessary thing for a person's success?**

All things considered, my answer is yes and no. To answer yes, you know, failure is the mother of success. Thanks to failure, people can accumulate more experience to achieve success in the future. The second feature I want to mention is that failure is kind of a source of inspiration for people not to rest on their laurel. To answer no, failure can deprive people of confidence and determination to keep moving forward.

- **What's the most difficult thing you have ever done?**

I have experienced ups and downs in life so it takes me a while to find the most challenging. Well, I guess it is passing the entrance exam to university with flying colors. You know, at that time, I did work flat out and study patiently. Luckily, my efforts came to fruition. I couldn't believe my eyes at that time. It is true that hard work pays off.

Other possible questions:

- **Do you consider yourself a real success?**
- **What are your accomplishments and achievements in your life?**
- **Do you think having an organized program can lead to people's success?**
- **Do you think those who are lucky are successful?**

3. Describe a present (a gift) you received when you were a child

You should say:

What the present was

Who gave it to you?

How you used this present

And explain how you felt when you got this present.

When I was a child, I was given a block set on the eve of Christmas as a gift. One of my **maternal uncles** gave that block set to me because I liked to play with the blocks more in my childhood. I was truly surprised when my maternal uncle came to our home to give me the wonderful gift, although, in the beginning, I did not realize that he was at our home for presenting me the wonderful block set.

A medium plastic container **wrapped in** papers was given to me on the Christmas day and when I opened the container, I found the blocks. I was **highly surprised and happy** too for the excellent gift from my uncle. The blocks were made of **top-class** plastic and there were no sharp edges. They were of different sizes and some of the block pieces **were attached with wheels**. The block shapes were not same. I used to make different structures with the block set. I preferred robots, airplanes, cars, houses and more other stuff using the block set.

The block set was important to me for several reasons. Firstly the blocks looked nice and **were handy to use**. Secondly, I have learnt many facts of my real life using the blocks. They have taught me **patience and perseverance** – when I used to fail in making any desired or imagined structure, I waited, **took a pause from** the making, used to **think deeply over** the structure and finally made that.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **maternal uncle:** cậu bên mẹ, họ ngoại (paternal = bên bố, họ nội)
- **be wrapped in:** được gói trong
- **highly surprised and happy:** rất bất ngờ và hạnh phúc
- **top-class:** hạng thượng lưu, có chất lượng cao, hàng đầu
- **be attached with:** được gắn với
- **be handy to use:** tiện lợi, dễ sử dụng
- **patience and perseverance:** tính kiên trì và
- **took a pause from:** tạm ngừng, nghỉ
- **think deeply over:** suy nghĩ rất kỹ về

Follow-up questions:

- **Why do people give gifts in our society?**

I think people give gifts for many reasons. One of the main ones is to celebrate a significant event, such as a anniversary or maybe a graduation. People also like to give gifts to show their appreciation to someone. I mean if someone has done a good job or helped someone in some way then they might be given a gift as a “thank you”.

- **What are some common gifts people usually receive in your country?**

In my country, people most usually choose to give each other money as a gift because of its practicality. It is not always easy to guess what people want so sometimes you may spend lots of money on something that is not going to be used at all. In order to avoid this from happening, Vietnamese prefer giving each other money so that the receivers can get themselves whatever they want.

- **What kind of educational gifts can be given to children?**

Hmmm, I’m not sure about that. Um, I think books are a good gift for children because they are a great way to learn about the world [How?] Books can be about anything. Also, because many children now have a smartphone or internet-connected device, maybe some kind of educational apps would make a good gift.

- **Why do some people like to give hand-made gifts instead of purchasing them in a store?**

I think it’s because something made by hand is more personal than something bought in a store. It shows that the person giving the gift cares about the person and is happy to put in some effort to make something nice for another person. It’s the thought that counts!

- **On what occasions do people in your country give gifts?**

There are many occasions on which people in my country give presents such as Birthday, Women's day or Valentines. As a matter of fact, exchanging gifts is not our traditional practice. However, for the last few decades, this has become extremely popular, especially among young generations. On special occasions, people give gifts as a way to express affection to or show gratitude for family members and friends.

- **What kinds of gifts would men; women and children generally like to receive?**

We all are unique individuals and have our own set of unique tastes. However, generally women prefer ornaments or clothes while receiving gifts. Some of them even like household appliances and handicrafts. Men, on the other hand, usually like electronic gadgets like phones or watches. There are even who prefer expensive pens or books etc. children are mostly attracted to toys and video games. They even love chocolates and other eatables.

- **What changes have been seen in past in receiving and giving gifts?**

There have been some major changes in our lifestyle since the past 50 years. With the rise of economy, people have more money and more reasons to celebrate. In earlier times, gifts were exchanged only in special occasions like marriages. However, in present times, gifts have become a part of our lives and a very frequent affair. People can be seen exchanging gifts in occasions like birthdays, anniversary, success in exams etc.

4. Describe a holiday postcard or email you received that you liked or it is important to you

You should say:

Who the postcard/email was from

Where it was sent from

When you received it

What the contents of the postcard or email were

And explain why you liked it.

Sample Answer:

I have received many important emails and out of these, I would like to talk about the email that I got from the **HR** of a Telecom company that **confirmed** my part time job there. When I was a student of 6th semester of the university, I needed to manage a part-time job. I applied for several jobs but my dream job was to **work as** a consultant for **a major telecom company** in my country. It was not easy to get the job as so many candidates apply for the job and the company prefers the full-time employees than the part-time employees.

One day I got an email from Mr. Atherton (...say a name common in your country...) and I found that it was from the telecom company where I was interviewed. It was early November 2001 and that time I was around 22 years old. I opened the email **went to the details of** the email very quickly. **My heart was pounding** and I felt really good when I found that the email confirms my appointment as a part-time employee for this company. I **re-read** the email and **took a printout** as well. The email was sent to me by the Head of the Human Resource department of the company.

It was a very important email for me as I was desperately expecting to work for this company and the email confirmed my joining there. Secondly, this was the first job confirmation of my life and I needed this job at that time. So this was very exciting news for me and that's why this was a very important email for me.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **HR** (human resources): quản lý nhân lực
- **confirm**: xác nhận
- **work as (a consultant)**: làm việc với vai trò (của một nhà cố vấn)
- **a major telecom company**: một công ty truyền thông/kỹ thuật lớn
- **go to the details of**: đi vào chi tiết
- **my heart is pounding**: tim mình đập rất nhanh, thành thích (thể hiện ý hời hợt hay lo sợ)
- **re-read**: đọc lại
- **take a printout**: in một tài liệu ra

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you often keep diaries?**

Umm! No. I do not keep diaries at all now. But when I was a teen, I used to keep a diary and penned all the events of the day on that. Sometimes I used to read the diary in my leisure hours and remembered all the events through my imagination. I gave up keeping a diary after I got promoted in my high school; I had to be very busy with my studies and extracurricular activities and sports events. My engagement on different events increased that made me highly occupied and I hardly could manage time for keeping the diary.

- **What is the difference between a diary and a letter?**

Well, letters and e-mails are different in several ways. Though both of them are used for communication, they differ in their nature. The first one is manual while the later one is electrical. To write a letter, you'll need a pen and a paper, then you are to go for the post office to post the letter yet sometimes it remains unknown whether the letter will be delivered or not in some cases. But to compose an e-mail, you need a computer with an active internet

connection. You also need to have an e-mail account to send the mail while the recipient also needs the same – an e-mail address to receive the e-mail. But sending emails have some benefits which are not found in posting letters. The important issue about e-mail is that it is much safer than sending letters.

- **What did the difference between a letter and an e-mail?**

There are huge differences between a diary and letter. First, the difference is about purposes. A letter is written for someone to inform over any specific issues who is living far away from the letter writer, and a diary is basically the combination of all the events that someone has experienced throughout the day. There are a few similarities are found as well like the letter is sent with information while the diary is also filled with information but the uses are different. Moreover, a diary is always private while the letter may not be private always.

- **Would post office disappear in the next 50 years?**

No, I don't think that post offices will disappear after 20 years. If there were even tiniest chances of the post office being disappeared, they would have been disappeared right after the invention of e-mail or the telephone. Post offices are maintained by the government and it is up to the government's consideration to close the post offices. But I think the governments will not do so. Letters are sent through the post offices and thus the post offices are the traditional sources of communication. It has played a very important role earlier and now it is also important in some cases.

5. **Describe a place you know where people go to listen to music/a musical event (such as a theatre or a music hall).**

You should say:

Where it is

What kind of music is performed there?

What types of people go there?

How you know this place

And explain your impressions of this place.

Sample Answer:

There are several occasions and places in our country when musical events **take place in** my country. I'd like to talk about a particular music event that takes place in my hometown and this takes place at the beginning of the spring. The event runs through 3-4 days and in 2-3 phases. In the first phase, the local music bands and individuals perform and complete in the event. At the end of the competition, three bands and three individuals are selected and are awarded. This is an important event as it makes the participants famous in the country. This

event **is broadcasted in local TV channel and in Radio**. This event takes place in the **city hall auditorium**. Thousands of **music lovers** and people attend the event to enjoy the music and the competition. Several kinds of music are played and among them classic, rock, folk and **contemporary songs** are most famous.

In the second phase, some famous singers and musicians perform their own songs and people enjoy this very much. Lots of people from different parts of the country come to attend the show and enjoy the music.

I have attended the event several times and enjoyed every time to be there. The event attracts lots of people and a festivity goes on surrounding this event. I enjoy the music, the gathering and the festivity of this event.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **take place in/at:** diễn ra ở nơi/vào khoảng thời gian
- **be broadcasted in TV/radio:** được phát trên TV/radio
- **city hall auditorium:** khán phòng của tòa thị chính thành phố
- **music lovers:** những người yêu nhạc
- **contemporary songs:** những bài hát hiện đại, hợp thời

Follow-up questions:

- **What kinds of music are popular with young people in your country?**

Well, thinking about it, I would say that there's an increasingly wide variety of music types which are catching on nowadays in Vietnam, such as pop music of course, as well as rock, R&B, and traditional Vietnamese folk music. But out of all of these, I'd say that pop music is, by far, the most in vogue at the moment. And I'm sure if you steal a glance at anyone's MP3 player here, you would find that the majority of the songs in the playlists on it, if not all of it, are pop music songs – at least that's the case with all of my intimates anyway.

- **How would your grandfather feel if you gave him some hip hop music to listen to?**

What an interesting question! As I have mentioned earlier, modern music like hip-hop or rap is definitely not their taste. Having that in mind, I have never thought of recommending that sort of songs to my grandparents.

- **What are the differences in the music that young and old people listen to?**

To be honest, I suppose there are a handful of differences, one of which would be that young people, on the whole, mainly like listening to pop music, whereas the older generation tend to

be more into listening to more traditional music, like folk music, Vietnamese opera, and even old revolutionary songs. So that's one difference, and I guess another would be that the youths often listen to Western music as well as Vietnamese music, whereas in contrast, I think it's fair to say that most elderly people just tend to listen to Vietnamese music.

- **Why do you think people of different age groups have different favorite songs?**

Simply speaking, people of different ages belong to different groups and each group has its own norms. So, teenagers are under the influence of other members in the group and would go for the latest pop songs of current artists on TV or songs that go viral on the social networks. Meanwhile, the older and more mature group would rather look back on past values and prefer old songs that usually have something to do with their life some 40 years ago. What I'm trying to say is they can recall bitter or sweet memories from those pieces of music.

- **Is it necessary for children to listen to traditional Vietnamese music?**

If I were to say, I don't think I would go so far as saying it's absolutely necessary, but it's certainly a good thing to do, because it's one way of helping children become more conscious of their culture. So for example, if parents occasionally put on some traditional music at home, it gives children the chance to develop an interest in this aspect of their culture, even though they might not be able to fully appreciate it.

- **Why do you think countries have traditional anthems or songs?**

It is commonly believed that a national anthem shows and describes a country and its culture and I am no exception. It also shows unity and solidarity among people. It develops patriotism and nation-wide consensus. We feel very proud when our national anthem is played in international football and cricket fields and Olympics.

- **What do you think influences a young person's taste in music?**

It is quite difficult to say, but I think music, composition and lyrics generally influence the taste in music young people in my country like to listen to. Modern musical instruments such as key board, electronic guitar, drum, harmonica etc. also have an impact on young music lovers. Hindi music videos are very popular among youngsters. Now listening to music by mp3 players is a fashion to young people.

- **How important is it for a culture to have musical traditions?**

Well, personally speaking, traditional music is very important for saving the cultural identity of a nation. Our traditional folk songs, spiritual songs, classical songs reflect our norms and practices, religion rituals, beliefs, social norms, education, our heritages, festivals etc. countries rich in music sector develop in the long run.

6. Describe an adventurous person who you know.

You should say:

Who the person is

How you know this person

What this person does that is adventurous

And explain why you think this person likes to take risks.

Sample Answers:

My younger uncle in my view and experience is the most adventurous person I've ever seen and met. He is my father's younger brother and is around 35-36 years old. I know him from my childhood as he is my uncle and visits us often. I have always known him as a mysterious man who loves adventure and love to explore new things and places. From my childhood till now I've heard lots of stories about him and many of them are so exciting and adventurous that they **can be easily converted to stories or movies**. I often found my uncle disappears from home and then nobody knows where he has gone. **All of a sudden** he comes back and disappears again. I heard he only lets my grandpa know about his departure and his next exploration. He does not **lead a conventional social life and still unmarried**. He loves to read and visit different places. All the stories I heard about him from other and some of them from him seem very interesting and new to me.

Once he disappeared and came back with the story that he has found a place where ghosts can be found. Then again he came back with long bearded and we learned that he lived in a forest with people for about 2 weeks. He knows a lot about people and their **customs of our country**. To me, the most adventurous thing I know he did is the time when he went to Nepal to reach the top of the Mount Everest. There are so many other stories that I heard about him like killing a giant snake, swimming in a big river to rescue a victim, Egypt and many other places. Everything he does is a mystery to me and I have never met anyone more brave and adventurous than he is.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **be converted to:** được chuyển đổi, cải tạo thành
- **All of a sudden:** bất thành lình
- **lead a conventional social life and still unmarried:**
 - lead a life:** có một cuộc sống (như thế nào)
 - a conventional social:** một cuộc sống với những mối quan hệ thông thường
 - unmarried:** chưa kết hôn, lập gia đình
- **customs of a country:** văn hóa, tập tục của một quốc gia

Follow-up questions:

- **Why do some people seem to like taking more risks than others?**

I suppose all people are different, some are naturally more adventurous and like to do things that other people would never dream of doing. It's just in their nature, they like to experience dangerous situations or test their abilities doing dangerous activities, and in some cases of course the greater the risk the greater the reward, especially in business. So some people like to take more risks so they can get a bigger reward for their efforts.

- **Why do you think it is that some people like to take part in dangerous sports?**

I think for many people, it is a way to get some excitement into their lives. When people thousands of years in the past lived in nature, they often faced dangers like wild animal attacks, but now many people just spend their lives sitting in an office. By participating in extreme sports, people can feel alive and get a rush that they can't experience in normal everyday modern life.

- **Do you think people take more risks now than in the past?**

It's difficult to say. There are so many things available to do nowadays that weren't in the past. Like, for example, extreme sports are popular nowadays, but in the past they didn't exist, so yes people take more risks than before, but in normal life I think it's probably about the same. We make decisions and almost all decisions carry some degree of risk – you either make a good decision or a bad decision and sometimes the consequences can be serious. Even choosing a career, or a life partner, where to live, buying a car, buying a house, etc. all these things have some element of risk attached to them – and those risks were the same for our parents and probably our grandparents, so there are many risks that haven't changed.

7. Describe your favorite means of transportation.

You should say:

What this transport is

When you began to use it

The advantages and disadvantages of using this form of transportation

And explain why it is your favorite form of transportation.

Sample Answers:

There are many **means of transportation** in my country. People in the **urban areas** usually have their own cars or they use the **public transport** whereas the people in the **rural areas** tend to travel on bicycles and tractors. People in this world use the means of transportation which are suitable for them. The previous mentioned means of transportation are used to travel within the country whereas the airplanes are used to travel from one county to another.

My favorite means of transportation is a car. I got this car when I was 19 years old. First I used to travel on a bus, but after getting the car my life got a lot of easier and felt that car **was a necessity rather than a luxury**. First I used to travel on a bus and I never **reached my destination** on time. There was a day when I missed a bus and due to that I also missed my exam so I got a zero on my exam. I think that the use of a car enables a person to reach on time and it also protects a person from bad weather. There are also some disadvantages attached to the use of car as it is very expensive to keep a car and a person also has to pay for the **maintenance charges**. Cars also **create pollution and traffic congestion**. I still feel that the **benefits of using a car outweigh the drawbacks** and more and more people in this world are trying to get their own car.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **means of transportation:** phương tiện giao thông, di chuyển
- **urban area # rural area:** vùng thành thị # vùng nông thôn
- **public transport:** phương tiện giao thông công cộng
- **be a necessity rather than a luxury:** là thứ thiết yếu hơn thứ xa xỉ
- **reached my destination:** đến điểm muốn đến

Follow-up questions:

- **What types of transport are there in your town?**

In Manchester I think you can find every form of transport apart from an underground system. You can drive around the city by car or get on a bus; there are even free buses that take people between the train stations. Manchester also has a tram system, and of course there are taxis too.

- **Have the types of transport people use changed much over the last few decades?**

Option 1: I don't think they have really. We've had the transport I mentioned before for many decades now in my country, and it is much the same today. Of course cars have become much more popular as people's incomes have risen which accounts for the problems we see on the roads today such as congestion and more accidents and pollution. This has probably led to some changes within cities. Many have now introduced environmentally friendly forms of transport such as trams and guided buses that don't run on gas and mean that people can travel without the use of the car. There has also been an increase in air travel, but like I said, this is quite expensive in my country so most cannot afford it.

Option 2: Yes I think so. There has been a significant rise in private vehicles used for leisure journeys and work journeys. The reason is that people in my country is becoming wealthier. However, among young people, using public transport is an increasing tendency. Part of the reason is that they are more aware of the positive impact of public transport on reducing the

number of private vehicles, air pollution and protecting the natural environment. Also, due to the rising costs of oil and legal insurance, many young people choose to use public transport.

- **What kinds of improvement have there been in transport in your country in recent years?**

Option 1: There has been several ways that transport has improved. More major roads have been built which means it is easier to travel long distances, though of course some would argue that more roads are not an improvement. They can be an eyesore in the countryside and they have encouraged more people to drive which may mean these improvements ultimately don't work because there are more cars using the roads. As I mentioned before, there has been the introduction of mass transit in many cities, such as trams and trains. In our capital city they have also extended the underground system so it now links many more areas of the city. This has helped many people as commuting times are horrendous if you have to travel on the roads. Those are the main improvements.

Option 2: The number of domestic and international airports have increased, which contributes to the growth of the tourism industry. Along with airports, the number and quality of sea ports, freeways and railways have gone up as well. Coaches and buses have been improved, allowing people to travel around a city and between cities in Vietnam. A good example is the introduction of high-quality in-city bus routes in Ho Chi Minh city that allow passengers to travel from and to Tan Son Nhat airport.

- **What do you think of public transport in your country?**

It has been improved so much over the past few decades but still does not meet international standards and needs of people in Vietnam. Currently there are no tram and underground systems therefore bus is essentially the only option of public transport. With respect to buses, many vehicles are not so clean and timely. I think a possible solution is to privatize the bus industry. Because of the profit motives, bus companies will try to find ways to improve the quality of their services.

- **Do you think that the government should invest more in transport projects?**

I think that developing transportation system will improve the capacity and efficiency of the Vietnamese economy. However, the problem of political corruption may kick in. Also, due to the huge costs of those projects, it is reasonable for the government to encourage private-sector investment. In the situation of Vietnam, my opinion is that much more money should be spent to improve public transport systems and make it more affordable to people from all social classes.

- **What types of transport do you think we will use in the future?**

I'm not sure, but hopefully we'll have cars that drive themselves and never crash. I think we'll probably fly more, and it might become normal to have your own plane. On the other hand, many cities are building more bicycle lanes, so maybe we will use cars less for getting around towns and cities.

8. Describe an important plant in your country (such as fruits, flowers or vegetables)

You should say:

What plant it is

How you first learned about this plant

Where it grows

And explain why you think it is important.

Sample Answer:

So first of all, as for how I know about mambo, well I can't really remember exactly how I first got to know about it, you know, it could have been in a biology class at school, or when I was out somewhere with my parents, but my guess would be that I probably first knew it at primary school because that was about the time when we first started learning about things like that.

Anyway, moving on to why bamboo is important, well I'd say it's pretty important for a number of reasons, the main one of which would be that it can be used to make so many different things, you know, such as chopsticks, shopping boards, flooring, what else, um...oh yes, and musical instruments, like the bamboo flute for example.

And **another thing to mention** is that bamboo is also used a lot for carrying stuff. For example, what I've seen people do is rest it on their shoulders, and then hang things on each end, because as well as being strong, it's also very flexible, so it won't break, even with very **heavy loads**. So it's extremely useful, and what's good about it is that it grows incredibly fast, you know, not like most other trees, and so although a lot of them are cut down to make stuff, there will still always be **an abundant supply** of it here.

But anyway, finally then as for how much I like bamboo well I'd say it's actually probably one of my favorite plants! Because I mean, it kind of just gives me a nice, peasant feeling whenever I see it. And it's also a plant which is often associated with Vietnam, because we grow so much of it here, so it's something that kind of **reminds me of my own culture**, if you know what I mean. So yes, I guess that's pretty much it then. Thanks for listening.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **another thing to mention is:** một điều khác nữa là
- **heavy loads:** những vật nặng
- **an abundant supply:** nguồn cung cấp dồi dào
- **reminds me of my own culture:** gợi nhớ về phong tục, văn hóa

Follow-up questions:

- **Do people in your country like growing plants by themselves?**

Well, I would say it depends; this may vary from the geographical location. You know, for people in the suburbs they most likely grow their own crops because they have a wide space like a barn or a plantation to grow their plants. What's more, this can ensure the quality of food is fresh especially vegetables and fruits like cabbage, carrots and strawberries. Another reason is that, they make this as a primary source of income, they sell their products on public market in town. Basically, this is where most people make money.

- **Where do people grow plants?**

There are several places where people plant their crops. The most common is the rice field, I can say that it's the best place to grow your plants because of the fact that rice fields has good soil quality and is sufficient for sunlight especially those plants that requires direct sunlight such as rice, corns, etc. But for some, they usually grow their plants on their back yard, they make a small area to plant some crops and some area to grow their flowers. Take my grandma as an example, she has a small backyard where she garden her plants everyday. She has varieties of tomatoes and flowers in it.

- **What do you think is the most important plant in your country?**

It is no doubt that paddy plant is the most essential plant in my country because rice is the main food in Vietnam. You know, people in Vietnam eat rice or noodles as part of their heavy meal. According to my history class, in ancient Vietnam people found a solution to feed their stomach using some basic ingredients, it is then they invented fried rice which has become the most common part of Vietnamese people's meal especially in the Southern area. I can tell that, it is not only an affordable meal but also a healthy meal as you can add vegetables and some seasoning to make it flavorful. So I have the thought that if there is no enough supply of rice, most people will starve especially the needy ones.

- **Do you want to be a farmer in the future?**

Farming is a decent job, I highly respect them and without farmers we will have no supply of crops, however, in my personal view point, I don't think it is a suitable job for me due to the reason that I want to be a good doctor. I have been an aspiring doctor since I was a kid and

my parents have been very supportive about it. The main reason why I want to be a doctor is because I want to help cure diseases all over China and to help spread health awareness to people. I respect farmers but being a farmer is not something I have thought of doing in the future.

- **Is it important to eat fruits?**

We all know that fruits must be part of our daily meals so I strongly believe that fruits are essential to us. I can provide a reason to prove this, first, when I got sick my doctor told me to eat healthy foods, what he meant was, to avoid processed foods and eat foods that grow on trees such as fruits like bananas, apple and grapes. I followed his advice and guess what? I recovered quickly. In general, fruits are natural remedies for illness and for long life.

- **Did you like to eat fruits when you were a child?**

If I can vividly remember, it wasn't difficult for me to eat any kinds of food during my childhood and fruits are not an exemption. So I am guessing that, I liked to eat fruits when I was young due to the fact that my mother prepared fruits in a very creative way. What I mean is that, she made different shapes out of an apple or banana which attracted me to eat it. Therefore, eating fruits was part of my meal when I was young.

9. Describe a family photo that you like.

You should say:

Who is in the photo?

Who took the photo?

Why this photo was taken

And explain why you like that photograph.

Sample Answer:

The family photograph that I really like and remember well is the one which was taken almost 20 years ago. This photograph was **framed and enlarged** by my father and it is still hanging on the wall of our drawing room. This photograph was taken when I was only 3 years old and at the 6th **marriage anniversary** of my parents.

My father, mother and I were standing in while my grandparents were sitting in front of us in this picture. The picture captured the memory of a very happy family. The time when this picture was taken, I was very little then and I don't have any particular memory of this event. Back then the camera was very rare in our country and I heard from my mother that a camera man was hired to take the photo of this event. The picture was taken in the garden of our house and my grandparents used to live with us at that moment.

My grandparents have passed away and this is **a revered memory** of them. I still look at this picture and feel sad not to have them with us now. I was very little and I still look at me in this photograph with **bewilderment**. This is the picture that gives me the memory of a happy event, happy family, and innocent me. As I notice this photograph very often at my home, I remember it very well. This is, in fact, the only picture I have of my **pre-school age**. So this is very important and memorable for me.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **framed and enlarged:** được đóng khung và phóng to
- **marriage anniversary:** ngày kỷ niệm cưới
- **a revered memory:** một kỷ niệm cao quý, đáng trân trọng, tôn sùng
- **bewilderment:** sự bối rối, hoang mang

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you like to take photographs? Why?**

I am not a professional photographer and my interests vary for a career. However, I do like clicking photographs from my iPhone, either when I am travelling or at parties. For me, photographs are a mere collection of the memories made which I often display at my house of social media account. Taking those crazy pictures, sometimes hazy fill me with joy and remind me of the great times I had.

- **Would you like to study photography?**

Presently not. I think there is already a lot on my plate. With a job at a corporate and being a freelancer leaves very little time for any learning. Also, my focus right now is on improving my writing and speaking skills. Having said that, photography is something I would love to learn but in the distant future and not immediately

- **What makes a good photograph?**

Although I love taking pictures for a long time, I haven't been concerned with the details and technical aspects of photography thoroughly. But I would say that the most important part of a good photograph is the theme of the picture. For example, a beautiful landscape could make a photo really impressive by just having beautiful colors or scenery. Furthermore, the angle that the photograph is taken from is significant as well, because with technique a simple theme can become an attractive one. Furthermore, lighting, focus on proper objects and use of right camera can make an ordinary scene to become a beautiful photograph.

- **What do you think about 'Photography' as a career?**

This question is equally interesting and difficult for me. My personal belief is that 'Photography' is a great occupation, not only because it is indispensable for many different fields but also because through it people can discover the world. To be more precise, by taking a photograph, the moment is frozen and the depiction is saved no matter what. Photographs decorate books, magazines, paintings and many other things. So, it's an essential vocation that is associated with other jobs, similar to it or not. In addition to this, photographers travel a lot across the world and see new places, landscapes, buildings and so on. It is something that apart from a profession is also a hobby and provides entertainment and spiritual education to photographers. As I see in my country the career of a good photographer is quite bright and full of possibility. With online journalism, this has become an even more demanding profession.

- **What are the improvements latest technologies has brought in photography?**

Technology has contributed to tremendous improvements in photography and its storage and distribution. First of all, smartphones and iPhone have built-in high-resolution cameras and that has made taking pictures easier and more convenient. People these days are no longer obligated to carry a professional camera with them to take pictures. Pictures taken from a mobile phone can be transferred and viewed on a personal computer and can be stored online. The photo editing software can not only change some basic characteristics of the photo taken but also the whole picture and can make it more appealing.

- **How often do you take photographs?**

Option 1: The truth is I used to take pictures very rarely in the past, but after I created my Instagram account, I've become accustomed to taking pictures very frequently. I really like capturing every important moment and other significant events with my friends and family and sharing them with my online friends has become a common activity for me. That doesn't mean, of course, that I take pictures all the time but I try not to miss capturing worthy moments and sceneries. My Instagram account, which is photograph storage and photo sharing website, has led and inspired me to use my camera more frequently than ever before

Option 2: It depends, if something funny or interesting happens then I'll snap it on my phone and share it on Facebook or Instagram, but if I'm not doing anything interesting then I don't really think about taking photos or pictures. I guess on average I take at least one picture a day, sometimes a lot more, so very frequently I suppose.

- **Do you take photographs of yourself?**

Not very often, I would say, but yes I do. Especially, when I have to go to a party, I click photos from my phone just to make sure that I am looking good. Also, it may sound funny, but

I do take my snaps when I am sad. The moment I see myself depressed I cheer up. It is my way of fighting back and reminding myself that life is beautiful. And then there are times when I am bored. So, I usually go to those crazy Instagram features and make funny faces and take pictures.

- **Do you have any good family photographs?**

Option 1: Very few I must say. And from the ones that we have, most of them are really crazy! Almost all of them have at least one of us making a weird face. But, there is a photograph of ours where my parents are holding me and my brother in their arms and we are smiling solemnly and are parents are looking at each other. It really makes me feel good and is framed and kept in the house.

Option 2: Yes, a lot. I like taking photos of my family, and so do my sisters, especially on special occasions like birthdays, anniversaries and other special days when we're all together. I've got quite a big family, so it's sometimes a challenge to get us all together in a photo – but we've got some really good ones over the years.

10. Describe a painting or work of art that you have seen.

You should say:

When you saw this work of art

Where you saw it

What it looked like

And explain your impression of it.

Sample Answers:

Ever since I was a little girl I have always been a huge fan of western style paintings. The most memorable piece of artwork that I have **come across** would probably be the Mona Lisa which was painted by the famous artist and inventor, Leonardo DaVinci.

I first saw this painting when I was in primary school, my art teacher taught us about DaVinci's paintings and of course the Mona Lisa was one of them. At first I thought it was just a boring **portrait** for an old woman but the more I looked at it the more I began to be attracted by her strange smile. It was also a little funny to me because she had no eye brows and her hair style is different to what I'm used to.

In my opinion DaVinci painted her almost like St Mary – She has **a kind and gentle look** and is always smiling at you, even her **sitting posture** is very **elegant** with one hand over the other. I think it's because Davinci was a Christian and also painted **religious paintings** such as the Last Supper.

I personally think the Mona Lisa is truly an impressive painting; after all it was painted by the great Leonardo DaVinci – without it the world just wouldn't be the same.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **come across:** tình cờ ngang quá
- **portrait:** bức chân dung
- **a kind and gentle look:** một ánh nhìn rất thân thiện và dịu dàng
- **sitting posture:** dáng, tư thế ngồi
- **elegant:** thanh lịch, tao nhã
- **religious paintings:** những bức họa về tôn giáo

Follow-up questions:

- **What benefits can you get from painting as a hobby?**

Well, I can think of several advantages from painting. First of all, painting boosts memory recollection skills and works to sharpen the mind through conceptual visualization and implementation. People who frequently use creative outlets such as writing, painting, and drawing have less chance of developing memory loss illnesses when they get older. More than that, painting allows people to express their feelings and emotions without words. Individuals that paint use art to overcome shyness and convey their personality. Using artwork to tell a story lets someone who is shy let go of normal social reservations.

- **Do you think people's preferences on arts changed in past few years?**

I would say that there were so many changes in people's life for the past few years and that have also changed people's preferences on arts. This is due to the reason that people's liking on arts alters because of the development of technology and changes of lifestyle. For instance, if you used to like ancient paintings in the past your preference today will be different it might be possible that you start liking modern abstract painting because of the effect of urbanization. I couldn't think of more reasons why but I suppose that in the near future there will be changes that will still affect people's preferences.

- **How do you think art classes affect children's development?**

I believe that art influences children in so many ways. One primary effect is their motor skills, many of the motions involved in making art, such as holding a paintbrush or scribbling with a crayon, are essential to the growth of fine motor skills in young children. Another positive influence is their language development, for every young children, making art or just simply talking about it provides the opportunities to learn words for colors, shapes and actions. When toddlers are as young as a year old, parents can do simple activities such as crumpling paper and calling it paper ball.

- **What makes a good painting?**

From my perspective, I suppose a good painting is one you can't take your eye's off, and from my perspective, it's either due to the colours and images or because of the emotional reaction I might have to the painting. This is largely due to the fact that I tend to like things I personally appreciate or enjoy. But of course, I also know that for other people, they think a good painting is usually because of the skill involved in painting it or because of the unique creativity of the artist. So all in all, I guess that a good painting means something different to everybody.

- **Are there many vegetarians in your country?**

Yes, they are. The number of people following vegetarianism has been increasing recently. It is thought that old people or those following a religious, like Buddhism, will be vegetarians; however, youngsters also join to vegetarian community because of many reasons.

11. Describe a library that you have used.

You should say:

Where it was

What (type of) building it was in /what type of library it was

What books and facilities it had

What you did in the library

And explain what you liked and /or disliked about this library

Sample Answers:

The library I'd like to talk about that I visited is 'Illumination Library' (Tell the name of a library from your home town) and it is situated in my home town. I have not visited this particular library for the last 2-3 years as I am not living in my hometown any longer and yet this is the library I will always remember. This library is situated at the center of our hometown and **occupies** the whole **three-story building**. There are plenty of books there and the library offers **a variety of books**, novels, research papers, magazines and so on for the **people of different tastes**.

The books are **well catalogued and arranged in a convenient fashion**. There are more than 3-4 librarians and several other assistants to help find any book. The library also **offers membership facility** and the active members are allowed to take books to home. Since the library **is funded by** the government **the membership fee** is very **negligible and affordable** for students, there are lots of people visiting and reading there.

People of our hometown consider this library as the best place to **gather knowledge, read in peace** and to find **reference books** for study or **professional reasons**. For me, this library **has**

a great influence on me. I became a member of this library when I was only 7 years old. My reading habit has been grown up from there. I became **a passionate reader of books and novels** and this library had a great influence on that. This library also helped me finishing some academic projects as I could find books and reference reading materials. I have read plenty of books in my **childhood and adolescence time** only because the library was conveniently there for me.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **three-story building:** tòa nhà có 3 tầng
- **a variety of:** đa dạng, phong phú
- **people of different tastes:** những người với những sở thích, thích hiểu khác nhau
- **well catalogued and arranged:** được hệ thống vào mục lục và sắp xếp tốt
- **a convenient fashion:** một kiểu dáng tiện lợi, thuận tiện
- **offer membership facility:** cung cấp cho thành viên những trang thiết bị
- **the membership fee:** phí thành viên
- **negligible and affordable:** không đáng kể và có thể chi trả được
- **gather knowledge:** thu thập kiến thức
- **professional reasons:** vì mục đích, lý do cho công việc
- **have a great influence on:** có ảnh hưởng to lớn đến
- **a passionate reader of:** người đam mê đọc (thể loại)
- **childhood and adolescence time:** khoảng thời gian tuổi thơ và thời niên thiếu

Follow-up questions:

- **Are there many public libraries in your country?**

Yeah, I'd say there are, because I mean, pretty much every city has a public library, at least as far as I know anyway. And to take my hometown as an example, we have a couple of them, one of which has actually just been built. And if you compare this to the situation in many other developing countries, you know, where libraries are pretty hard to come by, then I'd say we're pretty lucky with all the ones we have.

- **Do people in Vietnam prefer to read in a library or at home?**

I'd say on the whole people here generally prefer reading at home, simply because it's a lot less effort than going all the way to the library to read.

But then again, I suppose in some people's cases, going to the library might actually offer a more comfortable environment in which to read. For example, most libraries here tend to be air-conditioned during the summer and winter, whereas a lot of people's homes aren't, due to the fact that it costs quite a lot to keep the air conditioning on all day! So by going to the library to read, people can take advantage of the free air-conditioning!

- **What can people read in a library that they can't read in other places?**

That's good question, and to be honest with you I'm not really all that sure, but thinking about it, I suppose that a lot of libraries tend to have old books that are out of print, which you most likely wouldn't be able to find in a bookshop. And I think it's fair to say that in most cases, libraries have a much wider range of books than bookstores, especially when it comes to things like academic and specialist books, because after all, you know, bookstores are mainly focused on stocking books which they think are gonna sell well, which means that they're not gonna bother about having books which might only appeal to a small proportion of people.

- **Even though it might cost a lot to maintain a library, do you think every university should have its own library?**

Yeah, for sure. I mean, books are a great source of knowledge, and so for me I'd say they're one of the most important things that a university should have. You know, I think it would be impossible to get a decent university education without having easy access to a library.

- **With the rapid development of technology today, do you think we still need books in the future?**

Yeah, I'd say we most definitely do, because if you think about it, books have been in existence for hundreds of years, and through them, we've been able to pass on knowledge from generation to generation. And I'm pretty sure this will continue to be the case, because I mean, information which is stored through other means, for example electronically, can disappear or get lost very easily, whereas a book is a real object which is a lot easier to preserve over time. So yeah I'd say it's pretty certain that we'll still need them in the future.

- **Do you often go to libraries?**

Yeah, I go quite a lot, because for most of the assignments I get given on my major, there's normally quite a lot of background reading to be done. So yeah, I'd say I'm in the library probably about two or three times a week.

- **Why do you think a library is a good place for reading?**

Well first of all, libraries generally have a pretty good selection of books, which are all free to read, so it's a good place to browse through books without feeling any pressure to buy them, which you might feel if you were in a bookshop! So that's one thing, and I guess another good thing about libraries is that they tend to have seating areas where you can sit down and read for as long as you want without being bothered by anyone.

- **Who should be responsible for the cost of running libraries?**

That's a good question, and I guess it kind of depends. Because I mean, if, for example, the library belongs to a school or university, then it should be their responsibility to take care of the running costs, but if it's a public library, then I guess it should really be the responsibility of the local government, because after all, their funds come from the taxes of the local citizens, and I think it's reasonable to expect that these taxes be used to provide and maintain public services such as libraries.

- **Should the government spend more money on libraries?**

Well I'm not sure about everywhere else in China, but here in Hangzhou, I think the government's already spent a huge amount of money on the local libraries, you know, so I'd say there's no need for them to spend much more, apart from covering the operating costs of the ones we currently have.

- **Do you think public libraries should be free of charge?**

Yeah, I'd say they definitely should, because I mean, only in this way will everyone be able to enjoy their services, regardless of how rich or poor they are. You know, a lot of people can't afford a good education, or even books for that matter, and so libraries are one of the few places where everyone can go to to either enrich their knowledge or simply just read for pleasure.

- **What services and facilities should a good library have, besides lending books?**

Well, I suppose one thing they should have is a decent seating area, with Internet access of course, where people can go to either read or do their work in a quiet environment. So that's one thing, and I suppose another thing that good libraries should offer are meeting rooms, where people can get together in small groups and have discussions without disturbing others in the library.

- **Should libraries have computers capable of connecting to the internet?**

Yeah, I mean, why not?! You know, it's another good service which libraries can offer, especially for people who aren't lucky enough to own their computers with access to the Internet. Having said that though, I think it would be wise for libraries to restrict the kinds of websites that people can go onto, because otherwise you know, you might get people just going there to play online games, which obviously is not what the purpose of going to a library should be!

- **How do you think libraries can (or do) encourage people to read more?**

That's a good question, and thinking about it, I guess one thing that libraries could do would be to invite authors to come and talk about their books, which might increase people's interest in reading. And as well as this, I suppose another thing might be to arrange a book club, or something like that, where people could get together in the library to discuss various books they've read, because by doing this, people will probably be able to develop a deeper appreciation of books.

- **How do you think libraries will change in the future?**

Well, I don't know if some are doing it already, but in the future, as well as being able to browse books in the library, I think that there could also be a kind of digital area with iPads and things where you'll be able to actually browse through e-books.

So that's one thing, and as well as this, I suppose another possible thing that could happen is that people probably won't even need to go to the library in order to rent a book out, because I imagine that libraries will probably have an online database which people can access from their computers at home, and then have the books they want delivered to their homes. And I mean, this is already happening with online bookstores like Amazon, but it hasn't yet happened with libraries, at least as far as I know, so I guess it's just a matter of time before they start doing this.

- **Do you think we will still need libraries in the future, now that we have the internet?**

Yeah I'd say we do, because I mean, first of all, not everyone has access to the Internet, and not only that but a lot of people also don't know how to use the internet, especially the older generation. So yeah, I think that libraries will always be a valuable service for anyone with an interest in books and just learning in general

- **What kind of skills and personal qualities do you think library staff should have?**

That's an interesting question, and I've never really thought about it before, but I suppose one important quality that library staff should have is an interest in books, because if they do, they'll be able to provide more of a valuable service to people, such as recommend them on what books to read. So that's one thing, and, uh...what else.....um, ...I'm sorry, I'm sure there are other things, but right now this is all that comes to mind I'm afraid!

12. Describe a practical skill that you have (such as driving a car, speaking a foreign language, cooking etc.)

You should say:

What this skill is

Who taught you this skill; (how and when you learned it)

How long you learned this skill

And explain how this skill is useful to you.

Sample Answer:

Well one skill that I have is playing the guitar.

I learned it when I was young. I learned how to play because I had many friends that played the guitar and when they played and sang, I knew I just had to learn. At first it was a little difficult because to be quite frank, I really didn't see myself as someone **who was musically I inclined**. I had to tell myself that I could do it and little by little, a note here and a chord I there, I managed to pick it up. Even now I have a long way to go with playing but I have found it enjoyable not just for myself, for others have said they enjoy it as well. I have had a few guitars and although there are different styles and qualities, to me it seems that as long as they have **strings** on them and you can **tune** them, they are fine.

I use the guitar to **cheer myself up** when I am **feeling a little down** and also use it to teach songs to others. I have never made money teaching guitar but I have made a little money playing and singing. I don't know if I would want to **pursue this skill as a career** but as long as I still enjoy it, I am going to do it.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **be inclined:** có xu hướng, thiên hướng
- **strings:** dây đàn
- **tune:** giai điệu (n), lên dây đàn (v)
- **cheer up:** làm cho vui lên
- **feel down:** cảm thấy buồn, xuống tinh thần
- **pursue something as a career:** theo đuổi thứ gì như một sự nghiệp

Follow-up questions:

- **Can you compare the skills that are important nowadays with the skills that were important 20 or 30 years ago?**

Twenty/thirty years ago, traditional skills like weaving, knitting, sewing and earthenware pottery making were an integral part of people's lives. But, nowadays, computer, management, language, and data analysis skills are given more importance.

- **What skills are valued most in your country?**

My country is a developing nation and there are many sectors such as banking, manufacturing, information technology and tourism etc. In almost every sector, basic computer skills and communication skills are of utmost significance.

- **What kind of skills might be important in the future?**

This is an interesting question. Considering the amount of data generated every day, I think that in the future the demand for research and data analysis skills will rise considerably.

- **Why should companies invest a lot of money in training?**

Training programs are vital for the growth of a company. A company with the trained staff is more likely to outperform its competitors. Regular training sessions upgrade the knowledge and skills of employees which in turn leads to higher productivity and profitability. For this reason, many companies spend a major part of their annual budget on different types of trainings.

- **Do you think schools and universities prepare young people well for the future employment?**

Not really. I think that secondary schools and universities in most parts of the world focus too much on conventional academic subjects like mathematics, science and history etc. Professional skills are often neglected. This imbalance between theoretical and practical knowledge has a negative impact on the future job prospects of young people.

- **Compare the importance of practical skills and academic skills.**

Well actually both are much needed in society. It seems to me that practical skills such as knowing how to cook a meal or clean a house or take care of children are slipping, whereas academic skills such as teaching a class or doing research seem to be on the rise. This is not bad in itself because there need to be people who are thinking about how things work and how to improve them, but the skills needed for everyday life shouldn't be looked on as any less important than others.

- **How can people learn practical skills?**

A lot of these skills can be learned at home with their mother and father and family. Skills such as sewing, budgeting or maintenance can be learned from an aunt or uncle, grandfather or grandmother. If more difficult trades want to be learned, such as plumber or electrician or mason, there are vocational schools that could teach those. The main thing to learning a skill is the motivation that is involved.

- **Do you think children should learn some practical skills at school?**

I think that children should learn practical skills at school. This would help to prepare them for life outside of school. A lot of times not much thought is put into how to manage money or take care of an apartment but I think these skills would be helpful. Life in the working world can be a lot different than the sheltered life of schooling, so having some practical skills such as those learned from a part-time job would be beneficial to a student.

- **How useful will these skills be to the children after they leave school?**

Well as I was saying in the previous question, these skills would be very helpful to children after they leave school. When a teenager goes from high school to college he has to start managing things on his own without the security of mom and dad. Even more so when a young adult graduates from college or university, he would also be very grateful to have some practical knowledge on how to survive in the working world.

- **Do you think it's useful for adults to attend classes to further their education?**

Sure, why not, if it is something that they find useful in their lives and something that they enjoy. Learning is lifelong and I don't know if it has to stop in old age. Now I know that a lot of times these adults are looked upon as teachers, but if they feel so inclined why not attend a class to further their education. If they are not able to keep up with the young students then this would be a detriment, but if there are no disruptions why not?

- **What are some reasons why adults might attend classes?**

Well I guess one of the main ones is that they are working and they need to keep up with the latest technology that will help them to stay abreast of the latest in their fields. Sometimes they might even be thinking of switching careers so they take classes to get the training to do so. Other times they might just want to learn some things in their spare time that will enhance their life on a recreational level. Other times their bosses might want them to learn some special skill for the good of the company.

- **Who do you think should pay for adult education—the government, the student or the company (if it is a work-related course)?**

Again it depends on the course and why they are taking it. If it is for personal gain or gratification then of course students should be responsible to pay for it. If the government is offering a course and adults are interested in it then it is already paid for. If it is going to move the company ahead and bring financial results then of course the company should pay for it. Now if the company can't pay for it and it interests the individual then it is up to him to get the money together to attend the class.

Other possible questions:

- **Can you suggest a way that people can study together?**
- **Do you think government should pay for old people to learn something?**
- **Do you think of online learning?**
- **Do you think learning materials on the internet are reliable?**

13. Describe a couple you know who have a happy marriage.

You should say:

Who they are

How you know them

What they usually do together

And how you feel about their marriage.

Sample answer:

Well, I would like to talk about my own parents whose marriage is **undoubtedly long lasting**. They have been married for 30 years now and are the perfect couple in my eyes. Ohm, my mother and father are now in their 60s. They are still really busy with their **nine to five jobs** in a **government office** even though both of them are going to retire later this year.

During 30 years of marriage, my parents have **gone through a lot of thick and thin** but have never lost the love for each other. To be more specific, my parents **show their affection** simply by always being honest with each other and sharing their true feelings. Their **mutual understanding** is so profound that sometimes they only need one look to find out what the other person wants. And yes, **minor tiffs** still happen **every now and then** between my mom and dad, you know things like who will have to pick up the kids or who get the TV remote. However, my dad is always the first one to **give in** and turn to **comfort my mother**. I think that little action is actually the key to my parents' **long-term relationship**.

To me, mom and dad is **a perfect match** and I admire their love so much. Hopefully, in the future, I can get myself a partner that care for me as much as my parents care for each other.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **undoubtedly**: chắc chắn, không còn nghi ngờ gì
- **long lasting**: bền lâu
- **nine to five jobs**: những công việc làm từ 9 giờ sáng đến 5 giờ chiều
- **government office**: văn phòng chính phủ
- **go through thick and thin**: trải qua thăng trầm, vui buồn
- **show affection**: thể hiện niềm yêu thích, yêu thương
- **mutual understanding**: sự thấu hiểu từ 2 phía, lẫn nhau
- **minor tiffs**: những xích mích, mâu thuẫn không đáng, nhỏ nhặt
- **every now and then** = sometimes, occasionally, from time to time
- **give in**: đầu hàng, từ bỏ
- **comfort**: an ủi, làm vui lòng
- **long-term relationship**: mối quan hệ dài lâu
- **a perfect match**: cuộc hôn nhân hoàn hảo

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you often attend weddings?**

I seldom attend weddings, very seldom this is for the reason that it's not every day or every month that my friends or relatives get married. Hence, when I need to attend a wedding ceremony I never miss it since it's just once in a lifetime experience. As a matter of fact, the last time I attended a wedding was couple of years ago. It was my friend's wedding and the experience was impeccable primary because I got to see her in a beautiful wedding gown and I was able to meet my former classmates as well. We had so much fun!

- **How are weddings celebrated in Vietnam?**

Vietnam has 54 ethnicity groups therefore its wedding traditions are largely various. However, for the vast majority of ethnicity groups, grooms and their families take the active role, from inviting guests to organizing events during the wedding. When weddings are celebrated, traditional food, songs and wishes appear very often. Over the past few years though, it has been criticized that Vietnamese families are spending too much on celebrating weddings as a way to show off their wealth and social status.

- **Would you accept an arranged marriage?**

I would never accept to be in an arranged marriage. Some parents choose partners for their children base on wealth and social status instead of mutual love. In my opinion, arranged

marriage without any mutual love will come to an end by divorce. I think that everyone has the freedom to choose their lovers and partners. Having said that, parents should play the role of advisers who will help their kids in certain stages of their marriage, such as giving tips on when having children is appropriate.

- **Do you think the traditional roles of husbands and wives in Vietnam have changed?**

Yes and no. Many people believe that Vietnam has been a much more gender-neutral country where women can do jobs that men do. However in rural areas, a large number of women are still kept inside houses to carry out housework and agricultural tasks. Many of them are victims of domestic violence and sexism in workplaces. Having said that, in my opinion, a march of progress in gender equality has taken place. Vietnamese men are taking an increasing role in housework and Vietnamese women's participation in the labor force is rising as well.

- **What are the factors causing a rise in the rate of divorce?**

The first factor is the birth and regulations that allow couples to divorce easier, without the need to prove that their partners have violated a certain law. Secondly, as more women have jobs, their financial independence increases. This means they no longer have to rely on men to have a decent living. Thirdly, these days many people would like to choose a happy marriage rather than an "empty nutshell". Therefore, if mutual love has gone, they are willing to divorce.

- **Do you think people should live together before marriage?**

I am not against cohabitation but I believe that it will be a tough job. People who want to pursue a certain period of cohabitation should be aware that a lot of challenges will be created. Without formally registering their relationship as a marriage, they are certainly excluded from certain laws and regulations that protect couples such as child benefits. Unexpected pregnancy is another issue if there is a lack of knowledge and understanding about sexual relationships. Finally, if couples are young and lack life experience, conflicts may arise.

- **What are some of the disadvantages of marriage?**

I think marriage becomes an issue when it restricts the freedom of individual. Single people can happily live their lives pretty much as they please without having to be concerned with the needs or wishes of others. Even more, often people split up easier when they are not married. Marriage to an extent increases the time for which people are together. So, no matter people don't like the company, they tend to stretch on.

- **What are some of the advantages of marriage?**

I think most of the human beings seek companionship and I think life becomes more beautiful when it is shared with someone who has the same opinions as yours. Marriage benefits society generally because it is associated with stable families. Stable families produce happier children and a more stable society with less crime and other social problems. Even more, it reduces the risk of STDs.

- **What is the role of women in Vietnam?**

Well, women are playing an ever increasingly important role in our life. They can receive as much education and have the same access to job opportunities as men. Their contribution to the society is as important as, if not more than, men. They work in all walks of life, enjoying equality with men. But they have one more important role to play: to give birth to and to raise babies. Apart from their improved social status, they are more economically independent at home. After getting married, some wives have become economically dependent upon their husbands while others pursue their careers instead of taking care of the household chores.

- **When do you think is the perfect age to get married?**

That's an interesting question! Well, In my personal point of view, 27 to 30 years old is the best age for marriage for the reason that people have stable job and possibly be financially stable. Generally, most people graduate from the university before 25 years old and by then they could start hunting a job. One more thing is that, being a young parent can connect to their children when it comes to modern society situations. You know, now a days most parents have generation gap which causes misunderstanding of lifestyle and interest. Take me as an example, my dad often scolds me for hanging out with my friends every weekends, as a result, it leads to a small argument.

Other possible questions:

- **What are the roles men and women may play in Vietnamese marriage?**
- **Do you think Vietnamese wedding is waste lots of money?**
- **Why use lots of money for the wedding?**
- **Why just save them to do other things?**
- **Do you think man should take care of baby? Why?**

14. Describe your favorite piece of clothing.

You should say:

Where you got it

When you got it

How often you wear it

And explain why it is your favorite clothing.

Sample answer:

Well, I would like to tell you about my **pair of ripped jeans** which is the favorite **fashion item** among all the things I have in my **wardrobe**. You know, I bought it with an unbelievably cheap price a long time ago in a **second-hand clothing store**. At that point, ripped jeans were really popular and everybody in my school was keen on them. So, whenever I put on jeans, I felt fashionable and really **stood out from the crowd**.

After a while, when the trend changed, I still refused to **abandon** my pair of jeans. I wore them almost everywhere from home to school and only changed them for formal events such as a ceremony or a wedding. Sometimes I even slept in my jeans because it was so comfortable.

Actually, it is quite easy to understand why I **fancy** jeans so much. First, it instantly **creates a modern and active look for wearers**. Second, jeans are easy to **mix and match**, I can wear jeans with numerous types of shirt without worrying about looking **ridiculous in other people's eyes**.

And lastly, jeans' material is so tough that it cannot **be torn apart**, so I can use them for a long time and **save a great deal of money**. All in all, I love my jeans and cannot go through a day without them. I think such item should be made **trendy** again so that the youngsters nowadays can get to know its awesomeness.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **pair of ripped jeans:** những chiếc quần jean rách
- **fashion items:** những món đồ thời trang
- **wardrobe:** tủ quần áo
- **second-hand clothing store:** cửa hàng quần áo đã qua sử dụng
- **stand out from the crowd:** nổi bật so với số đông
- **abandon:** bỏ rơi, từ bỏ
- **fancy (v):** thích, muốn
- **creates a modern and active look for wearers:** tạo cho người mặc vẻ ngoài hiện đại và năng động

- **to mix and match:** phối đồ, kết hợp các trang phục
- **ridiculous in other people's eyes:** kỳ cục trong mắt mọi người
- **be torn apart:** bị xé, rách
- **save a great deal of money:** tiết kiệm được rất nhiều tiền
- **trendy:** theo xu hướng, thời thượng

Follow-up questions:

- **How important are clothes and fashion to you? [Why/Why not?]**

Clothes and fashion are not that important to me. I always prefer comfortable clothes but making sure that I'd look presentable and clean. I am more of being practical in choosing what I wear.

- **Do people in your country like to go shopping?**

Absolutely, there is no doubt that people in China like shopping a lot especially young ladies. They go shopping almost every day, as a matter of fact, this has become their addiction because ones they see something attractive they will buy it in an instant or some just go for window shopping. Take me as an example, I often buy something at the shopping mall whenever I see something that attracts me. On the other hand, shopping is a stress reliever for most people. Let's say for instance my aunt, whenever she is stress or gloomy she will buy a new pair of shoes. She is a shoe addict and a new pair of shoes can enlighten her day.

- **What kinds of clothing do people in your country like to wear?**

Fashion is very essential for millennials as it represents their lifestyle and well-being. As you know, in Vietnamese young people normally wear skirts or shorts and tank tops, they usually show much of their skin because to them they find it cute and sexy. I have a thought that, this fashion trend they have is like a revenge of their strict custom as they are known to be conservative especially in ancient times. On the contrary, adults dress according to their age; they wear casual dress or shirt and jeans with a sense of style. Most likely, you can see them wearing branded bags or shoes to showcase their sense of fashion.

- **How often do people in your country buy clothes?**

Impulsive buying is very common for Vietnamese. Can you believe that people in my country usually buy clothes almost every week or once in two weeks. This is due to the fact that in Vietnam you can buy affordable clothes in the shopping mall or online. Once they get attracted to a certain piece of clothing they will just purchase it in an instance. Another reason for this is because clothes have become a basic necessity especially for women. Especially that we're influenced with fashion industry, more and more women are too curious about how they look, being fashionable is just part of their well-being

- **How do people choose what style of clothing to buy?**

Many people buy clothing because it is a new style or it's a color that they like. Often people will buy something because it looks like what a favorite movie star or singer wears. Other people buy clothes that suit them, or that they will wear most often. Other people just buy clothes because they are functional.

- **Do you think people enjoy buying clothes**

I think many people do. Living in today's material world where books are judged by cover, both literally and figuratively, many people are concerned about how they look to others. So shopping for clothes has become an increasingly popular hobby especially among young people.

- **Do you think the brand of clothing is important?**

Personally I don't really care about the brand of clothing as long as what I buy is good quality. Famous brands are usually too expensive for me so I will rarely buy them. Often I can find inexpensive brands that are just as good a quality and very nice. Of course here in China you can get brand name clothes at a very cheap price.

- **Why do some people go together with other people when shopping for clothes?**

Well, like I've just said, shopping in our society is more of a hobby than a task to be done, and most hobbies aren't meant to be enjoyed alone. Besides, when you are shopping for clothes, it sure helps if there's someone to tell you how you look in those clothes when u try them on. And since you can't really count on the opinion of the shop assistants because their main concern is the number of sales, you can certainly use an objective opinion from a friend or a family member who tags along.

- **Why do some people buy brand-name clothes?**

Many people buy brand name clothing because they like the style. However, some people simply want their clothes to last a long time, so they buy a certain brand of clothing that is known for its good quality. Other people buy brand name clothing because they feel it make them look more stylish and hip. Some people just like to have that name on their clothing. I think it might make them feel important.

- **How different are the clothes you wear now from those you wore 10 years ago?**

Well, I can say that there hasn't been much change with the clothes I wear now with that of about 10 years ago. I still wear the regular jeans and shirt for casual days or formal clothes on business events. But, I think since the trend has changed, the kind of these basic clothing has also changed for me, especially when it comes to the style of the jeans and shirts. I used to wear straight-cut jeans but nowadays, I wear contemporary style such as slim-fit clothes.

- **What do you think the clothes we wear say something about us?**

At times, I think the clothes we wear may show part of our personality or status. For example, clothing may determine the kind of job a person has. For some, it may be a tool for expression. Some could be stylish and fashionable which may reflect their personality as being creative.

- **Do men and women have the same shopping habits when they buy clothes?**

No, they have very different shopping habits. Often men will shop less and only because they need new clothes. They often do not buy much, and they will spend less money on what they buy. Actually I think that they dread shopping and probably would rather go to the dentist. Women buy clothes more often and they usually pay more for their clothing. Often they will buy new clothes because they want to be in style. I think women also don't mind spending money as long as it's their boyfriend's or husband's.

- **What's the effect of fashion industry on the current fashion?**

Wow, this is a very broad question. I obviously think that the fashion industry plays an important role in shaping people's mindset towards fashion and influencing their buying behavior through social media, but i can't really tell how it happens or to what extent people's ideas of fashion are influenced by the fashion industry.

15. Describe an English lesson that you enjoyed

You should say:

When it was

What it was about

What happened?

And explain why you liked it

Sample answer:

Well, I would like to share with you about a really **pleasant experience** in an English class I had in my university. During one of our grammar lessons, the **regular teacher** was sick so the school had to send **a substitute teacher to cover her place**. And Thomas Hall, the one who took care of our class that day, **delivered an amazing lecture** in English about how he thinks we all should learn languages through watching films.

Throughout two hours, he explained to us **the process of learning** a language and how films can **serve as** an effective way to **immerse in a language**. **Basic elements** like vocabulary and grammar can **be easily absorbed** if we focus on dialogs on a TV show. So in the long run, our overall language skills can be improved. This helps us learn any languages **effortlessly** in **a short period of time**. At first, we all were **skeptical** about the

ideas he introduced, however, after watching a short video to practice and doing **a trial test**, we were all **convinced** that learning by movie was not hard at all and we could apply this to **enhance our performance** at school.

I enjoyed this lesson so much because I find it particularly effective to me. I always felt **demotivated** when learning by the traditional methods and my results were not **desirable**. But when I tried learning English by using my favorite movies, you know what? My English got better and better and very soon I am able to remember thousands of new words and write really complicated essays. Now, I even **proudly say** that I have mastered the English language.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **pleasant experience**: một trải nghiệm dễ chịu, thoải mái
- **regular teacher**: giáo viên chính thức
- **substitute teacher**: giáo viên thay thế
- **cover someone's place**: thay thế, làm thay vị trí của ai đó
- **deliver an amazing lecture**: có một bài giảng tuyệt vời
- **the process of learning**: quá trình học (= the learning process)
- **immerse in a language**: đắm mê, đắm chìm trong ngôn ngữ
- **serve as**: đóng vai trò như
- **be easily absorbed**: dễ hấp thụ
- **effortlessly**: rất dễ, không tốn nhiều công sức
- **a short/long period of time**: một thời gian ngắn/dài
- **skeptical**: đa nghi, hoài nghi
- **be convinced**: bị thuyết phục
- **enhance our performance**: tiến bộ
- **demotivate**: làm cho mất đi động lực
- **desirable**: như mong muốn
- **proudly say**: nói, kể một cách từ hào rằng

Follow-up questions:

- **What do you think of children learning a foreign language?**

I think it's a great idea especially for children. I myself had to start learning English more fluently while in my university to go for my Master's degree in the UK. If I had started as a child like my nephew I wouldn't have had to put in so many hours now as an adult. Everyone knows that children grasp foreign languages much easier than adults.

- **Some students hate to learn foreign languages, what can teachers do to develop their interest?**

Stop focusing on grammar and focus more on the spoken language which may be somewhat different than learning strictly from text books. Grammar for most people is boring and This turns off many people from studying a language especially in China and other countries that rely heavily on grammar and reading for their classes. Teachers should speak more of the foreign language they are teaching to make it more fun. Then the learners can understand some common phrases and idioms much faster and have a lot more fun with the new language they are learning.

- **Some people travel for learning a foreign language, what do you think?**

I think it can be beneficial if you have enough money to visit a country that has native speakers of the chosen language that you want to learn. The problem is that it is costly and unless you are a student going to a university in that country the cost is hard to justify. If you are a student perhaps learning in the UK and your target language is English then it's a great idea. You will get to know the pronunciation, slang, common phrases etc. much faster than studying it in your home country

- **What's the best way to learn a foreign language?**

I think the best way to learn a foreign language is to learn from a native speaker if you have some of the basics of the language you want to learn. What is common nowadays is to learn a foreign language from a native speaker online. This is efficient because you don't have to visit a school and travel 30 or more minutes in each direction. This save a lot of time and the cost of learning the target foreign language is considerably cheaper than face to face classes at a school specializing in that language. You just need to find an online native speaker that suits you well and understands you and you understand him/her well enough to have long term classes

- **Why can some people learn languages fast while others learn slowly?**

A lot has to do with age and whether the person is a male or female. It is well known that children learn foreign languages much faster than adults. Another factor is that girls/women's brains are slightly different and they can usually grasp foreign languages faster than guys. And lastly, the person learning the language must be somewhat motivated to learn that language. If a person has no desire to do it they will learn the language very slowly if at all.

- **Does one's age affect their language learning?**

Of course! As the saying goes, "You can't teach an old dog new tricks." goes along with older people learning a new language. Older people are somewhat set in their ways and find it harder

to remember new vocabulary than younger people. Younger people especially children haven't learned all of the vocabulary of their mother tongue so they compare the words they know in their own language and make it a synonym in the foreign language so it's much easier for them to learn than older people.

Other possible questions:

- Do you want to become a foreign language teacher in the future? Why?
- Why some people learn fast while others are slow?
- Do you think grammar is important when you learn a foreign language? Why?
- Why there are strong demands for language skills?
- Do you think foreigner should learn Vietnamese when they arrive to Vietnam?
- What kind of quality should language teacher have?
- Why people want to learn a foreign language?

16. Describe a person who solved a problem in a clever way.

You should say:

Who the person was

When you met the person

Where you met the person

And explain why you think he or she was clever.

Sample answer:

Well, I would like to talk about my mother, who I consider to have the smartest ways to **deal with any problems** she encounters. My mother's intelligence has been shown since she was still in school. At that point, she was an excellent student in almost every subject she had, especially math. She could **figure out** really complicated exercises which no one in the class can.

And I think that was actually the reason why she was always the favorite students of all her teachers. Even after leaving school, she can still apply her amazing **problem-solving skills** to **cope with** various situations at work or at home. My mother is the only person I know who **have no difficulty balancing between work, family's matters**, and her own **personal life**. It is mainly due to her **effective working techniques** and **time management skills**. For example, she can easily **sort out** how much money needed to be spent on a particular aspect of the family and she never **misses a deadline** for any of her works at the company.

Another reason why I think my mother is such a smart person is because of the **endless efforts** she put into studying. My mother has never stopped learning even after she left university. She has tried her best to **broaden her knowledge** day by day by reading books or watching the news on TV. I can say that that woman is always **well-prepared** and ready to **face any hardships** life could throw at her. I have learned a lot from my mother and hopefully can become a person just like her in my future.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **deal with problems:** giải quyết những vấn đề, rắc rối
- **figure out = sort out:** nhận ra, tìm ra giải pháp
- **problem-solving skill:** kỹ năng giải quyết vấn đề
- **cope with:** đối phó, đương đầu với
- **have (no) difficulty Ving:** có/không có khó khăn trong
- **family's matters:** những vấn đề gia đình
- **personal life:** đời sống cá nhân
- **time management skills:** kỹ năng quản lý thời gian
- **miss a deadline:** trễ hạn chót
- **endless efforts:** nỗ lực rất nhiều, vô kể, không ngừng
- **broaden her knowledge:** mở mang kiến thức
- **be well-prepared:** chuẩn bị thật tốt, sẵn sàng
- **face hardships:** đối mặt với khó khăn

Follow-up questions:

- **What is the difference between the role of a teacher and a parent in the education of children?**

Well, primarily, I think parents are more responsible for imparting values and ethics to their children and teachers at school are given the task of equipping children with academic skills. You could also say that parent's educate more by example, how they do things and react to things whereas teachers teach children how to do things based on a curriculum designed by educational experts, it's not such a personal experience.

- **What suggestions would you give to teachers to improve education?**

I know when I was at school some of the subjects seemed very uninteresting to us as students. I think maybe teachers need to look at how they relate the subject matter to the real world or the student's experience of the real world. I know they are now using more technology in schools than before and this is a good thing. In general, students have to see that something is relevant, or at least interesting, so if teachers can make it obvious why it's important to learn something then maybe students will be more interested.

- **What is the best way to educate children in your opinion?**

Children need to be taught real skills, things which will be relevant in their future life. They need to learn what will be needed by society in the future. Most children seem to learn quicker by doing things than listening to teachers talking about something. If children can be involved in a variety of activities that help develop the skills they need then I think they will learn successfully.

- **How can we help children realise their talents?**

The first thing is to identify those talents. That is not an easy thing to do in many cases. It's then a case of making sure that children receive support and the resources to explore and develop their talent to the fullest. Schools need to be able to give children access to equipment, resources or facilities that they may not have in the home environment or that their parents cannot provide.

- **Does the government provide enough support to education in your view?**

They can always provide more... but it's not the quantity so much as the quality of support they provide. It must be relevant and focused on the key areas of education. It must be well planned and provide the best possible resources and facilities for children to grow and develop their academic and life skills.

Other possible questions:

- **Do you think children's lives are influenced by their parents?**
- **Do you think children have a good habit nowadays? Why?**
- **Why are children cleverer than before? Nature or nurture? Why?**
- **What kind of skills are helpful for children? Why?**
- **Do you think parents should send their children to a better school? Why?**

17. Describe an interesting experience during your childhood.

You should say:

When it happened

Who you were with

And explain how you felt about it

Sample answer:

Well, I would like to tell you about the time I prepared a **handmade present** for my mother on my own for her birthday when I was a small child.

So, it was on my mother's 32nd birthday and I really wanted to give my mother a special gift that wasn't like others'. **After much thought and consideration**, I **came up with the idea** of drawing a portrait as a gift. So, I **rolled up my sleeves** and started working really hard on the painting two weeks before her birthday. However, it was an **overwhelmingly difficult** task to me because at that point, I had no drawing experience. I just tried my best to portray her on a piece of paper as careful as possible, even though the way I drew was really **messy and clumsy** (I did not know that till I grew up).

The picture was finally completed after ten days of **struggling** but I was afraid that my mother would think this was just an ugly **piece of art** and throw it away. But **things turned out to be** completely different! When I gave my mother the picture, she **was completely moved** and became really **emotional**. She said that was the best gift she ever received in her life. It was **an unforgettable experience** to me as that was one of the few times I did something for my mother.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **handmade present:** quà làm bằng tay, thủ công
- **After much thought and consideration:** sau rất nhiều suy nghĩ và cân nhắc
- **came up with the idea:** nghĩ ra một ý tưởng
- **roll up my sleeve [idiom]:** bắt đầu, tiến hành
- **overwhelmingly difficult:** rất khó
- **messy and clumsy:** bừa bộn và vụng về
- **struggle:** khó khăn, vất vả
- **piece of art:** bức họa, bức tranh
- **things turned out to be:** mọi thứ trở nên (thường là trái với với mong đợi)
- **be moved:** bị làm cho cảm động, xúc động
- **emotional:** có nhiều cảm xúc, dễ xúc động
- **unforgettable experience:** một trải nghiệm khó quên

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you think people often idealize their childhood?**

Certainly they do. The older we get, the more nostalgic we get about the past. It's only normal. And why should we dwell on the negatives. I don't think it does any harm to idealize a bit if it makes us happy to remember things in a more positive light. The only danger is that it may make unhappy with our current lost to believe that everything was so much better back then.

- **How does a person's childhood influence what kind of adult they become?**

Well, I suppose the adult you become is influenced by three main factors. Firstly, your childhood, that is nurture; then your genes, that is nature and last but not least, the choices you make as an adult. To my mind, of all three, nurture has the greatest impact. They've conducted research on twins who were separated at birth and while there are undoubtedly many similarities between them, they are also very different in many key ways: their success in the world of work, their relationships with other people. I think all this is influenced by the role models we have throughout our childhoods.

- **What does a child become an adult in your view?**

That's a difficult question to answer and all societies grapple with this issue. It is, of course critical for the criminal justice system to define an adult correctly, or at least try to, because if somebody commits a crime as a child, they get treated more leniently than if they commit a crime as an adult. So I suppose you have to decide when you think people become fully responsible for their actions. I wouldn't want to be the one making the decision. I just don't know.

- **Do you agree with the saying children should be seen and not heard.**

I'm assuming this means that children should respect their elders and not create havoc by being noisy and answering adults back. I have some sympathy with this view. However, moderation is usually the best course to take in doing as they're told. Too many children nowadays think they run the household, making demands, etc. However, it is also true that child is part of the family, too and also deserves respect. I think this means they should be allowed to express their points of view and they should be listened to and consulted. It's a fine balance. I suppose.

- **It is good for children to be exposed to frightening and sad experiences or should they be protected from these as far as possible?**

I don't think they should experience too many sad or terrifying experiences, it can be helped. Nevertheless, what is very useful for teaching children about these darker sides of life without scarring them is stories. In stories they can learn about evil and the dangers in the world around them, but in a controlled way where the 'baddies' are punished and everyone ends up happy. This gives them a focus for the fears that all children have but it is a fictional one so doesn't upset their peace of mind.

- **Are children in your country generally well brought up?**

My instinct is to say so, because you see many misbehaving children when you're out and about. In reality, there are probably many more well brought up children than badly brought ones, it's just the good children don't attract your attention as much.

- **What kinds of children's activities are there available in your city?**

Children in our city often play outdoor games, though this trend is changing day-by-day with the advancement of computing and gaming devices. Children can visit the museum, zoological garden, and amusement parks in my city. They often go to exhibitions from schools which they enjoy a lot. Many parents take their children to their relative or friends' houses where they play and make friends with other kids. They are also allowed to watch cartoons and other programmes suitable for them.

- **What activities do you think there will be in the future?**

As the technology is advancing rapidly and is becoming more popular among the children, I think computer games, Internet and TV programmes would become more popular among children in the future. The schools are evolving from merely educational institutions to more entertaining and interactive, the schools would arrange a more social gathering, party and tour that would become prominent in the future and many children would get engaged in these activities. Parents would become more conscious to nurture the hidden talents among their kids and that's why they would take them to different places to let them experience the world.

- **What kind of pressure do children have at school?**

From my experience, I can say that children nowadays have more classes to attend, more home works to do and more exam to take. From this regards, the children are burdened with the extended syllabus and lot of home-works. Many schools even make the project works and day-long classes mandatory and as a result, today's children are under a lot of pressure.

Other possible questions:

- What do you need to do to interest a child in such activities?
- How do you think adults should improve their relations with children?

18. Describe a favorite sport which you like to watch.

You should say:

What it is

When you watch it

How you watch it

And explain why you like watching it.

Sample answer:

Well, I would like to talk about football, which is my favorite sport of all time and how I enjoy watching it so much. You know, football is the most popular type of sport nowadays and it has millions of fans all over the world. I fell in love with football when my father first

taught me as a way to exercise when I was small. Ever since, I have **become a huge fan of** this sport. I spend all my free time in watching football matches and practicing it. Especially, I can never **miss a match** of my favorite football team, Manchester United if it is on TV even if I have to **delay** all my **schoolwork**.

Usually, my father and I would watch football on the old TV in our living room. Both of us **are crazy about** football and talkative so we have a lot to share. During a match, we listen to the other's comments on the players' performance and **discuss the strategies** of each team. To me, this is not only a chance to **let my hair down** after **hard-working hours** but also a time to **strengthen the relationship** with my father. Watching matches is also a great way for me to learn new moves and apply them into my real games with friends at school. You know, I even dream of being a **professional footballer** someday.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **become a huge fan of:** trở thành fan/người hâm mộ lớn của
- **miss a match:** bỏ lỡ một trận đấu
- **delay schoolwork:** trì hoãn, tạm ngừng
- **be crazy about:** rất thích, cuồng về điều gì
- **discuss the strategies:** bàn luận chiến lược
- **let my hair down [idom]:** đi 'quây', thừa giãn
- **hard-working hours:** những giờ làm việc chăm chỉ, vất vả
- **strengthen the relationship:** củng cố, làm cho bền vững mối quan hệ
- **professional footballer:** vận động viên bóng đá chuyên nghiệp

Follow-up questions:

- **What sports are popular in your country? = What kinds of sports are popular in your country now, but weren't popular 20 years ago?**

I think that sports like rollerblading and snowboarding have become very popular in the last few years. There has also been an interest in extreme sports where people have to overcome certain natural obstacles or compete with others in different disciplines

- **What are the major differences between 'extreme sports' and ordinary sports?**

Personally speaking, what sets dangerous sports from normal ones is the degree of fear people feel. Doing sports like bungee jumping or sky diving can be said to suit the courageous men only, and those cowards can hardly imagine themselves taking up such sports. However, extreme activities like these can be a great opportunities for us to experience different feelings and cultivate our self-confidence. Just think of yourselves moving at top speed in a

rollercoaster, all your stress is released, and you can feel more confident in yourselves in real life as you have accomplished something extraordinary like that.

- **What do you think of expensive sports?**

I have no say in this regard. It simply depends on the tastes of those playing them, and if they can afford to take up that sporting activity, it is not a big deal. For example, the rich usually play golf or tennis and a poor person like me would take no issue with it. Having said that, those expensive kinds of sports give people a sense of respect and admiration from others.

- **Why do people dislike playing sports?**

To the best of my knowledge, people in the modern world are too preoccupied at the workplace and hardly enough time is given for leisure pursuits like taking up a good sport. I can perfectly understand that they are unable to practice certain sports activities out of their own will. However, for those who basically hate sports for its own sake, I think they must be suffering from some mental illnesses, because as a normal person, everyone wants to stay in the pink, build up muscles or have a slim body.

- **Do you think people should be encouraged to try some of these extreme sports?**

Why do you think some people like to do these dangerous activities?

I personally feel that we shouldn't encourage people to have a go at extreme sports. The simple explanation for this can be the poor safety conditions in some developing countries, which means that accidents can take place anytime. I have witnessed several cases on the social networks about a child falling from the rollercoaster due to the old seatbelt which broke out of the blue. On top of this, it would be hard to change people's mind if they just insist on not doing something. At the end of the day, it is an individual's own decision whether to get himself involved in what I would rather call "dangerous" sports.

- **Do you like (or. would you like) to do a rather dangerous sporting activity?**

Frankly speaking, I'm not a courageous person and would love peaceful activities rather than thrilling ones. Besides, the poor safety conditions in some developing countries mean that accidents can take place anytime. I have witnessed several cases on the social networks about a child falling from the rollercoaster due to the old seatbelt which broke out of the blue. So in a nutshell, I prefer to be set in my own way. Truthfully speaking, I am dead tired after returning home from work so I can hardly gather my strength to participate in any kinds of sporting activities in the evening or at night. Instead, I'd rather listen to music to let my hair down or simply do some body stretching to relax myself

- **What are the benefits of playing sports?**

Clearly, taking part in sports is greatly beneficial in several ways. The first merit is that we can keep our body in better shape and relieve our minds quite effectively. For example, when you join in a football match, you have to exercise your body. This builds up your muscles and by sweating profusely, you burn up some kilos and it helps your blood to circulate better. Apart from those health benefits, with your participation in sports, you can broaden your social circle by meeting people of different backgrounds, as well as cultivating team spirit and cooperation skills.

- **What's the difference between playing sports on your own and playing sports in a group?**

It is quite common knowledge that sports come in a variety of forms like martial arts in which you can practice on your own, or some sports which require you to play with a group. It depends on a person really. If you are an extroverted guy/girl, you would prefer a match of football or volleyball as you can both exercise your body and have casual talks with others during the game. However, in case you are an introvert, you can do some solo sports like running, swimming, bicycling or martial arts. You don't have to worry about anyone else other than yourself. And through these individual sports, you can learn some of the greatest qualities such as perseverance, discipline and endurance, which can be hardly found in team sports

- **Do children need to exercise?**

Obviously, children in modern society need plenty of physical exercise. It is not surprising to see that with the fast paced lifestyle and increased study pressure, many students fail to manage time to take part in certain forms of sports to work out their body. Therefore, they end up suffering from various health problems like obesity or shortsightedness. It is my recommendation that teachers and parents should encourage them to join some sports to help them relax their minds and build up their bodies as health is the most important asset of a person.

- **Why do people need to play sports?**

Needless to say, taking part in sports is greatly beneficial in several ways. The first merit is that we can keep our body in better shape and relieve our minds quite effectively. For example, when you join in a football match, you have to exercise your body. This builds up your muscles and by sweating profusely, you burn up some kilos and it helps your blood to circulate better. Apart from those health benefits, with your participation in sports, you can broaden your social circle by meeting people of different backgrounds, as well as cultivating team spirit and cooperation skills.

- **What are the most popular outdoor sports in Vietnam?**

There are a number of popular sporting activities which are held outside the house in my country, like volleyball, badminton and basketball. However, the kind of sports that attracts people of almost all ages is football. People from the young to the old not only watch football matches on TV, but also participate in this game actively and enthusiastically. It is no exaggerating but people will gather at a football field and enjoy a good match together whenever they find time.

- **Do Vietnamese people like to play indoor sports or outdoor sports?**

It depends greatly on how old a person is really. To support my claim, small kids are likely to be into indoor games like indoor football or swimming whereas adults tend to derive more pleasure from outdoor sports activities such as football or volleyball. This is due to the fact that today parents are more protective of their children so they encourage them to take part in indoor sports to protect their children from bad injuries or serious accidents. On the other hand, adults would love the social interaction and team spirit from sports matches played outside the house, particularly after a stressful week of hard work.

- **What are the benefits for children to play outdoor games?**

There're a number of benefits a child can obtain from taking part in games played outside the house. The first one is that playing games outdoors is a form of exercise that helps children to increase their physical fitness. By running around and kicking a ball in a match of football, for instance, the small kids can develop their muscle strength and flexibility. The second plus point is that small players can hone many skills and qualities through their participation in outdoor games. By interacting and socializing with their teammates, they can be more active and have a chance to get to know not only their peers but also the surrounding environment. As a result, they have more coordination and cooperation skills.

- **Do you think sports can help people improve their health?**

I can't agree with you more. Sporting activities are a highly recommended way to keep fit and get into a better shape. Through sports like football or basketball, the body sweat profusely, which helps us lose weight and makes the blood circulate more properly. Besides, people can cultivate team spirit and enlarge their social circle through participating in sports.

Other possible questions:

- **What is the difference between doing sports in a gym and in other places?**
- **Is there any sportsman whom you admire? Why?**
- **Will sports events and sports programs on TV increase in the future? Why?**

19. Describe a bicycle tour.

You should say:

When you had this trip

Who went on with you

What you did during this trip

And explain why you liked it.

Sample answer:

I would like to describe a really exciting tour that I went on last Saturday, a bicycle trip around Hoan Kiem Lake (or Sword Lake), one of the major scenic spots of Hanoi, the capital city. I had three **travelling companions**, three close friends of mine and we agreed on driving our bicycle to Ly Thai To Statue, our **point of departure** before 5 am. Actually, I'm a **morning bird**, so I found it quite easy to get up early. Luckily, the weather was really nice that day. The **fresh air and tranquility in the morning** made me **feel relaxed and energetic**. We biked five rounds around the lake, until 7pm, when the sun began to rise and the streets became crowded. After that, we gathered at our favorite cafe to **sip cups of strong coffee** and chitchatted.

I really enjoyed that bike trip because of several reasons. Firstly, it was a great chance for me to see our city **from a very different angle**, a peaceful Hanoi without traffic jam and polluted air. I was able to escape from **the hustle and bustle of the city life** for a while **and** refreshed myself to be prepared for a new week. Moreover, I think that cycling is also a great exercise that helps me **strengthen my health, build up my stamina and improve the immune system**. Last but not least, I think this trip was a great opportunity for me and my friends to gather together and share with each other all stuffs in our daily life. You know, we are often too busy to meet regularly, so chances like this are really valuable.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **travelling companions:** bạn đồng hành trong chuyến đi
- **point of departure:** điểm khởi hành, xuất phát
- **a morning bird:** người hay thức dậy sớm
- **feel relaxed and energetic:** cảm thấy thư giãn và tràn đầy năng lượng
- **fresh air and tranquility:** không khí mát mẻ, trong lành
- **sip cups of strong coffee:** uống những tách cà phê có nồng độ caffeine cao
- **from a very different angle:** từ một góc nhìn, góc độ khác
- **the hustle and bustle of the city life:** sự nhộn nhịp, sầm uất của đời sống ở thành phố
- **strengthen my health:** làm cho khỏe lên, củng cố sức khỏe
- **build up stamina:** hình thành khả năng chịu đựng
- **improve the immune system:** phát triển hệ thống miễn dịch

Follow-up questions: Refer to question 7

20. Describe an organization or company where you live and they employ a lot of people.

You should say:

What it is

How many employees work there?

What its work is

And explain what you think about it.

Sample answer:

And explain what you think about it.

Now I'm living in Hanoi, the capital city so there are many large companies to choose. But I guess I'd like to describe a company of which I've been a **loyal customer**, a **food-beverage company** with a large number of employees. It is BamiKing Joint Stock Company.

As far as I know, this **firm** has over 40 **food stores** all over the country, half of which are located in Hanoi. Each store has approximately ten to fifteen employees, including managers, accountants, salespeople, processors, and shippers so the total number of staff could be more than 500 people. BamiKing originally served "banh my", which is considered the world's best sandwich, with **diverse fresh ingredients** including roast chicken or pork, homemade pâté, cured ham, **headcheese** and some veggies like carrot and cucumber. Now this company has **expanded its menu to a wider variety of side-dishes**, drinks and desserts such as fries, fruit juices and even ice-cream.

Personally, I usually eat my "banh my" with sausage and pate with Maggi sauce and mayonnaise. They have a secret recipe of making the bread **crispy** outside but **moist** and **tender** inside. All ingredients are fresh and **combined perfectly with each other**. Besides, as a **full-time office worker**, I don't really have much time for cooking, so this kind of **quick-service restaurant** is an **ideal choice** for me to **fill my stomach** during lunch breaks. It allows me some free time to relax and **recharge my batteries**, or even **take a short nap** before getting back to work.

Vocabulary and Collocations:

- **loyal customer:** khách hàng trung thành
- **food-beverage company:** công ty kinh doanh thực ăn và thức uống
- **As far as I know:** theo những gì mình biết thì
- **firm** = company
- **food store:** cửa hàng thức ăn

- **diverse fresh ingredients:** nguyên liệu tươi đa dạng
- **expand menu:** nói rộng, phát triển thực đơn
- **a wider variety of side-dishes:** sự đa dạng, phong phú hơn của các món ăn thêm
- **crispy:** giòn
- **moist:** ẩm
- **tender:** mềm
- **full-time office worker:** người làm việc văn phòng từ sáng đến chiều
- **combined perfectly with each other:** kết hợp rất hoàn hảo với nhau
- **quick-service restaurant:** nhà hàng phục vụ nhanh
- **an ideal choice:** một lựa chọn lý tưởng, hoàn hảo
- **fill my stomach:** ăn, dùng bữa
- **recharge battery:** sạc pin
- **take a short nap:** ngủ một giấc ngủ ngắn, thiếp đi

Follow-up questions:

- **What are the differences between being a boss and working for others? = Why do some people open their own business?**

They are worlds apart, I personally feel so. What sets working for others apart is that, you don't have to suffer from a lot of pressure, but the motivation is not so strong. As many people contribute their effort to the wellbeing of the whole company, you usually receive help when facing some trouble with the work, but as I have said, many would leave their work at some point because they gradually become less interested in what they are doing. On the other hand, if you are a boss, you should have comprehensive abilities. To put it simply, you have to possess leadership, organizational skills and are responsible for the success or failure of your own business.

- **Which is harder, working as a boss or an employee?**

It can be pretty clear that the higher your position is, the more responsibility you have to undertake. Bearing this in mind, being a boss is going to be more demanding as a boss has to take care of all aspects of the company. He must know who to employ and how to make a good use of the resources as well as thinking ways to expand the business. My parent is a manager in a large corporation and often complains about the backbreaking workload which keeps him at work and can never leave work before 8 p.m. in the evening.

- **What are the benefits of working for others?**

When you are employed by others, you don't have to worry about the whole running of the market. If the company is in a bad condition, you may choose to leave. On top of that, you will have more time to pursue other leisure pursuits like going to the cinema every weekend to

watch a blockbuster or having casual chitchat with your friends sometimes. This I reckon is a wild dream if you are a manager in a multinational company.

- **What are important abilities for those working in a company?**

You should be clear about the details of your responsibility. To put it in other words, workers are supposed to carry out their assigned tasks effectively and efficiently, without lazing around or thinking that laziness won't affect the success of the whole company. After all, they are paid for their work and contribution. I wouldn't forget to mention that team spirit is essential as well, and your efficiency can be improved when you cooperate with others, rather than individually sail through the difficult times.

- **What kind of small business is popular in this city?**

In my city, people prefer to open beauty salons or small coffee shops. I can put it down to the fact that most girls or women would try their best to look gorgeous in others' eyes, and spending money to beautify themselves is considered as a must for them. Or in a similar situation, the youths tend to hang out with their buddies for some casual/idle chitchat, which means many cafes are doing well recently. Ah, not less popular are some small restaurants that can only accommodate no more than ten people. It can be understandable that many would call on these places for a snack or drink when they have time or feel hungry.

- **What are the things that you learned from a university and from your working experience?**

In my personal situation, I learn the basic knowledge from my university, and from my work, I learn how to apply theory into practice. The importance of university study can never be denied as it equips you well with the working or operation of certain things, so it's much easier and faster to make something work. Whereas, experience is the best teacher for the fundamental reason that when you actually involve yourself in something, you can learn anything without much prior knowledge. As well as this, I learn to find problems and then try to solve them with the knowledge obtained from tertiary education.

- **Which is important if you want to run your own business? = What challenges and difficulties do people face when they try to have a successful small business?**

It requires people to have perseverance as well as response to challenges, and I guess careful planning is more essential. To be more specific, you need to calculate how much capital needed for investment, how many employees to hire, or whether the business can last long once it is in operation. Another factor worth mentioning is luck. From my experience, I have seen some entrepreneurs succeed only because they launched their business in the right place and at the right time.

- **What changes in employment have there been in recent years in your country?**

There has been a rejuvenation of the “entrepreneurial spirit” in our country; more and more people are involved in starting their own businesses. The “start-up” community is now more alive than ever, even college students launch their start-up businesses while in a university. Even though there is a high failing rate of start-up businesses; still, people are starting to take risk and put their ideas into creation

- **Is it easy to set up a company in Vietnam?**

It's not very easy. A person has to have enough capital to set up a business. This is the most important stuff to take into account as you need enough money to make sure that your business is gonna survive despite some initial difficulties. It can break even, make a loss or a profit. Ah, I guess that you need to have some knowledge of the field you're going to invest in so that you can manage it more effectively and efficiently.

21. Describe a leisure activity near or on the sea

You should say:

What it is

What you should prepare

Why you have to prepare

And explain how you feel about it.

Sample answer:

I would like to talk about one of my favorite activities on the beach, swimming. You know, I live in Hai Phong, a **coastal city** with **golden beaches** and the nearest seashore is just fifteen minutes away from my house. So, in the summer, my friends and I often go there and swim in cool water to avoid the hot weather. Actually, swimming is a relatively easy sport. You know, I learned how to swim when I was 8 and it took me only a week to be familiar with some swimming strokes like the **breaststroke**, the **backstroke** and the **butterfly stroke**. Before **entering the water**, I often **warm up and stretch my muscles** and joints to **avoid injuries**, then put on my swimsuit and **jump into the water**.

I really enjoy swimming on the beach because of some reasons. Firstly, unlike other water sports like diving or windsurfing, which **require costly equipment**, swimming costs nothing. Secondly, swimming is **extremely beneficial to our health**. It provides an all-over **body workout**, as nearly all of our muscles are used during swimming. So, it builds **endurance**, **muscle strength** and **cardiovascular fitness**. Lastly, going swimming is a **good means of recreation** as it allows me to **unwind myself**, **alleviate stress** and have great time with my friends. Summer is coming so I'll definitely make a plan to visit some beaches. I

intend to go to Nha Trang beach because it is considered as one of the most magnificent beaches in the world.

Follow-up questions:

- **Why do so many people like going to places with water such as lakes, rivers or the ocean?**

Option 1: Well, I guess the main reason is that water has a kind of calming effect on people. And when you consider all the stress that people are under these days, and then I think it's easy to understand why people gravitate to places new water.

Option 2: If you ask me, I would have to say that the youths benefit more from going to the beaches or the seaside than the elderly. The first point worth mentioning is that young people are dynamic and adventurous, so they are pretty into taking part in a mixed diversity of outdoor activities. So obviously, they can take a full advantage of their trips. On the contrary, the older citizens are passive and wouldn't love to move their bodies around. This means that they merely consider such travel trips as an occasion to idle their time away

Option 3: That's very hard to say, because personally I think the seaside is a good place to go for both the young and old, but in terms of which age group it's more suitable for, then I suppose I'd have to say the elderly, simply because they are more aware of the dangers of the ocean. So if children go to the beach, their parents need to keep a close eye on them.

- **As a place to spend some leisure time, do you think the seaside is more suitable for children or old people?**

Option 1: That's very hard to say, because personally I think the seaside is a good place to go for both the young and old, but in terms of which age group it's more suitable for, then I suppose I'd have to say the elderly, simply because they are more aware of the dangers of the ocean. So if children go to beach, their parents need to keep a close eye on them.

- **What activities would you do if you were spending some leisure time at a beach?**

Option 1: I think I would do a few things. For example, I would definitely go paddling in the sea, because I always enjoy doing that whenever I go to the beach, and it's much less effort than swimming! So that's one thing, and what else would I do? Um...well, I suppose another thing I would probably do is just lying on the beach, which I know is quite boring, but's also really relaxing – you know, you can just close your eyes and listen to the sound of the waves crashing against the shore.

Option 2: There is a great deal of stuff we can take part in when going to such places. Firstly, we can take advantage of some voyages to do the sights, look at the blue sea and skies and enjoy life. Secondly, we can go for a swim or soak in the sunshine on the beach, feel the cool

breezes in our faces. Finally, at some riverbanks or lakes, we can have a good time recharging our batteries, and enjoying our temporary escape from the hustle and bustle of city life

Option 3: All kinds of things really, you know, some people like doing exciting things jet skiing or scuba diving, while others prefer doing more relaxing things, such as just lying down on a deck chair with a book. So it really kind of varies!

- **Do you think the government should invest money in developing facilities for water sports?**

No, not really. Because I think there are a lot more important things that the government should focus on. I mean, after all, water sports are purely recreational, so if no money's invested in them, then it's not really going to have a significant effect on anyone. So I think the government could put their money to much better use by investing in things such as education and healthcare, which will make a much bigger difference to people's lives.

- **Do you think children and old people do the same types of things when they go to a beach?**

No, I don't really think so. The range of activities and their interests vary a lot. For the young, they show a fancy for strenuous physical activities like surfing, swimming or sand castle building, so they tend to be really engrossed in what they are doing. By contrast, old people would rather pick up a good book to read, prepare some snacks for their kids to graze or find time to have a chat with one of their relatives, whom they may not have been in touch for ages.

- **Why do some people like water sports?**

Obviously, some like the youths are extremely into aquatic sports. This can easily be understood because they are dynamic and adventurous so they are pretty drawn by water polo, surfing, snorkeling to name but a few. Some sports like those tend to be risky so it can be a time for the young guys to challenge themselves and test their own limit, which can give them more confidence in life.

- **Do you think the government should invest money in developing facilities for water sports?**

Not necessarily I reckon. This is because governments should rather provide more essential services for its citizens like improving healthcare or education. The task of upgrading and expanding water sports facilities should rest with the clubs that do business in these areas. Besides, not many people are into water sports these days since they even can't find time to go to somewhere with water during the whole year.

- **Do you think that human activity is posing a threat to the oceans of the world?**

Yes, definitely. Although some argue that the ocean is vast and the pollution we cause is trivial, I would say that it does have negative effect on the marine ecosystem. For example, more trading activities mean more vessels being used to transport the goods across the oceans, and there have been many oil spills reported till now. This has claimed many lives of animal creatures and affected the local environment as well. Furthermore, sewage being directly dumped into the rivers means sometime in the future the ocean will probably suffer

- **How important is water in people's everyday lives?**

Well, water plays a crucial role in our routine lives. Imagine that if there were no water, human beings would be dirty and smelly as there would be nothing to wash our bodies cleanly except for water. The second one is that we need water to wash the raw foods and vegetables we eat on a daily basis; otherwise, humans could suffer from some health related issues like food poisoning, cholera and diarrhea, to name but a few.

- **What do you think are the advantages and disadvantages of traveling on the ocean?**

Going in a boat is an adventure. The food on cruise ships is probably as good as it can be on a budget for economy class and when fresh ingredients are out of reach, and when thousands of meals have to be cooked and served nearly at once. It's also relaxing and you get a chance to meet many other people. However, a voyage can be really costly and with soaring competition among travel agencies, it has become difficult for tourists select the right one. Moreover, as we all know the pristine environment of these regions is now vulnerable to pollution, so this exposure is undoubtedly affecting terrestrial and aquatic life adversely.

22. Describe an important change in your life.

You should say:

What it is

What you should prepare

Why you have to prepare

And explain how you feel about it.

Sample answer:

I would like to talk about one of **the greatest transformations** in my life. I used to weigh 65 kilos and after 6 months of continuous diet and workout, I successfully lost 15 kilos.

When I was a teenager, I mainly **subsisted on fast food** such as fried chicken pieces, hamburgers or crisps. Numerous exams at high school even **forced me to** stay up late and eat even more. As a result, I **put on weight rapidly** and one day, when I **stepped on a scale**,

which read 65 kilos, I knew that I had to start my **weightless journey** or I could **become overweight**.

After **consulting my aunt**, who worked as a **nutritionist**, I understood that losing weight was all about **diet and workout**. First, I cleaned my fridge of all my favorite **unhealthy foods**, and began cooking **homemade meals**. I also drank at least 2 liters of mineral water a day instead of soft drink. Second, I **registered for a gym class** and started to work out at least three times a week. Besides, I slept early at night and woke up at 5 am to go biking every morning.

After 6 months of **resisting junk food** and working out regularly, my weight dropped to 50 kilos. However, it was not only about the weight loss, but also the changes to my **health condition**. I felt stronger and happier than ever before. I rarely got sick and my skin also looked brighter. More importantly, I could **regain my self-confidence**. I used to run from cameras, but now I am comfortable with taking photos. I am finally also able to try on dresses and skinny jeans. That's all I think.

Follow-up questions:

- **Some people think that an important decision should be made quickly and based on intuition while others believe an informed choice is better. What's your view?**

Personally, I believe it's a combination of the two. I certainly think you need to have all possible information available to you before a decision can be made but I also think that a certain degree of intuition or 'gut-feeling' can really help to guide the decision-making process. It's unexplainable, but I know that some of my best decisions have been based on intuition more than anything else.

- **Do you think that individuals nowadays have more or fewer important choices to make than in the past? Why?**

Today's society certainly confronts people with more important decisions than in the past. For a start, there is so much more choice in lots of different areas, like in the area of career and occupation for instance. My parents or grandparents' generation often had the same job for forty or fifty years, but people nowadays

- **What kinds of decisions are more difficult: those which solely affect you or those which also have an impact on other people?**

I think it's more difficult to make decisions which are going to have an effect on other people's lives, but I also think that this relates to most decisions we make – decisions very rarely only impact on one person. Anyway, it's obviously a matter of degree, for instance if you are the

manager of a large company and you have to decide how many redundancies are necessary to keep the business from failing, then that's a decision which will have a huge impact on many people. On the other hand, if you are deciding which house to buy then that probably only affects you and your family. Overall, I think it's wise to consider the potential impact of your decision in any case.

- **In your opinion, is there such a thing as too much choice?**

I definitely believe that there is too much choice for young people nowadays, and this creates a lot of pressure for them. Whether it is in terms of what career path to take or where to live and study, there are an overwhelming number of choices available to this generation and I think it can be extremely difficult to feel as though one has made the right choice, whatever that is. However, choice provides us with options and freedom as well, so I believe it's important to value that.

- **What kind of events may be life-changing events?**

Like I said, breaking up or ending a relationship would be one. Having an accident or hurting yourself when playing sports sure is life changing. Winning the lottery is another life changing event. Getting married will change your life, too.

- **Do Vietnamese people change jobs very often? Do you think that's good?**

Yes I think that Vietnamese do change their jobs pretty often, and I think that it is a good thing. Until you really find a job that you feel comfortable with, then I think it is okay to change jobs. Some Vietnamese and people around the world have to change jobs because they get laid off or their company gets gobbled up by some big corporation, and they are forced to leave.

- **Why do so many people in China move to a different city or even go overseas to study or work?**

Well. I think that people are just looking for their groove and where they belong. Now that the opportunity is there to travel, people want to take advantage of it, and see where their fortunes lie. There is a big world out there and some people want to find out if it is their "cup of tea" as they say. I hate to use so many idioms and I hope that I am using them right, but some people just have the proverbial "grass is greener on the other side of the fence" syndrome. They think that once they get there, all their problems will be over.

- **What do you think are the major challenges of working or studying in another country?**

Well. I guess that one of the biggest ones is that you are going to a different culture, and you are not sure how you are going to fit in. In most countries one of the hardest things to deal with is prejudice. People always seem to have a little suspicion of foreigners in their country. I think that loneliness would be another thing that would be hard for someone working or studying overseas. A person would be away from family and friends, and that would be difficult.

- **Do you think young people can adapt to changes easier than old people?**

Not necessarily. I have seen some young people that didn't know how to deal with changes at all, and then I have seen some older people who take changes without breaking a sweat. Of course I do know, like the old saying goes about teaching an old dog new tricks, that it is sometimes harder for an older person to change, but they can do it. I think that a lot of young people here in China have a hard time with changes because they have seen such few changes and like the way things are now.

- **Should important choices be made by parents rather than by young adults?**

As I see it, important choices should be made by both parents and young adults. Each generation has their own advantages and shortcomings. Therefore, before we make important choices, it is indispensable for us to consider both opinions of parents and young adults to make the best choices.

Other possible questions:

- **Do you think children should have new experience?**
- **What kinds of changes people have to make in their life?**
- **Why do some people dislike changing?**

23. Describe an occasion that you had a cake that was special.

You should say:

What kind of cake it was.

When you ate the cake

Whom you are with

And explain why you think it was special.

Sample answer:

I would like to talk about one of my best friends' birthday last year which was **an unforgettable occasion** because of a really special cake. While I do not **have a sweet tooth**, most of my friends are **big fans of confections**. Some of them are even addicted to

both **sweet and savory pastries**. That's why they decided to make a delicious Red velvet cake as a birthday gift for Kelly- one of my best friends.

Despite my **limited baking skills**, I **rolled up my sleeves** and **gave them a hand**. When Kelly saw the beautiful Red cake, she was **totally astonished** since she knew none of us were actually **a decent cook**. You know what, we were **quarreling** all day long only to **make up our mind** whether we wanted to make Choco Lava or simple cupcakes. We almost messed it all up before finishing the Red velvet cake at the end of the day. Luckily, the cake wasn't so bad. The **cream was rich** and the color was just right. Kelly agreed that it was, however, a bit **oversweet** because we somehow decided ten teaspoons of sugar would be reasonable. But, Kelly said she loved it as much as she loved us and this birthday party couldn't be any happier.

To be honest, it doesn't matter how **well-designed** or expensive your gift may be, but it is the effort that counts and my cake **proves** just that.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you think it is important to have dinner with family?**

I have to admit that it's extremely vital that family members spend their time together at the dinner table. The most obvious explanation for this is that this can strengthen family bonds and help the whole family get on well with one another. To be more specific, during a meal, they can share their stories and trouble in life, receive valuable advice to sort out their problems. At the end of the day, people can build a close-knit family and forget about all the difficulties in their life

- **Why do some people not always eat with their family?**

I personally feel that a number of factors are responsible for why some people in modern society refuse to have a meal with other family members. One of the reasons is the lack of time caused by increasing pressure from work or study. A case in point is that my high school friend often spends more than 8 hours a day studying and preparing for the university entrance exam that he can hardly manage any hour for eating with his parents.

The second explanation is the generation gap. To put it simply, youngsters today love eating out with their friends rather than sitting at the table and being asked several questions about private matters like "What is going on with your study", or "Do you have a girlfriend?"

- **How often do people in your country eat with their (work) colleagues or with their fellow students?**

From time to time, I would say. It is not difficult to catch sight of many coworkers gather outside the company and head off to a local street vendor to have something to eat together or have a drink at least. As for the fellow students, they tend to go straight home after school as their parents often wait and pick them up. Even so, they would ask each other out whenever possible to have some chitchat about their study

- **In your country is food important?**

Absolutely it matters a lot. Food is of great concern to people in all parts of my country. What I'm trying to say is Vietnamese people boast of their diverse and exotic cuisine, with different dishes, like you can have phở, bánh chưng, bánh dày and so on. This means that it has become part of our customs and traditions, not just a nourishing stuff.

- **Tell me about the types of food that people eat in your country (What foods are popular in your country?)**

In my country, the Vietnamese, rice is a staple food. We eat rice for breakfast, lunch and dinner. Rice comes with different kinds of viand (piece of food, or a tasty dish) such as pork, beef or chicken cooked with vegetables or fruits and other ingredients. Since my country is located in the tropics, tropical fruits are also popular here especially mangoes. They say that the best mangoes can be found in the Vietnamese. We also like to eat bread for breakfast or for snacks.

- **How healthy is your country's food?**

It is the choice of the people whether to eat healthy or unhealthy food. In my country, there are many choices of healthy food especially vegetables and fruits. However, I don't think that people eat much healthy foods nowadays because of the presence of fast food and processed foods. Also, many dishes in my country is usually greasy and salty which I think are not very healthy.

- **More and more people are becoming overweight nowadays. What do you think might be the causes of this?**

One major consequence of eating fast food every day is excess calorie consumption. Most fast food contains calories from refined sugar and fats. It is also high in sodium from salt and other addictive substance which can cause someone to eat it more and more. Consuming more calories than human needs leads to obesity which causes some health problems such as hypertension, diabetes, heart disease and even cancer.

- **Do you think people enjoy their food as much as they should?**

I don't know really ... I suppose it's true that people will often eat a quick snack because they're bored not because they're dying of hunger and often they just bolt it down and don't savor it ... so yes ... perhaps we could take more time over our food ...

- **At different times, people will choose different food?**

It may somehow depend on their personal moods and the circumstances in which they are in. When someone is down in the dumps, they are more likely to drink and eat every little, and instead they give more time to think about how to get over that stormy period in their life. In contrast, if a person is in high spirits after winning the lottery or passing the exam with flying colors, the chances are that they will throw a big party with different beverages, foods and fruits, and eat to their heart's content.

24. Describe a time when you moved to a new house or a new school.

You should say:

When it happened

What kind of home did you move into?

Why you moved

And explain how you felt about the moving.

Sample answer:

One year ago, I had to leave my old house and moved to Ho Chi Minh City. Now I would like to share with you about this experience and how I feel about it. For 18 years, I lived happily in my **sweet home** in a peaceful hometown to the Southwest of Vietnam though it is much less developed than other provinces in the neighborhood.

After I passed the **university entrance exam**, my family decided to move to Ho Chi Minh City so that I could go to school more easily. The fact that I must leave my **dear house**, especially my little **cozy bedroom** hurt me seriously at the time. When I first came to Ho Chi Minh City, I couldn't remember streets and their names. I got exhausted with the traffic in rush hours and I told my parents that I hated this place. I wished to come back to my beautiful garden with plenty of trees and **green space**.

However, several weeks later, my family made friends with some neighbors next door and they turned out to be quite friendly and **assisted us to adjust to our new life**. My new classmates were also funny and kind, and some of them also came from **rural areas** like me. Therefore, I managed to get along with my **new companions** and the city life seems

to be less **challenging**. So, I think moving to HCMC was not that bad of a decision and I will definitely miss this city if I have to move again.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you think it's better to rent or to buy a place to live in?**

I think it's better to buy your own home if you can afford to do that. Buying your own home is a better investment in the long term, because you can sell the home and perhaps even make a profit on it. The alternative is to pay rent to a landlord who can ask you to leave at any moment.

- **Do you agree that there is a right age for young adults to stop living with their parents?**

I'm not sure what the 'right' age would be, but I do agree with the principle that young adults should try to live alone if they can. For some people, the right age is when they get their first full-time jobs and can afford to pay rent, and for others it's when they start university and move into a hall of residence with other students. This was what happened in my case; I moved out of the family home at age 18 when I started university.

- **Do you like to move house frequently?**

Of course not, transferring from one house to another is a difficult task. First of all, moving to another place takes a lot of time and effort. We have to pack our things, send it to the new address and re-arrange it. Next thing is that, it cost a lot of money because we have to pay an advance payment for the new place. Also, we have to consider paying the transport fee for moving our stuffs. It is very inconvenient to keep moving from one place to another.

- **Why do people in your country choose to move home?**

Well, there are several instances why people transfer from one house to another. One thing I can think of is, they look for a better employment that could offer them career advancement and a higher salary wage. Take me as an example, I live in 'name' but I decided to move in 'name' because they offer twice as much as I earn in Kunming. Second reason is because, some people move because of marriage. In Vietnam, once you get married you must separate from your parents and find a place to stay in but there are still some people who prefer to live with their parents in one roof.

Other possible questions:

- **Do you think people may feel uncomfortable after they moved to a new place?**
- **Why do they move if you say so?**
- **Can children adapt new environment easier than adults?**

25. Describe an invention that changed the people's life.

You should say:

What it was

Who invented it

When it was invented

And explain how it changed people's life

Sample answer:

I would like to talk about telephone which, in my opinion, is one of the most **revolutionary creations** that have greatly changed our life. As far as I know, Graham Bell was the father of this terrific device and he invented it in the last century after **countless numbers of trials and errors**.

It is no exaggeration to say that human's life has been totally changed since the first telephones were devised. Few centuries ago, it took us ages to **deliver letters**. **In case of emergency or confidential cases**, people could hardly contact with each other because no such **instantly communicative means** as telephones were available back then. You know, **communication enhancement is widely believed** to act as **the central core** of the **social development**. **As the most obvious example**, telephones made it much easier for people to **express their urgent messages to distant recipients**. Moreover, when we want to find someone without any ideas where he is, we just need to **call him via telephones** and problems may be solved in no time. So, that's why the advent of telephones has considerably improved our society by the way we contact with our family, acquaintances or even strangers.

Follow-up questions:

- **What do you think is the most important equipment in schools?**

At school, one of the most essential equipment is computer. As we know, computer is already a part of modern teaching; teachers can use PowerPoint or Microsoft Word to present their lectures in class. By doing so, the lecture can be more fascinating and fun than just simply talking in front of the students. What is more, computer is used by students to make their research and do their paper works. Take me as an example, I use Microsoft Office to deal with my homework as I can just copy paste some information on the internet such as pictures or some important details I need to complete my assignment. As a matter of fact, most schools has their own computer facility usually located in the library where students can use it for free.

- **Which invention do you think is the most useful at home?**

I can say that there are plenty of useful technologies out there but I guess that electricity is the most valuable invention. This is because of the fact that we can do everything with electricity.

An example for that is, running our household chores such as doing the laundry and cooking. Another point here is that, without electricity life will be gloomy. Obviously speaking, electricity makes everything work, without electricity most of our devices such as printers, computers, TV and radio won't function.

- **How often do you wear jewelry?**

There is no doubt that indeed it made people sluggish. As far as I am concern, due to the rapid development of technology people's life has become more convenient, as a result, people get used of this convenience which make people more inactive. As we know, technology has brought comfort and made our lives easier where people become dependent to different devices and equipment. I am guilty of this statement, as I am too much attached with my mobile phone. I can sit all day playing mobile games, scrolling through Facebook or playing videos on YouTube. It's embarrassing to admit that this made my life sedentary.

- **How can technology make our life easier?**

Thank you for allowing me to answer this. Technology is a blessing for all and has made life easier. With the use of the technology, you can do the unimaginable things now. Earlier, people had to control their television set like increasing or decreasing the volume or changing channels manually. But in the current days, you do not need to get up to the television set raise the volume or change the channel and get back to the sofa again. It is the time to change channels or increase/ decrease the volumes with the help of a remote controller. Moreover, people now can travel easily than the past and travelling hours has been reduced to a great extent.

- **Can internet education replace teachers?**

Though contemporary modern technology has a significant influence on our life, I personally believe that the essence role cannot be simply replaced or subtract in favor of computerized lifestyle. This is certainly true in dealing with children who need sensitive approaches to fortify their perceptions and skills. Therefore, human instructors could not be replaced fruitfully with advanced apparatus. However, we should utilize this equipment in order to reinforce the teacher's contribution in the educational progression.

- **Why should we restrict the use of mobile phone in public places?**

Though there are no exact reasons to restrict the use of mobile phones in public places, it should be accomplished for some reasons. Undoubtedly mobile phones help us to communicate with the world and have numerous blessings, but there are some demerits as well. For instance, you are in a public library and it is expected that silence should be maintained. But if a mobile phone cries out loud, it is really annoying for the others who are

busy with reading. The noise created by the phone and discussion over the phone inside such places is really un-welcomed. In such situations, the use of mobile phones is always unwanted. So, the use of mobile phone should be restricted in public places.

- **How easy is it for an adult to think of a new idea?**

I would say, to an extent it is difficult. Because an average adult, often gets laid back, learning becomes too tiring and there are so many other things going on that thinking of learning and putting in ideas seems quite difficult. But, if someone is constantly learning and working on improving, I would say it is not a big deal to get an idea and start working on it.

- **How can children be taught to become innovative?**

Children must be taught to question to make them innovative. Often, we are not able to answer the WHYs of a child and by force ask them to ask better questions. This leads in them not answering any questions at all. So, instead of stopping them asking silly questions, we should answer these questions and make sure they ask more of them.

- **What role should the government play in encouraging innovation?**

Government has a very important role in making sure that an innovation takes place. Firstly, they should make some laws favoring it. So, maybe the strict laws and implementations could be eased out to make it easier for innovators to do things. Even more, sometimes funding is required in bringing a revolution, I think in those cases government can and should help.

- **Most innovations have patents. What do you think are the advantages and disadvantages of patents?**

Looking at the positive side, patents allow the inventor right to stop the manufacturing, copying and selling the product without his/her content. It also gives the inventor the commercial benefits. So, an inventor can then earn all the money from the product. Even more it provides other benefits, like recognition and hence provide opportunity for bigger discoveries. However, on the negative side, a patent is only for 20 years, after which other individual or companies can use the product freely. Even more, it is a very lengthy and time consuming process.

Other possible questions:

- **Mention 2 famous scientists in your country?**
- **Why should we invest more in research?**
- **What is the single most important invention in your opinion?**

26. Describe a place where you felt crowded.

You should say:

Where it is

When do you usually go there?

What do you do there?

And explain why it is crowded.

Sample answer:

I would like to talk about my recent trips to Ba Den pagoda, which was a **memorable experience** due to a **massive number of visitors** I encountered. During Tet holiday, my family often drives Tay Ninh province to visit my grandfather and last year we decided to take a short trip to Ba Den pagoda on Ba Den Mountain.

Before getting on **the hanging cable** to the pagoda, I felt that it would be surrounded by hundreds of **Buddhists** because this sacred place attracts countless visitors on a daily basis, let alone the biggest holiday in Vietnam, Tet. And, I was right: People with their **punches of flowers and candles** were everywhere. At the corner, **lines of people** were trying to **ignite their incense sticks** with some oil lamps or candles. Inside the pagoda, many Buddhist visitors were **kneeling and praying** with their eyes closed. It was pretty hard for my family to even **find some room to stand**.

However, we successfully managed to find a way through the crowd and got close to the worship place. My grandfather stayed outside since he couldn't stand the smoke and lack of oxygen. Although I understand that most Vietnamese enjoy going to pagodas or temples in these special days of the year to wish for good luck, well-being and happiness, I don't think I want to follow that tradition in the future.

Follow-up questions:

- **Is there a completely quiet place?**

What a fascinating question! My personal thought is that there's virtually no absolutely peaceful and quiet spot in modern society. At least there's some soft background noise or music to make the air less dull and heavy. Having said this, at night, we can catch sight of many parts of the town noiseless and dead quiet, which can be explained by the fact that most people might have fallen into a sound sleep.

- **Do you like large place?**

It's hard to tell, I don't have any preference when it comes to this but sometimes it depends on the purpose of liking it. First and foremost, if I talk about my own place at home, of course I

would say that I would like to have a huge space because it feels comfortable and cozy to live in a spacious house. As a matter of fact, we just moved in to a bigger house recently and living there seems to feel like heaven. However, there's an exemption, if it talks about the city I prefer a small city because it is less hassle and way more peaceful compared to large cities.

- **Do you like to go to the places where there are many people?**

Like some of my friends, I'm an extrovert and really love being surrounded by a great many of people. Therefore, I often hang out with a bunch of buddies in some vibrant places like the cinema or parks to let my hair down after some hardworking days.

Another point worth mentioning is that only by being in somewhere packed with people can I broaden my social circles and have fresh experiences. Otherwise, I will feel dead bored if there are no gorgeous chicks around to flirt, just a joke.

- **What types of noises do you come across in your daily life? Do any noises bother you?**

Living in a city like HCM city, I usually hear the noises of traffic, music played aloud to attract more customers at the shops as well as the noise of construction. Most of the times, I get sickened by the high level of noise. Noises from traffic or construction sites bother me a lot. Anyway, I feel irritated at any kind of noise.

- **Would you like to work in a noisy place? (Why?/Why not?)**

No. Never! What kind of work I do, I bet I need to focus and think in an organized way. A noisy place drives me crazy, and I don't think I can do anything in such a circumstance. If I remember rightly there was a time when I was in a coffee shop with deafening background rock music and I didn't manage to get any work done at all.

- **How might the level of urban noise be reduced?**

There can be a number of approaches that can be adopted to relieve the level of noise in urban areas. The first one should be the installation of noise proof walls, which can immensely curb the noise from neighboring houses interfering in the daily routines of other households. The second approach is that government should impose strict regulation, meaning that people mustn't do things that affect surrounding people after midnight or at noon, where people are supposed to fall sound asleep or take a short nap before their next hardworking period.

- **What kinds of places do people want to go to when they want to be alone?**

Honestly speaking, city dwellers often try to manage a trip to the countryside, where the atmosphere is tranquil and serene, away from the hustle and bustle of city life. Some others who are preoccupied with their work tend to make an escape to a secluded lake or park where

they spend time reading a book or pursuing other hobbies like drawing. Also, some people would rather just stay at home, in their room listening to music or doing other trivial stuff.

- **Why is it sometimes important for people to be alone?**

Do people feel comfortable in quiet places? Being on your own sometimes proves to be a good chance to contemplate on life, the challenges you are confronting and therefore figure out ways to sort those problems out once and for all. Meanwhile, others just hope to get themselves away from the hustle and bustle of the city life and spare some room for their own to pursue their own hobbies and interests, like listening to their favorite melodious tunes or drawing some pictures

- **What places, in your opinion, can be considered as peaceful places?**

Well, although in this modern society, we can see hustle and bustle here and there, we still could have some peaceful places to go around us. For example, libraries are usually quiet places, even when some people may chat with their friends, they would lower their voices to the lowest degree, so that little disturbances will occur to others. Also, in some temples, where people are praying in their hearts before the Buddha or God, all the noises and chaos will be gone. If one pays attention, there will be many other peaceful places around us to go.

- **Where can you hear loud noise?**

Actually, loud noises can be heard everywhere if you live in a busy city, regardless of whether it is day or night. Noises from the car engines, nightclubs, from the airport or some nasty neighbors throwing a party and singing karaoke are only few instances. Even worse, some are unfortunate to have a noisy family so it is natural for them to hear fierce quarrels on a daily basis.

- **Do you think there is more noise in people's lives today than in the past?**

Well to be honest, I would have to admit that modern humankind is suffering from greater levels of noise pollution than our ancestors some decades ago. The most reasonable explanation for this is that as the population swells, people live closer and closer to one another. Consequently, some frequently complain that their neighbors are a nuisance especially when they throw an overnight party, sing karaoke loudly or have fierce quarrels. Another factor is the development of high-tech; most people in public places are often in hold of a smartphone while having a loud conversation. Somehow, technology is to blame, I think.

- **Do you think that cities will become noisier in the future?**

It is difficult to predict the future, but I reckon there are going to be some changes with regard to the level of noise future generations have to bear. I'm not sure exactly what will happen but

one possibility is the rising number of vehicles on the roads and the increasing popularity of high-tech gadgets in our daily life, which I bet will lead to the uneasiness and bad moods among people. Furthermore, this might sound a bit crazy, but I think one day, everyone will have to wear hearing aids or noise cancelling headphones since as the moment they goes out of the house, noise will come from everywhere.

- **What would you do if your neighbors were noisy all the time?**

I suppose there is not much I can do if my next-door neighbors make incessant noises since it is their right to do what they want and no persuasion is effective, from my experience. However, as I am a brutally honest kind of guy, I would come straight to their house and propose my suggestions. If they are so persistent and refuse to listen to my words, I think I would have no other choice but call the police to solve the matter once and for all.

Other possible questions:

- **Why do some people not like quiet/crowded places?**
- **Do you need a quiet place when you are working?**
- **Where do Vietnamese people like to go on weekends?**
- **Why do you think people like to visit shopping centers?**

27. Describe an occasion where everybody smiled

You should say:

What happened?

When it happened?

Who were there?

And explain why everyone smiled:

Sample answer:

Today I would like to talk about a very enjoyable occasion when my parents and I were watching a funny movie, and then we were so happy that all of us **smiled hilariously**. It was the last Tet holiday when my parents didn't have to go to work and I didn't have any homework to do either. We felt that we were really enjoying my life when spending our leisure time together **regardless of the hustle and bustle** of our **ordinary days**. My parents and I chose a funny television movie named "Scary Movie the series".

Though it got that name, this movie turned out to be a comedy one, which **deliberately** made well-known horror films become awkwardly funny. We all loved the way the film made itself become interestingly ridiculous then we **laughed so hard** during the film. My mom smiled when the protagonist made fun of the scary ghost when it was trying to scare him and

my dad burst out laughing when he saw those old characters in the movie **illogically** grew stronger when they beat the antagonists who, in fact, were not as horrible as they looked at all. Though the film was totally amusing, what made me happiest was that I could feel happiness and coziness everywhere in the air. It was really hard for us to gather as in such a night and this was a very good chance for us to **escape from our hard working or studying days**.

So, I really appreciate every moment when we can spend our time for each other and I believe every member of my family also love it as well as try to be together whenever we can.

Follow-up questions: [Refer to question 61]

Other possible questions:

- **Why do people love to keep smiling when taking photos?**
- **Who smile more frequently, men or women?**
- **Why children love to smile?**
- **On what conditions that we should not smile?**
- **Is it common to see Chinese people smile to others?**

28. Describe a plan you haven't done yet

You should say:

What it is about

When you plan to do

Why you want to do it

And explain why you haven't done now.

Sample answer:

And explain why you haven't done now. The plan that I haven't done yet is my intention to study overseas. When I was a young man who has just turned 22 and just graduated from my university, I've always dreamt of pursuing my postgraduate education in another country.

Moreover, with my very high GPA of 3.5/4.0, I was offered a great chance to **gain a 100% scholarship** to the University of Huddersfield, **a highly ranked university** in the UK. This even further **fueled my desire** to go and realize my dream. However, I've **encountered tons of obstacles**, one of which being the **financial conditions**. I as supposed to spend as much as 20.000 pounds to pay for the **living costs** there, and this was not something that my parents, a teacher and housewife, could afford.

Another trouble is that I didn't manage to get a Visa because the procedures were too complicated and required many papers and documents that I failed to get them all at that time.

Now I am 25 and fully **prepared both financially and spiritually**, I hope that in the next several months, I will **re-launch my plan**.

Follow-up questions

- **Do you think it's important to have realistic goals?**

Well, in my view if it's not realistic – then it's not really a goal – it's just a dream. A goal is something which is achievable, something you can actually work towards, whereas if it's not realistic, like you could never achieve it, then it's just a thought, or a dream, as I said – it's not something which is actionable so you'll probably never achieve it.

- **Do you think people should talk to others about their goals?**

It's not necessary in my view, although if someone wants to share their goals then it's okay. I mean, if me and my best friend had the same goal – then it would make sense that we talk about it with each other. But if I had a personal goal, whatever it was, and it didn't affect anybody else but me, I probably wouldn't bother sharing it with others. For example, if I made a goal to lose weight, read more, or learn a new skill, I'd probably just keep it to myself.

- **What is more rewarding, working towards the goal or achieving it?**

Personally, I found both are just as rewarding. It's sometimes difficult to working to achieve what you want to do, especially if things don't always go as planned, and sometimes it can take a long time, as in my case, but actually looking back at the steps I took to get where I am now, it was a good journey, and I enjoyed it. I met other people with the same goal and made some new friends, and it really was like a journey – not all of it was exciting, but there were some important and memorable moments.

- **Is it always necessary to have something to aspire to in the future?**

No, not always; not in the same way as having a goal that will change your life. There are plenty of people who don't really have any big goals for the future, and that's okay. Many people just want to be happy with their family or job, and that's enough for them. I guess those are goals which most people could say they have.

It's not always necessary to be working towards something big, or constantly trying to improve yourself, or learn new things. Some people are like that naturally and others are more relaxed and seem happy doing the things they do and are not very ambitious about achieving other things in life, and that's fine for them, as long as they're happy about it.

- **What is your general day to day plan?**

My general day-to-day plan typically involves working, playing with my baby, cooking for my family and taking care of some other household chores. Of course every day is not the same because my baby is very small and, no matter how hard we've tried, we just can't get him on any fixed routine so we have to follow his schedule instead. Basically, I wake up when he wakes up and between the meals I would play with him until he gets tired and naps and I would take advantage of the quiet moments to work on my lesson plans or post something on my teaching page. When it's sunny and dry we would take a walk in a park nearby but if it's cold or wet we would spend the whole day inside snuggling and playing and reading together.

- **Why do some people hate planning ahead?**

I myself am not a huge fan of planning ahead so I can totally relate to this question. There are people like me who prefer to live impulsively, make decisions on spot and just be in the moment. We find that way of life more interesting. We believe that when we spend too much time planning for the future, we miss out on the great moments that are happening in front of us, to us. Prior planning may sound like a wise thing to do but, more often than not, it turns out to be a total waste of time because you simply can't predict the future.

- **What are the advantages and disadvantages of planning?**

The biggest advantage of planning is that you always know what you're gonna do next. Planning ahead is important for us if we desire to achieve some certain goals in our personal and professional lives. Prior planning can be a powerful tool which helps you manage your time more effectively and increase your productivity. Having everything planned out may make it easier for some people to go through their day. Having said that, too much planning can distract us from the now. We all want to be happy in the future, eventually, but what about now? Isn't it much better if we can be happy right here, right now? Too much focus on the future can lead to stress and negative thinking.

Other possible questions:

- **How parents encourage their children to achieve goals?**
- **What's the difference between dream and goal?**
- **What kinds of goals do young people usually have?**
- **How do you achieve your goal?**

29. Describe a kind of vegetable or plant you like to grow.

You should say:

What it is

What it looks like

Where you want to plant it

And explain why you like to plant it

Sample answer:

I'd love to grow water spinach, a typical sort of vegetables in Vietnam. It is a **greenish, long-stemmed veggie** that is **mainly cultivated** in **aquatic environment**.

I am fortunate enough to have a small garden in my backyard (I live in the suburbs of Ho Chi Minh city), so I plan to **set aside** a part of the garden, among all tropical flowers and Bonsais of mine, to plant it. If I have enough time, I'd also love to grow more so that I can make it a part of my family meals as well as give them away to my relatives and friends. The reason why I like it is that it's pretty easy to prepare; even a 12-year-old Vietnamese kid can make a simple dish with water spinach. Another reason is that it's the best example of Vietnamese vegetables.

Along with rice, water spinach appears in **virtually** every Vietnamese meal. Vietnamese normally **stir-fry** it with **sliced beef**, or even just a dish of steamed water spinach with fish sauce is fine. Anyway, the plan's already settled; after today's test, I will get down to growing it soon!

Follow-up questions

- **Do people in your country like growing plants by themselves?**

Well, I would say it depends; this may vary from the geographical location. You know, for people in the suburbs they most likely grow their own crops because they have a wide space like a barn or a plantation to grow their plants. What's more, this can ensure the quality of food is fresh especially vegetables and fruits like cabbage, carrots and strawberries. Another reason is that, they make this as a primary source of income, they sell their products on public market in town. Basically, this is where most people make money.

- **Where do people grow plants?**

There are several places where people plant their crops. The most common is the rice field, I can say that it's the best place to grow your plants because of the fact that rice fields has good soil quality and is sufficient for sunlight especially those plants that requires direct sunlight such as rice, corns, etc. But for some, they usually grow their plants on their back yard, they

make a small area to plant some crops and some area to grow their flowers. Take my grandma as an example, she has a small backyard where she garden her plants everyday. She has varieties of tomatoes and flowers in it.

- **What do you think is the most important plant in your country?**

It is no doubt that paddy plant is the most essential plant in my country because rice is the main food in Vietnam. You know, people in Vietnam eat rice or noodles as part of their heavy meal. According to my history class, in ancient Vietnam people found a solution to feed their stomach using some basic ingredients, it is then they invented fried rice which has become the most common part of Vietnamese people's meal especially in the Southern area. I can tell that, it is not only an affordable meal but also a healthy meal as you can add vegetables and some seasoning to make it flavorful. So I have the thought that if there is no enough supply of rice, most people will starve especially the needy ones.

- **Do you want to be a farmer in the future?**

Farming is a decent job, I highly respect them and without farmers we will have no supply of crops, however, in my personal view point, I don't think it is a suitable job for me due to the reason that I want to be a good doctor. I have been an aspiring doctor since I was a kid and my parents have been very supportive about it. The main reason why I want to be a doctor is because I want to help cure diseases all over China and to help spread health awareness to people. I respect farmers but being a farmer is not something I have thought of doing in the future.

- **Is it important to eat fruits?**

We all know that fruits must be part of our daily meals so I strongly believe that fruits are essential to us. I can provide a reason to prove this, first, when I got sick my doctor told me to eat healthy foods, what he meant was, to avoid processed foods and eat foods that grow on trees such as fruits like bananas, apple and grapes. I followed his advice and guess what? I recovered quickly. In general, fruits are natural remedies for illness and for long life.

- **Did you like to eat fruits when you were a child?**

If I can vividly remember, it wasn't difficult for me to eat any kinds of food during my childhood and fruits are not an exemption. So I am guessing that, I liked to eat fruits when I was young due to the fact that my mother prepared fruits in a very creative way. What I mean is that, she made different shapes out of an apple or banana which attracted me to eat it. Therefore, eating fruits was part of my meal when I was young.

Other possible question:

- What kind of fruit do you enjoy the most?
- Did you enjoy the same type of fruit when you were a child?
- Do you prefer to eat fruit or vegetables?
- Are there any fruits or vegetables you don't like? Why?
- Do most people eat vegetables in your country?

30. Describe an appointment that was put ahead of schedule.

You should say:

What this appointment was

When it happened

Why it was brought forward

And explain how you felt about the result.

Sample answer:

I'm usually a person who hate changes; so every appointment that I've made is usually firmly, or even **rigidly**, fixed. However, there was a time when my appointment was annoyingly brought forward. It happened around 2 years ago, when I had my very interview for a part-time job as a teacher of English in a local English center.

Before the interview, I **was informed via email** that I would be teaching a **45-minute demo lesson** in a real classroom context, **under observance of** the headmaster of the center. I **was speechless upon** receiving that news, since I did not have even **the faintest idea** of how it would be like to be teaching in front of a class full of young learners. Therefore, I planned to spend at least 3 days and nights so that I could be well prepared for that important day. However, what did not go according to my plan was that the headmaster sent me another email telling me that that class would be brought forward 2 days earlier, which meant that I would have to start my class tomorrow evening! I was **both furious and scared**. I **worked through the rest of my night in panic, cramming everything into my head**, and putting everything I could into the PowerPoint slides.

Eventually, my lesson was a mess. Animation effects didn't work, I forgot nearly everything I learned, and the kids weren't able to **refrain from laughing out loud** with my **constant silly mistakes**. It was absolutely not a memorable experience of mine, and I hope that I won't be encountering such a thing in the future.

Follow-up questions

- **Do people in your country accept excuses for being late? Why? / Why not?**

It depends on the situation and if the excuse is genuine or not. We are very hospitable and respectful here and we believe that if a person arrives late it is better than not arriving at all, but most people try to arrive on time and most of the time it's not a problem. I think excuses are only a problem if the occasions are too frequent or inconvenient for the other person.

- **What type of excuses do people in your country accept?**

There are many reasons why people might be late arriving somewhere or attending a meeting or appointment. Problems with the family, having to help an older member of the family or look after one of the younger children in an emergency, problems with transport or delays in traffic are common and of course when you are sick or ill and have to postpone an event or appointment. Most other people understand these situations, because it has also happened to them at one time or another in their lives, you know, sometimes you just can't avoid being late for an appointment.

- **Do you think it is important to remember things?**

It can certainly help make things easier. If you can remember things easily and not forget them it can be very beneficial. Activities such as studying and learning seem much easier, for example, learning English is much easier if you can remember all the vocabulary and grammar you learn and how to use it correctly, and if you can recall things easily it can save you a lot of time instead of having to look up information or ask someone else if they know.

It can also make life generally easier if you have a good memory for faces and names and can remember them when you meet people, or recall a telephone number or some useful information without the need to access your phone or write everything down to avoid forgetting it.

- **What are some of the benefits of having a good memory?**

I guess some people think you are maybe more intelligent, or certainly smarter than most people, especially if you have an excellent memory and can remember everything. It can help you avoid embarrassing social situations if you never forget someone's birthday, or if you don't forget people's names when you haven't seen them for a long time.

It can also be useful in activities like quizzes or competitions which rely on general knowledge if you can remember the relevant information and answer the questions. And I suppose it's probably a good thing in relation to your career or work if you are able to recall information

which is relevant without having to ask someone else to help, or refer to a reference book or something like that. Not having to look up stuff can save you loads of time.

- **Are there any things that are especially important for people to memorize?**

It all depends on the situation, even remembering your name is important, when someone asks you what it is. Or where you live; imagine if you couldn't remember that kind of information one day... it would be really awkward, wouldn't it? Really, all information we need to operate normally is critical... maybe we can consider other information to be useful but optional, or non-critical.

- **Why do people often forget small things?**

Well, I suppose it could be because they have a lot of things to think about or remember and sometimes it's easy to remember big important things - but little things are more easily forgotten.

Most people try to remember everything without using anything to help them and while it may be easy enough to remember a few important things – the more things you have to remember the higher the probability that you forget some of the smaller things that maybe aren't so important.

- **How can we improve our memory?**

I suppose the easiest way would be to practice memorizing things more often – practice makes perfect - or as I said earlier, get into the habit of making notes or reminders for things that you don't want to forget, nowadays it's easier than ever – just program a reminder in your phone anytime and set the alarm so you can't forget.

- **How memory can help you to learn a new skill? = Do you think having a good memory is important for students?**

Well, it certainly helps, doesn't it? I mean it's so much easier to remember all those facts, or formulas or information or whatever it is you're studying. It can save a lot of time if you can just recall most things you need in an instant and not have to review your books or look it up again each time you some information.

Other possible questions:

- **What kind of ways can be used to help remember things?**
- **Do you think which is more important, work meeting or friend dating?**
- **Do you think it is a good idea to use electronic devices for putting reminders?**
- **Is human memory important nowadays?**
- **Is it important to be punctual in your country?**

31. Describe a time you talked to a stranger.

You should say:

Where it happened.

When it happened

What you talked with each other

And explain how you felt about it

Sample answer:

I have to admit that I'm not of much of a sociable person – I mean, I am quite **shy and inhibited**, so most of the time I tend to avoid talking to strangers. But there was a time when I was forced to talk to one, and it happened around 5 years ago, on my very first trip to Ho Chi Minh City.

I was a 20-year-old freshman back then, and I was unable to **navigate my way to HCMC University of Education** where I applied for. Back then Google Map wasn't as popular as it is nowadays, so the only way I could **figure out** the way is by asking the locals. After hours wandering around, I finally resorted to asking a lady who was selling noodles at a food cart near where I stood. I **put all the efforts and courage into uttering those words** "Aunt, would you be so kind as to show me the way to the HCMC University of Education?" I did find myself a little bit **absurd** for being too formal, yet anyway I did it, and I was proud of it. The elderly lady smiled and pointed at the large, **nameless building** across the road, saying "It's over there, my son." It took me around 3 minutes to pull myself together to finally understand that I had spent roughly 3 hours going around my destination!

The university was **under repair** back then, so I was unable to realize that it was the right one. Finally, I passed through **the school entrance**, with a smile on my face, promising myself that I would be more willing to talk to people in the future.

Follow-up questions:

- **What might be a reason for a person to start a conversation with a stranger?**

Well, I suppose one of the most common situations would be when you might want to ask someone for directions or for help if you are lost in a strange place. You could need to find out about something and need to ask for information about a product or service and so start a conversation with a customer service representative or salesperson. And you might find yourself waiting or stuck in a place with some other people unexpectedly and just start talking or complaining about the situation, as a way of killing time until the situation is resolved.

- **Do you like to start conversations with strangers? [Why/Why not?]**

Personally, no, I generally don't mind if someone talks to me first, but I'm not the one who usually starts a conversation. I'm quite shy and reserved so I prefer to listen to music or read a book if I have to wait somewhere. I only start conversations with other people if I find myself in a situation as I mentioned earlier and I need some information or help.

- **How often do you do that?**

I suppose it doesn't happen that often, maybe once or twice a month. I remember the last time was a couple of weeks ago when I was going for an interview for an internship and I got confused about the address. I had to ask two different people to help me find the right building where the interview was to be held, even though I managed to find the correct street on my own.

- **What is the advantage of network communication, for example through Facebook or Twitter?**

The main advantage is probably the fact that you can talk and communicate with people from all over the world. And it's usually instant or certainly easier than arranging to meet to have a chat. There are no geographical boundaries so you can be in contact with many more people than those you would normally come into contact with personally in your everyday life. I regularly chat with people in other countries and I know that I'll probably never meet them in person, but it's interesting all the same.

- **Which one is better, being introvert or extrovert?**

I think there is no definitive answer to this question as it is a controversial issue and everyone has an opinion. On the one hand, an introvert enjoys solitude and operates as a loner most of the time. Furthermore, they have only a few friends and they don't open up easily to others about personal matters. Great scientists, poets, artists and talented people were often introverted. Being introvert means people will have more time to think and create something new.

On the other hand, being extrovert means that someone is friendly, outgoing, sociable, and affectionate and has large groups of friends. Oftentimes, they engage in different kinds of activities and they share things that concern them with their friends. Regarding which type of personality is more preferable, I would say that 'ambient people' is the answer to me. I don't think that being totally introvert or extrovert is good, but combining these two types would be the most appropriate.

- **What type of person are you?**

That's a really difficult question for me and I confess that I haven't even thought about it. The truth is that I have only 5 close friends, they are like siblings to me and I discuss anything that happens in my life with them. I wouldn't say that I'm always an outgoing and sociable person except for the times that I really want to. For example, I am not the type of girl who will go out every day and meet new people but when I was at university I showed others the social part of myself in order to make friends. I know it sounds a little weird and creepy, but this is the way I am. So, I would say that I'm more of an introvert person, with some elements of extroversion when needed.

- **What important aspects do you consider to make new friends?**

'Friend' is a sacred notion for me and they are as important as family. First of all, as I mentioned earlier, friends are nothing less than siblings to me and they are the people we have chosen to have in our life for whatever reason. A real and strong friendship should be based on true feelings and not on selfishness. Virtues like love, trust, honesty, compassion, affection and kindness are indispensable parts of this concept. Moreover, being there when your friend needs you, help them whenever you can, console them when they get hurt and be happy with their achievements are some of the main characteristics. Everyone should invest in emotions and show them to friends in certain circumstances. Besides, if people don't give and receive love in their life, nothing would have a meaning and I believe friends are there to do just that.

32. Describe a famous person in your country.

You should say:

Who this person is

How you know this person

What this person is famous for

And explain why you like this person.

Sample answer:

Today, I'm going to talk about Ho Chi Minh who is well-known in my country. He was the first President of Vietnam who **led the whole nation to independence**. As a citizen of Vietnam, it is normal for everybody to know him because **children are educated about him** since starting to go to school. Since I knew Ho Chi Minh, I have seen a lot of films and read a lot of books about him. He is always my greatest idol to study and follow. The reason why he is well-known in my country is that Ho Chi Minh **devoted his life to our nation**. If he had not been born in Vietnam, our country could have **been invaded by other countries**. I admire him for a number of reasons.

Firstly, President Ho was **a very determined man**. He showed his determination at a very young age when he decided to travel to France to **obtain knowledge**, hoping to find a way to rescue the nation. During his journey, he did various jobs to survive despite many difficulties. Being inspired by him, I have been working very hard to **fulfill my dream** until I can achieve it. Secondly, I knew that Uncle Ho was very good at foreign languages; he could speak fluently fifteen languages. In fact, I have been studying English for ages but I haven't been satisfied with my English. I think this is a good opportunity to learn his experiences to improve my English level.

Follow-up questions

- **What kind of people becomes famous in your country these days?**

Answer – In my country, it's people who work in the film, sports and music industries that become more famous than others. It is mainly because their jobs are in the public. Their career is all about performing to the satisfaction of others. They would not have a job if nobody watched their work. So if they are talented, they will become famous automatically. Many politicians in my country are also famous especially those who appear in the media often mainly television.

- **What kind of achievements made people famous in the past?**

Answer – I understand that in the past political and military achievements made people famous. Those who were in the forefront of political and military movements naturally became famous all around the country. At that time the presence of the media was less strong so it would have been difficult for performers or artists to become famous. I think what has made all the difference now is the medium that is used to reach out to people.

- **How do you think people will become famous in the future?**

Answer – I think probably the same way people become famous today, through the mass media. As long as people depend on the mass media, those who work in the entertainment industries will be famous. Politicians too will continue to be famous because what they do has the potential to affect people's lives. What I find strange is that the ones who are most gifted or talented always remain unsung and it will always be like that.

- **What are the benefits of being a famous person?**

Answer – Being famous can of course be a good thing. You can use your fame to do good things for your community. If you are a famous person, you can exhort people to support a cause or draw their attention to an issue which requires public attention or intervention.

- **Can you think of any disadvantages to being famous?**

Answer – One obvious disadvantage of being famous is that you will lose your privacy. You won't be able to go anywhere in public, without people following you. You will always have cameras flashing in your face. Another drawback is that your personal life will become common knowledge. You may even feel isolated from the real world if you are so famous.

- **How do the media in your country treat celebrities?**

Answer – I don't think that the media in my country is any different when it comes to treating celebrities. They take a keen interest in their professional and personal lives and keep holding interviews and all sorts of things with them. Sometimes I get the feeling that they are overdoing it a bit. Sometimes I fail to see the news value of a story they have published about a celebrity.

- **Why do you think ordinary people are so interested in the lives of celebrities?**

Answer – What I have noticed is that it is people who have more free time on their hands who take a keener interest in the lives of celebrities. They are bored and unsatisfied with their lives. Maybe many find it a good way to forget about their own problems, to find something else to think about. It could also be to draw some inspiration from them to work harder or become more productive as the celebrities always have tales of success to share.

- **What do you think of celebrities appearing in advertisements?**

Answer – I don't support celebrities appearing in advertisements. Many of them hardly use the products they endorse. They appear in the adverts just for the money. I think that governments need to hold them accountable for the endorsements they make. Many a time the products turn out to be ineffective and the only reason someone has bought it was because their favorite movie star or sports star appeared in its commercial. So it's not honest for celebrities to appear in advertisements for products they themselves don't believe in.

- **Many professional athletes are very well paid. Do you think that they deserve to be so well paid?**

Answer – I think so. I mean we must understand that it's not every athlete who has a high remuneration. It's only the extremely talented who are paid so much money. I am of the opinion that they deserve it. They should have spent most part of their lives practicing, working hard to develop their technique. Second of all, in any sport fame is passing. They are only in the lime light for a while. They have no job security. So it's totally justified that their salaries are high. As long as their participation in a sport generates revenue for it and the government, they must be well paid.

- **What kinds of things give status to people in your country?**

Well, education, wealth, money, large house, car, fame, career are some of the things that give status in our country. There are some other aspects of status in my country like luxury gadgets, political power, expensive dresses and publicity. However, the things I mentioned before are most prominent aspects of status in my country. For instance, people with higher education and knowledge naturally get a status that others can't have. Similarly, wealth, cars, houses, branded dresses, and many other things are often considered as part of people's status in many cases.

- **What are the important qualities to achieve our ambitions?**

Determination and hard work, in my opinion, are two most important qualities to fulfil our ambitions and goals. Luck often plays its tricks but I believe fortune always favours the hard working and strong-minded people to succeed.

Apart from that, proper planning, timely execution, expertise and experience are some other qualities we need to achieve our goals in life.

- **Are all ambitions good in life?**

I guess every positive ambition that brings happiness, success, prosperity and well-being of others is a good one. However, we are often driven by our selfishness, greed and materialistic achievements and any ambition which is aimed to fulfil our personal greed is a bad one.

In general, ambitions in our life help us to work harder and give meaning in life and that's why we should have ambitions, positive ambitions I mean.

- **What type of ambition young generation in your country has?**

That's a good question. The young generation in our country usually aims for a prosperous career and economic freedom. Their ambitions in life also include being someone famous so that people will know them, being a successful and happy person in later life and having a beautiful and nice life partners. They also want to explore the world and want to see a flourishing country in the future where violence and crime would be a thing of past.

- **Would you focus more on achieving your ambition or doing things you love to do?**

Personally, my ambition in life is quite realistic and not something we hear in fairy tales only. Being able to do something I love and have passion is not different than my ambition. I want to lead a life that would be surrounded by my family members, relatives, friends and people I care about. Being able to set up my own business or doing a job that I would feel interested in is both my ambition and dream.

33. Describe a trip you plan to take in the near future.

When possibly it will be

Where would you go

What preparation do you need for that trip?

And explain why this would be a special trip.

Sample answer:

Today, I'm going to share with you a place where I usually hang out with my sister. It is a small café which is quite far from the center of this city. As an undergraduate, my schedule is pretty busy so it is really hard to travel to another place. However, at weekends, I always try to **save time for** my little trip to this café.

The coffee house is located on the top of a hill surrounded by a lot of fields. Additionally, **it is decorated with antique decorations**, which makes the atmosphere become so cozy. I am also pleased with this place because the waitresses here are hospitable as well as friendly. Therefore, I always feel welcomed whenever I go to this café. Finally, it **serves a wide variety of refreshment** for customers to choose which one they prefer the most.

There are many reasons explaining why I am into this café. Firstly, because this place is in the suburbs, it offers me an opportunity to **get out of the hustle and bustle of the city**. I find myself comfortable to chat with my sibling or simply enjoy **the tranquil views**. Secondly, this is an ideal place for me to review all lessons before my upcoming exams. I always drink a cup of coffee during break times to relax after studying for a long time.

Follow-up questions:

- **What problems can people have when they are on their journey, for example to work or school? Why is this?**

I think lesser known places are more fun. You can research those places and determine what's interesting there and then go and do what you want there without tons of people in line like a crowded traffic jam in downtown Guangzhou at rush hour. Like I told you previously, I've been to Sichuan Province before to experience the food and beautiful scenery there and the places I've gone to there were never overly crowded and I had a wonderful time there soaking in the scenery and eating the yummy food.

- **Do people prefer short trips or long trips?**

These days I prefer to take longer trips than shorter trips. With the longer trips I like to take 9 to 10 days because the places I go are usually outside of China for the past 2 years. In this way after you get on and off the plane to a place like Thailand or also in my case Australia to

check out the schools there and to tour around you lose 2 days just in traveling. After the jet lag I want to relax and take my time in the city where I'm staying so relaxation is the key thing when I go on a trip and that's why I like longer trips these days.

- **What kinds of problems would people have when they go on a long trip?**

Probably forgetting something is one of your biggest problems when you're taking a long trip. My parents had a trip out to the United States last year to visit my sister in university and my father forgot to bring his medicine for his diabetes and so he had to visit a hospital there to get a blood test done and get his prescription filled. Likewise, my mother forgot her wallet that has all of her credit cards on that trip so my father had to go shopping with her to all of the stores so that they could use his credit card.

- **What do you think people can learn from travelling to other countries?**

The best thing is the experience of dealing with everything, from the planning, the actual travel and then dealing with other people in a different country. It's life experience and appreciating how people do things in other parts of the world is very important, especially in today's global marketplace.

The more varied your experience is the better it is for you as an individual. That's why language skills can be so important too. Traveling to other countries teaches you to plan, prepare, adapt and think on your feet as well as solve problems on your own sometimes. It makes you more independent and resourceful. But most importantly it gives you a better understanding of the world you live in.

- **Can travel make a positive difference to the economy of a country? How?**

Absolutely, there are many countries which rely on travel for tourism or business. In fact, in some countries tourism is the main industry so without international travel their economies would probably be in big problems. It's not just the travel, it's the whole range of services and jobs which support the travel such as transport, accommodation, restaurants and so on.

- **Do you think a society can benefit if its members have experience of travelling to other countries? In what ways?**

Yes, because when people travel they see other things which maybe aren't normal in their own country and they may be like them or don't like them, so they can either appreciate their own country more or perhaps try to improve it by introducing new ideas or ways of doing things which they have seen in other places.

All it takes is for someone to see something they like and then copy the idea in their own country, it might be as simple as a style of cafe or bar, or as complex as a transport system,

but without having travelled and seen something different it probably would never have happened.

34. Describe a work of art or a statue

You should say:

Where you saw it

When you saw it

What it looks like

How do you feel about it

Sample answer:

I'd like to tell you about the statue of King Ly Thai To, which is located in the center of Hanoi, the capital city. This is **a cultural and architectural work** which aims to honor King Ly Thai To, the first king who found Thang Long, or Ha Noi today.

The statue **was erected to** celebrate the 50th **anniversary of the liberation** of Hanoi in 2004. It is the largest **bronze sculpture** in Vietnam and weighs 12 tons. The right hand of Ly Thai To holds the Chieu Doi Do or **the decree of the relocation** of the capital city to Thang Long, and the left hand points to the location where the construction began. The statue of Ly Thai To is located in Indira Gandhi Park, which is named after the slain Indian prime minister who was a supporter and friend of Vietnam. The park is known as a place for locals to dance, jog and play games.

As for me, the area around this statue is the perfect place for me and my friends to come and dance. It really helps us to **let the hair down** for a while. To be honest, I don't know enough about arts to say if it is a great piece or not. However, it is important to me because it **represents the political and cultural history of my country**.

Follow-up questions: Refer to question 10

35. Describe a second language you would like to learn

You should say:

What language you would like to learn

When you want to learn it

Is it difficult to learn?

Why you would like to learn it

Sample answer:

I am planning to move to the UK in the next year after completing my Bachelors as a computer engineer and hope to take the post-graduation degree there. As far as I know that the British people are **perfectionists** and they do not prefer students who have some other tones except their native. It becomes difficult for the foreign students to compete among the natives unless at least the speaking tones are similar to them. So, I want to learn the language, particularly the spoken part. Gradually, I will follow the British writing style and will start using their native words in my writings so that I could have a native writing style too. Learning the language will help me to **reach the goals**.

I am quite fine in English but **lack the ability to** speak a standard form of English in formal situations. French-tones block my natural flow when I start speaking English. I have tried several times, alone, to change my French tone during the English conversations but failed each of the moments. Being a French national, **I am highly dominated with** the local French tone that makes me feel bad when I speak English. Besides, the pronunciations also become weird to listen by the others. A professional English language course will help me rid of the local tones. Besides, I have to practice a lot too to bring the natural tone as the English people use. Hope I will be able to learn the language for my betterment. That's all I think.

Follow-up questions: Refer to question 15

36. Describe an important/happy stage in your life

You should say:

How old you were at that time

Where you were at that time

What you did at that time

Why do you think it is important to you

Sample answer:

Thank you very much for this nice cue card topic. The best part of my life is undoubtedly the childhood I have had. In fact, childhood is favorite to everyone and my childhood was extraordinary, magical and full of excitements.

I spent my childhood in a **suburban area** which is (...say the name of the place where you spent your childhood...). This was a very beautiful place and I was lucky that I was born in this wonderful town. My parents always loved me and they had been my best companion in my childhood. Once in a year, they took me out of the country to enjoy our summer holidays. I was **the center of their universe** and my childhood became so gorgeous due to them.

Why my childhood is the most enjoyable stage in my life? - Well, I guess this was the time my **inquisitive mind** enjoyed everything new I saw or heard about. Reading, going to the school, playing, going out with my parents, learning new things, travelling and so many activities I had in my childhood make it extraordinary. There was no tension, responsibility and I had been surrounded by my parents love. I could ask for anything and my parents were ready to **fulfil my wishes**. I was in a dream world where no pain or sorrow was usually allowed to enter. My parents were my protector and I was their prince! **The family bonding was strong**, people cared more about others, they had more time to socialize and life was not that much mechanical that we see these days. The love, surprises, innocence, inquisitive minds, **unquenchable thirsts** to learning, beautiful surroundings, and worry less life made my childhood even more enjoyable. It was magical and **full of wonder**.

Follow-up questions:

- **What do you think is the best age in a person's life?**

Personally, I don't think there is just one best age, each stage of life has something special about it. I suppose that maybe life seems more exciting when you're younger, but then as you go through life you begin to understand that it's quite a long journey and many things can happen. Age isn't really a barrier or limitation unless you allow it to be, and there are many great things in life you can enjoy even when you're much older.

- **What are some things that make you happy?**

Let me have a little think...um... well, first of all, what always makes me happy is seeing my friends and family happy, which I suppose is probably the same for everyone. And as well as that, I'd say just doing the things I enjoy always puts me in a happy mood, you know, like playing the piano, and going to KTV with my friends.

- **Do you think people who have more talent are happier than others?**

No I wouldn't say they are. I mean, there are countless examples of famous singers and actors who were extremely talented, but for some reason turned to things like drugs or alcohol in order to escape the depression they felt. And on the other end of the scale, there are people with seemingly very little talent, but who are very happy and content with their life. So for me I'd say happiness bears no relation at all to the amount of talent a person has.

- **Do you think money makes people happy?**

Yeah, I suppose it does. You know, I think it's fair to say that money makes us all feel happy to some degree, because you can do so much with it, like buy new clothes or go on holiday or whatever. But saying that, I'd say it's only a kind of short-term happiness that we get from money, because the feeling soon fades, as I'm sure you'll agree! So I think if we want to enjoy long-term happiness, then it's really other things that bring about it, like appreciating what we already have in life.

- **Are the things that make people happy today the same as several decades ago?**

I guess the answer would have to be yes and no. Yes, because there are things like helping others which have always made people feel happy and will always continue to do so. And no, because people nowadays have generally become more materialistic, which is a reflection of the society we now live in. So a lot of happiness now comes from acquiring material goods and possessions, like houses and cars, which wasn't so much the case several decades ago.

- **In general, what do you think makes a happy family?**

That's a good question, and thinking about it, I would say it's basically just showing love, support and appreciation to one another. So in other words, I think it's not enough for us to just love our family members, but also show it, and by doing this we will be able to create happiness within the family. For example, you know, if a child does badly in a school exam, their parents should encourage and support them, as opposed to telling them off, and if they do well or win a prize, then their parents should show how proud they are. And in this way, I think the family will definitely be a happy one!

- **What kind of people do you think are most likely to be happy?**

I guess it's probably people who have a positive outlook on life, because they always tend to look on the bright side of things. So for instance, if they come across problems, they'll probably see them as challenges rather than problems.

- **Do you think there is any relationship between a person's age and their happiness?**

Yeah, I'd say there probably is, because for example, most young children seem to be very happy most of the time, one of the reasons being that they're blissfully unaware of all the pressures of modern-day life. And for a lot of adults, the pressure they face can be overwhelming, which naturally has an effect on their mental well-being, and can lead to a mid-life crisis. Having said all that though, I think it's very possible to go through one's whole life being happy if you live it in the right way.

- **Do young people and old(er) people find happiness from the same things?**

No, I'd say there's probably a slight difference. Because I mean, older people seem to find happiness from the simple things in life, such as playing a game of chess or simply sitting outside their homes watching the world go by, whereas I think it's fair to say that young people often need a bit of excitement in their lives to feel happy. So that's one thing, and what else...um... oh yeah, I'd say being in good health is another thing that makes elderly people feel happy, whereas a lot of young people kind of just take it for granted.

- **Do you think old people are very happy?**

Yes, I'd say on the whole they are, because I mean, the feeling I get whenever I'm with them is that they have a calm demeanor about them, which I think reflects a kind of peace of mind. You know, it's as if they've learned to accept everything they're faced with in the world, and as a result, I think this generally gives them a feeling of happiness.

- **What is the attitude to older people in your country?**

It's a lot better than it was, but then I think it's because older people are not so 'old' anymore, if you know what I mean. It's like older people now are less old – they are still active and I know some who still do things they did when they were younger. the fact that older people are 'younger' means that people's attitudes have changed also and now there are a lot more things for older people, events, clubs, activities and nobody seems to treat them as if they're useless or just a waste of time. A lot of them are really active and enjoying life and people see that and so they get a lot more respect.

Other possible questions:

- Is there a stage of life which is more difficult or easier than others?
- Is there a stage of life you particularly look forward to, or look back on fondly?

37. Describe an vehicle you would like to buy

What the vehicle is

When you want to buy it

Whether it could be expensive

Why do you want to buy it

Sample answer:

I do not own a car and have been planning to purchase a personal car for the last 1 year. I have planned to purchase a car that would facilities me and my family members to go to different places as an alternative to the public transportation.

Currently, we use public transportations and because of that, we can't plan our schedule in a flexible way. We have to **heavily depend on** the schedules of the public transportations and that kills lots of time. **Waiting in a long queue** for the bus is very inconvenient and we often **feel the need of** a personal car. I guess owning a personal car would give us lots of flexibilities and we would be able to go our together more frequently in our free time. We often cancel attending programs arranged by relatives and friends because of the **heavy traffic jam** on the road. A personal car would allow us to avoid the busy roads and attend more social programs.

I often get late for important meeting and schedules because of my **dependency on** the public car. Furthermore, in a personal car, I would be able to spend time the way I like and that would be relaxing while being in a public car is sometimes very exhausting.

Sometimes the shopping I do becomes cumbersome to carry on in a public transportation and my car would allow me to easily carry them home. We have 2-3 kids in our home and we feel unsafe to take them with us in public transportation. A personal car would ensure the safety for the kids as well on the street.

Follow-up questions:

- **Why do people need to travel every day?**

Well, I suppose the main reasons are to go to work, school or university so they can attend their jobs, classes or whatever they need to do. They may need to simply tavel to their office

and then stay there all day, or maybe they need to travel as part of their work, visiting customers or clients or fly to another city for an important meeting.

- **What problems can people have when they are on their daily journey to work or school for example? Why is this?**

I suppose one of the most common ones would be traffic jams, which can sometimes be very bad at peak hours when everybody is trying to travel at the same time. Or maybe they miss the bus or train because they were a little late - and then have to wait for the next bus or train but arrive late at work or wherever they needed to go. Then of course they could be involved in a traffic accident, especially if they're driving, and that can cause a lot of problems for them.

- **Some people say that daily journeys like these will not be so common in the future. Do you agree or disagree? Why?**

That's probably true, I mean more and more people are working from home now or even working on projects in different countries using technology and so they don't need to physically travel to an office to do their work. It would certainly make traffic less of a problem in big cities if more people could do that. Another factor which could reduce the necessity for these daily trips is the fact that many universities are now offering their courses online so students don't have to travel to the campus every day... and it's highly probable that more work will be done in the future without the need for employees to be sitting in a company office.

- **Is traffic a problem in your city?**

I come from (..say the city name...) and this city accommodates a large number of population. Due to this huge population and the increased number of public and private cars, the city often faces bad traffics. The number of people living in this city, the cars they are using and the public transportation they need is higher than the number of roads. As a result, the traffic jam often occurs and people have to suffer. Another reason for the traffic jam is the unauthorized parking of cars in the street. People do not often follow the exact traffic rules and because of their sincerity, we often face the horrible traffics in the street.

Other possible questions:

- **Why don't people pay enough attention to traffic jam?**
- **What is the most dangerous vehicle in the traffic? Why?**
- **Why don't people obey the traffic rules?**
- **Is your hometown suitable for tracking?**
- **Why do you think nowadays students use motorcycles much more than in the past?**

38. Describe a wild animal that you saw before

You should say:

What the animal is

What it looks like

Where it lives

And explain how you feel about this animal.

Sample answer:

Tiger is a wild animal which is very common in our country. It is the largest animal of the cat species and they grow up quite large. It can grow up to 11 feet and can weight more than 300 kg. Tigers generally live about 25 years and they require **a large habitat area** that supports their **prey requirements**.

The **most recognizable feature** of a tiger is its **dark vertical stripes** on **reddish-orange fur** with a lighter underside. They have got a big head and sharp teeth claws. It is **a carnival animal** that mostly depends on the meat of other animals. The largest number of tigers can be found in India and **the total subspecies** and the numbers of tigers are decreasing over time. Tigers are good swimmers and are often found crossing rivers and lakes **in heavy tides**. Tigers usually hunt alone unlike other animals that prey in a group. They first target their prey and aim at it. When the target is fixed, it attacks with **a sudden ferocity overpowering** the prey with the strength and size. Tigers have **great leaping ability** and can run very fast.

This **formidable large wild animal** is getting extinct over time and they have become numbered in the world. Approximately only 3500 tigers are present in the world and the number is decreasing. Many tigers are held in the zoo for public and they usually live on **supplied meat**.

In my opinion, since the human is superior to any other living species, we have a responsibility to **prevent the extinction of the tiger** as we are the primary reason for their extinction. Wild animals are part of **the eco-system** we live in and we have a natural responsibility to **preserve a balanced eco-system** for our own good.

Follow-up questions:

- **Should tourists be allowed to feed the animals in the zoos?**

I guess it depends on the safety of the zoo goers that the zoo keepers should make a decision as to whether they can feed the animals or not. For some friendly and convivial animals like elephants, monkeys, it's relatively safe for visitors to give them some pieces of bananas or sugarcane, which can enrich their experience and learn more about the habits of the animals.

By contrast, some dangerous animals like tigers or lions, visitors mustn't give those animals anything because their life can be in danger if they come in contact with them. Some people breed animals such as dogs for money.

- **How do you feel about that?**

I think every animal is entitled to their own right to live in freedom, especially those which we often call "pets". Forcing them into labor can be an acceptable idea as long as they receive a decent treatment from the owner. However, if their labor is exploited to the benefit of the owner, then that person should be condemned of his behavior.

- **Do you think there should be laws to protect the welfare of pets and farm animals? (For example, laws against cruel treatment.) Why?/Why not?**

I think such a law can't work really, given that even human rights are not respected, let alone giving such a privilege to animals. I think laws shouldn't come into effect in this respect, as what matter most is to change the attitude of people towards these precious and lovely animals

- **Are there any wild animals in Vietnam that are not found in any other country?**

I am no expert on this, and I hardly know the names of any rare animals in English, so there would be no point in making it up and explaining it to you. You can look it up in the Red List, in which I guess there are an abundant number of such rare species.

- **Are there any animal reserves in Vietnam where wild animals can live in protection?**

In Vietnam, there are few. Mostly we only have zoos where wild animals can be given a bit freedom and can receive special treatment. To the best of my knowledge, there are some on the outskirts of the city, but I can hardly think of a specific name to give you.

- **What are the benefits and drawbacks of keeping animals in zoos?**

It is true to say that by keeping animals in zoos, people could have a chance to get a close look at them without being attacked, while at the same time some animals can also be well protected and receive professional care. However, animal rights activists believe locking animals up in cages is inhumane as they are isolated from the wildlife, which is the ideal place for their physical and mental growth.

- **How do you think zoos might develop in the future?**

There are going to be some changes in the way zoos operate in the distant future, and the most likely one is that zoos might grow much larger in scale to provide enough space for all the

animals inside, which will definitely be good for creating an environment similar to their natural habitats. Besides, this could result in more varied recreational activities and the viewers will appreciate those wildlife creatures more and more thanks to their improved awareness.

- **Why are animals sometimes used in scientific experiments?**

It is common knowledge that animals are often used in scientific experiments for the good of humanity. Though it may sound selfish that one's happiness is obtained from another's suffering, it is considered by most a necessary suffering, as men themselves suffer too. Because by doing so, many new medical cures have been developed and lives saved.

- **Do you think animal testing will continue in the future?**

Just as I've said, as long as people still see it as a necessary suffering on the part of the animal it'll continue, and it's proved quite effective. Why do people like to keep pets? People mostly have pets to keep their company. Besides, they are useful for us in some cases too. When a dog sees a stranger, it barks and the home owner becomes aware of the existence of someone else outside the house. Besides, cats kill mice and protect the home from different mischief created by the tiny creatures.

- **What should we do to protect endangered animals? = How do Vietnamese people feel about the protection of wild animals?**

There are a number of courses of actions available to conserve the animals facing the threat of extinction. The first step is for the common people to actively participate in and support environmentalists' campaigns against illegal poaching, which is the main cause of the issue. Meanwhile the governments should impose strict punishments on those who engage in illegal hunting. Also, they should increase their spending on expanding nature reserves for these endangered creatures so that they can live and breed well in the future

- **Do you support doing experiment on animals?/ Researchers are being conducted on animals, is this good idea?**

Studies are on over the animals and I think it will be helpful to generate newer species or we should try to sustain the endangered species. More researches should be conducted on the animals as they are part of our ecology and their improved living condition will help maintain the ecological balance too. Moreover, the wildlife around the globe is in danger and the researches should help to discover the ways to protect them. If the researches are continued and the results are applied into the animals, the animals, human and the environment can benefit at the same time.

- **Why do some people refuse to eat animals?**

There can be two reasons as to why some are determined not to eat animals. The first reason can be for religious purpose. In some Muslim countries for example, cows are holy animals and eating beef is banned. Another reason can be that some are animal rights activists and choose to abstain from meat to show others that some animals need to be protected and that we should stop the hunting activity.

- **What would happen when some species disappear on earth?/What do you think are some of the benefits to humans from protecting wild animals?**

There can be a number of negative consequences if some species become extinct on our planet. The first effect is that there will be an imbalance in the ecosystem. If mosquitoes, for example, disappear forever, other creatures can suffer as a result, like frogs or lizards which usually feed on mosquitoes. Furthermore, there could be a number of hazards to people's lives, if there were no cats, the mice would dominate the house and run freely around, causing sanitary issues like food poisoning.

- **What kind of animals do people have in their home?**

Usually pet animals are kept in the house for different reasons, one of which is to keep the family members in company. But the preference differs from individual to individual. However, small four footed animals like dogs and cats are preferred and popular as pets for homes. Sometimes people also pick rabbits or fancy rats as their pet animals. Further, some of the people prefer birds as their pets too.

39. Describe a gift you sent to others recently

You should say:

What was the gift?

Whom did you give it to?

How did you feel about it? Why?

And explain why you chose this gift.

Sample answer:

The gift I gave to my younger sister recently is the one I would like to talk about. I gave her a cell phone recently. The model of the cell phone is Sony Experia Z and it has Android Operating System. This is a **water resistant cell phone** manufactured by Sony Mobile and is a hot one in the market. The cells phone cost me around 40 K and I had to save the money for the last 6-7 moths to present her the gift.

I knew that she had been wishing to buy a smartphone for a year but could not do so. I thought to buy her one on her next birthday and started saving the money. I saved almost 7-8 k each month and just before 3-4 days of her birthday, I bought the phone.

I felt really great after I gave the gift to my sister. That was **an unexplainable pleasure**, amusement, satisfaction that I felt after I saw her **bewildering face** after she opened the gift. She was so happy that I felt like that was a perfect gift for her. I am sure I would not have felt the same pleasure as I felt giving her the gift doing something else. She **had been longing to own a smartphone** and after receiving it from me she hugged me.

As I already told, from her conversation I knew that she wished to own a smartphone that she would be able to use the internet and **take quality photographs**. From that day, I promised myself that I would buy her one. And I wished to buy her a really good one. I could have bought her a phone for 10k but seriously I wanted to give her the best one that I can accommodate.

Follow-up questions: Refer to question 39

40. Describe an advertisement that you remembered very well

You should say:

What type of advertisement it is

What product it advertises

Where you first saw it

And explain why it was interesting.

Sample answer:

There are several advertisements that we see on the TV daily and some of them are very boring and others are average while some are very interesting and creative. One such advertisement that I really liked was regarding **the unmatched contributions** of mothers for their kids which I saw a few months back. The advertisement was broadcasted for the 'Mother's Day' and it was not for any product. **The ministry of child & mother care of health department** was **the sponsor of** this ad and I saw it 3-4 days before the last 'Mother's Day'.

This ad was a very creative one and it was not like the most other ads that **publicize or advertise their products**. Rather it was an advertisement dedicated to the mothers and it reminded us that the toughest job in the world is the job done by mothers. They take care of their kids with **the utmost care and dedication**. They sacrifice their own wished and will to **properly bring up the kids**. I saw this ad in the (...say a channel name...) UR TV channel.

This was a creative ad that effectively delivered the message it intended to. It has shown some successful person in the history at the end and before that it showed how mothers are taking care and **inspiring their kids to do good things** and in the end, it shows the tribute to the mothers of the world for their valuable and second to none contribution.

Follow-up questions:

- **In general, what are the pros and cons of advertising?**

Option 1: In my opinion, advertisements are an important part of our daily life. Whether you like them or not, they are there all around you: in the streets, in the newspapers, on TV and the Internet, actually everywhere. Advertisements keep the consumers informed as to what are there to choose from while they help the manufacturers to publicize their products. In addition, when the producers run their advertisements in the media, we don't need to pay so much money to enjoy the papers and TV or radio programmes. However, some advertisements may not be objective. On the contrary, they try to sound more encouraging and persuasive than the goods can guarantee. Sometimes, they create a need that otherwise wouldn't exist. But on the whole, the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

Option 2: Well, looking at the advantages, I'd say that the main one is that it can help increase the awareness of a product or service, and in a lot of cases, you can reach a very wide target market through advertising, for example with TV and Internet ads. And as for the drawbacks, well I suppose the most obvious one is the cost, because as I'm sure you know, advertising isn't cheap, and you have to pay for it up front, before you can start enjoying the benefits. So in other words, there's quite a big element of risk to it, because you know, you could end up losing quite a lot of money if your advertising campaign isn't successful.

- **How important are clothes and fashion to you? [Why/Why not?]**

Yes, definitely. If there were no advertising and you went to a shop, then you would just buy what you wanted based on maybe what others have told you, what the product looks like, or, depending on the product, what it says on the label. Advertising builds up a brand and people then trust a certain thing because they have seen it on television or elsewhere. Also, there is so much advertising around it must influence us. You can't escape it as it is fed to us constantly in our daily lives - not only in magazines, radio and television, but on billboards, on TVs installed on trains and platforms, even in schools and universities. So yes, advertising influences what we buy.

- **Describe the attitudes of the Vietnamese people towards advertisements.**

I think we take a positive attitude towards advertisements. Nowadays, you just can't imagine how imaginative those advertising people are. All the color schemes, imagination and creation attract so much attention. But when choosing any goods, we really don't only look at the

advertisements; instead, we look at the quality, service, price and even the social record of this company. But of course I have to admit some creative and colorful advertisements have really attracted some young consumers. Whenever they look at an item, they have an obvious association with the advertisement.

- **Do you think there's too much advertising in our daily lives?**

It could be seen to be necessary in terms of the fact that, as I mentioned before, there is so much choice that we need someone to guide us in what to buy or to give us some extra information about products. Without this, it would be difficult to know where to start. However, that said, I'm not sure that I would regard it as 'necessary' as overall I think it may do more harm than good. As we just discussed, advertising encourages people to buy things they possibly do not need. We live in a consumer society and many people are in debt because we are encouraged to buy and buy, and I'm sure advertising plays a major role in this. Without advertising we could just do our own research and decide what we really need. So no, I would not say that advertising is necessary in modern society.

- **Do you think there are too many advertisements?**

I'm not sure if you can measure how much is too much – because there is no limit, is there? I guess if companies advertise, then they must be moving their products, and they wouldn't advertise something if it wasn't going to be successful for them, because that would just be bad business, so I suppose they must assess the level of advertising they do and are happy with it. Maybe some people might think there are too many ads everywhere, but then it's not like anyone is forcing you to look at them or respond to them.

- **Do you think advertisements are a good or bad influence on children?**

Looking at today's children, I would have to say advertisements have predominately had a negative influence on their lives and character. Ads create a discontentment with what children have and a desire to own more and to be like everyone else. Advertisements usually tend to be unrealistic and give a false impression of how the children should be or what will happen when they buy the product.

- **Do you think there should be some controls or restrictions placed on the advertising industry?**

Yes, I do. Some things should not be advertised, such as cigarettes, which are harmful to people's health. Most people are aware of their existence, so they don't need to be promoted more. Children especially should not be shown advertisements that make harmful things look cool or interesting. Advertisements that have age-inappropriate content should also be banned.

- **What's the most frequently used method of advertising?**

Well nowadays I'd say it's probably online advertising, because people are spending so much time on the Internet. And companies have basically latched on to this fact, because almost every website you go on now has advertising of some sort on it.

- **Which do you think is the most effective means of advertising?**

Well I'm no expert, but I suppose it kind of depends on the product you're trying to sell. So for example, if it's a mass-market product like shampoo, then I guess TV advertising would be the most effective, as it reaches the widest audience, and also uses moving images and sounds, unlike newspaper ads, which just use still images. But if, on the other hand, it's a niche product which only has a very small target customer group, then I'd say you're better off using a more focused means of advertising, for example putting ads on websites which are related to that particular product or service. Because that way, the ad will only be viewed by people who might actually be interested in it, and it will also be a lot more cost-effective than using other ways to advertise.

- **What do you think is the purpose of advertisements (or advertising)?**

As the name suggests, advertisement is a public promotion of some products or services. Advertisements are mostly used by manufacturers and companies to make their products or the services they offer known to people, which is an effective means of publicity.

- **What kinds of products do you think are most suitable to be advertised?**

That's a difficult question, and I've never really thought about it before, but I guess it would be those which are new on the market. Because if you think about it, those are the products which people don't really know about, and if they don't know about them, then chances are they're not gonna buy them. So yeah I think it's logical that these are the products which are most in need of advertising.

- **Do you think the number of advertisements will increase in the future?**

Yes, I imagine it's very likely that it will, because I mean, it's already increased considerably from 20 years ago. You know, it seems that everywhere you look now, you can see advertising, for example, in lifts, on the street, and so I can't see any reason why it won't go on increasing, especially seeing as commercialism in society seems to be getting more and more prevalent, which, I think you would agree, goes hand in hand with advertising!

41. Describe a well-paid job that you think you would be good at.

You should say:

What the job is

What qualifications are required for this job

How this job is different than other jobs

And say why you would be good at this job.

Sample answer:

Well now I would like to tell you about **my ideal occupation** in the near future that I've done quite a lot of research about. I want to become the first Vietnamese male IELTS examiner in Hanoi. You know the title "the first Vietnamese IELTS examiner" was taken a couple of months ago by an IDP female teacher, otherwise it would be my **initial goal**. Truly sad!

Anyway, so I actually did my homework and **googled** the process as well as requirements. In order to **accomplish my ambition**, I must have at least a bachelor degree and **a TESOL degree which stands for Teaching English to Speakers of Other Languages**. Totally **achievable**, in my opinion. In addition, after **submitting the application form**, followed by an interview in person, applicants **are obliged to** complete **a mandatory training** for 160\$. Seems like a lot, but you see, **hard work pays off**.

If I become an examiner, my current salary would **quadruple** from 10\$ to 40\$ per hour. I will also have the bragging right with all of my colleges and I believe these two reasons alone are quite enough, right? That would be the end of my story and thank you for spending two minutes listening to what you have already known and been through.

Follow-up questions:

- **What kinds of jobs can also get high salary in your country?**

As in other nations, how high a person's salary is determined by their time and efforts. It is not unrealistic that doctors or CEOs of certain corporations receive significantly higher incomes compared to other professions because they have to spend years honing their skills and accumulating hands-on experience before practicing their career. Besides, celebrities like MCs or comedians also have a handsome salary since they contribute greatly to our lives. Just imagine how life would be if there are no comedy shows or reality programmes.

- **Do people who have different levels of income feel happy about how much they earn?**

This is a fascinating question, really. The discrepancy in income levels generally reflects the degree of happiness a person may feel. This is due to the fact that when people have the means, they can easily afford high-quality services and enjoy their life better. They can go to

the cinema with their buddies to watch a blockbuster or hang out at some coffee shops. These things make people satisfied in life. On the contrary, if people can't take their mind off stuff like how to earn a living to support their family financially, definitely they sense no happiness in this life.

- **What do you think employers (or supervisors) can do to help motivate their employees to perform better at work, besides giving them a pay raise?**

There is a number of ways that bosses or supervisors can adopt to raise their employees' morale and enhance the overall work productivity apart from offering them higher salary. I guess the most effective approach would be for companies to organize annual excursions so that their workers can socialize with one another and cultivate team spirit while they can escape from the stress for a while. The second one is that more a flexible working schedule should be brought in as this would allow workers to have more quality family time and a worry-free set of mind at work.

- **Do you think it is good to change jobs frequently?**

If I have to choose, the answer would be no. Instead of job-hopping on a frequent basis, it would be better if we reflect on our interests or make greater efforts and determination in what we are doing. This helps us to have an overall picture of our genuine abilities and better adapt to an environment for longer stay. Another plus point is the promotion prospects are more promising if we set our heart on staying at the same place because the more we work, the more hands-on experience we gain. This makes us qualified for a pay rise or a good promotion

- **If someone feels bored in their job, is it easy for them to change a different job?**

Definitely Yes, It is not uncommon that many people change their occupation simply because they can derive no sense of satisfaction in what they are doing. If your job only means getting up early and rushing to the workplace and nothing else to you, the chances are that you will make more mistakes while working on your assigned tasks or lose your temper on a daily basis. So, leaving your current post and going to somewhere with more fresh challenges turns out to be the choice that fills you with energy and eagerness to contribute.

- **What should schools do to help students survive in society well?**

There is a whole lot of stuff schools and teachers can do to enhance their survival rate of students when they leave the protection of teachers and step into society. The first meaningful thing is that teachers should give more practical lessons besides the solely theoretical curriculum the kids learn at school. For example, guiding them how to do first aid can help them rescue others from drowning when they go swimming, or how to protect themselves

during a sexual intercourse. This essential knowledge is what truly helps students not to get lost in the big world out there.

- **What kinds of jobs are unpopular in Vietnam?**

Well to the best of my knowledge, I would say that like other nations, Vietnamese people have different occupations to make ends meet these days. I can only tell which one is popular. So if you ask me the opposite, the answer would vary. To be honest, being a nurse is the least popular job among people at my age.

- **Why do many young adults keep changing their jobs?**

There are a couple of reasons explaining why the youths today are constantly moving to different places of work. The main cause is not enough income. As many companies give a low pay but require them to work harder, young people have no choice but quit their current job and look for other positions that can give them some sense of satisfaction. Another reason for job-hopping is that some people can't find a suitable work environment and try different workplaces to find out their own interests, which is really important for long-term commitment.

- **How to find a perfect job?**

Frankly speaking, a perfect job is not one that gives you a lot of money. Rather it's the one that gives you a sense of satisfaction. This is because when you are working in an environment where you can receive support from your boss, nice treatment from your colleagues or annual pay rise, the chances are that you would love to stay there longer and contribute wholeheartedly to the wellbeing of the company. As an expected result, you will think that what you have is an ideal, a dream job

- **Would you ask your parents for advice about work?**

Since my parents and I have different occupations, frankly speaking I am an office worker and my parents are manual laborers, So, you can see there is no point in asking them about what I should do when I come up against a certain issue at the workplace.

However, in some cases, tips from parents are especially practical. For example, when I attended the birthday of my boss and didn't know what to give, I asked my dad and followed his advice. The result is that I gained respect from my boss thanks to my parents' tips. After all, we all work under someone.

- **Would you like to apply for challenging jobs or common jobs?**

Personally speaking, I would love to take up the challenge and see where my limit lies.

As I'm quite an adventurous person and willing to take risks, I will definitely choose challenging position. By working in an environment that I haven't got used to yet, I can explore my potential and see my strengths and weaknesses. For example, as an officer, I wanna try higher position to test my management ability and see what I need to improve in the future.

- **What is your opinion regarding different jobs and the different payment received for doing them?**

It's something that's normal I think; jobs which can be done by anyone don't usually pay much, simply because so many people can do them, employers don't need to pay more than the absolute minimum.

Then there are jobs which only a few people can do, either because of the skills or knowledge required to do the job, and employers have to pay more for these types of jobs because the higher payment reflects the scarcity of individuals who are able to do them.

It's basically the law of supply and demand, just as it would apply to any other product. The labor market is subject to the same law, the more common the job skills are, the less the job pays, and the rarer the job skills are the more the job pays.

- **Is it possible to eliminate this kind of discrimination?**

Unless all jobs are made the same – the answer is no, different pay rates will always apply to different jobs depending on the level of expertise needed. Clearly an easy job which requires little or no training or education will never pay as much as a difficult or dangerous job which needs the individual to be highly trained or educated to do it. Nothing in life works like that.

- **Do you think it is necessary for a company to encourage its employees?
What are some of the motivational factors for workers to perform well in their work?**

Yes I do believe it is essential for a company to push their employees to achieve high productivity and work performance. I suppose the most common ones are money, satisfaction, recognition and personal self-esteem. Different people are motivated by different factors and while we all like to be paid for the work we do, it's not always the most important factor. There are many people who put social factors such as being part of a team, contributing, and helping others as greater priorities than simply earning money.

Then there are people, who perform well in the hope that their efforts will be recognized by management or their boss, or they simply take pride in doing their job well, or they seek promotion or greater responsibility within the company.

- **In your opinion, where does such inner motivation come from?**

Sometimes it comes from a need, such as wanting to prove to others that you can do something well or better than other people. Some people are naturally competitive and it is this which drives them to perform better than other people at work. Many people who come from humble backgrounds are motivated to perform well at work so they can build a better life for themselves and their family in the future. In other cases, it may simply be just a desire to earn more money so they can be financially better off in the future.

- **How do you think companies could improve the job satisfaction levels of underpaid workers?**

I'm not sure that's possible. I mean, if they are underpaid, they obviously get paid less than they think they should, but employers are not going to pay more than is absolutely necessary for any employee – most low paid jobs can be done by almost anyone, so investing additional resources to try and make employees happier makes the cost of the employees higher.

Other possible questions:

- **Do you think it is fair that some people can get high payment but not very work hard?**
- **Do you think you want to be taking up this job?**
- **Which occupation should be given a better pay?**

42. Describe an interesting or unusual thing you did recently

You should say:

What and where was it?

When and with whom did you do it?

Did you enjoy it? Why?

Sample answer:

Few months back while our visit to a friend's hometown, all of a sudden a friend **proposed us to go** inside a nearby forest and have a picnic there. This was a plan proposed by Arnold (...say one of your friends name...) and 4 of our friends agreed to do so.

This was bit dangerous as people scarcely go inside the forest and from the local people we have heard **different scary and wild stories** about this jungle. Our main attraction **was the abandoned house** inside the jungle and we planned to do the picnic there and take photos of wild lives and the abandoned house. We knew that my friend's guardians won't permit us to do that and hence we planned not to let them know about it upfront.

On a Thursday morning we left the friend's house and bought the necessary ingredients, vegetables, foods and other things that would be required for us to do the picnic. We entered inside the jungle and to our surprise the inside was much more open and beautiful than we thought it would be. With some difficulty we reached near the abandoned house and spent time till the afternoon. This was a very exciting and unusual experience for us. We collected some woods and **made an arrangement for cooking**. We eat the food we cooked and that was horrible in taste. However, we were looking for the adventure and interesting stuffs so **a bad food did not kill our spirit**. We could not enter the abandoned house as it was blocked and very fragile. We took several photos of the place and we notices some of the wild animals were **observing us with suspicion**.

I have to confess that was a bit **dangerous and imprudent thing** to do but we enjoyed our **interesting and unusual picnic** inside a forest.

Follow-up questions:

- **How the types of gifts people send to each other have changed in recent years?**

I guess some people who feel tired of their routine duties want to try new things at times. Most people need a break from the same things they do every day, and I am not an exception. I think my brain has been so used to what it has been doing, so I sometimes stimulate it by trying something new. I believe that it is a great way of living a more exciting life.

- **What problems can people have when they try new activities for the first time?**

When people try new activities that they have never experienced before, they may face fear, anxiety or tension. I think psychological problems are the most common when trying a new thing. New activities, in the end, will allow people to learn how to overcome such feelings.

- **Do you think it's best to do new things on your own or with other people? Why?**

Personally, I feel that it is a lot better to try new things with other people who can share the same interest. It is not necessary to reveal your courage and willpower right in front of other people, but it's more enjoyable to do fun activities with those who can feel what I feel. I don't think everything should be about learning or studying. I believe having a great time with good people is always great even when I feel afraid trying a new thing.

- **How do people in Vietnam spend their leisure time, for example, after school, after work or on weekends?**

It is a fascinating question; to me different people have different ways to while away their leisure time. A lot of young people like staying at home to surf the internet or log onto some social networking websites. Some sports lovers will play a game of sports, such as basketball,

football, and tennis. As for women, might be into shopping tremendously because they want to make themselves look more gorgeous in others' eyes.

However, there're also some people who would play cards during their free time, which I don't particularly approve because most of this kind of game involves gambling.

- **In general, who do you think has more leisure time, men or women?**

I reckon that for a lot of married couples, men might have more spare time than women because it's very common for women to do the house chores and take care of the children. Since most women also work after getting married, they don't have much time left for other leisure pursuits. However if a woman is a housewife, she will definitely have more free time.

- **Do you think that people today have more leisure time than people in the past?**

Maybe, not actually. Nowadays, modern people suffer from more pressure than previously. People have to keep learning in order to stay competitive in their professional field, and because of the urbanization, a lot of people need to commute for several hours each day to go to work, which makes their time budget even tighter. However, for those living in the countryside, their life is probably still very slow-paced, relaxing and fortunately, they have a lot of free time to enjoy themselves.

- **Are there any differences in the way people relax today compared to the past?**

The answer is a yes for me. I'd say there are, because for example, in the past, I assume it's fair to say that people mainly used to let their hair down in front of the TV, whereas nowadays, it seems to be the case that people are moving away from the TV and spending more time on the computer instead. So that's one difference, and I suppose another thing to mention would be quite a lot of people now, especially young people, like going to cafés to have some chitchat with their friends. And this is reflected in the fact that there are lot more cafes around than there used to be.

- **So why are people spending more time on the computer?**

I'd say there are a handful of reasons as to why this is the case, one of which would be that we are now capable of doing more stuff on the computer, like watching films and TV series, whereas some 40 years ago, we were only able to watch them on TV. And if you watch stuff on your computer, you don't have to sit through all the annoying adverts which you get on the TV.

- **Why do you think some people find it hard to relax? Would you say that people have enough leisure time today?**

That's a tricky question, and I suppose there are a number of possible reasons for this, one of which might be that they're overloaded with work, and generally just too stressed out to relax. I mean, a lot of people I know find it very difficult to completely forget about their work when they're at home, because their work is always at the back of their mind, regardless of what they're doing.

- **Are there any differences in the way people relax today compared to the past?**

How do you think science and technology has changed people's lives in Vietnam in the past few years? Yeah, I'd say there are, because for example, in the past, I think it's fair to say that people mainly used to relax in front of the TV, whereas nowadays, it seems to be the case that people are moving away from the TV and spending more time on the computer instead. So that's one difference and I suppose another thing to mention would be that quite a lot of people now, especially young people, like going to cafés to relax with their friends. And this is reflected in the fact that there are lot more cafes around than there used to be.

- **What about the future, do you think there will be less stress than today, or more?**

Well I'm not altogether that sure, but my feeling is probably that there will be slightly less stress, because I mean, I think we've reached a point where life can't get much more stressful than it already is! So in the future, I imagine life will go back to being a bit simpler. In other words, I think what will most likely happen is that people will get better at prioritizing their time and cut out doing things which aren't that important to them.

43. Describe a team project you took part in

You should say:

What was the project about?

Did it help you on a personal level?

Whom did you participate on the project with?

And explain what you learned from the experience.

Sample answer:

I have worked on several projects both in my school and in my office and out of those; I would like to talk about **an electronic project** that I worked on in my college level. It was a **physics project** in our final terms and we had 3 team members. We were asked to create 2 radio devices that would be able to clearly communicate within the 300-metre range.

Our physics teacher Mr. Nephew gave us the talks and I worked on this project with two other

classmates of my college. The teacher gave us 15-day time but after 10 days passed, we noticed that more than half of the task was **pending** and we **extended the time**. The work took around 22 days for us to complete and show the demo.

We had to create two radio devices that would basically similar to the devices the traffic controlling officer usages. But our device would have a shorter range and would work within 300 meters. Another objective was for us to make such two devices **with a very minimal cost**.

We had to work hard to make it work. I learned many things from this project like, how to work on a major project with a team, how to reduce **the interferences of radio frequency**, how to **build quality equipment in low budget**, how to fine tune a project and many other things that later became **handy** for my university and office projects.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you like teamwork? (Why? /Why not?)**

Yes, I do. I think it is more interesting when various people work together in a team. You can learn a lot more because different people have different knowledge and also experience. Especially when the people come from different countries around the world - it can make it very interesting - because they think in a different way.

- **How does teamwork help?**

Well, as I said, it can generate more creativity and sharing of ideas which may not happen otherwise. Problems seem to get solved easier when they are discussed in a team, possibly because there are various ways of approaching problem solving and sometimes having a different perspective, that of another person, is enough to see the problem in a different way, and eventually come up with a solution.

- **Do you think children should develop skills for teamwork?**

Yes, I think this is why many parents spend a lot of time telling their children that it is important to share things with others. Working in a team requires some skills, which you have to learn, but they can be learned early in life as a child. So I think it's a good idea that children are taught to work in teams to solve problems. They should also be encouraged to develop their problem solving skills so that they can work on their own - but teamwork is important in adult life, so yes, they should be taught how to do it.

- Does having leadership skills qualify a person to be a team leader?

Not just leadership skills - because working in a team is not really about a group of people following a leader - it is more about the individual team members working together, equally, to solve problems or create whatever it is they are working on. team work requires a lot of different skills, and just because someone has good leadership skills does not mean that they will automatically work well in a team. if they try to dominate the rest of the team members, then there will likely be problems within the team and it will become ineffective.

44. Describe a life project that is not related to your work and study.

You should say:

What the plan is

How long you have this plan

How important it is to you to achieve it

And say how you think you will achieve the plan.

Sample Answer:

I have a plan to establish a playground for kids and a club for the adults in my hometown. This is something I missed a lot in the place where I grew up and that's the why I **have the plan and determination to achieve it.**

Establishing a kid's playground adjacent to a club for **grown-up people** would not be an easy task. I will need to manage **the necessary budget, manpower and financial support** to actually do that. I will have to be **financially rich** and connected with the **local authority** and **political leaders** to start the plan I have. Honestly, I have this plan for a very long. When I got admitted in my high school, the realization started **popping up in my mind** that these are two things that our community is missing although they are very important. I knew that was something pretty tough to achieve, but yet I started **fostering this tough plan** in my mind.

As I already said, that would be pretty tough as it involves money, space, power, and **people's involvements**. There would be lots of obstacles and I would have to **face and resolve** in order to fulfill the plan I have. The determination and good will along with **the prudent decision** would be required. If I do not **possess a great enthusiasm and strength of mind**, it would become almost impossible to achieve it.

Follow-up questions:

- **Which do you prefer? Having plans or having no plans?**

I deem it a necessity that you should be an organized person and always prepared for upcoming challenges. Drawing up a plan in advance can equip people with some knowledge when something unexpected comes up, or when everything just doesn't go according to plan. Without a plan, people can feel at a loss and have nothing to fall back on when they are in adversity. However, it should be pointed out that we shouldn't get into too much detail, instead, just conjuring up the picture as to what's gonna happen is enough for us to tackle it.

- **Do you think most people can carry out their plans?**

I think only the minority have the ability to realize their plans. What need to be pointed out is that the majority tend to set up their plans in an ideal and perfect way without being aware of the fact that external circumstances can prevent them from being fulfilled. Some might end up being driven to a dead-end and feel at a loss as to what to do next. We should blame this on our inflexibility and inexperience, rather than regarding the plan as a bad one. At the end of the day, what counts most is our capacity and experience to make our intentions come true, not just preparing a detailed plan beforehand.

- **What's the difference between dream and goal?**

As far as I'm concerned, there's only one big difference that distinguishes a dream from a goal, which is your determination and stamina. In other words, when you are committed to something, you will probably spend more time on it; make better efforts to achieve the goal you have set. On the contrary, just like its literal meaning, a dream is what you only wish to come but it is almost impossible to come into reality as you are lazy and take no actions to make your dream come true.

- **How do you achieve your goal?**

It is popularly believed that 90% of the success chance depends on how much time and effort you devote to your goal. In other words, if you learn 100 English words a day, for example, the chances are that you can master the language in fewer than 4 or 5 years. Having said that, in some cases, luck plays a certain role; to illustrate I didn't have to revise and review all the lessons but still was able to pass the Maths test with flying colors since I was lucky enough to run into questions I had prepared. In a nutshell, for a long-term goal, I will set my heart on it and stay really focused while for short-term one, I'd rather let luck decide my fate

- **What kinds of goals do young people usually have?**

To be honest, it depends how an individual really. Most students will want to have a good academic performance, or pass the IELTS exam with flying colors to apply for a scholarship

and continue their education abroad. For the others, it is a common desire that they would be able to secure a decent job with high salary in the future. But as for me, I would say my goal in life is to gain a sense of happiness in life, whatever it may take

- **What will be the most popular jobs in the future?**

It is difficult to predict the future, but I think there are going to be some major changes with regard to what the most popular occupations will be. I'm not sure exactly what would happen but one possibility is that more and more people will choose to become a doctor. I think the appearance of new diseases is on the cards and this will make this job so profitable.

Furthermore, it may sound a bit crazy but being a real estate agent will be trendy as the need to buy houses of an increasing population means a lucrative business in this area

- **What is the impact of parents on the career of their children?**

As I feel it, parents are so much influential in the decision making process of children when it comes to what career they would pursue upon high school graduation. If your parents are teachers, it's likely that they will persuade you to opt for a career path in the education field, and the same is true for other professions. Having said this, the final decision should always rest with the children as they are ultimately responsible for their decision. Doing something that you don't have any interest at all during a lifetime can make you feel bored to death, I'm pretty certain of this.

Other possible questions:

[Also refer to question 28]

- **Should parents set goals for children?**
- **When do young children start to set goals for themselves?**
- **What kinds of goals are not realistic?**
- **Why do people set goals?**
- **What would you feel if you couldn't achieve your goals?**

45. Describe a historical place that you know about.

You should say:

What the place is

Where it is located

What is the historical significance of the place?

Sample Answer:

I **have a special interest in** visiting famous places and on my list historical places always get preferences. I have visited many historical places like Machu Picchu in Peru, The Pyramids at Giza, Taj Mahal, Parthenon in Greece and many more. **The historical significance** and the site attractions sometimes **mesmerized** me. The historical place that I would like to talk about today is Colosseum (also known as Coliseum, also known as the Flavian Amphitheatre) which **is situated in** Rome, Italy.

It is basically **an elliptical amphitheater** in the center of the city of Rome, Italy which is the largest amphitheater in the world and is **made of concrete and stone**. The construction of Colosseum began under Emperor Vespasian in 70 AD and was completed under Titus in 80 AD.

The Colosseum could hold approximately 50,000 to 80,000 spectators and was used for **gladiatorial contests** and **public spectacles** such as mock sea battles, animal hunts, executions, re-enactments of famous battles etc. The Colosseum was listed as a World Heritage Site by UNESCO in 1980 and was also included among the New Seven Wonders of the World. It is 189 meters long, and 156 meters wide, with a base area of 6 acres .The height of the outer wall is 48 meters. The Colosseum nowadays is one of the **major tourist attractions** in Rome with thousands of tourists each year paying to view **the interior arena**.

I have heard and seen of this famous place a lot and when I witnessed it for the first time, I became speechless. The huge architect, the **overwhelming interior and exterior decoration** was **beyond appreciation**. The place kept reminding me the **classical mythological** and **historical facts** I have read and heard about.

Follow-up questions:

- **What is the importance of history? Do you think history is important?**

Option 1: Definitely yes, history has a significant role to play in our daily lives. Through historical lessons, people are more aware of their ancestors' achievements and therefore appreciate the freedom and peace they are enjoying.

Option 2: History is to enrich our understanding of ourselves. History helps us learn about our origins, backgrounds, Ideas, traditions and institutions that have shaped the development

of our country. Our history and traditions give us a sense of connection with the past: it can bring people together and remind us of the memories that we share.

- **What is the importance of learning about history?**

Studying history enables us to avoid repeating the mistakes of the past. History is illuminating and allows us to understand and conclude how past human actions impact on the present and

- **What do most people like to do when they visit a historical site?**

I guess what the majority of people do is just, like, take photos of the place. That's really the main thing. But as well as that, most people will also look at the things on display and uh, what else? Um...Oh yeah, and maybe buy one or two souvenirs to take back home as mementos. So that's pretty much it really!

- **Do you like history?**

Well, in general I would say that I'm not really fond of history. To be more specific, I really can't stand the historical lessons delivered by my teachers at school. I think this is due to the fact that I'm not good with figures and have a bad memory when it comes to learning by heart the names of war heroes and the dates that the events took place.

- **How can more people become interested in history?**

I'm not that sure, but I suppose um... the way it's taught at school could be improved, and possibly made more interesting. So for example, instead of simply staying in the classroom, teachers could take students out more to visit historical sites and anything of historical relevance. So that's one thing, and as well as this I guess, um..., increasing the amount of history documentaries on TV could also have a positive effect on developing people's interest in history. And finally I think parents can play an important role by introducing history and all its wonders to their children, and if they do it well, then I'm sure it's going to help children develop their enthusiasm for it

- **Are young people in your country interested in historical museums?**

Yeah, I think most young people are, to a varying degree. So in other words, I think young people here have at least some level of interest in them, although it's probably fair to say that they're not that high up on the list of favorite things to do! You know, I'd say the young here are generally a lot more interested in stuff like computer games and foreign TV series, but history's deeply rooted in our culture, so I think it will always hold some level of interest for anyone in my country, both young and old.

- **Do you think internet is a good way to learn history?**

It is true that the Internet is a good source of information and a means through which people can discover and learn more about the past history. However, it's quite unpopular among people nowadays as more youths merely see the internet as a place to relax themselves. Therefore, TV programs or films, I suppose, are better alternatives

- **Should museums be free?**

Option 1: To be honest, although charging a small amount of entrance fee will give the organizers funds to continue their operations and encourage the artists to produce more decent works, in Vietnam, people seem to show no appreciation of artistic values. Therefore, the local authorities had better let people enter for free to arouse the public's interests first and then, if people are interested, a small admission fee should be considered afterwards.

Option 2: Um....yeah, ideally I think they should be, because they're great educational resources. But if it's not possible, then a small entrance fee I guess is acceptable, cos that will help a museum cover its costs and stay running. Alternatively, museums could be free and have a donation box, so that if you can afford to donate something towards the upkeep, then you have the opportunity to do so.

- **Do people in Vietnam like visiting museums and art galleries?**

Not everyone in Vietnam enjoys going to museums. Most of my friends are not interested in art, but I have a small passion for it. After I graduated, I began to enjoy taking trips to various art exhibits. Since then I have made a few friends that are artists, and now they invite me to their galleries quite often.

- **Do you think going to museums and art galleries is beneficial for children?**

Option 1: Yes, I believe going to museums can be very beneficial for children. They can learn more about history and culture. Art can broaden their minds and their outlooks on life. It can also inspire them to be more creative, to have original ideas, and to be inventive.

Option 2: Yes, museums are a great educational tool. They act as windows into the past better than any textbook. Seeing a picture of something isn't as good as seeing it up close. The way some museums are set up, you can almost feel like you are back in time as you view the items. Sometimes we find out that things "way back then" weren't really all that different to today in many ways, while they are so different in other ways.

- **Would you say movies help people develop more interest in history?**

Yeah, I'd say they can, because after all, movies are quite vivid and so they make history come alive. And another thing is that a lot of people can't be bothered to read a book about

history, but they'd gladly go and watch a film about it, simply because movies are a bit more entertaining. So yeah, I'd say they generally do help people become more interested in history

Other similar possible questions:

- **Do your parents think learning history is important?**
- **Which way is better for learning history: reading books or visiting museums? Do major cities in your country all have museums?**
- **Will current things be exhibited in future museums?**
- **How to show life two thousand years ago in the museums?**

46. **Describe a friend who you think is a good leader**

You should say:

Who is he/ she

How you met him/her

Do people behave differently when he/she is around?

And explain why you think he/she can be a good leader.

Sample Answer:

Let me tell you about one of my close friends who worked with me in the same company several years ago. Actually it was he who had an interview with me when I applied for a position in that company after I graduated from university, we had a nice talk and he was obviously satisfied with my related experience.

He was really **an optimistic and infectious man** with his work, therefore when he started to be responsible for the new business, some colleagues were very interesting in his plan and tasks, and were always likely to offer their help. Besides, his superior was quite confident of his success, and gave some necessary financial and human supports.

I had been working with him for over two years. I believe he was really good at encouraging his staff into doing something that seemed to be tough to realize and **inspiring them to greatness**. As our business was quite new in the market, he made us feeling like **pioneers** in this field, which definitely **inspired my enthusiasm tremendously**. It was really a cool thing, because to be honest, I learned the most things in my work during that time.

Follow-up questions:

- **How do you see a leader now and in the future?**

I personally don't think there would be much difference between leaders now and sometime in the future for their core values are much likely to be the same. By this, I mean most true leaders tend to operate on similar principles such as innovation, integrity, positivity and so on. Not all these characteristics would be acquired or presented by all leaders but some of them would. Hence, in spite of living in different times, leaders would still be those with some particular admirable traits that are distinguishable.

- **Do you think there will be changes?**

Well, changes are inevitable since they are the causes of any advancement. Therefore, it's not surprising that there might be some alterations in leadership style and their effects. If we trace back history, the differences are noticeable. Many emperors or royal governors in ancient time ruled their kingdom by inflicting fear and pain on their people, which flatly contradicts how leaders conquer others' minds and hearts nowadays. Modern leaders no longer impose anything on anyone but inspire them with their vision and yearning for a better life.

- **How does leadership apply to children at school?**

Leadership is not only adults' realm but people of all ages can practice it, including children. Most are not natural-born leaders, instead, they are likely to go through painstaking processes to attain certain skills since they were young. For example, kids with a leadership mindset probably stand out for their initiation, persistence and optimism. If they take part in group activities, potential leaders are usually those who take on team leader roles and enthusiastically enjoy the game as well as encourage others to do the same.

- **What do you think are the qualities of a good leader (or, a good decision maker)?**

Option 1: Out of the many qualities that a leader should have, I believe being a good listener and a responsible person are the two essential factors. Firstly, a leader must be willing to listen to opposing views, weigh the pros and cons of each option and never impose their thinking on others. Secondly, as he is the person who leads the whole team, a sense of responsibility can give other team members a feeling of security and trust. This can motivate the whole team to focus on accomplishing the tasks despite some potential hurdles.

Option 2: The definition of an ideal leader varies from people to people for good reasons, I suppose. As far as I'm concerned, a leader who is a true influencer and would leave great impacts on his people is someone who is a man of his word, knowledgeable and inspiring with a visionary mindset. It's an undeniable truth that neither an organization nor any person wants to be led by those who are pretentious and lack of capacity and vision. We all need those who take actions and are ahead of their time to guide us to a better place.

Option 3: I believe honesty is the most important thing that is required out of a leader. It is very important for a leader to be able to put down the real situation in front of the team mates so that the situation can be dealt as a team. Also, communication, commitment and confidence are the three C's required out of a leader. And in the end, the patience and the will power to be able to look ahead with great positivity, to endure failures is what is required of a leader.

- **What characteristics does a bad leader have?**

I believe manipulation is that one thing that a bad leader possess. Anyone who tries to manipulate the people or try telling lies, just to hide is surely a bad leader because he or she cannot or does not have the strength to face the consequences of a bad decision.

- **Do you think it's important for parents to encourage the development of leadership abilities in their children? (Why? /Why not?)**

I think it is unnecessary to stimulate a sense of leadership in the children. The reason I feel this way is that some kids end up becoming aggressive people and just impose their way of thinking on others without trying to be a good listener. Instead, what parents can help is to educate their children to be a morally correct individual first. Otherwise, they can accidentally turn their children into a bad guy in the future.

- **If you were the leader of your school, what changes would you make?**

If I was the leader of the school, I think there are only a few things that I would like to change. One of them is punishment. I know that punishment is a great way to teach people, but then I also believe that a little award is never a bad things. So, if one sees a person getting punishment daily, it might be possible that he or she needs counselling and not just another punishment.

Also, there should be more Parent teachers meet. So, that parents and teachers can remain connected throughout, not just when the results come out.

- **Why do some people think it's a bad thing to always follow other people?**

I think it must be mostly because leaders come along with the image that says that these are the most powerful people, that they can bring out change, and it is often so larger than life that people think that anyone who is not a leader is not a great person to be. However, people often forget that it is not the power that makes a leader great, but the person himself that makes use of power great.

- **In what ways can parents encourage their children to develop leadership abilities?**

As I have just mentioned, the task of stimulating a sense of leadership is not really necessary. At this age, they should be educated to be a morally sound correct individuals as well as building their knowledge base. As long as this step is done, teaching them leadership qualities can be taken into consideration

47. Describe an occasion you got up extremely early

You should say:

When this happened;

What you needed to do that day

Who you were with;

And how you felt about getting up that early on that day

Sample Answer:

Let me talk about an occasion I got up extremely early, which happened in April this year. I was planning to **take a business trip** with a colleague. In that morning, I woke up early, at about 3 o'clock to get to the airport where we agreed to meet. I took a seat in the cafe bar in the airport and waited for him.

One hour soon passed, but he didn't show up. I was beginning to worry a bit then, hoping he would not forget the business trip or wake up late. **I made a telephone call to him, but could not put through**, which made me more depressed. I had no ideas but made another telephone call to my superior and told him about my **current situation**, he told me to fly alone if my colleague didn't get to the airport in time in the end.

To my surprise, after I hung up the telephone, I saw him entering the gate of the airport slowly. I asked him why he came to airport so late. He just said he never hurried to catch the airplane, and told me that I should take it easy. Oh, I doubted whether he lived near here. Getting up early is really hard for me, but waiting for someone who doesn't keep time is even harder. I really didn't want to go on a trip with him next time.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do late working hours affect people's sleep patterns? How are they affected?**

I suppose they might, but then it would really depend on the rest of the person's daily routine. I mean, if the person normally works late at night but doesn't have to get up early the next day – so it's a regular routine – working late – sleeping late - then maybe they manage to sleep fine during the day and get enough sleep to rejuvenate themselves.

After all, it's what people who work shifts have to do all the time – they might work nights for a couple of weeks or even a month and then switch to daytime shifts. So they have to get used to sleeping at different times of day or night depending on their work pattern.

But the important thing is that their routine is not irregular or changing every other day – it's normally fixed for a period of time so that they can plan their life around it.

- **Do you like studying late? Why?/Why not?**

Sometimes, yes. It depends if I'm studying something I'm really interested in or not. I can remember some nights when I was studying for my degree when I literally lost track of time and studied almost right through the night.

When it's a topic or subject that is interesting the time just flies by. But, there are also times when I had to study certain subjects that I didn't find very interesting and those I usually left for the daytime, early in the morning when I felt I had more energy to concentrate on it.

So it totally depends on what it is that I have to study. But when I do study late I quite enjoy the change in routine, and there is an added bonus – late at night there are less distractions because normally all my family are asleep and the house is nice and quiet.

- **Why do you think some people like to study late at night?**

Well, as I said, one of the advantages that I found was that I was interrupted less, so maybe people like the fact that they have more peace and quiet to study late at night, they might like the fact that they've had time to relax a little after their day, have something to eat and shower and be feeling fresh and reenergized and ready to concentrate on studying.

Some people might like it simply because it's the only time of day they can actually find the time to focus and concentrate without other people always asking them something.

In the evening or at night it's usually easier to study for an extended period of time. During the day there tend to be many more things which have to be done or maybe you can only find short periods of time to study during the day before you need to be someplace else.

- **Some places have fixed times of day and night and in other places it varies. What are some of the advantages and disadvantages of both?**

I would guess that, for example, in Europe where the days are longer in the summer and shorter in the winter there are various advantages, especially in the summer. You might be able to take advantage of the additional daylight hours after work to do some kind of sport or

activity outside with your family or friends or simply enjoy the summer evening outside in the garden.

A disadvantage would be that the winter days are shorter with less sunlight, so you get up in the dark, go to work in the dark, and go home again in the dark in some cases. That would mean that for people who work inside all day they might not see much natural daylight except at weekends.

As for places which have fixed times, well, I suppose an advantage would be that you don't have to make any changes to your habits or adapt your routines to suit the seasonal changes as much. I mean, we just have a dry season and a wet season, but we don't have to make much of an adjustment to the way we live. It's still light at the same time every day and dark at the same time of night every day all year long.

Other possible questions:

- **Who usually get up early, young people or old people?**
- **Will working late at night influence the next day's work?**
- **Do young Vietnamese stay up late at night?**
- **Is it easy to get up early for you?**
- **What do you do to guarantee a good sleep?**
- **Can you sleep well if there is noise around?**

48. Describe a useful APP on phones, computers or tablets you know

You should say:

What the app is?

How long you have used it?

What it is use for?

And explain why you think it is useful.

Sample Answer:

'Mobile phone' is one of the greatest inventions of the modern science. It appears that without the mobile phone life would not be as easier as it is today. The use of mobile phone is everywhere and it has become an important part of our daily life. We cannot do without it. I have an iPhone and there is a built-in application named compass. But I have also installed another compass which is **more functional and attractive** than the built-in one of my iPhone. The compass is a great thing for me. It is used **to navigate and get directions**.

I use the compass for **navigational purpose**. The compass is my favorite application on the phone. As I like travelling much, I visit different places in the country but it is not possible for me to know about the directions of the areas I am travelling in. Then I unlock the phone and use the compass to navigate and get the best direction towards my destination.

The compass is **highly useful** for a traveler and hiker like me. It helps me to recognize the directions to my objective and the most important issue is that I do not get lost wherever I go. I could get a direction to get out of **the unknown roads** and areas using the compass and a map of the area. It is also helpful to navigate at night times when there are no lights. I could also use the compass with the association of stars and get the right direction even in the darkest night when there is no light or **directive measures** to guide the travelers.

Follow-up questions:

- **Is it convenient to use an APP?**

Yes, current apps in the mobile devices are definitely user friendly. For example, when you want to take a picture, you just click the icon of that app, point to the people or landscape that you want, and then click the virtual shutter on the display to shot. The pictures will be saved in the devices automatically.

- **What are the drawbacks about using an APP?**

Well, I think it is fair to say that there are a few negative aspects with regard to these apps. I guess the most unfavorable quality would be that people will indulge themselves into the virtual world, rather than interacting with others in the real world. For instance, there are several social network apps that attract users so much that they are addicted to chat with online friends but neglect to communicate with people nearby. As well as this, an additional limitation may be that these apps would to some extent leak the users' privacy. On top of that, another shortcoming of using app too much is that it will do harm to people's eyesight's, especially for children.

- **Is using an APP more acceptable for the young people than the old?**

Yes, I feel that young people will find much easier to handle them than the old for a couple of reasons. First of all, young people would like to try new things and learn them very fast. For example, I still remembered that I spent a week learning the computer programme language to draw a Super Mario in my computer when I was in elementary school. As well as that, I believe most of these apps spring up to cater to the young people, such as the social network, mobile games, music; whereas there is a limited range of apps that designed for old people, like news particularly.

49. Describe a course that you want to learn

You should say:

What this course is

When you want to learn it

Where you can learn it

And why you want to learn it.

Sample Answer:

Well, speaking of the course I'd like to do, I would say that it's an English course. Today, English is considered to be the most important language in the world. That's why it became one of the compulsory subjects and we now have to **study English from elementary onwards**. I'd like to get admitted to the Foreign Trade University which offers a professional course in Business English. They have a good reputation for teaching this course effectively to a high standard. As I have other classes in the morning, I would like to enroll in the afternoon course. Also, the course fee is both **cheap and convenient** for me to pay using my bank account.

There are so many reasons why I'd like to enroll in an English course. First of all, English is an international language; hence, having a good knowledge of English can help people around the world to communicate better. Second, it also **gives us countless opportunities** to become more acquainted with other cultures. We depend on English to **keep up to date with the latest news from all over the world**, since almost all the books and magazines are written in this language. Finally, learning English can really help us in our careers and enhance our CVs, as these days, many firms need good office employees to **conduct international business**.

Follow-up questions:

- **What kind of things do children learn to do when they are very young? How important are these things?**

Most children begin to play with toys and friends when they are little. They learn how to deal with and resolve different kinds of conflict by spending time together with other people. This is very important since such experiences lay the foundation for their social intelligence, which is essential for them to establish successful relationships with others later in their lives.

- **Do you think children and adults learn to do new things in the same way? How is their learning style different?**

Yes, I do think there is a difference. Little ones, for example, don't usually follow some instructions or manuals to learn to do something new. They tend to just jump in and struggle with difficulties when they arise, and they spontaneously work things out for themselves and

remember the process in the future. On the other hand, grown-ups often rely on the information they get from some reliable sources or some sort of directions when learning what they've never done before. Adults have a tendency to avoid any kinds of failure, which may cause them stress.

- **Some people say that it is more important to be able to learn new things now than it was in the past. Do you agree or disagree with that? Why?**

I absolutely agree with the idea. It is very difficult to keep up with the rapid pace of change in this world. For example, the way to use public transport; buses and trains, has changed a great deal in my country. Of you don't become familiar with the revised system soon, it may be very difficult for you to live a modern life. Therefore, I believe that it is vital to get used to learning and accepting something new in this modern world.

Other possible questions:

- **Can you suggest a way that people can study together?**
- **Do you think government should pay for old people to learn something? Why do people give up their hobbies?**
- **What are the difficulties that people may have to continue to learn something? What do you think of online leaning?**
- **Do you think learning materials on the internet are reliable?**

50. Describe a time of seeing interesting animals

You should say:

Who the animals were?

When and where you saw it?

What it was doing when you saw it?

And explain how you feel about it.

Sample Answer:

I am raising an Alaska dog, which is a large breed of domestic dog. My dog has a double coat: the **undercoat** is soft while the outer one is **coarse** and **water-proof**. Also, his coat has two colors, black and white.

In my opinion, his most attractive feature is the **small upright ears** which **are out of proportion to the head**. Having had this dog for almost a year, I find him intriguing. He is very smart, so he learns everything quickly. I once taught him how to **fetch**. Surprisingly enough, he successfully chased and **retrieved** the object after I tossed it for the second time. He acted as if he had **intrinsically understood** the game. He is also friendly to

everyone, especially children. Whenever someone visits my house, instead of barking, he welcomes them by licking their feet.

For me, my dog is a friend I can play with after school. I often walk him around the park at the weekends and he seems to like this, as there are different dogs there. I also talk with him regularly and I feel that he can understand what I say.

As a final point, I hope that my dog can live with me for a long time.

Follow-up questions:

- **Tell me about an animal you saw which is very rare in your home town.**

There are some rare animals too like guinea pigs. Originating from Andes, the animals do not have any connection with pigs and they are mostly used in laboratories to test different medicines and bring out the result. I have seen one of my neighbors having guinea pigs as her pet, which is rare in my hometown.

- **Do you think people do not respect animals these days? What about 10 years ago?**

Currently people have been busier. As a result, they cannot pay proper attention to their pets. They do want to respect the pets or look after them better but unfortunately, their good intentions are not achieved due to the hefty workload. About 10 years back, people used to spend their time with their pets, they would bathe and feed them every day by themselves, played with them but this is rare and irregular in recent times.

- **Earlier people used animals for their work. Now, what do people use to do their work?**

With the advancing age, everything has become modernized and mechanized. Vehicles have replaced the animals like horse or buffaloes to pull carts or transport goods from place to places. Sometimes, they used dogs to hunt animals for meat, but now they are buying processed meats from stores. Moreover, earlier there were horse races which have been replaced by car racing events. These days, people rely on technological devices mostly to have their job done. So many animals are extinct these days.

- **What do you think about this? Why it is happening?**

Animals are of great use for us. But there are some people who indiscriminately are hunting down animals which are bad for the environment and for humans too. Mostly the animals are killed for their skin and horns. Precious products and medicines are made from the animal skins and horns and thus poachers are killing them illegally in the jungles resulting in their extinction. It should be prevented strictly or the species will disappear forever.

Deforestation, new constructions, people's greed and temperature change are some of the other reasons why many animal species are getting extinct. Global warming is a threat both to human and other species. We should take every measure to reduce the global temperature. Apart from that, hunting of wild animals should be completely banned.

Other possible questions

- Why do people like to keep pets?
- Do you support doing experiment on animals?
- Why do some people refuse to eat animals?
- What would happen when some species disappear on earth?

51. Describe a piece of good news you heard from TV or the Internet

You should say:

What the news was about?

When you got this news?

Where you got this news from?

And explain why you think it was a good piece of news.

Sample Answer:

Well, I'd like to talk about the news about the law to cut the use of the plastic bags. Several years ago, our Chinese government **approved a law to reduce the excessive consumption** of the plastic bags which proved to be a main source of pollution because the bags aren't degradable. I got this news in the CCTV-1 news channel.

In the past, people could get the plastic bags from various supermarkets for free. As a result, our country had witnessed high consumption of the white pollution for years which would take centuries to degrade. Therefore, we'd like to see a law **banning the use of plastic bags** in supermarkets and shopping malls while encouraging people to use paper or cotton bags, or repeatedly use the **handy plastic bags** instead.

Consequently, things are improving. Large supermarket chains, such as Wal-Mart and Carrefour in China, have started to introduce **reusable bags** and give some rewards to customers who refuse to use plastic bags. As well as that, the law also raises the **public's green awareness** to protect our environment, with various efforts to reduce **the carbon footprint**. For example people tend to buy the **fuel-efficiency vehicles** instead of the **gas-guzzlers** in order to **emit less carbon dioxide** in the same **mileage**.

Follow-up questions:

- **How important is it to know the world news?**

I believe it is crucial to know both the world and national news. Knowing news gives you the ability to question actions and things happening. A person might not be able to relate to the decision taken by his or her country without the awareness of the international ongoing. Not only this, a person who reads news also develops the ability to hold a conversation.

- **Where do the Vietnamese people get their news?**

Well, there are three main ways people in Vietnam get their news from: television, newspaper, and the Internet. But I think the newspaper is the most popular simply because it is convenient and cheap and everyone can afford it. People nowadays may not be aware of their excessive reliance on the mass media, take TV as an example. If the TV stations stopped working for one day, many people would just feel so uneasy and wouldn't know what to do. As for me, I don't have time to watch much TV. I watch TV only for the news.

- **Do you think people will use the internet to read news online?**

Absolutely, people would prefer to use the internet for reading news online especially through their mobile applications. They are already using the internet to a much larger extent that they check for weather updates, news updates and watch talk shows online on their computers or mobiles. In the future also, this trend is likely to get wider.

- **Do you think the information on the internet is reliable?**

Generally, yes, just as reliable as the TV news or newspapers provide. Information, rather than news, on the internet - well, there's a lot of it, but you can always find a reputable site and learn what's considered to be good information. There is a lot of rubbish on the internet sometimes, but on the whole, even if you check a couple of sites and they basically say the same thing - then you know it's as reliable as almost any other source of information.

- **Are most people in Vietnam more interested in local news or international news?**

I think most Vietnamese people are more concerned with local news and domestic news, which I'd imagine is the same across the world. Unless there are huge stories going on elsewhere, local news has more of an impact on the average citizen. Also, it is easier to understand news that is about areas that you know as opposed to some town in a country you might not even have heard of.

- **How do you think people will get their news in the future?**

In my opinion, traditional newspapers and television will be less popular methods of getting news in the future because of the time lag between when news happen and when readers get them. By contrast, I believe mobile devices will be a dominant way of updating news because they can offer instant news. Another trend that I am thinking of is that readers will play the role of correspondents. In other words, they will report stories by themselves and post those online.

- **How do most people get their news in your country?**

It depends on where they live and how wealthy they are. In rural areas where economic growth is limited and telecommunication infrastructure is still developing, I think traditional newspapers and television are the two most common ways of getting news. In more economically developed areas, people use the Internet and mobile devices such as smartphones and tablets to update news instantly.

- **How has the social media changed the way we share the news with other people?**

Social media has had a huge impact on the way the world functions. We have surely moved from days when people shared news through regions and then letters. We have even grown apart from calling each other. It is all about now, sharing news on WhatsApp or Facebook. The twitteratis tweet about it and some others share videos online! From having intimate conversations, we now prefer sharing things to a group of people. Apart from the personal news, even the world or international news, people often read about them in their social media news feeds.

- **How has TV changed our life?**

TV provides people with a good opportunity to update reliable and censored news on a regular basis. It also creates a good reason for family members to gather, talk to each other or have a family meal together. However, many people have been so addicted to TV that they forget aspects of their real life. Scientific researches have indicated that watching a lot of TV can increase the probability of diabetes and obesity.

- **What do you think of children watching TV?**

Watching TV is certainly beneficial for children in some way as it helps them relax and feel excited about something new. There are a range of TV programs aiming at children that provide really useful academic knowledge and understanding. However, watching TV for a huge amount of time without physical exercises can lead to physical and mental issues such as being overweight.

- **Do you believe everything said in the news?**

No I do not. Certainly before being published, news and stories in the newspapers must be censored by newspaper providers. However, sometimes this process is done quickly and irresponsibly, which results in unreliable information. There are cases where journalist's bias on a certain issue affects the validity of stories. For example, a feminist journalist would probably see all men as the causes and offenders of domestic violence.

- **What's the difference between broadcasting news in the past and in the present?**

With internet gaining so much of momentum, I think people have changed their way of reading news from printed one to the news on internet. There are many newspaper companies and news channels that have already created their account on social media. So, when most of the people are glued to their Facebook ids, they often get the latest updates from the news channels or papers. Although, there are some people who still prefer newspaper or news channels, I think in coming times, there will be more people who will be taking in information from the internet.

- **In terms of news, do you think there is much difference between newspapers and news channels?**

Surely there is a difference. Newspapers have a limited space and they need to cater to a larger and broader audience. Giving simply news is not going to help the newspapers. So, there are sections for editorial and then news. Even more, there are newspapers with a section of games. With news channels, their prime motive is showing news. They don't have much foundation on the content limit. Certain news can be broken down and telecasted more number of times to give it the entire perspective.

- **Are young and old people interested in the same news content?**

I think this question partially depends on how old young people are. If they are in their twenties, I think for the most part, the news they are interested in is the same. Younger people do seem to be more interested in things like celebrities and pop culture than older people, but I think they stay pretty educated about the more important news. Older people are less concerned with the pop culture news, and are more concerned with the news that matters more to the world and their country.

Other possible questions:

- **Is it convenient to read news on the internet in your country?**
- **What do people like negative news?**
- **How often do Vietnamese people buy newspaper?**

- Do you think negative information in the news will have negative influence?
- Do you think there is too much news about celebrity?

52. Describe a mistake that you once made.

You should say:

What the mistake was

When and where you made it

Who you were with

And explain how the mistake affected you.

Sample Answer:

No one wants to talk about his mistakes and it seems like the human psychology **is prone to** forget **blunders** and remember good things in life. But some mistakes are hard to forget and have **severe consequences** in life. I, too, as **an ordinary human** try to learn from my mistakes, forget them most of the time and go ahead with my dreams to do something remarkable in my life. I would like to thank you for this cue card topic that expects me to talk about a mistake I have made in my life.

The biggest mistake in my life was falling in love with the wrong girl who had a completely different view about life, love and relationship. I was hardly 17 years old when I fall hard for this girl. Initially, we were classmates and then became friends. In a year I started to feel something about her that was quite extraordinary and hard to explain. I guess people call this 'love'. My whole world started to **shift** and I was surrounded by a **mirage** for this whole time. Not a single moment had passed when I didn't think about her. She was the center and **power source** of my universe. When I proposed her, she expressed her **boundless joys** and acted as if I should have proposed her earlier. So far, this is **a sweet and innocent love story** of a teenager and I was happy to have her in my life.

However, it took me only a few months to realize that she was not serious about our relationship. When she was my whole world, I was her just another temporary boyfriend. The relationship ended in ten months and I was so **broken-hearted** that I could not concentrate on anything for a while. My parents also knew about it and they **were very supportive to me**. First few days, it was quite difficult for me to get back to my normal life, study or go outside. I simply could not **appease my mind** that I made a great mistake and it was **like an illusion** that I need to come out from soon. However, when I started realizing that I made a big mistake by approaching to **a serious relationship** without even knowing the girl genuinely, I started making peace with my mind. I was completely honest with myself and that eventually helped me to **get out of the depressive time** I went

through at that time. The lesson learned from this mistake made me more cautious about making any kind of relationship and I am happy that I took this mistake as an event to learn a lesson. However, I often feel bad that how someone could be so **naïve** to **play with someone's sentiment so cheaply**.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you often make mistakes?**

We all make mistakes. I don't reckon I particularly make more than the average person but it's still too often for my liking, to be honest. I usually make mistakes when I'm not concentrating, when I allow my mind to slip. For example, when I'm revising something and I'm testing myself, if I rush, don't pay enough attention to the question, I'm more likely to get the answer wrong. Also, double-checking is important. When I'm speeding through the questions, I'll assume I've got it right the first time and then be shocked when I realize otherwise. When I take my time, focus, not let myself get distracted, it's plain sailing.

- **What can people learn from their mistakes?**

I think it depends on what kind of mistakes they make. If, for example, it's a language mistake, they can obviously learn the correct version of whatever it was that was wrong, but if it's something more general like a life mistake, they can't go back and change it but they can use that new knowledge to help prevent themselves from making the same mistake again in future and possibly also educate others. Making mistakes is a part of life, from constantly falling over when you first learn to walk right up until you're at death's door. I don't think anyone who you'd consider successful got there without making a few mistakes along the way.

- **What should teachers do when students make mistakes?**

I believe teachers should generally tell their students when they have made a mistake, but how they do it and how often they do it is something that needs to be considered. If a teacher was to ignore a mistake, the student might believe that they hadn't done anything wrong and would then continue repeating the mistake until, hopefully, eventually, someone would let them know, at which point, it would probably be a habit of the student and so even harder to stop. Obviously, if someone's constantly correcting you, that might lower your confidence, so at times, teachers need to be selective about what mistakes they address and usually it's better to not constantly interrupt the student while they are talking. Little gestures, though, might work well and let the student correct themselves if they want.

- **Do you usually listen to someone's advice?**

It depends on the situation a lot. I mean, if it's a serious situation and I have to make a big decision then usually I'll ask people I think can help me for advice. If the advice seems to be good then I would certainly consider it.

- **Who should give young people advice about their future career? Why?**

It's a good idea for young people to listen to a variety of advice from different sources and then make up their own minds about what they want to do. Teachers and career counselors have more knowledge about careers and the employment opportunities, but parents, relatives and friends also have a different insight which they can offer you... a more personal viewpoint sometimes. But at the end of the day, everyone should make their own decision because it's their career... they need to be happy doing what they choose.

Other possible questions:

- **Do you think making mistakes is necessary?**
- **What do people do to avoid mistakes?**
- **Do you think young people should ask old people for advice?**

53. Describe an antique or other old thing that your family has kept for a long time.

You should say:

What it is

How or when your family got this thing

How long your family has kept it

And explain why this thing is important to your family

Sample Answer:

Some of the books which once owned and used by my grandfather are still **kept with care** in our house. My grandfather was a doctor and he kept his medical books and **reference books** with him. When he died, I was a 5 years old kid and can hardly remember things about him. But I heard that he was a great person and a **first-class doctor**. Everyone in our locality **revered him and respected him** very much. After his death, my father took one of his used tables, an armchair, and a big portrait of my grand-grandfather and some of my grandfather's books as the **remembrance** of his memory. Among those things my grandfather's medical books survived and are still reserved in our bookshelf.

These books would be more than 70-80 years old and we have those books on our shelf for the last 20 years. The **caretakers** sometimes bring out those books and clean those and finally put them on the shelf again. These books are mainly the academic books of my

grandfather's medical college and some of the reference books for his practice as a doctor. I once opened some of the books when I was a school boy and found almost everything very obscure. Basically, they are **medical related terms** and that's why **seemed jargon to me**.

My family has kept these books as the souvenir of my grandfather's memory. My father **was very beloved by** my grandfather and I am sure he **esteemed my grandfather** very much. These books are **the only tangible belongings** my father has which were used by my grandfather and **conveys my grandfather's reminiscences**. Though these books do not have their **material values** but they are priceless to our family and **remind us the precious memory** of our grandfather.

Follow-up questions:

- **Why do some people still keep old things?**

I believe that people collect things from the past either for their usefulness or their aesthetic beauty. Some collectibles have great investment value. They preserve their value over the years and can be easily sold in the event cash is needed. The reason can also be personal interest. Some collect old objects just for enjoyment or fun. Many find it an easy way to broaden their social lives, meeting like-minded individuals and exchanging information about their possessions.

- **What's the value of old things?**

Old things are souvenirs of the past. They remind us of our past relatives and the good old days. They also reflect the history and traditional culture. I know personally from my own experiences when I go travel at somewhere, I usually buy souvenir at that place and keep it from time to time as a reminder of the place itself.

- **Do you think it necessary to preserve old things?**

I think it depends on the value of the thing, the specific thing you are talking about. Some old things have been out-of-date and they could be the hamper of present development so they shouldn't be preserved. However, some old things represent traditional culture, art and customs and have value for research and appreciation. Those are the one should be preserved.

- **What do you think are the main differences between old people and young people?**

I suppose the differences could be divided into physical attributes and other characteristics like experiences and attitude. First, regarding their bodies, it goes without saying that young people are more energetic whereas old people have lost all their vigor and tire easily — making them not nearly as powerful. Next, as far as their minds are concerned, old people have a big

advantage in the amount of experience they have accumulated throughout their lives. In comparison the young mind is immature and lacking in a worldly outlook. One advantage that the youth might have regarding their minds, however, is their attitude, which tends to be not as stubborn and more open-minded and positive. What I'm trying to say is that many old people are cynical and have a negative disposition.

- **Have you noticed any differences between the kind of things people collect now and those collected in the past?**

Traditionally people collected stamps, period furniture, rare books other than antique jewelry and art by well-known artists. But the kind of collectibles that are currently popular range from classic cars to old photograph records as well as comic books and bottles.

- **How do you think collecting things benefits people?**

I guess by collecting things people continue to learn. As they build their collection, they develop skills in identifying, selecting, evaluating and classifying items. They become more knowledgeable about the field their collection pertains to.

- **What sort of things do people in your country usually collect?**

I have noticed that people in my country collect all sorts of things. While some collect small items such as coins, miniatures, stamps and jewelry, other collect large items like vehicles or buildings. There are many who are interested in collecting valuable things like paintings and antiques or things from a specific period in the past. It is also not rare for some people to collect things that belonged to a person such as a movie star or a famous scientist. The reason for collecting certain things can be their emotional value even though they have little or no monetary value.

- **How do people in your country usually collect things in your country?**

Different things are amassed in different ways. Some buy things at auctions or antique shops. Others join clubs and exchange items. There are even people who go to junk shops looking for collectibles.

Other possible questions:

- **How to educate children to respect old values**
- **How can family members get on well with each other?**

54. Describe an important skill you learned when you were a child.

You should say:

What this skill was

When you learned it

How you learned it

And explain why you think it was important.

Sample Answer:

I'll talk about driving which I think is the most important skill I've ever learned. I guess the main reason as to why it's so special is that it was **a long life passion** for me to see myself at the wheel driving at a fast speed and going where ever I fancied. What's more, my father bought me a car when I got my **driving license** which is a great gift to me, both financially and sentimentally.

It is not a very difficult skill to learn but it requires some dedication, practice and concentration to learn. One can learn it in 7 days with few hours practice daily. But to become **a really expert driver**, someone needs to keep driving regularly for about a year in my opinion.

Someone interested to learn driving can contact to the local driving school and can **get enrolled with** the quick driving lessons they have. Alternatively, if someone has his/ her access to a car and can manage someone to teach him/her the driving; s/he can do it as well.

Follow-up questions:

- **What skills can children learn in school?**

Well, I think it's important for children to learn all the basic and traditional academic skills at school, you know, like math, language, science and so on. But it's also important that they are encouraged to develop their ability in critical and analytical thinking. Then there are other skills, for example, creative skills and problem-solving abilities which should be nurtured while at school. Certainly at the school I attended that was the case, with a lot of emphasis on the development of creative and problem-solving skills.

- **What do you think of the role of family for children to learn skills?**

With regard to skills which should be learned at home, I believe that parents do have a responsibility to teach their children to be good citizens or responsible members of their community, and that is usually best done through setting them a good example through their own behavior as parents.

- **What is the most popular skill that people want to learn?**

I suppose many young people are interested in technology skills because they seem to be almost essential in most careers nowadays. A lot of my friends are interested in people-based skills as well and are interested in pursuing careers in marketing and consulting so they are interested in the psychological and social aspects of managing people among other things. Another thing which is important is that many young people tend to be choosing a broader range of career paths these days, which involve a greater blend of skills from more traditional professions.

55. **Describe an interesting tradition in your country**

You should say:

What the tradition is

When do you celebrate it

How you celebrate it

And explain why it is interesting

Sample Answer:

Day of the Dead, or Dia de Muertos, as we call it. It's a **national holiday**, and it is based around the family coming together to remember and pray for all those relatives and friends who have died in the past – the prayers are supposed to help their spirits on the journey to **the afterlife**.

Many families **gather together** at **family alters**, or 'offends', where they spend time with their loved ones honoring those who have died. They bring items like flowers, **sugar skulls** and often women in the family will prepare the favorite dish or food that a particular person loved to eat and take it with them when they **visit the grave site**. Some visitors to the family graves also leave items which belonged to the person who died; **mementos** of them. **The origins of this tradition** go way back, hundreds of years to the time of the Aztecs and an annual festival they used to hold worshipping a goddess; I can't remember her name now though.

And it became a national holiday back in the early 1960s when the government decided to **consolidate the tradition of the indigenous natives** to unify the whole country because apparently it wasn't a special event in the north of the country originally, or something like that, but it **gradually spread throughout the whole country** over a long period of time.

The three-day event has separate parts to it. So the first day is when kids dedicate their prayers to children who have died, 'angelitos' they call them, and ask the spirits of the

children to visit. The second day is dedicated to the spirits of adults who died, and then the final day is when families visit their family grave or cemetery with their special gifts, food and so on and spend time praying for the souls of their loved ones who have died.

I think it's an interesting tradition because it involves all family members and all families across the country, so it really is a strong tradition and it brings families together every year.

Follow-up questions:

- **How do people celebrate festivals in your country?**

Festivals are truly the time when people do come back home and celebrate with their family and friends. People dress up according to the occasion and cook delicacies, invite friends and have a family time. Almost all festival in our country start with a puja, i.e. prayers to God after which the gatherings take place.

- **Do you think festivals are important for the society?**

I think definitely yes, festivals are surely the binding force for the society. In lives of people who are truly dissatisfied, festivals bring in the hope of something good and something new. Most people forget their issues and come together to celebrate a festival. Even more, with prayers being associated with each of the festivals, they bring about so much positivity in life.

- **How would you describe young people's attitudes towards tradition?**

Um I would say that at the beginning many of young people would maybe not embrace fully the idea of going through every painstaking detail of preparations and err behaviour codes for all these celebrations and feasts. But then uh, gradually it will become a part of their lives, and um that would be their connection with their families and extended families, so they would kind of grow more and more into it, and trying to adhere to every rule that tradition was brought to them by their parents and grandparents. So at the beginning maybe the youth would take it lightly on the surface only, but then later um I think the traditions will be embraced fully.

- **Do you think customs and traditions are changing these days?**

Um, I would say so inevitably because of the adjustment to urban- to the urban living if you wish, and to the fast times that we live in. So definitely there are concessions to what err used to be done before. But the core, which is much more important, is always preserved. At least has been the case so far.

- **Do you think traditions and customs are affected by advertising?**

I never actually gave it a thought. Uh there might be, but again in my personal experience I haven't seen any kind of uh direct influence that would uh change or alter, take people from their original directions whatever the advertisement is about.

- **Do some countries celebrate traditions more than others?**

Um I wouldn't say so, I have impression that all countries celebrate traditions, or rather the people who live in these countries. Even in some new countries, a conglomerate of different people, and all these people would stick to their old traditions. That's how I see it. So, people who wouldn't follow the traditions would do it in all sorts of countries, or in any country.

Other possible questions:

- **What's the difference between Vietnamese traditional festivals and western festivals?**
- **How do Vietnamese people celebrate some private holidays like honeymoon?**
- **Is it important to celebrate traditional festivals?**
- **Do young people in your country like to celebrate foreign festivals?**

56. Describe a situation that you got angry.

You should say:

What the situation was

Who or what made you feel angry

When this happened

And explain your feelings.

Sample Answer:

Let me tell you about the recent situation that made me angry. A couple of weeks ago, I was planning to **go on a business trip** by airplane to another city. But I got a bit nervous and didn't sleep well that night. So the next morning I woke up late at about 9:00, but my airplane departed at 11:00. It **was really urgent** because there was about one-hour driving to the airport. In a great hurry, I took a taxi and told the driver to drive as fast as possible.

But unfortunately as soon as we got to **the express way to the airport**, we found ourselves get stuck in **the heavy traffic congestion**. We moved so slowly that I got totally mad. I was afraid of missing the airplane to meet my clients. I repeated asking the driver to move fast but he told me there was really nothing he could do about it. Finally it turned out that it

was caused by **two crashed cars** in one lane, and it took me an extra 30 minutes to get past them and nearly **missed the flight**.

I **felt frustrated and powerless** because there was nothing I could do to change the situation and I had no idea how long I would be sitting there waiting. When I finally saw the reason for the congestion, I was feeling angry towards the two drivers who were so careless and did the car accident which wasted my time. If I missed the plane that day unfortunately, there were a huge loss both to my company and me.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you think it's good to show your emotions when you're angry?**

Option 1: I think it depends on the situation and how you show your emotions. I find that if I'm angry with a friend or someone in my family, it's best to tell them what the problem is and try to express how I feel. However, I don't think it helps to argue with people when you're angry; it's better to control the anger and explain what's wrong.

Option 2: I think to express the reason for anger is good and should be done, because until then nothing can be done to solve the situation. However, harming oneself or others without trying to solve the main reason for anger, is not a very great thing to do. Because, it not only harms you but also others. However, there are other ways to show off anger. Some write, paint or scribble. I think until it is not harmful, anger should be expressed like every other expression.

- **Do ill-mannered people tend to upset you?**

Ill-mannered people do sometimes tend to upset me because there is so much negativity that they bring along with them. Often times there are no logic behind what they are saying and no reasons for what they are doing. It just becomes in their nature to behave badly, which tends to get annoying. However, if someone behaves rudely rarely, I prefer finding out the reasons for it.

- **Do you think men and women feel angry about the same things?**

I think men and women value different things which can lead them to feel angry about different things. I think women are more likely to get angry about irresponsible behavior than men while men are more likely to lose their temper. However some issues could cause anger in the both of them such as violence.

- **In your opinion, do women show their emotions more than men?**

If we go by the stereotype, women tend to show emotions more than men. But, in my opinion, both the genders tend to show emotions equally. However, the emotions that they

choose to show are different. For instance, a woman is less likely to show anger as compared to her male counterpart but more likely to show her tears. Also, when a woman is happy she tends to share it with others in a very calm way, however, a man is more likely to show off in a grandiose way.

- **Does it upset you when you see children or animals being abused?**

It surely does irritate me because these are the two section of society that I believe deserve the love most from us. Children being so innocent are rarely able to raise any voice, accepting every abuse as their destiny. Often times, there are few who raise the voice but their voices don't get the ears they deserve, may be because they themselves are not able to express well. With animals, I think it is more of shame for us humans to treat them badly. We often forget that they, like we, are equally part of nature.

- **How does a slow computer or mobile phone makes you feel?**

Oh!! it makes me feel like a loser, trust me. You know there are times when you want to do things and then when the gadgets starts showing up, it becomes so irritating and when the work if of someone else, you cannot even tell the issues, it is up to you to face and do something about it. Even more, it spoils the entire mood of doing things.

- **When is anger justified?**

Anger is justified in many instances such as when we are on the receiving end of unreasonable behavior, when we are faced with crime, perhaps even small things such as someone being late without reason for a meeting. It depends on each individual what they perceive to be accepted standards of behavior and any deviation from it could reasonably evoke anger. Though simply because anger is justified should not be seen as a reason to act upon it and cause distress to others.

- **What are the physical and mental effects of getting angry?**

An increase in your rate of heartbeat, trembling, sweating, clenching your jaws and grinding your teeth are physical symptoms of getting angry whereas mental symptoms include feelings of anxiety, stress in terms of more pressure and in some cases even sadness. Anger is universally known to be detrimental to both, physical and mental well-being.

- **In your culture, how do people generally respond to anger?**

In my culture, people usually have verbal confrontations when they are angry. There is often yelling and swearing but very rarely does it lead to a physical altercation. However in

the northern parts of my country, it is not uncommon to hear of people engaging in fights, especially in groups.

Other possible questions:

- What do you usually do when you get angry?
- How to teach children control their angry?
- Why do some people get angry so easily?
- Tell me some negative consequences of getting angry.

57. Describe something that you have shared with others or another person.

You should say:

What you shared

When you shared it

Who you shared it with

And explain why you shared it or how you felt when you shared it.

Sample Answer:

Thank you very much for this wonderful topic. I believe that human is **a social being** and we need to share so many things with our relatives, friends and **unknown persons** in different occasions. I will talk about a time when I shared my room with one of my cousins who suddenly visited our house a few months ago.

I have my personal room where I usually live along. We have two guests room and that's why I have never shared my room with anyone who stays our house at night. A few months ago when my cousin came to visit our home, we were renovating our second floor and that's why we had no **spare room for the guests**. My cousin, Stephen, came to our town all of a sudden and informed us that he would need to stay in our town for a couple of days. He also informed that he is planning to stay in a hotel. My father insisted him to stay with us and I thought I could easily share my room with him for a couple of days. He was 2 years younger to me but we had a friendly relationship from our childhood.

Stephen stayed two nights in our house and I shared my room, bed and bathroom with him so that he can stay in our house comfortably. We talked about our grandparents, other cousins, our works and future plans. I enjoyed his company and we had good times together. **I am not habituated to share my very personal belongings** and rooms with others, but sharing it with my one of the most favorite cousins was not a bad experience at all. In fact, during his stay, we had so many fun events that I invited him to visit our house again.

Follow-up questions:

- **In general, who do you think gives more help in a family (or marriage), the husband or the wife?**

It depends, there are different kinds of help and every family is different also. I suppose that maybe a wife might help more with children, especially daughters, but a father may help more with sons in terms of teaching them certain skills and things like that. Then there is financial help, it may be a case of helping aging parents or other family members and this would depend on whether or not both the husband and wife are working or only one of them.

- **How can (or does) an employee help his or her employer?**

Well, normally an employee is contracted to do a certain task, fulfill a certain function or take responsibility for something. This allows the employer to meet their business goals through providing products or services and generating sales and profit. But again, it's a case of... without the employees the employer couldn't achieve what he or she wants to, but without the employer the employees wouldn't have a job and therefore probably couldn't do many things they would like.

So in reality they both help each other – it's a mutually helpful relationship.

- **How can (or does) an employer help his or her employees?**

Firstly, an employer provides regular income for an employee, a degree of stability and meets certain social needs of the employee. An employee might feel particularly happy in their job, proud of the work they do, and it might also allow them to provide things for their family that otherwise they wouldn't be able to. Having a job where there is potential or opportunity to grow and develop as a person can also be helpful for the employee. It boosts their self esteem and makes them more content and satisfied.

- **Do you think an employer helping an employee can motivate that employee to work better (or work harder/ work more)?**

Yes, if the employee is interested in improving themselves, developing better skills or learning new ones. If an employer helps an employee when the employee is having difficulty, the employee might feel more loyal to the employer's business and want to work harder. If the employer helps the employee by offering better work opportunities or more responsibility, for example, the employee may also develop a stronger feeling of loyalty and develop more pride in their work and their position within the organization and work harder or better to protect it and help the business grow even more.

- **How can (or do) colleagues help each other at work?**

There are many ways; they can collaborate on projects or individual tasks by discussing ideas, problems or simply sharing the workload. They can offer support and advice when required, especially if a person is having a difficult time, for whatever reason.

Covering for a colleague if they are unwell or absent is a common favor done by many people, and also helping colleagues learn things they need to in order to do their jobs better.

58. Describe a place near water (such as a river, a lake) that you enjoyed visiting

You should say:

Where this place was?

What you did at this place?

Who you went there with?

And explain why you liked this place.

Sample Answer:

I have visited many places near a river or a sea and I enjoyed **the scenic beauty** and vast water very much. I would like to talk about a river I visited 2 years back. I chose to talk about it because I really enjoyed my visit there.

The name of the river was (...say a river's name...) and it was in (...say a place's name...). One of our relatives invited us to visit their house and we decided to visit there. I went there with 4 of my family members including my parents. After we reached there, I **was amazed to** notice that our relative's house was near a big river. This was the first time I visited that relatives and I was very excited for **the natural beauty** there.

After we reached our relative's house, my younger sister told me that she would like to visit the river. I **restrained her** by saying that we will all go there in the evening. In the evening we went near the river and the river was very calm at that moment. **A sweet wind** was blowing from the river and the weather was very pleasant. We sat near the river and had our tea. That was kind of family picnic. I had my younger brother, sister, my parents and 3 of our relatives at this place. Since this was the summer season, we felt very comfortable being at the bank of the river. We noticed many boats were in the river and we planned to rent a boat for an hour. When we were in the boat, the wind suddenly started blowing heavily. We quickly came to the high land and left for our relative's house.

Follow-up questions:

- **Not being able to get clean drinking water is a big problem in many places.**

What are some ways in which people can be provided with clean water?

I do agree with the problem that people all around the world are facing regarding clean water. In my opinion, the easiest technique is conservation. Making sure that the water that we get from natural resources like rain are conserved well and then purified well. Apart from this, it comes upon government to ensure that everyone gets equal amount of water. It can be seen that some people are having more than required access to water while others are starving. Even more, different supply for water can be provided. Like for drinking water, fresh water should be given while for things like cleaning dishes and clothes, a little compromise on quality is possible.

- **Which is the biggest river in your country? How much polluted is it and would you ever try swimming in it?**

Ganga is the biggest river of our country, stretching around 2500 km. Lately, Ganga was one of the most polluted rivers of our country, especially because of its religious importance. Some materials like food, waste or leaves are left in the Ganga for ritualistic reasons. People come here to take a bath to wash away their sins. Also, with the establishment of industrial areas near it, there was lot of industrial waste getting accumulated in Ganga. However, in recent times it has seen some initiatives to get cleaned. I have tried swimming in Ganga but the shore that I chose was clean.

- **Where does the biggest city in your country get its clean water from?**

The biggest city in my country is Mumbai. It gets its clean water from different sources, like Bhatsa, Tansa, Modak Sagar and the Vaitarna.

The world's population is increasing rapidly. Getting clean water for everyone might become difficult in the future. Think of three ways we can avoid this problem.

I think awareness is the first thing that needs to be done. The way people were aware about AIDS or cancer, people need to be aware of the dead consequences of water shortage. Next, we need to bring out more tangible solutions for saving water. Simply putting down theoretical solutions won't help us. Something like ensuring everyone, irrespective of the stature in society gets limited water. This will ensure that everyone gets water and at the same time we will be able to conserve water for future. Use of water for washing, cleaning etc should be limited or the quality of water for doing this should be changed.

- **What is the major use of water in your country?**

Ummm, water is primarily used for drinking in my country. Besides, it is also used for numerous purposes including bathing, washing clothes, irrigation, cleaning and also serves

many other functions. In fact, the answer to this question cannot be given in one or two statements, you know. Water is synonymous with life. If there were no water on earth, there would have been no life. So, the use of water cannot be bracketed into some specific use. Accordingly, the use of water in my country, India, is not limited to drinking only. It is also used for diversified aspects, not into my country alone, rather globally. Different light to heavy industries need water to clean their raw materials, vehicles need water to cool their carburetors and cleaning, electricity production, and domestic uses etc.

- **Is it important to conserve water?**

Well, to me, it is important to conserve water. Water is limited and collected mostly from the ground. Sometimes the groundwater dries up for excessive use and creates water shortage. As a result, the sometimes massive water shortage creates famine in some areas. If they have any preserving system, they would not suffer from the deficiency of water. Besides, someday it may happen that the water scarcity will be so acute that people will lock into fights to get their respective share of water. With the increased population, the pressure on ground water has increased to a great extent and my thought may come true (though I don't want it to be true). But people may say that they will depend on nature or rain then I will say that they have forgotten about the climatic changes around the world. Rainfall is not abundant in the current days. Thus it becomes too risky to rely on nature for water and therefore, I think it is important to conserve water for future use.

- **Why should scientists focus on space exploration rather than exploring water?**

Good question for me to test my intelligence level. The scientist should focus on space exploration for several reasons instead of wasting their priceless moments after water exploration. Someday it may happen that the water bodies and all the other available sources may get dried and there will be not a single drop of water. But if they explore the space, they might discover any planet or galaxy where a habitable environment may exist similar to our solar system. If they start exploring the space, I believe they could be able to invent some sort of transportation system to reach the external livable planets. But if they explore water on earth, it would be mere wastage of their time and labor.

[Also refer to question 21]

Other possible questions:

- **What is the importance of the ocean to your country?**
- **Do you think the oceans should be protected? (Why?)**
- **In general, do you think people like to live near water? (Why?)**
- **Do many people in your country today like traveling on ships**
- **What are the sources of pollution in rivers, lakes and the ocean?**

59. Describe a small and successful company you know.

You should say:

What is the company called?

How did you know this company?

What kind of business this company does;

And explain why you think this company is successful.

Sample Answer:

I'd like to tell you about my cousin's company. He's an electrician and he's been working in **the construction industry** for a few years. About 6 months ago he decided he wanted to start his own business because he didn't really like where he was working or his boss. He talked with one of his coworkers and they decided to start their own **electrical installation** and repair business together.

They started doing a lot of **domestic repair work**, emergencies and things like that. Then they managed to get a contract with a new house builder here in the city. They won the contract because they were prepared to work seven days a week to get the project finished on time and that's why the building developer chose them.

Now they have many more construction contracts and they hired two more **electrical technicians** to help with all the work they have. It seems they do very good work at **reasonable prices** and the word is spreading. They even have their own Facebook page and Twitter and they post **helpful information and tips** for people about **domestic appliances** and how to save money on their energy bills at home. They are really modern in their approach.

In my opinion, they became successful because they were willing to work hard, be flexible about when and where they worked, for example, at the weekends, and they are also good at what they do. If there are any problems, they fix them - no questions. That's why they're popular with **contractors and construction bosses**. They do a great job, fast and with no problems. They always do what they say they will do.

Follow-up questions:

- **Why do some people decide to set up their own business?**

I suppose it's the idea of being in control of your own destiny or of believing in a product or service idea you may have plus it must be very exciting launching products, winning contracts and seeing your sales figures improving must be wonderful ...

- **What skills are required to start a small business?**

Setting up a small business can be risky, and so you need a broad range of abilities. One of the most important is being well-organized. You have to be able to keep track of your company's revenue and expenses and find ways to save and make money at the same time. Having a calm temperament is also important. If you get too stressed, you might make some bad decisions and your business might fail because of them.

- **What are the risks of running your own business?**

Option 1: Well obviously you need to have a good idea some people say you need to do market research beforehand so you know what the market wants if you don't do this you could go under and if it is a good idea the chances are someone else is doing the same thing so you could end up facing stiff competition.

Option 2: Of course, the biggest danger is that you'll go bankrupt. I think much more than half of all new businesses go out of business in the first six months. If you invest too much in your business you might be personally liable, which could mean you would lose your house. Another one is the fear of failure. Many people don't even take the chance to start a business because they're worried about failing and being embarrassed."

- **What are some of things you have to do when running your own business that might not appeal to everyone?**

Well obviously you need to have a good idea some people say you need to do market research beforehand so you know what the market wants if you don't do this you could go under and if it is a good idea the chances are someone else is doing the same thing so you could end up facing stiff competition

- **Do you think academic education is more important than experience in the field?**

Um, I think they're both important, but I'm not sure which one is the most essential. Obviously, academic qualifications provide basic knowledge which might be necessary to do a certain job. For example, a doctor definitely needs a medical degree. On the other hand, there is a difference between theory and practice and some things can only be learned by doing them.

60. Describe a success in your life

You should say:

When and where this happened?

Who you were with ?

What you did ?

And how you felt about the success?

Sample Answer:

The way we look at our success and the way people look at it differ. We sometimes consider our small and **personal achievements** are great successes while to others; those might not **be counted as successes** at all. Thus we **judge ourselves in a different angel** than people do. However, some successes are **exemplary and inspiring**. The success that I achieved and would like to talk about is my involvement in **a social welfare activity** that I greatly feel proud of.

The local authority of our hometown once planned to build **a multi-storied shopping mall** in a public park. Some of us suddenly noticed that they have started cutting the trees and we later learned that they will build a shopping mall there. We instantly planned to **protest** if though we knew that it would be **complicated issues** and we have little power against the powerful authority that has planned to destroy the park and make it **a profitable marketplace**. We were initially 5-6 persons involved in the protest and we let the community people know about **the mischievous plan** the authority has taken. Later 20 more people joined our group. We went to the local authority, journalists; police station met local politicians and social workers and presented our view and abhorrent plan the authority has taken. Because of our protests, the tree cutting was halted. Later we found that more community people joined us and big news has been published in the local newspapers regarding this issue.

The park was the only green place and **recreation center** for the local people. People came there in the morning and evening to walk, run and do other short of social activities. Children enjoyed playing there and some social programs held there. A large number of birds stay at the trees of the park and destroying this park would have been **a serious threat** to our environment as there were more than 300 different trees there. It was not easy to fight with the powerful authority and we had to struggle a lot for more than 6 months. We finally went to court and got the decree against destroying the park.

This whole event occurred 5 years back when I was a fresh college student. I still consider my involvement to save the park as a great thing I did and being able to save the park and nature is a big success in my life.

Follow-up questions: Refer to question 2

61. Describe a time that a child did something that made you laugh.

You should say:

When this happened;

Who the child was;

What the child did;

And explain why it was funny.

Sample Answer:

Often, **the aptitude of the children** is far better than **the intelligence level** of some adults. My recent experience with a child proved the statement again. I was amazed at a sudden event when a child took a special decision and that was quite surprising and funny in a way. I am really happy to describe the event here.

This was the child of one of my colleagues. I was invited to his place for the first time on the occasion of the birthday of his only child. The child, Ethan, turned three on that day. But he was a bit different than most of the average children, at least that was my impression.

The event took place in the middle of the last week. His parents had arranged a party and I were also invited there. I was quite comfortable with them. We are in fact neighbors and been living there for past three years. So, I and my wife have become close associates of their family. The child did the special thing once it received the gift from me. I presented him with a large water gun to play. In fact, Ethan was fond of guns and thus he desired for the gun to me and I **kept the promise**.

Ethan sees many television shows and knows that the guns are used to shoot. So, he started playing with the gun. He **refilled** the gun with water and pointed that to the guests and shoots them with water. He wanted to have fun and did so. But finally, when the water was finished and his parents did not allow him to refill with water, he shot them. When he shot his dad, the dad fell on the ground. When he shot his mother, she also fell in the ground as if she died. He was surprised. He could not decide what to do. So, he shot himself and fell beside his mother until they stopped pretending to be dead.

The entire event was hilarious and made me laugh with all other invited guests. In fact, the kid was highly intelligent and his gestures made me laugh. He was confused what to do when he shot his parents. So, finding no other options left, he killed himself. In fact, it proves his guiltiness but the representation of the situation was really interesting that everyone could not stop laughing with this **scenario**. Despite the issue being a grave one, it was a kind of comical event. So, I laughed with my heart. In fact, it was **the rapid decision** making skill of the child and **the implementation of the decision without any hesitation** was **the key element** of the genuine laughter.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you think having a sense of humor is important? Why/why not?**

I think it's very important. Being able to make people laugh can make a big difference in our life. Telling jokes can brighten someone's mood if they're feeling down. Also, if you can laugh at yourself it shows that you don't take yourself too seriously which will make you more likeable to other people?

- **Do you like movies or TV shows that make you laugh?**

Option 1: I like watching comedies sometimes, but they're not my favorite kind of film. For example, I really hate romantic comedies. The plot is always ridiculous and is something that would never happen in real life. Normally the conflict in the movie could be solved if the couple just talked to each other for a minute.

Option 2: Sure, I love movies that are funny and silly. I'm not really a big fan of sad or dramatic films. When I'm watching a movie I just want to be able to switch off my brain and enjoy a funny story without having to pay attention to the plot too much.

- **What is the difference between comedy on TV and comedy in books?**

I'm not really sure; I can't remember ever reading a comedy book, or a book that was funny. I usually read non-fiction or novels, and they're generally not funny, but I suppose comedy on TV can be more spontaneous – I mean it's difficult to transmit comedy in a book, isn't it?

- **Do you think it's important for people to laugh? [Why?/Why not?]**

Personally I think it's quite a good thing to laugh, it relaxes you. Someone once said that laughing is like 'internal jogging' – it's good for you.

But you can only laugh if you find something funny, right, and there are some people who just don't laugh much naturally, but I don't think that's a problem because everybody's

different. Some people seem to laugh at almost anything and others are generally more serious and rarely laugh.

- **Is laughing the same as feeling happy, do you think? [Why? / Why not?]**

No, I don't think it is the same. I'm happy most days, but I don't go around laughing all the time. Maybe you show that you're happy when you are laughing, but I think you can feel perfectly happy without laughing.

It's like if you have a good your job and things are going well in your life, then you're naturally going to feel happy, but it doesn't necessarily mean that you have to go around laughing in front of everyone. Happiness and laughter are quite different, although the two are often combined.

- **Why do children feel happy easily?**

As the mindset of a small child is very simple and optimistic, he has quite an outgoing and relaxed attitude towards life. What a child does is to play and he also receives much protection and care from their parents. They don't have to worry much about how to make ends meet or other complicated situations in life. Moreover, they tend to take things less seriously and only retain sweet memories in their minds.

- **How would you define happiness?**

From my perspective, the definition of happiness is subject to multiple interpretations. Some people argue that accomplishing a sense of satisfaction in life means possessing as much money as possible. Therefore, people will sacrifice whatever it takes to become wealthy. However, my view is that having a good job and a happy family life is what makes us truly happy in life. If we feel what we are doing is worthwhile and financially rewarding; or our children behave well and love their parents, then happiness is no longer out of reach.

- **Do Vietnamese people like to watch comedy? = Do you like to watch comedy?**

Yes, of course, there are many benefits that a comedy could bring. Firstly, it helps me to unwind and let off steam after stressful working hours. Secondly, if the whole family gathers for a funny reality show in the living room, people in my family can relieve their tensions, which greatly strengthens the bonds between members as today we usually cannot manage time to sit together at the dinner table for a meal.

- **Are Vietnamese people happier than they were 30 years ago?**

Of course, I would say that modern Vietnamese people are definitely more satisfied with their lives than they used to be some 30 years ago. It is true that in the past, people had to

struggle against and suffer from many civil wars which claimed many innocent lives, caused tremendous losses, whereas people in modern era enjoy greater freedom in terms of economy and politics. Besides, there has been a distinct improvement in the standard of living like the ability to afford luxury items or enjoy more leisure activities, which was quite a rare thing to see in the bygone days. In a nutshell, it is safe to say that Vietnamese people are way happier than previously.

- **Is it possible to be happy during whole life?**

I would have to say it is quite out of the question to stay happy all the time during one's life. Whether we like it or not, there are ups and downs; happy moments and sorrowful ones. Therefore, it would be unrealistic to expect only good things to come to us and paint a rosy picture of one's life. Rather, one is supposed to face up to unpredictable difficulties and make their best efforts to overcome them and become happy again. It's safe to say that life is a vicious circle.

- **Can people be happy after a retirement?**

Obviously, people would definitely feel happier when they retire. The reason is that after their retirement, people can manage more time to travel, which seems virtually impossible when they are still working. To be more specific, retirees have more chances to go on a tour to faraway countries, get to know about the local cuisine, their exotic customs and traditions; or people can find time to pursue their old hobbies and interests such as planting trees and doing the gardening. These things are what make people blissfully happy when they grow older.

Other possible questions:

- **Do you think that both boys and girls have the same taste for enjoying comedy? Why?**
- **What are the differences in comedy between the past and present?**
- **What is the importance of jokes in family?**

62. Describe a person you know that had made a contribution to the social

You should say:

What the person did?

Who the person is?

How you know that?

And explain why you think it is a contribution to the social

Sample Answer:

In my life, there are several persons in my family members who **made unmatched contributions** to help me go ahead and among them my father's contribution is unforgettable. He is the person whom I love most in this world and I consider him to be a perfect human being with his **uncompromised honesty, bravery and responsibility**. I know my father from the very beginning of my life as he is the person who brought me in this world. From my childhood, he has raised me with his love, affection and mentorship. He taught me about the world, people and values. He helped me on my education and has devoted his life to properly raise me.

My father is **an exemplary person** who has led an honest life. As a **high-ranking** government officer, he had many chances to **pile up the riches** but he had always known what the right things to do. **The basic of humanity** and the importance of education were something he delivered to me. He is now a retired person and leads his **serene and peaceful** life with **contentment and happiness**. He was a brave person who never feared **the rough power of the society**.

As a father, I would say he has done everything humanly possible to raise me and my 3 other siblings. He spent his entire earning for our happiness and necessity while he **went through hardship**. I learned **the true meaning of life** and started achieving some of the qualities he has. The person who I am now is mostly because of my father's devotion and dedication. To me, he is **an ideal person** whom I often mimic and consider as my idol in my life.

Follow-up questions:

- **What are some of the ways people can help others in the community? Which is most important?**

There are many other ways to help people living in a community or society. The notable helping ways are showing kindness to others, assist in doing something regardless of the task shape or size, behaving in a courteous manner, provide support in mental distress, be with them during their sorrowful events, sharing the joys, offering voluntary services to

the social organizations or during social events, arranging employment for the unemployed (if possible), lending money in soft-terms during distress or supporting with foods, help to get justice etc. But the most important thing, I believe, is to arrange for an employment. There is a proverb – Give a man a fish and you feed him for a day; teach a man to fish and you feed him for a lifetime.

- **Why do you think some people like to help other people?**

People who are kind and soft-hearted usually love to help others. They find a sort of good feelings inside their mind when they could help someone in danger or misery. They are on the view that they are performing some good deeds and in return, they will get that back. There are theories that everything is round. If you do well of others it will come to you unexpectedly, and if you do bad things that will hurt you too, unexpectedly. But most of the people who do well to others are not the theory-believers. They do it selflessly and enjoy the satisfaction of sacrifice.

- **Some people say that people help others in the community more now than they did in the past. Do you agree or disagree? Why?**

The range of good deeds has increased in the society comparing the past. Earlier, people had not the necessity to mix with people as they are socializing now with the demand of time. So, as they are socializing more, they are experiencing the necessity of others and accordingly providing support to the distressed. But, a few decades back, people lived in a constricted loop and their life was limited to specific people or community consisted of very few members. So, they did not have the chance to help others in the community as they have today.

- **What types of services, such as libraries or health centers, are available to the people who live in your area? Do you think there are enough of them?**

In my area, we do have health centers but we need libraries more. We have a single library and the books are insufficient for the increasing readers. At times it appears that the number of patients is on the rise and people are forgetting to meet their thirst for knowledge in the fast-paced age. Thereby, the health centers are on the rise while the libraries are on a decline. Mostly the young people, in the evening, pass their time on the library by reading books. So, the number of libraries needed to be increased and the existing one should be enriched with books and other reading materials.

- **Which groups of people generally need the most support in a community? Why?**

Women, children and the old people are the most vulnerable section of a society or community. They need more support in a community than others for their vulnerable nature. For instance, if there is an earthquake, the aforesaid section should be prioritized regarding escape or taking shelter to a safer place as they cannot move like men. Besides, disease resistance power is lower among them comparing the male members of a society. So, they should be allowed to get advantages in hospitals or other health-related services. The feeble nature has made them dependent on others and the issue should always be kept in mind regarding behavior with them.

- **Who do you think should pay for the services that are available to the people in a community? Should it be the government or individual people?**

Only the government or any individual cannot run a community service alone. The expenses are increasing rapidly and thus the maintenance cost is turning higher day by day. So, the people who are taking the services should also contribute on the sectors so that everyone could get smooth services. For instance, the health centers provide different vaccines and it may happen that a certain vaccine price has gone up which is beyond the budget. So, if the other service receivers contribute a portion of the annual or monthly budget of the health center, the vaccine will be affordable to all. So, I think the government, the individuals and the beneficiaries should pay for the services.

- **What type of people influence the young in your country?**

Well, thank you very much for asking such an important question. Usually, the youths are influenced by the teachers and sometimes they follow their immediate superiors. Most of the time they are out of the home and thus they do not have any close connection with their parents. When they are not in close contact, they do not show the urge to the directions of the parents. But the scenario is opposite for the teachers and superiors. The youths spend most of their times at the educational institutions with their teachers, mates and seniors. So, they are greatly influenced by the teachers and their seniors regarding their attitude and learning skills.

- **Why it is important to have role models in our life?**

Youths always want to follow. They experience a new world before them when they are out of their homes and consequently get influenced by the external facts. They need to have role models for several reasons. I think you have the idea how the youths are influenced by movies or songs and the people who are performing in the movies. When they see something negative, they try to imitate the negative issues in their real life and as

a result invite disorders for them with their family and friends. For instance, if they see someone smoking on television or on cinema, I can bet they will follow the smoking style immediately after enjoying the movie or the specific television series. They get highly influenced and take them as role models for them. But it could be used for positive aspects as well. When they will see someone of their ages is having an award for outstanding contribution to any social sector and the issue will be publicized, they will be inspired to be like the award winning youths. Therefore, since they are out of control of the parents and influenced by the role models, I think it is important to create more and more role models for them.

- **Do you think the education system in your country influences young people's behavior?**

Umm! Yes. Education has many things to do with the behavior of the young people. The educational system in Australia does not teach the student to read and write only, it also plays a great role to socialize the students. The course curriculums are made in different ways to teach them the right manners in different situations. But there are some youths – wicked by nature, do not follow the learning. The entire education system is formed in a way that if the students follow the system properly, they would be considered as assets for the country. But in reality, the scenario is different. Sometimes the learning process is not easier as it is imagined. Besides, the teachers are cordial in spreading the learning and in many of the cases the students are unwilling to learn. As a result, the education cannot play its role in making law abiding citizens. I think you are well informed about the issue that education is a two-way process and ‘pushing knowledge’ on the students cannot bring the desired outcomes. They are also to be willing in learning newer attitudes and behaviors through the educational system.

- **What types of person (parents, teachers, friends etc.) are best to influence young people's behavior?**

As I said before, the teachers are the best people to influence the young people and their behavior. They usually imitate the attitudes and behaviors of the teachers and in some exceptional cases, they follow their friends. I think you will agree on the point why they are not influenced by the parents after my answer of your previous question. Parents cannot control their kids as they stay less time at homes and spend more on out of home activities. They have a close interaction with the teachers and friends. When the teachers order them to do any specific thing, they perform the tasks happily while this is not possible for their parents to make them do.

63. Describe one time when the weather changed your plan

You should say:

When it happened?

What you planned to do?

What did you do after you changed your plan?

And explain how you felt about it when the weather stopped your plan.

Sample Answer:

Well, just last weekend my plans **were ruined by** the weather. Like I said before... the weekends are usually when I'll travel back home and visit with my parents and family, so that was my plan for last weekend.

I'd arranged my schedule and made sure I didn't **have any studying or other things pending**... I'd worked during the week to free up the weekend so I could relax and spend two days back home. But on Friday afternoon the weather started to change **look ominous** and by Friday evening, when I had planned to leave for home, there was **an incredible storm** which developed. **The rain was torrential with a wind that was gusting** and a lot of roads were reported as being flooded... and traffic stopped in various places in the city.

I called home and spoke with my mother and she told me that it was the same there and that I shouldn't travel in such bad weather because I might get delayed. I was a bit sad, but the weather was so bad nobody really wanted to go out at all. In fact the journey from the university back to **my apartment was horrendous**. The traffic was terrible and by the time I arrived I **was completely soaked** because of the rain, so I had to admit that travelling all the way home would not have been **a smart choice**.

I waited for a couple of hours to see if things would change, but it didn't, so eventually I **gave up on** the idea and started to think what I could do instead. I decided to phone a couple of friends and see if they wanted to do something together, and so we got together on Saturday and we spent the day together and in the evening we went to see a movie and then went to a restaurant for a meal. The weather still wasn't great, but it was at least possible to go out without getting absolutely soaked again.

On Sunday, I decided to have a lazy day, you know... just reading, relaxing, and then another friend came to visit me in the evening and so we chatted for a while and then watched a movie in the evening.

Follow-up questions:

- **Describe the weather during these seasons.**

Okay, so in the summer it's incredibly hot sometimes, and it runs from around May through to October typically. It's mainly hot and dry although there are some days when there might be rain showers, but they're not really very heavy and they don't last for long either.

Then, around the middle of October or the beginning of November, the winter season begins. The temperature drops quite dramatically and there's a lot more rain and wind than in the summer. During the day there's still quite a bit of sun and sometimes it can feel warm, but by the evening it can feel really cold some days... and in the middle of the night it gets extremely cold.

- **What kind of weather is preferred by people in your country?**

Generally speaking, most people prefer the hot weather in the summer, although it can be a little uncomfortable at times when temperatures soar in July and August. There are some people who prefer the winter because it's easier and more comfortable to work, for example, when the temperature isn't so hot, but the majority of people like the summer time because they get to spend more time outside and there's a lot of tourist activity in the summer, so things are a lot busier and more lively. Young people like to spend a lot of time at the beach and doing activities outside.

- **How do weather reports affect people's life?**

It affects people in different ways, or not at all, in some cases. Some people are just happier in the summer because they like the warmer weather, and likewise some people are glad when the winter comes because it's a nice break from the intense heat of the summer, and then there are people who like both seasons. Personally, I get a bit sad when it's too cold in the winter – it's just not very comfortable when you go outside, especially when it's raining and cold at the same time... it's horrible.

- **What kind of activities do people do in the different seasons?**

During the summer, most people spend a lot more time outside. They might spend time in their gardens or walking, and in particular if they live near the coast they'll typically spend a couple of days a week at the beach, especially at the weekends. You'll see whole families camped out for the day or maybe even the whole weekend at the beach, enjoying the ocean and all the water sports and activities you can do.

In the winter, it's different. Almost Nobody goes to the beach because it's too cold to swim, so people spend more time inside than outside and so parties and events in the winter are all organized indoors, whereas in the summer most of them would be outdoors. I guess we do typical things inside like watching TV, movies, meeting friends for a drink or meal and other stuff – just inside more than outside.

- **Do you think that celebrities can be good role models?**

I do not think so. A good role model must be hardworking, honest and care about others besides themselves. Unfortunately, many celebrities do not possess these qualities. Usually, the qualities that helped them to become famous in the first place were different. Besides, much of what we hear about them is very negative, leaving them unqualified to become role models.

- **Why do you think the media in most countries often carry stories about celebrities?**

Of course, I see that a lot of information in the media is centered on celebrities because stories about these people, especially scandalous stories will sell newspapers or make people watch television. What I am saying is that their interest in celebrities is often commercial. They know that the general public likes to follow the personal lives of movie or sports personalities.

- **Why do you think many young people tend to copy their favorite celebrities?**

Yes, I see that many youngsters in my country have a tendency to copy their favorite movie or sports personalities. But it is never their life styles that they copy because most of these celebrities lead luxurious lives and the young people never have that kind of money. So it is usually their looks or clothing that they copy. Sometimes, the youngsters sport the looks of a character their favorite actor has played in a recent film, either to express their solidarity with it or to show their love for their favorite star.

64. Describe something you would like to do if you were give a day off

You should say:

What you would like to do?

Who would you like to be with?

Where you would like to do it?

And explain how you would feel at the end of the day.

Sample Answer:

Day off is a rare thing for me due to **my occupational engagement**. I am a **gymnasium instructor by profession** and thus I have to remain busy round the week or month.

If I could **get a day off**, suddenly, I will do only a single thing. Though there a wide number of tasks to pass a day off, I will follow a different idea. I like to watch Hollywood movies and in fact, I am a fan of action and drama movies made in Hollywood. So, when I will get the day off, I would like to watch movies. I have a huge collection of DVDs but I cannot enjoy those for the want of time. I have a plan to watch as much of the movies possible in a single day. Thus, I have **accumulated the movies** and waiting for an unexpected day off from the role of a gym instructor.

Watching movies is fun when you will have companies. But in this case, I would like to watch the movie on my residence where nobody could reach me. **The taste of watching movies alone** is also different. I have a small living room at my home which is decorated with a nice set of sofa, a television, and few small chairs. I will play the movie on the television with the DVD player and sit back on the sofa. This is my own special style for watching movies. I try to have a comfortable position and thus move my legs frequently while I am sitting on the sofa. Sometimes I bend my legs and sit on the sofa and some other times I keep the legs straight and touching the ground.

Follow-up questions:

- **What is the relationship between leisure and the economy?**

Well, people spend a lot of money on all sorts of leisure activities nowadays, so I think leisure is a very important part of the economy of most countries. Leisure could be anything that people do in their free time, such as eating out, going to the cinema, watching a football match, or staying in a hotel. Millions of people are employed in these areas.

- **How does the economy benefit from people's leisure activities?**

The leisure industry makes a huge contribution to the economy. As I said before, it keeps millions of people in employment, and all of these employees pay their taxes and have money to spend on other goods and services. At the same time, most people spend some of their earnings on leisure activities, and this money therefore goes back into the economy.

- **Do men and women enjoy the same type of leisure activities?**

Yes and no. I think both men and women enjoy things like eating in restaurants or going to the cinema, but I'm sure there are other activities that are more popular with one gender. For example, I think more men than women go to football matches.

- **Where do people in this country usually spend their days off?**

Well, it actually varies in terms of age and gender, too. Young people tend to have a preference of exciting activities, playing basketball or football or computer games for boys while girls are certainly a lot more into fashion and umm Korean films. However, the middle age are more likely to watch TV series or chit-chatting about social issues. And the elderly who usually get up early in the mornings would prefer to listen to the radios to keep themselves updated or some could spend time looking after their grandchildren.

- **Why is it important for people to have free-time activities?**

I definitely believe that it's very important for a person to have at least one hobby or free time activity of their own. This can either help you to relax yourself as you have been long time involved in work and study or calm you down, give you comfort when you are frustrated, you know, like a stress reliever. In addition to that, it gives you a sense of accomplishment and a feeling of self-worth, which is essential for you, even sometime you cannot recognize.

Other possible questions:

- **Do men and women spend their free time differently? How?**
- **Do people's leisure time activities change as they get older? How?**
- **How do free time activities differ now compared with the past?**
- **What does the idiom "Time is money." Mean? Do you agree with it?**
- **Do you think a four day work week would be a good idea?**

65. Describe an interesting conversation you had with other people

You should say:

Who the person was?

Where and when you talked with the person?

What you talked about with the person?

And explain why it was interesting

Sample Answer:

While my journey in a train to my hometown, I had a very interesting conversation with a person named Smith (...say a name...) who was a journalist of a daily newspaper. I can't recall his last name but he was a man around 35 years and sat next to me on the train.

I usually read books in long journeys or listen to music. That day I was reading a book by Dan Brown and the person who sat next to me asked about the book. This is how the conversation started. The conversation was mostly about writers in general, the political condition in our country, the role of an ideal leader, journalism, corruptions and the major problems of our country. I rarely continue longer conversations with strangers but that conversation I had on the train was pretty different and lasted almost 3-4 hours.

This conversation was interesting mostly because of three reasons: one, the person I had the conversation with was a smooth talking **person with good knowledge and experience**. Secondly, the way the conversation started and progressed was really interesting. I took my whole effort to debate on issues that I did not agree and also agreed with the notion that was similar to my viewpoint. Though this person was around 12 years senior to me, he never took any advantages of it and even he did not give any hint about it in the issues I disagreed with him. He **treated me as an equally skilled opponent** on many issues and **listened to me very attentively**. Finally, the place and circumstances when the conversation took place were really interesting and unusual. I must say, I learned many things from the opinions and experiences he shared that day.

Follow-up questions:

- **How is communication changing between people?**

Communication has definitely changed in the past few decades. From communicating through pigeon dropping letters we are now able to see each other while talking. Earlier people went on to meet others personally, but with advancement in technology people are now comfortable sitting in their room and interacting through smart phones. Instead of those long letters now see the cut and short messages.

- **It used to be common to talk to strangers. Do you think it's okay to talk to people you don't know?**

I think it is fine only with an intention of knowing the other person or may be just passing time. Because no matter how great friends we have, they also were strangers at some point of time. But, if one starts interacting with complete strangers, whom we never meet of have no connection in common, sometimes it turns out in a very negative way, especially if one is traveling alone.

- **How often do you start up a conversation with people you don't know?**

I do it rarely, especially when I am in a journey and I see my comrades. I remember, there was a journey that I took and I met people from my company and we didn't knew each other. So, we talked off and got to know about the company and stuff. The other time I was taking a journey to Puri during the path yare and met so many people during my journey. Some told me about the temple's history, others shared their passion for touching the rope of the chariot.

- **Think about how your Grandmother talks with people. Is it the same as how you talk to people?**

My grandmother is very sincere when she talks to people. I have seen her speaking her heart out, being honest with what she feels about the other person. Rarely, does she speaks with those she is not interested in. Too an extent I think I am like her only, because I also speak to the ones I like to.

- **Use your imagination. How will people communicate in the future?**

I think it will be all technology for communicating. Most probably, people will communicate using their minds. Technologies where people will be able to send their thoughts off to the other person will be available. It might even be possible that people are able to feel the other person virtually and interact with them.

- **How have smart phones changed communication?**

Smart phones have taken talking as the form of communication to messaging as the foremost method we use to communicate. Earlier people interacted using a call, now we have whatsapp, social media and so much at our tip. There was wait in earlier times, the curiosity for the letter about to come, and then the fun in reading it and writing back. Now, it is very instant. The moment, I feel like talking with someone, I can interact in jus seconds, get a reply and move on. Although, it has made conversations easier but I think it has taken away the fun of waiting and reading about the other person life.

66. Describe something you do to (help you) stay healthy.

You should say:

What you do?

When you started doing this?

How much time you spend doing this (or, how often you do this)?

And explain what benefits you get from this activity or explain how this activity helps you stay healthy.

Sample Answer:

Nowadays, **keeping fit** is everyone's concern and **I am no exception**. Since I am a **full time employee**, I can't **arrange time to** go to the gym as often as when I was a student.

However, in order to stay fit, I **register for a hip hop class**, which is held twice a week.

– Unlike **running on the treadmill**, dancing is more fun. It helps me **burn a lot of energy**. In addition, it **enhances my flexibility** with a lot of **stretching movements**.

Dancing also allows me to work on all the parts of my body. You might look at dancers and think that dancing is light and easy, but you are wrong. In order to be that flexible and light, dancers have to work on their **core muscles** to **maintain their stamina**.

Dancing can help **burn as many as 360 calories** in just an hour of **intensive training**.

By maintaining a schedule of dancing twice a week, I successfully manage to keep fit. Not only that, dancing helps me relax after a busy day at work and my mind is always **fresh and alert** during and after the class.

Follow-up questions:

- **How can we encourage people to eat more healthily?**

I think the best approach is to have everything in moderation ... processed food won't kill you if you only eat it occasionally ... but people should also be encouraged to eat a balanced diet ... try to cook fresh ingredients at home a few times a week ...

- **Do you think people pay enough attention to their health today?**

Times have changed, I believe. There was a time when people stopped caring about their health but I believe in recent times, people have again become more aware of their health. Most people prefer doing some sort of physical activity in their lives to make sure they are healthy. When making small decisions like the food they prefer, people are going for, much healthier foods.

- **What costs are involved when you are ill in your country?**

It depends on the kind of hospital we go for. The government hospitals are way too cheaper than the private ones. Also, having medical insurance and things in place, cost does become less. However, for the daily workers, the cost of getting ill is usually high.

- **Do you think most people worry more about their health as they get older?**

Definitely yes. I think as the person starts getting old, they start getting the signs of bad health. It is during that time that people realize the importance of health. So, one can see a lot of old people going out for walks or jogging.

- **How can people be encouraged to stay healthy?**

The best way a person can be encouraged to stay healthy is by talk and promotion using advertisements. So, if there are few who get motivated by it, then there are others who start following. Also, one can motivate others to be healthy by adopting a healthy lifestyle for themselves.

- **What are the most popular ways of keeping healthy in your country?**

The ways by which people stay healthy in my country is usually divided into age groups and sometimes their income as well. So, the younger group is usually found in the gym or playing a sport. With age, the older generation prefers walking or jogging along with nature. With different income groups, the higher ones usually have their personal trainers, while the middle of the lower finds out ways for themselves.

- **Why do you think some people continue bad habits when they know that they are damaging to their health?**

The only reason that people have for continuing their bad habits is that they have become their habit and as they say bad habits die hard. So, even when people know that it is harming them it is quite tough to stop doing things that they have inculcated in their routines for a long period of time.

- **Do women pay more attention to their health than men?**

In my country, women are always more concerned about their men and their family more than they are about themselves. But as an individual, I think yes, a woman makes sure that she does not indulge herself into the habits that are not good for her health.

- **Do you think people have become more health conscious in recent years?**

In my opinion, yes people have become more health conscious. It could be because of the influence of their favorite stars or the images that are being portrayed. Even more, with advancement in technology people have very less to do physically, so there has a sense of consciousness among people for their health.

- **How can children learn to have a healthy lifestyle?**

The best way a child can be taught to have a healthy lifestyle is by showing them how to have one. If we as a society in large, will try to be healthy, every child will adapt to it. Like, a child learns about cigarette only when he or she sees someone lighting a cigarette and likewise if he or she sees someone leading a healthy life, he or she will lead one for himself or herself.

- **Do you think the government should promote a healthy lifestyle among the citizens?**

I think yes there should be campaigns by the government for a healthy lifestyle but I also believe that government can only do a certain part to it. It always boils down to the individuals if they want to go for it or not.

- **Would you say modern science and technology has more of a positive or a negative influence on people's health?**

There are many ways in which modern science and technology have helped, like in curing diseases and making operations better and more successful. However, there have been some negative impacts as well, I believe if we keep focusing on the positive impacts, the negative will surely become minimal.

- **What are the best ways to keep fit?**

The best way to keep fit is to do exercise that raises your heart rate. The heart is a muscle and has to be worked like any other muscle. So golf, in my opinion, is not the best form of exercise. Something like jogging or swimming or surfing is much more beneficial.

- **Do you think most people consider exercise a chore or do they find it fun?**

I think most people feel it is something they should do. That is a mistake, as far as I'm concerned, because the best way to exercise is not to think about the fitness aspect and just have fun. You can exercise without even noticing you're doing it if you play volleyball with your friends, or go snorkeling, or go for a long walk on a sunny day or something like that.

- **What is the most popular form of exercise in your country?**

I would say the most popular form of exercises is going to the gym. I'm in two minds about the gym as a way to keep fit. On the one hand, it is convenient. But on the other hand, a gym is a very controlled environment, somewhat lacking in imagination and spontaneity.

- **Do you think people in your country are less healthy than they used to be?**

Yes, definitely. I would argue that the invention of TV has led to people being much too sedentary. I know some people who refuse to have a television because they think that without one they are much more likely to keep active – it's all too easy to become a couch potato. Also, most people work in offices so they just sit in a chair all day long and only move to go to the photocopier. That's very unhealthy. People used to work the land and so be on the go from morning till night. Obesity was unknown then, except among the super-rich, I imagine.

- **How can we encourage young people to stay healthy?**

Parents should set a good example. But I strongly believe that schools have a crucial role to play. Not only can they offer a wide range of sports for children to play, they can teach them about eating a balanced diet, and the negative effect of eating junk food and not exercising. If children don't hear all this from home, they have to hear it from somewhere, and I would argue that it's the schools' responsibility. Once they get a taste for playing sports, they will love the sense of achievement it can give you and the feeling of camaraderie with your team mates, and then hopefully they won't ever want to stop playing sports.

- **Should governments intervene to force people to be healthier?**

Hmm, I'm highly skeptical of the idea that governments should force their citizens to be healthy. People ought to be encouraged to lead healthy lives, but not forced to. They could, for example, run an ad campaign showing people how to eat a balanced diet – that you need to eat some carbohydrates, some vegetables and fruit, some meat and so on.

I think most people don't know that. But I'm unconvinced that trying to force people into healthy habits would work because when bullied like that people tend to resent it and react by sticking even more firmly with their unhealthy lifestyles. The one area where I strongly believe legislation is necessary is with smoking. Smokers can harm others through passive smoking so they should not be allowed to smoke in public places. In fact, this has just recently been outlawed in my country.

Other possible questions:

- **What is your diet like? Do you eat mostly fruits and vegetables?**
- **What do you think is the most serious health problem in Vietnam?**
- **Who do you think is responsible for the care of your health--you yourself, your parents, or your doctor and medical people?**
- **What do you think about the health care system in your country? How could it be improved?**
- **People are living longer and longer thanks to medicine. How long would you like to live? How about forever?**
- **Do you think traditional medicine is a good alternative to modern medicine?**

67. Describe a change that will improve your local area.

You should say:

What the change is;

How the change works;

What kinds of problems the change will solve;

And how you feel about the change

Sample Answer:

Well, you know, the city of Beijing has become infamous for its **heavy smog**, which is thought to lead to **widespread illness and discomfort**. But In recent months, air pollution has dropped significantly, and jokes about Beijing's pollution have given way to surprised expressions about the lovely weather. So nowadays, I could enjoy more white cloud and blue skies this year.

Beijing had been badly polluted by the **toxic industrial exhaust** and **chemicals**, making the whole city **unlivable**. But nowadays, thanks to **the strict pollution control policy**, more **coal-fired power plants and factories** have been closed in the neighboring province, and petrol quality has been improved as well. Therefore, though pollution might still **persist for a long time** in Beijing, we could enjoy more fresh air in the city.

Since the weather surprisingly turns excellent, my friends and I are in the habit of taking pictures of blue sky with mobile phones, and sharing them in the social media. And I'm keener on doing outdoor activities with my child to enjoy the warm sunshine and clean air.

Follow-up questions:

- **What are some of the ways people can help others in the community? Which is the most important?**

I think there are many ways to help others in our local communities. For example, where I live, some people volunteer to run activity clubs for children, or they help out in residential homes for elderly people. Others give money, food or clothes to organizations that support people living below the poverty line. In my opinion, there isn't a scale of importance when it comes to helping others; all forms of help are positive.

- **Why do you think some people like to help other people?**

Most people get a good feeling when they help others, and they understand that we can all experience difficult times in our lives when we might need support. For example, we all grow old, and we all run the risk of losing our jobs or having a health problem that affects our ability to look after ourselves. So, I think people help others because they empathize with them.

- **Some people say that people help others in the community more now than they did in the past. Do you agree or disagree? Why?**

I disagree with that kind of opinion. It's impossible to generalize about how much people help in their communities from one generation to the next, so I don't think we should try to judge or compare how altruistic people are now or were in the past. There have always been those who help others and those who don't.

[Also refer to question 62]

Other possible questions:

- **How has your community changed since you were a child?**
- **What do you like about your community?**
- **Would you like to raise your children in a community like yours? Why or why not?**
- **Do you think recycling is an important community service?**

68. Describe a place that can be good to relax (not home).

You should say

Where this place is

What it is like

How do you spend time there

And explain why you think it is a good place for relaxation.

Sample Answer:

Well, your questions have reminded me of the Classical Chinese Garden which is just a 10-minute walk away from where I live. It's always a perfect place to visit. The **covered walkways provide shelter** so the beautiful views can be appreciated in any weather.

The place is very peaceful, almost like a window on another world. Like other traditional Chinese park, there are **a whole bunch of meadows**, waterfalls, lakes, rockery there. The scenery seems to change every few feet. Therefore, many elementary school teachers take their students there to **discover the secrets** of the Chinese culture and the garden is often rented for filming.

I always go to the park to **let off steam** after work because of **the stunning natural views** there. **The garden is breathtaking** in every season. When in spring, everything in the garden turns green and **the flowers bloom** almost at the same time. In summer, **the trees are pretty shady** so we can watch fish play in **the glistening ponds**. The trees change colors in autumn and **the foliage** looks absolutely fascinating. The garden is brilliant even in winter because snow makes it **pure and neat**.

Follow-up questions:

- **How do people in your country like to relax?**

It depends on personalities, you see. Not everyone is weird and use video games to unwind like me. While some might relax by hanging out with their best buddies, others release all their stress simply by a quick power nap.

- **How were people relaxing in the past?**

Well I am not entirely sure. I mean I wasn't there to witness. My dad told me that he never rested a day in this life as he had to work his ass off to feed six other siblings. Of course I don't really believe in word of mouth but his dad, whose pride is off the charts, would never tell me how he chilled.

- **Is it different today? Why?**

Yea I feel like kids these days are offered more time for relaxation thanks to better living standards. Although I don't completely buy my dad's boasts about his diligence, I acknowledge that life 20 years ago significantly differed from now and children had to join the workforce at an early age, hence relaxation was probably a luxury.

Other possible questions:

- **What is the importance of relaxation?**
- **How did people relax earlier and how do they now?**
- **Do you think we should take a day off from our working?**
- **Do you think relaxation should include some activity or doing nothing is enough?**

69. Describe a song that means something special to you

You should say:

What this song is about

When you listened to this song for the first time

How often do you listen to this song

And explain why you think it is special to you.

Sample Answer:

The song 'Return to Innocence' by music band 'Enigma' is one of **my all-time favorite songs** and this song **bears a special meaning to me**. This song is about the human life: the beginning and ending of our lives, the meaning of life, the aim and journey to eternity, and the vision of our life. It **signifies the importance of life** and how much we should **cherish our life**. Finally, it is about our journey to another life and **life transformation** in different stages.

As I mentioned earlier this is a song by famous music band 'Enigma' and this band is particularly famous for the **extraordinary music** they produce. I heard this song many years back when I was in my 9th grade. In my birthday one of our relatives gave me a CD of 'Enigma' band and then I heard this song. I liked most of the songs on this album but this particular song 'Return to Innocence' was bit different and I liked it instantly I heard it for the first time. After that, I heard this song several hundred times and still this music appears as a new inspiration to me. I believe this would never turn into a lost song for me.

The brilliant lyrics and extraordinary music of this song **soothe my heart** each time I listen to it. I can feel this music with every sense of mine and that's **an out-of-the-world feeling**. I have found the lyrics pretty rich and meaningful that gave me special meaning about the life we lead. In my **stressful and tiresome** time this pretty rich and meaningful that gave me special meaning about the life we lead. In my stressful and tiresome time, this particular song has **inspired and motivated me** many times. This song has become a memory of me. Whenever I listen to this song, I **feel a special sensation** and that's why this has **a special meaning and strong significance to me**.

Follow-up questions: Refer to question 6

70. Describe an educational trip you went on.

You should say:

Where this place was;

What you did at this place;

Who you went there with;

And explain why you thought this trip was educational.

Sample Answer:

When I was in class six, the school authority arranged **an educational tour** to **the city botanical garden**. I was very much interested to participate in it and after I got my parent's permission, I **enrolled in the trip**. It was a trip to the largest botanical garden called (...say a name...) and we were almost 30 students and 5-6 teachers in the trip.

After we reached the garden I **was very much enthralled to** watch such a beautiful place that seemed very green and different from the place we lived. The journey took 3-4 hours and I enjoyed my visit a lot. The place very large and there were several thousands of trees, some hills, lakes etc. the large trees gave us the impression of the woods and I felt like we came to visit **a large woods of a mediaeval age**. The teachers introduced us with several plants and flowers and there were many plants and flowers that I read or heard about but have never seen before that day.

We learned about the importance of forests, the necessity and our responsibility to make the world a better place for all the species and not just for humans only. We learned some **medical and herbal aspects** of many trees and one of the teachers explained how the plants and their ingredients are still used to make **life-saving medicines**. The whole trip was educational and enjoyable as well.

This was a very important trip for me as I **had the scope to** visit such a beautiful place surrounded by green trees and flowers. I learned many things about the plants and their usefulness. I also learned about **the natural equilibrium** and why should we maintain a greener environment **for our own betterment**.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you think it's true that travel broadens the mind?**

I do, yes. I wouldn't want to disparage people who haven't travelled because that is almost invariable due to a lack of opportunity. I doubt any of my great-grandparents' generation ever travelled anywhere. But I can't help but think that it does make you a more open-minded person, as you see different ways of living, eating, drinking, interacting with others, and it allows you to see your own culture more objectively. It also leads to you having a wider range of experiences and makes you more interesting to talk to.

- **Do you people and older people benefit differently from travelling?**

I think younger people tend to enjoy adventure and having fun. And older people value relaxation more because they have so many responsibilities at home that what they want more than anything is to switch off when they go away. Of course, that's a generalization and only takes you so far. I know it's true of me, though.

- **How can you make sure you get the most from your travels?**

I've always thought learning something of the language of the country you're going to is the best possible way of benefiting fully from your holiday. That way, the local population isn't so likely to see you as an outsider, but rather as someone who has made the effort of learning some words and expressions, and has an interest in their culture.

- **What are the positive impacts of tourism?**

They are manifold. Tourism brings investment and better infrastructure to poorer communities. This means that tourists find it easier to get around, but it also leads to an improved quality of life of the local people. It also brings about greater work opportunities of the local community. Previously, for example, they may just have had finishing or farming, but tourism opens up the possibility of higher earning jobs.

- **What about the negative impacts of tourism?**

Well, I've seen areas where larger numbers of visitors have had a detrimental effect on local habitats. For example, coral reefs in the Caribbean. It's really tragic. The best solution, as far as the wildlife is concerned, would be to ban tourism for a few decades to

let the reefs, recover, but, of course, the local economy has come to rely on tourism and there would be an uproar if the government were to take that drastic step.

- **How has tourism impacted tourist sites in your country?**

I think, because my country is a big tourist destination yet, the small number of visitors we get have had only a positive effect. For ample, small souvenir shops now have a larger clientele because of the visitors coming to see our temples.

Other possible questions:

- **What is the importance of travelling?**
- **What type of places do you recommend people to visit on vacation?**
- **What places do you want to visit in future? Why?**
- **Can travelling affect children? How?**
- **What is the best kind of holiday for children/teenagers/adults?**

71. Describe one of your best friends

You should say:

When and how you became friends?

What kind of person he/she is?

What you usually do when you are together?

And explain why he or she is one of your best friends

Sample Answer:

Well, I have a friend named Son who is studying at Hanoi Medical University. He used to be my classmate during the secondary and high school time and he is now one of my best friends that I want to talk to you about. I still remember that the first time I met him was in the school yard when we were both in Class 9 and he was a new student who came from another school in the neighbor district and was introduced to my class by my teacher.

We then became good friends during the final year of secondary school but only the time in our high school and university has **tightened our relationship**. At that time, after passing the entrance exam into one of the finest high schools in the middle of Vietnam, we left our home province and moved to live together in the dormitory of the high school in Hue City. We completed high school and interestingly we both chose Hanoi for college time, so altogether we have nearly 10 years of friendship.

We not only have studied together for a long time but also have **numerous common hobbies**. We are both Liverpool football fans and really keen on football, so I usually hang out with him watching English football and support Liverpool FC in a cafe every weekend. That was a really exciting time. Also, he's studying medical while my major is pharmacy so we have many **overlapping subjects** during the initial years of college. As his roommate, I usually **consult him about** medical knowledge to apply to my study. In turn, I can **help him in pharmaceutical chemistry** and other relevant subjects. We are really perfect partners, both in football and in studying.

He has many characteristics that make me consider him my best friend. The first thing, as I have mentioned, I and he have spent a long time studying together. We know each other very well and have experienced **many ups and downs** not only in study but also in life. Besides, I really admire him for his **diligence and responsibility**. He often told me that genius comes from one percent of intelligence and **ninety-nine percent of perspiration**. His spirit inspires me and whenever I **encounter a trouble**, he will be the first one I turn to for help. So all in all, those are the reasons why he is always one of my best friends.

Follow-up questions:

- **Why childhood is important for us?**

It is an indisputable fact that childhood is the best period in our life. Children are carefree, play all the time and have no concerns. In addition, childish memories are really important and many times determine children's life and personality. It's true that there are many cases when people with an extremely unpleasant childhood tend to be mentally disturbed not only when they reach adulthood but also later in their life. So I would jump to the conclusion that it's imperative that a child is raised in a caring, loving and supportive environment in order to maximize their future well-being and become emotionally- secure adults.

- **What changes have you gone through from your childhood?**

It's obvious that all of us have undergone changes through the transition from childhood to adulthood. First of all, external appearance has completely changed, as my body has developed and I have grown taller. In addition, I would say that I am able to maintain my composure when difficulties come up and I am more mature than the time when I was little. Furthermore, I am tolerant to diversity and I have learnt to respect other people's preferences, opinions and attitudes. Lastly, my educational level isn't the same as it was in my early years, as I have graduated from university and specialized in a particular field.

- **What are the differences between childhood friends and college friends?**

That's a really interesting and substantial question. Friends during childhood are just some children who we spent time with and share some common interests. They are more like our playmates than soulmates. On the contrary, college friends are some important people with whom we share a really strong bonding and become close to. Furthermore, most of the time friends from higher educational institutions are like siblings and long-time relationships are built, as they are based on true feeling such as trust, compassion, love and so on. For example, my best friend from university is like a brother to me and also my best man and in this way, we have sealed our relationship while I do not have any childhood friends whom I still communicate.

- **What do you think makes someone a good friend to a whole family?**

It seems to me that the main element in order for someone to be considered a friend to all members of a family is having common values and interests. If these two characteristics are absent or not compatible, it's really difficult for someone to be accepted as a family friend or to hang out with.

Moreover, if parents see that someone has a good personality and some basic virtues that support the notion of friendship, it is likely that they will like and accept this person to their family. In my opinion, family friends play an important role as there are many cases when parents consort with some people they consider friends, and many times it is likely that their kids also interact with those people.

- **Do you think we meet different kinds of friends at different stages of our lives? In what ways are these types of friend different?**

I totally agree with that statement as I believe we have different expectations and requirements for our friends in different stages of our life. When children are **in primary schools**, they just have one or two friends and this is because at that stage they are not capable of assessing and appreciate the importance of friendship. In the early stages of our life, we require friends who would love to play with us, do things that we like to do. So, these relationships are slack and nothing is invested as far as feelings are concerned. However, we start understanding the significance of this bond **in the high school** as we make some friends who have similar interests and can help us in studies. Friends during puberty, on the other hand, are in many cases the most important in someone's life and often these relationships are really strong and based on solid foundation. At that period of life, people's relationships are true and substantial as real feelings such as love, affection, support and trust are dominant. When we **start our career**, we will have many friends

who are basically colleagues. In **the old age**, people usually have friends who are more like family members.

So, I would say that friends in the very early ages are just some playmates who kids hang out and spend some time with and the teen to adult stages include very important and worthy people that are much more than friends.

- **How easy is it to make friends with people from a different age group?**

It's a **controversial issue** as some would say it is quite easy to make friends from different age groups while others would deny it.

In my opinion, the most important characteristics in making friends are communication and common views. In this way, people are able to talk about different things, make **meaningful conversations** and **swap ideas**. If these elements don't exist, even among the people of same age group, then it's really difficult for someone to make friends. I would say that usually, people find it easier to have friends of same age groups, but if effective communication and common views **work smoothly** between two persons of different age groups, they can become good friends. For example, a friend of mine who is around my age has a close friend of 60. When I found about that I was surprised, but when I saw that they have so much in common and they have great times together, I **totally endorsed** it. As far as I'm concerned, I don't have friends who are much older than I am but I have younger friends and common interests make us **a really tight group**.

72. Describe a situation (or a time) when you helped someone

You should say:

What the situation was?

Who the person was?

How you helped them?

And explain how you felt after helping them

Sample Answer:

Well. I try to help people whenever I can, even if it is in a small way. I try to help my parents with work in the house, and I usually help with the cooking whenever it's around the time the meal is being made. If I **pass beggars on the street**, I often give them something, though not always. Sometimes I'm not sure they are real poor people because I've heard there are a lot of fakes who just pretend to be poor or sick.

One time in particular, I passed an old man who was begging. It was early in the morning, and I was on my way to a class. Something inside me caused me to **take special note** of this man. I started to get some money out of my bag for him when it seemed, as if a little voice inside told me to get some food for him instead. I surprised myself at this idea so I **hesitated for a moment**, but I couldn't **shake the thought**. So I went to the **nearby market** and bought him some fresh stuffed buns, about five of them and a cup of warm soy milk. Then I went back to the man and handed it to him, and said some kind words to him. I think he was very happy to have some warm food on a **chilly morning**.

Honestly though, I think doing this might have made me happier than it did him. I really felt good after helping him.

Follow-up questions:

- **In general, why do people help others?**

I think it's the kindness that exists in most human hearts, at least a little. Many of us have needed some help ourselves from time to time, and we know what it feels like to need something. We know it feels good to have help from others when we need it, so we want to help others in the same way. Also, as I mentioned before, often it simply makes us happy to help others in some way.

- **Do you think it's important to help people who need help?**

Of course it's important. We have a responsibility to do our part whether it's in our family, our workplace, or amongst friends. None of us are like little islands with nothing or no one around us. We influence each other, and contribute to the atmosphere and environment around us, at least we should. And just as we want others to help us, we should naturally be willing to help others.

- **Why do you think some people like to help other people?**

Maybe because it makes them feel good... being able to help someone else. It might be because they were once helped by somebody in their past and they would like to return the favor. People help other people for many different reasons, it's almost impossible to generalize, but I think that if a person can see that another person needs help it is almost a natural instinct to offer help if the person is able to. It's one of the foundations of many societies; those that can help – help those that can't.

- **How do you feel after you have helped someone?**

Usually I feel very good when I've helped someone. Even if the help I gave was difficult for me or an inconvenient time. Even if it was a sacrifice for me, afterwards it seems that I am happier than when I began, and sometimes I even seem to have more energy or time left for myself. It may sound funny, but sometimes it seems a little like magic how I end up with more time or more energy or more money or whatever, after I have given some away to another person.

- **Many people only look out for themselves and never think about helping others. What do you think of this attitude?**

I think it's sad. I know it is common, but it's a sad statement of modern life, at least in big cities. I know not everybody is that way, but nowadays a lot of people have become very selfish. It seems that so many people are in such a rush to get rich or get better jobs or into the best schools that they hardly even notice people who need help. Maybe if people were not so absorbed in their own worlds, they would see the needs more and would do something about it. At least I hope so.

- **What kinds of people need help in Vietnam?**

I think one of the biggest groups in our society needing help is the farmers. It would be better if the wealth and economic progress in our country was more evenly distributed. I live in a fairly prosperous family. We're not rich but we do have plenty, and though I'm happy for this, I feel a little guilty that others have so much less than I do.

- **How does the government try to help these people?**

I think one of the main ways is by investing in business in a certain part of the country so that more jobs are created for the local people. Another way is by providing training, for example in farming, in ways that can increase productivity. Also the government should make sure that officials of the provinces are doing their jobs correctly. The government is trying to eliminate corruption at the local level.

- **Some people say that people help others in the community more now than they did in the past. Do you agree or disagree? Why?**

I don't know if that is true or not. It might be the case that there is more help available nowadays for many more people who need help, but it is not always provided by individuals in the community. Sometimes it is provided by government agencies or organizations or even charity organizations. So I guess there might be more help given but it's not simply people in the community helping other people in the community – it's a more structured help system than in the past.

- **Are there any non-government organizations in Vietnam that help people?**

Yes, there are. At first many of these were foreign, but that is changing now. Although there are still foreign organizations that help people, there are also more and more Vietnamese charitable organizations being set up. I just read some articles about this.

- **Where do these organizations get their money from?**

The foreign organizations get their money from overseas. Some of the funding is governmental, but a lot of it comes from private donations. Here in China, more individuals are getting involved in charities. It's relatively new, but with the increased income of people, there is more of an awareness of a need to help others who are less fortunate.

73. Describe something interesting you learnt from the internet.

You should say:

What you learnt?

What website you learnt it from?

How you learnt it?

And explain why you think it was interesting

Sample Answer:

I'm really into learning cooking in the Internet. There is a website called the Expert of Cate, which is very popular teaching visitors how to cook simple but tasty food. Each lesson is produced in video with **up-to-date culinary tips and advice**, along with the **tasty recipes**. I believe it appeals to anyone who loves life and food particularly.

There is a **woman hostess** in the video whose sound is really kindly. She looks like a **patient and kind-hearted housewife**, as same as my lovely mom. She is good at cooking all kinds of food, and teaching you how to cook it yourself step by step as well. I always **get access to the website** to learn some new food during the weekends, especially before starting preparing the dinner at night. I only spend no more than five minutes to learn a new recipe, sitting in front of my computer and taking some notes from time to time.

Thanks to this website, I can cook something for my family now. Although I can't cook very well, I will **acquire a sense of achievement** when someone enjoys my dishes. Besides, this website helped a lot and changed me from a **layman** to a person who enjoys cooking. **On top of that**, it may be an easy way to **let off steam** during the weekend after a **one-week tiring work**.

Follow-up questions:

- **What are some of the advantages of internet?**

Internet has surely come up with great advantages to offer all of us. Firstly, it allows for free communication with people far off from us. You see, it is very easy to know how your friends miles away from you is actually. Also, internet provides us with information regarding anything and everything. There are so many people writing about so many things and often people share their experiences helping others stuck in the same issue. Internet surely has made the world a smaller and a better place.

- **Do people in your country use internet a lot?**

There has been a recent trend of internet with the coming of smart phones. I surely think that since the past decade the use of internet has surely risen in my country. You can now see even the elderly people learning how to use it and chat with their kids online. They would form groups and laugh at the new WhatsApp joke. Apart from them, internet is surely very famous among the younger generation, who is ever so active to use it for either education or fun.

- **How do you think the internet has changed our lives?**

In many ways, I suppose. First of all, the internet has changed our study and working habits. The internet had made access to information and communication a lot easier, faster and cheaper. Social network websites such as Facebook have changed personal relationships. More and more people seem to be keeping in touch with their friends and family through it. The internet is also being used to arrange for holidays and to buy products.

- **Do you think people take notice of advertisements on the internet?**

Despite the fact that there are many adverts on the internet these days, I think actually many people tend to ignore them, or at least that is my experience. People usually go onto the internet to find something specific that they are looking for, which may be a product, or to read about something, so they will ignore what is not relevant to that. But of course there is no doubt that some people take notice of them. Advertising on the internet is a practice most companies partake in now, and they have to pay quite substantial sums to advertise on highly ranked sites. Of course they would not do this if it were not attracting customers for them.

- **Can you think of any type or class of people in your country who have not been affected by the arrival of the internet?**

I think the internet hasn't made much difference for the older people in my country. Except for those who move with the times, life hasn't changed at all for the elderly with the introduction of the internet. They still prefer to go out and meet their friends rather than chatting online. I have noticed that in some businesses too, personal contact is still important despite the rise of the internet.

- **How do you think the Internet will affect our lives in the future?**

I think the Internet will have a huge impact on our lives. In terms of personal perspective, more and more people are using social websites to keep in touch with friends. I think the Internet will probably replace TV because most channels are already available online. About economy, I think we'll do more online shopping. Web-based companies like Amazon are already really successful. In the future, there will probably be more companies that only sell via the Internet, and I expect we'll spend more money online than in traditional shops. Speaking of educational perspective, schools and universities might also use the Internet to provide courses, so online learning will probably become a normal part of life.

- **How do you think it will change people's buying habits in the future?**

Buying from the internet is becoming more and more popular. For example, we've seen many book shops close down because people can buy online at cheaper prices from sites such as Amazon. It makes life much easier if products can be delivered direct to our door, especially with our busy modern lifestyles. I think this will only increase in the future as more people feel safe to buy online and online shops make it easier to purchase this way. Also, I think our lives are only going to become busier, so more people will choose to shop this way.

- **Are there any disadvantages to shopping on the internet?**

Buying from the internet is becoming more and more popular. For example, we've seen many book shops close down because people can buy online at cheaper prices from sites such as Amazon. It makes life much easier if products can be delivered direct to our door, especially with our busy modern lifestyles. I think this will only increase in the future as more people feel safe to buy online and online shops make it easier to purchase this way. Also, I think our lives are only going to become busier, so more people will choose to shop this way.

- **Some people say that working from home will be quite common in the future. Do you agree?**

It is foreseeable that more people will work from home in the future. If the internet becomes faster and there are more programs, such as Skype, that allow people to work from home more easily, I'd predict that more people will stay at home. If you think about it, most people don't need to be physically present to do their jobs and I envisage that face to face meetings will be a thing of the past.

- **Can we live without the internet?**

Well, we used to live without it, just like we lived without the car and color television. But nowadays everything is based on the internet. Business, commerce, banking, shopping, education, social interaction and almost anything you can think of.

The internet is now an integral part of modern life. Most people don't even think how marvelous it is or how incredibly powerful it is. I guess it's like the electric light bulb - we take it for granted, most people don't know exactly how it works, but it's part of life and it's an essential part of modern life. So I don't think we'll stop using it, but it might be possible to live without it if you really want to, but your lifestyle would be very different.

- **Do you think the government should consider educating elderly people to become computer-literate?**

No, not really. It's a personal thing I think. Not everybody wants to or needs to be computer literate; they just need to learn the basics of email and maybe how to pay things online, like bills. However, I think most kids are happy to show or help their parents if necessary and my grandparents, for example, just aren't interested in searching the web for information. They like to do things the way they have always done - by speaking to a person and asking questions.

Other possible questions:

- **Should the Internet use be compulsory for all students? Why?**
- **Can elderly people benefit from using the Internet, as well?**
- **How do you think children could be encouraged to use the Internet in positive ways?**
- **Do you think online education is good?**
- **What impact has the Internet had on modern people's lives?**

74. Describe a family member you would like to work with

You should say:

Who this person is

What kind of person he or she is

Whether you've worked together before

And explain why you would like to work with this person (more than with other members of your family).

Sample Answer:

Let me tell you about my brother that I'd like to work with in my business. He is very **considerate and thoughtful person** who has always done his best to help me make decisions **in the face of day-to-day difficulties**.

My brother has **a strong personality** and he never lets others tell him what to do. I learned how to be more responsible and also more determined in my daily life. Although we've never worked together in business before, he always reminds me that things are not as easy as they appear and that I should work hard in order to get results.

I'd like to work with my brother because it's lucky enough to find a wonderful partner in him, both personally and professionally. We can be honest with one another, and I trust him significantly more than I've trusted partners in the past. My brother is very loyal and I believe he will always watch my back. Although, I will say it is very important to **define roles and boundaries** with family immediately. He does tend to **push the limits of** what is acceptable if rules are not clearly defined. It also just happens that our skill sets are completely **opposite and complementary**.

Follow-up questions:

- **Do you think what the causes for the success of a family business are?**

There are various causes. Like any successful company, a family business must develop with the trend of the world, so it won't die out. To achieve that, the young generation of the family must be able to take the lead and have their new idea in managing and running the company, rather than just relying on the experience of their parents and grandparents. Secondly, the family members should be in conformity, otherwise, the company won't enjoy a further development with members fighting for their own interest.

- **What are the advantages and disadvantages of a family business?**

On the positive side, most people in charge in a family business are members of the family; therefore they sincerely care about the development of the company, as its development is closely related to their family. However, there may be problems because of that. For example, staff, those not belong to the family, may not be pointed to important positions even they are professional and capable, so the development of the business may not be so rapid as it could be.

- **What are the relationships among the members of a family business?**

In a family business, members may be direct or indirect relatives. A man, or with his wife, founded a business, and then his children and grandchildren may be likely to take part in the business, in charge of managing. Then if the rapid development of the company is in need of more people in management, then other relatives, such as relatives by marriage, will gradually join the business if they are able to.

- **In what ways have families in your country changed in recent?**

The roles of husbands and wives changed in recent years. Both spouses have been more open to perform different roles such as working outside the home or pitching-in with the household duties. Another change I think is limiting the number of children in the family. Parents nowadays think of having smaller families due to high cost of living.

- **Should husbands and wives have different roles within the family?**

Why (not)?

Traditionally, husbands and wives had clear-cut roles in the society. Husbands used to provide the financial need of the family, while women were expected to take care of the house. Changes had occurred over time and both husbands and wives started to take part in each of these roles. I think this change is good. It is not necessary to define each role. I think whatever role each husband or wife takes, as long as it is good for the family, it is okay.

- **Which are more important to you: your family or your friends?**

Both are important but family is more important for me than friends. Friends may come and go but I know that my family is always there and will always be there no matter what happens in my life and no matter what decisions I take.

75. Describe something you want to learn which you can't learn now?

You should say

What it is?

How you will learn it?

Why you want to learn it?

And explain why you can't learn it now?

Sample Answer:

I would like to learn the taekwondo which is historical Korean **martial arts** and also is an excellent method of **keeping fit and getting toned**.

I guess it is just a fashionable hobby because it will enable me to build strength, **improve my balance, coordination and flexibility**. Apart from its health benefits, it can also teach me how to be calm, respect for others, **control my movements and self-defense**. Furthermore, it will **help reinforce the traditional values** like honesty, courtesy, courage and **indomitable spirit**.

There is a traditional taekwondo school located just near the sub district. Every time I pass by the school gate, I really would like to go inside, enroll **the entry-level course** and select my instructor. It would be very excited to wear the uniforms and the belt. But unfortunately I cannot get around to doing it currently due to my stressful work which makes me stay far away from all my hobbies. I am not sure if I will have some **consecutive period of time** to follow the courses. Hopefully one day in the future I would **be a bit idle**, I could be really into it and enjoy the pleasures of martial arts.

Follow-up questions: Refer to 12

76. Describe a person who once moved to live with you (moving house)

You should say:

When and where this person moved in

How you know this person

How you got along with this person.

And how you feel about living with this person

Sample Answer:

In our country, it is quite common that close relatives move to live with a family, especially when someone needs to stay in a different area. For instance, whenever my uncle, aunt or grandparents come to the city we live in, they stay with us at our home. This stay is mostly **short-term** but in few occasions, it can be for a long. For this cue card topic, I would like to talk about my uncle Joseph who moved to our house and stayed with us for approximately 2 years.

My uncle, Joseph, is the youngest brother of my father and was **a renowned football** player in our hometown. As soon as he finished his high school graduation, he moved to our family and **got admitted to a college** here. As an elder brother, my father took his responsibilities. My uncle stayed with us for about 2 years and then moved to his own apartment after he **managed a steady job** for himself.

I liked him very much and when he moved to our house, I was very happy. I am the only child of my parents and when my uncle started living with us, I felt like I have got a good friend and someone to talk to about everything. Joseph was an interesting and talented person. We often talked for a long time and went out to watch movies. Both of us got involved in some sporting activities and he often helped me in my studies.

Since Joseph was a nice person and respected my parents, they also liked him. I never **felt irritated or disturbed** due to his presence at our home. As an intelligent person, Joseph knew how to **behave and treat** other members in a family, especially who are close family members. He is now married to a woman who is a lecturer in a college and he has a two years old daughter. I still miss some of the activities we did together. Though he was my uncle, I often felt like he was the brother I never had!

Follow-up questions: Refer to question 24